

PARZIVAL

A KNIGHTLY EPIC

BY

WOLFRAM VON ESCHENBACH

TRANSLATED BY

JESSIE L. WESTON

VOL. I

ANASTATIC REPRINT OF THE EDITION LONDON 1894.

NEW YORK

G. E. STECHERT & CO.,

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KNIGHTLY EPIC (VOL. 1 OF 2) ***

PARZIVAL

VOL. I

BOOKS I.-IX.

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TO THE MEMORY OF
RICHARD WAGNER
WHOSE GENIUS HAS GIVEN FRESH LIFE
TO THE CREATIONS OF MEDIÆVAL ROMANCE
THIS TRANSLATION IS
DEDICATED

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INTRODUCTION

N presenting, for the first time, to English readers the greatest work of Germany's greatest mediæval poet, a few words of introduction, alike for poem and writer, may not be out of place. The lapse of nearly seven hundred years, and the changes which the centuries have worked, alike in language and in thought, would have naturally operated to render any work unfamiliar, still more so when that work was composed in a foreign tongue; but, indeed, it is only within the present century that the original text of the *Parzival* has been collated from the MSS. and made accessible, even in its own land, to the general reader. But the interest which is now felt by many in the Arthurian romances, quickened into life doubtless by the genius of the late Poet Laureate, and the fact that the greatest composer of our time, Richard Wagner, has selected this poem as the groundwork of that wonderful drama, which a growing consensus of opinion has hailed as the grandest artistic achievement of this century, seem to indicate that the time has come when the work of Wolfram von Eschenbach may hope to receive, from a wider public than that of his own day, the recognition which it so well deserves.

Of the poet himself we know but little, save from the personal allusions scattered throughout his works; the dates of his birth and death are alike unrecorded, but the frequent notices of contemporary events to be found in his poems enable us to fix with tolerable certainty the period of his literary activity, and to judge approximately the outline of his life. Wolfram's greatest work, the *Parzival*, was apparently written within the early years of the thirteenth century; he makes constant allusions to events happening, and to works produced, within the first decade of that period; and as his latest work, the *Willehalm*, left unfinished, mentions as recent the death of the Landgrave Herman of Thuringia, which occurred in 1216, the probability seems to be that the *Parzival* was written within the first fifteen years of the thirteenth century. Inasmuch, too, as this work bears no traces of immaturity in thought or style, it is probable that the date of the poet's birth cannot be placed much later than 1170.

The name, Wolfram von Eschenbach, points to Eschenbach in Bavaria as in all probability the place of his birth, as it certainly was of his burial. So late as the end of the seventeenth century his tomb, with inscription, was to be seen in the Frauen-kirche of Ober-Eschenbach, and the fact that within a short distance of the town are to be found localities mentioned in his poems, such as Wildberg, Abenberg, Trühending, Wertheim, etc., seems to show that there, too, the life of the poet-knight was spent.

By birth, as Wolfram himself tells us, he belonged to the knightly order (Zum Schildesamt bin Ich geboren), though whether his family was noble or not is a disputed point, in any case Wolfram was a poor man, as the humorous allusions which he makes to his poverty abundantly testify. Yet he does not seem to have led the life of a wandering singer, as did his famous contemporary, Walther von der Vogelweide; if Wolfram journeyed, as he probably did, it was rather in search of knightly adventures, he tells us: 'Durchstreifen muss Der Lande viel, Wer Schildesamt verwalten will,' and though fully conscious of his gift of song, yet he systematically exalts his office of *knight* above that of *poet*. The period when Wolfram lived and sang, we cannot say *wrote*, for by his own confession he could neither read nor write ('I'ne kan decheinen buochstap,' he says in *Parzival*; and in *Willehalm*, 'Waz an den buochen steht geschrieben, Des bin Ich kunstelos geblieben'), and his poems must, therefore, have been orally dictated, was one peculiarly fitted to develop his special genius. Under the rule of the Hohenstaufen the institution of knighthood had reached its highest point of glory, and had not yet lapsed into the extravagant absurdities and unrealities which characterised its period of decadence; and the Arthurian romances which first found shape in Northern France had just passed into Germany, there to be gladly welcomed, and to receive at the hands of German poets the impress of an ethical and philosophical interpretation foreign to their original form.

It was in these romances that Wolfram, in common with other of his contemporaries, found his chief inspiration; in the *Parzival*, his master-work, he has told again the story of the Quest for, and winning of, the Grail; told it in connection with the Perceval legend, through the medium of which, it must be remembered, the spiritualising influence of the Grail myth first came into contact with the brilliant chivalry and low morality of the original Arthurian romances; and told it in a manner that is as truly

mediæval in form as it is modern in interpretation. The whole poem is instinct with the true knightly spirit; it has been well called *Das Hohelied von Rittersum*, the knightly song of songs, for Wolfram has seized not merely the external but the very soul of knighthood, even as described in our own day by another German poet; Wolfram's ideal knight, in his fidelity to his plighted word, his noble charity towards his fellow-man, lord of the Grail, with its civilising, humanising influence, is a veritable 'true knight of the Holy Ghost.' In a short introduction such as this it is impossible to discuss with any fulness the fascinating problems connected with this poem, one can do no more than indicate where the principal difficulties lie. These may be briefly said to be chiefly connected with the source from which Wolfram derived his poem, and with the interpretation of its ethical meaning. That Wolfram drew from a French source we know from his own statement, he quotes as his authority a certain 'Kiot the Provençal,' who, in his turn, found his information in an Arabian MS. at Toledo. Unfortunately no such poet, and no such poem, are known to us, while we do possess a French version of the story, *Li Conte del Graal*, by Chrétien de Troyes, which, so far as the greater part of the poem (*i.e.* Books III. to XIII.) is concerned, shows a remarkable agreement not only in sequence of incidents, but even in verbal correspondence, with Wolfram's work. Chrétien, however, does not give either the first two or the last three books as we find them in Wolfram. The account of Perceval's father, and of his death, is by another hand than Chrétien's, and does not agree with Wolfram's account; and the poem, left unfinished by Chrétien, has been continued and concluded at great length by at least three other writers, who have evidently drawn from differing sources; whereas Wolfram's conclusion agrees closely with his introduction, and his whole poem forms the most harmonious and complete version of the story we possess. Wolfram knew Chrétien's poem, but refers to it with contempt as being the wrong version of the tale, whereas 'Kiot' had told the venture aright. The question then is, where did Wolfram really find those portions of his poems which he *could not* have drawn from Chrétien? Is 'Kiot' a real, or a feigned, source?

Some German critics have opined that Wolfram really knew no other poem than Chrétien's, and that he boldly invented all that he did not find there, feigning another source in order to conceal the fact. Others have maintained that whether 'Kiot' be the name of the writer or not, Wolfram certainly had before him a French poem other than *Li Conte del Graal*.

It certainly seems in the highest degree improbable that a *German* poet should have introduced the Angevin element, lacking in Chrétien; Wolfram's presentment of the Grail, too, differs *in toto* from any we find elsewhere, with him it is not the cup of the Last Supper, but a precious stone endowed with magical qualities. It is true that Chrétien does not say *what* the Grail was, but simply that '*du fin or esmeree estoit, pieres pressieuses avoit el graal de maintes manieres*,' yet it seems scarcely likely that Wolfram should have interpreted this as a precious stone, to say nothing of sundry Oriental features peculiar to his description. But whence Wolfram derived his idea of the Grail is a problem which it is to be feared will never now be completely solved.

The discussion as to the ethical meaning Wolfram attached to the story seems more hopeful of results, as here we do possess the requisite data, and can study the poem for ourselves. The question between critics is whether Wolfram intended to teach a purely religious lesson or not; whether the poem is an allegory of life, and Parzival a symbol of the Soul of man, hovering between Faith and Doubt, perplexed by the apparent injustice of God's dealings with men, and finally fighting its way through the darkness of despair to the clear light of renewed faith in God; or have we here a glorification of the knightly ideal? a declaration of the poet-knight's belief that in loyal acceptance of, and obedience to, the dictates of the knightly order, salvation is to be won? Can the true knight, even though he lack faith in God, yet by keeping intact his faith with man, by very loyalty and steadfastness of purpose, win back the spiritual blessing forfeited by his youthful folly? Is Parzival one of those at whose hands 'the Kingdom of Heaven suffereth violence'? It may well be that *both* these interpretations are, in a measure, true, that Wolfram found the germ of the religious idea already existing in his French source, but that to the genius of the German poet we owe that *humanising* of the ideal which has brought the *Parzival* into harmony with the best aspirations of men in all ages. This, at least, may be said with truth, that of all the romances of the Grail cycle, there is but one which can be presented, in its entirety, to the world of to-day with the conviction that its morality is as true, its human interest as real, its lesson as much needed now as it was seven hundred years ago, and that romance is the *Parzival* of Wolfram von Eschenbach.

Some words as to the form of the original poem, and the method followed in translation, may be of interest to the reader. The original *Parzival* is a poem of some 25,000 lines, written in an irregular metre, every two lines rhyming, *reim-paar*. Among modern German translators considerable difference of opinion as to the best method of rendering the original appears to exist. Simrock has retained the original form, and adheres very closely to the text; his version certainly gives the most accurate idea of Wolfram's style; San Marte has allowed himself considerable freedom in versification, and, unfortunately, also in translation; in fact, he too often gives a paraphrase rather than a reproduction of the text. Dr. Bötticher's translation omits the Gawain episodes, and, though close to the original, has discarded rhyme. It must be admitted that Wolfram is by no means easy to translate, his style is obscure and crabbed, and it is often difficult to interpret his meanings with any certainty. The translator felt that the two points chiefly to be aimed at in an English version were, that it should be faithful to the original text, and easy to read. The metre selected was chosen for several reasons, principally on account of the length of the poem, which seemed to render desirable a more flowing measure than the short lines of the original; and because by selecting this metre it was possible to retain the original form of *reim-paar*. As a general rule one line of the English version represents two of the German poem, but the difference of language has occasionally demanded expansion in order to do full justice to the poet's meaning. Throughout, the translator's aim has been to be as literal as possible, and where the differing conventionalities of the thirteenth and nineteenth centuries have made a change in the form of expression necessary, the *meaning* of the poet has been reproduced, and in no instance has a different *idea* been consciously suggested. That there must of necessity be many faults and defects in the work the writer is fully conscious, but in the absence of any previous English translation she can only hope that the present may be accepted as a not altogether inadequate rendering of a great original; if it should encourage others to study that original for themselves, and learn to know Wolfram von Eschenbach, while at the same time they learn better to understand Richard Wagner, she will feel herself fully repaid.

The translator feels that it may be well to mention here the works which have been principally relied on in preparing the English translation and the writers to whom she is mostly indebted.

For the Text Bartsch's edition of the original *Parzival*, published in *Deutsche Classiker des Mittelalters*, has been used throughout, in connection with the modern German translation by Simrock.

In preparing the Notes use has been made of Dr. Bötticher's Introduction to his translation of the *Parzival*, and the same writer's *Das Hohelied von Rittersum*; San Marte's translation has also been occasionally referred to.

The Appendix on proper names has been mainly drawn up from Bartsch's article on the subject in *Germanistische Studien*; and that on the Angevin allusions from Miss Norgate's *England under the Angevin Kings*, though the statements have been verified by reference to the original chronicles.

For all questions connected with the Perceval legend in its varying forms the authority consulted has been *Studies on the Legend of the Holy Grail*, by Mr. Alfred Nutt, to whom, personally, the translator is indebted for much valuable advice and assistance in preparing this book for publication.

BOOK I

GAMURET

ARGUMENT

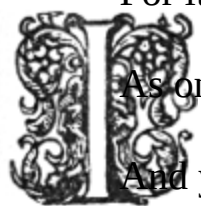
In the Introduction the poet tells of the evil of doubt and unsteadfastness—against which he would warn both men and women; he will tell them a tale which shall speak of truth and steadfastness, and in which many strange marvels shall befall.

Book I. tells how Gamuret of Anjou at the death of his father, King Gandein, refused to become his brother's vassal, and went forth to seek fame and love-guerdon for himself. How he fought under the Baruch before Alexandria, and came to Patelamunt. How Queen Belakané was accused of having caused the death of her lover Eisenhart, and was besieged by two armies, which Friedebrand, King of Scotland, Eisenhart's uncle, had brought against her. How Gamuret defeated her foemen, and married the Queen, and became King of Assagog and Zassamank. How he grew weary for lack of knightly deeds, and sailed away in secret from Queen Belakané, and left her a letter telling of his name and race. How Feirifis was born, and how Gamuret came to Seville.

BOOK I

GAMURET

If unfaith in the heart find dwelling, then the soul it shall
 reap but woe;
And shaming alike and honour are his who such doubt shall
 show,



For it standeth in evil contrast with a true man's dauntless
might,

As one seeth the magpie's plumage, which at one while is
black and white.

And yet he may win to blessing; since I wot well that in his
heart, 5

Hell's darkness, and light of Heaven, alike have their lot and
part

But he who is false and unsteadfast, he is black as the
darkest night,

And the soul that hath never wavered stainless *its* hue and
white!

This my parable so fleeting too swift for the dull shall be,
Ere yet they may seize its meaning from before their face
'twill flee, 10

As a hare that a sound hath startled: yea, metal behind the
glass,

And a blind man's dream yield visions that as swift from the
eye do pass,

For naught shall they have that endureth! And at one while
'tis bright and sad,

And know of a truth that its glory but for short space shall
make ye glad.

And what man shall think to grip me, where no hair for his
grasp shall grow, 15

In the palm of mine hand? The mystery of a close clasp he
sure doth know!

If I cry aloud in such peril, it 'seemeth my wisdom well.

Shall I look for truth where it fleeteth? In the fire that the
stream doth quell,

Or the dew that the sun doth banish? Ne'er knew I a man so
wise,

But was fain to learn the wisdom my fable doth ill disguise,

And the teaching that springeth from it: for so shall he ne'er
 delay
To fly and to chase as shall fit him, to shun and to seek
 always,
And to give fitting blame and honour. He who knoweth the
 twain to tell,
In their changing ways, then wisdom has tutored that man
 right well.
And he sits not o'er-long at leisure, nor his goal doth he
 overreach,²⁵
But in wisdom his ways discerning, he dealeth with all and
 each.
But his comrade, of heart unfaithful, in hell-fire shall his
 portion be,
Yea, a hailstorm that dims the glory of a knightly fame is he.
As a short tail it is, his honour, that but for two bites holds
 good,
When the steer by the gad-fly driven doth roam thro' the
 lonely wood.³⁰

And tho' manifold be my counsel not to *men* alone I'd
 speak,
For fain would I show to women the goal that their heart
 should seek.
And they who shall mark my counsel, they shall learn where
 they may bestow
Their praise and their maiden honour; and the manner of
 man shall know
Whom they freely may love and honour, and never may fear
 to rue ³⁵
Their maidenhood, and the true love they gave him of heart
 so true.
In God's sight I pray all good women to keep them in
 wisdom's way,
For true shame on all sides doth guard them: such bliss I for
 them would pray.

But the false heart shall win false honour—How long doth
the thin ice last,
If the sun shineth hot as in August? So their praise shall be
soon o'erpast.40

Many women are praised for beauty; if at heart they shall be
untrue,
Then I praise them as I would praise it, the glass of a
sapphire hue
That in gold shall be set as a jewel! Tho' I hold it an evil
thing,
If a man take a costly ruby, with the virtue the stone doth
bring,
And set it in worthless setting: I would liken such costly
stone 45
To the heart of a faithful woman, who true womanhood doth
own.
I would look not upon her colour, nor the heart's roof all
men can see,
If the heart beateth true beneath it, true praise shall she win
from me!

Should I speak of both man and woman as I know, nor my
skill should fail,
O'er-long would it be my story. List ye now to my wonder-
tale: 50
And this venture it telleth tidings of love, and anon of woe,
Joy and sorrow it bringeth with it. 'Stead of *one* man if *three*
ye know,
And each one of the three hath wisdom and skill that
outweigh my skill,
Yet o'erstrange shall they find the labour, tho' they toil with a
right good-will
To tell ye this tale, which I think me to tell ye myself, alone,
55
And worn with their task and weary would they be ere the
work was done.

A tale I anew will tell ye, that speaks of a mighty love;
Of the womanhood of true women; how a man did his
manhood prove;
Of one that endured all hardness, whose heart never failed in
fight,
Steel he in the face of conflict: with victorious hand of might
60
Did he win him fair meed of honour; a brave man yet slowly
wise
Is he whom I hail my hero! The delight he of woman's eyes,
Yet of woman's heart the sorrow! 'Gainst all evil his face he
set;
Yet he whom I thus have chosen my song knoweth not as
yet,
For not yet is he born of whom men this wondrous tale shall
tell, 65
And many and great the marvels that unto this knight befell.

NOW they do to-day as of old time, where a foreign law
holds sway
(Yea, in part of our German kingdom, as ye oft shall have
heard men say),
Whoever might rule that country, 'twas the law, and none
thought it shame
('Tis the truth and no lie I tell ye) that the elder son might
claim 70
The whole of his father's heirdom—And the younger sons
must grieve,
What was theirs in their father's lifetime, they perforce at his
death must leave.
Before, all was theirs in common, now it fell unto one alone.
So a wise man planned in his wisdom, that the eldest the
lands should own,
For youth it hath many a fair gift, but old age knoweth grief
and pain, 75
And he who is poor in his old age an ill harvest alone doth
gain.

Kings, Counts, Dukes (and no lie I tell ye) the law holdeth
all as one,
And no man of them all may inherit, save only the eldest
son,
And methinks 'tis an evil custom—So the knight in his
youthful pride,
Gamuret, the gallant hero, lost his Burg, and his fair lands
wide, 80
Where his father had ruled with sceptre and crown as a
mighty king,
Till knighthood, and lust of battle, to his death did the
monarch bring.

And all men were sore for his sorrow, who truth and
unbroken faith
Bare ever throughout his lifetime, yea even unto his death.
Then the elder son he summoned the princes from out his
land, 85
And knightly they came, who rightly might claim from their
monarch's hand,
To hold, as of yore, their fiefdoms. So came they unto his
hall,
And the claim of each man he hearkened, and gave fiefs
unto each and all.

Now hear how they dealt—As their true heart it bade them,
both great and small,
They made to their king petition, with one voice from the
people all, 90
That to Gamuret grace and favour he would show with true
brother's hand,
And honour himself in the doing. That he drive him not from
the land
But give him, within his kingdom, a fair Burg that all men
might see,
That he take from that Burg his title, and he held of all
tribute free!—

Nor the king was ill-pleased at their pleading, and he quoth,
 'A small grace, I trow,⁹⁵
Have ye asked, I would e'en be better than your prayer, as ye
 straight shall know,
Why name ye not this my brother as Gamuret Angevin?
Since Anjou is my land, I think me the title we *both* may
 win!'

Then further he spake, the monarch, 'My brother in sooth
 may seek
Yet more from my hand of favour than my mouth may as
 swiftly speak,¹⁰⁰
With me shall he have his dwelling—I would that ye all
 should see
How one mother alike hath borne us; his riches but small
 shall be,
While I have enough; of free hand would I give him both
 lands and gold,
That my bliss may be ne'er held forfeit by Him, Who can
 aye withhold,
Or give, as He deemeth rightful!' Then the princes they
 heard alway,¹⁰⁵
How the king would deal well with his brother, and they
 deemed it a joyful day!

And each one bowed him low before him. Nor Gamuret long
 delayed,
But he spake as his heart would bid him, and friendly the
 words he said:
'Now hearken, my lord and brother, if vassal I think to be
To thee, or to any other, then a fair lot awaiteth me. ¹¹⁰
But think thou upon mine honour, for faithful art thou and
 wise,
And give counsel as shall beseem thee, and help as thou
 shalt devise.
For naught have I now save mine armour, if within it I more
 had done,

Then far lands should speak my praises, and remembrance
from men were won!"

Then further he spake, the hero: 'Full sixteen my squires
shall be, 115

And six of them shall bear harness; four pages give thou to
me

Of noble birth and breeding, and nothing to them I'll spare
Of all that my hand may win them. Afar in the world I'd
fare,

(Somewhat I ere now have journeyed,) if Good Fortune on
me shall smile,

I may win from fair women favour. If a woman I serve
awhile, 120

And to serve her she hold me worthy, and my heart speaketh
not amiss,

True knight shall I be and faithful! God show me the way of
bliss!

As comrades we rode together (but then o'er thy land did
reign

The King Gandein, our father), and sorrow and bitter pain
We bare for Love's sake! At one while I knew thee as *thief*
and *knight*, 125

Thou couldst serve, and thou couldst dissemble, for the sake
of thy lady bright.

Ah! could I steal love as thou couldst, if my skill were but
like to thine,

That women should show me favour, then a blissful lot were
mine!"

'Alas! that I ever saw thee,' spake, sighing, the king so true,
'Who lightly, with words of mocking, my heart would in
pieces hew 130

And would fain that we part asunder! One father hath left us
both

A mighty store of riches, I would share with thee, nothing
loth.

Right dear from my heart I hold thee; red gold and jewels
bright,
Folk, weapons, horse, and raiment, take thou as shall seem
thee right,
That thou at thy will mayst journey, and thy free hand to all
be known.¹³⁵
Elect do we deem thy manhood, didst thou Gylstram as
birthplace own,
Or thou camest here from Rankulat, yet still would that
place be thine,
Which thou boldest to-day in my favour; true brother art
thou of mine!'

'Sir King, thou of need must praise me, so great is thy
courtesy!
So, courteous, thine aid be given, if thou and my mother free
¹⁴⁰
Will share with me now your riches, I mount upward, nor
fear to fall,
And my heart ever beateth higher—Yet I know not how I
should call
This life, which my left breast swelleth! Ah! whither
wouldst go mine heart?
I would fain know where thou shalt guide me—'Tis time that
we twain should part.'

And all did the monarch give him, yea, more than the knight
might crave,¹⁴⁵
Five chargers, picked and chosen, the best in his land he
gave
High-couraged, swift to battle; and many a cup of gold,
And many a golden nugget, for naught would his hand
withhold.
Four chests for the road he gave him, with many a jewel rare
Were they filled. Then the squires he took him who should
for the treasure care,¹⁵⁰

And well were they clad and mounted; and none might his
grief withhold
When the knight gat him unto his mother, who her son in her
arms did fold.

Spake the woman, as woman grieving: 'Wilt thou tarry with
me no more,
King Gandein's son? Woe is me! yet my womb this burden
bore
And the son of my husband art thou. Is the eye of God
waxed blind, 155
Or His ear grown deaf in the hearing, that my prayer doth no
credence find?
Is fresh sorrow to be my portion? I have buried my heart's
desire,
And the light of mine eyes; will He rob me, who have
suffered a grief so dire,
Who judgeth with righteous judgment? Then the tale it hath
told a lie,
That spake of His help so mighty, Who doth help unto me
deny!' 160

'God comfort thee,' quoth the hero, 'for the death of my
father dear,
For truly we both must mourn him—But I think from no lips
to hear
Such wailing for my departing! As valour shall show the
way,
I seek knighthood in distant countries—So it standeth with
me to-day.'

Quoth the queen, 'Since to high love's service thou turnest
both hand and heart, 165
Sweet son, let it not displease thee to take of my wealth a
part
That may serve thee upon thy journey; let thy chamberlain
take from me

Four chests, each a pack-horse burden, and heavy their
weight shall be.

And within, uncut, there lieth rich silk of Orient rare,
No man as yet hath cut it, and many a samite fair. 170
Sweet son, I prithee tell me what time thou wilt come again,
That my joy may wax the greater, and I look for thee not in
vain!"

'Nay, that I know not, Lady, nor the land that shall see my
face,
But wherever I take my journey, thou hast shown unto me
such grace
As befitteth knightly honour: and the king he hath dealt with
me 175
In such wise that grateful service his rewarding shall ever
be.
And this trust have I, O Lady, that for this thou wilt love him
more
Henceforward, whate'er the future yet keepeth for me in
store.'
And as the venture telleth, to the hand of this dauntless
knight,
Thro' the favour he won from a woman, and the working of
true love's might, 180
Came a token fair, and its value was full thousand marks, I
trow,
E'en to-day an a Jew were craving a pledge, he would deem
enow
Such jewel, and ne'er disdain it—'Twas sent by his lady true,
And fame did he win in her service, and her love and her
greeting knew,
Yet seldom his pain found easing—Then the hero he took
his leave 185
Of mother, brother, and brother's kingdom, and many I ween
must grieve
Since his eyes never more beheld them. And all who his
friends had been,

Ere he passed from the land of his fathers, tho' the grace
were but small, I ween,
He gave them of thanks full measure; he deemed they too
much had done,
And, courteous, little thought him, that of right he their love
had won!190
Straighter his heart than straightness; did one of his praises
speak
In a full and fitting measure, then doubt were not far to seek,
But ask ye of those his neighbours, or of men who in distant
lands
Had seen his deeds, then the marvel ye were swifter to
understand.

And Gamuret he trode ever where Temperance aye should
guide, 195
And naught else might rule his doings, nor he boasted him in
his pride
But bare great honour meekly; from loose ways he e'er had
flown;
And he thought him, the gallant hero, that none bare on earth
a crown,
Were they King, or Queen, or Kaiser, whom he deemed of
his service worth
Were they not the mightiest reckoned of all monarchs that be
on earth.200
This will in his heart he cherished—Then men spake, at
Bagdad did reign
A monarch so strong and powerful, that homage he well
might claim
From two-thirds or more of earth's kingdoms. The heathen
his name held great,
And they spake of him as the Baruch, and kings did on his
bidding wait,
And crownèd heads were his servants; and his office it lasts
to-day—205

See how Christian men baptizèd to Rome wend their pilgrim
way,
So there was the heathen custom. At Bagdad was their papal
right,
And the Baruch as 'seemed his office purged their sins with
his word of might.

From Pompey and Ipomidon, two brothers of Babylon,
Nineveh, the town of their fathers, the Baruch with force had
won, 210
And bravely 'gainst him they battled. Then came the young
Angevin,
And the Baruch he showed him favour, yea, he did to his
service win
Gamuret the gallant hero—And he deemed it were well he
bore
Other arms than Gandein his father had given to him of
yore.
Then the hero he well bethought him; on his charger's cloth
they laid 215
An anchor of ermine fashioned, and the same at his will they
made
For shield alike and vesture—And green as the emerald rare
Was his riding-gear, and 'twas fashioned and wrought of
Achmardi fair,
('Tis a silken stuff,) and he bade them to make of it at his
will
Both blazoned coat and surcoat, (than velvet 'tis richer still;) 220
And he bade them to sew upon it the anchor of ermine
white,
And with golden threads inwoven was the badge of this
gallant knight.

And his anchors they never tested or mainland or haven fair
And found in that place abiding—But the hero must further
bear

Thro' many a land, a brave guest, the load of this heraldry,
225

And behind the sign of this anchor but short space might his
resting be,

And nowhere he found abiding—The tale of the lands he
saw,

And the vessels in which he sailed him? If the truth unto ye I
swore,

On mine own oath must I swear it, and my knightly honour
true

In such wise as the venture told me; other witness I never
knew! 230

And men say that his manly courage held the prize in far
heathendom,

In Morocco's land, and in Persia, and elsewhere he high
honour won,

At Damascus and at Aleppo, and where knightly deeds
should be:

In Arabia and lands around it was he held of all conflict free,
For no man might dare withstand him, he won him such
crown of fame;235

And his heart for honour lusted, and all deeds were brought
to shame,

And became as naught before him, as all men bare witness
true

Who a joust with him had ridden, and Bagdad of his glory
knew.

And his heart never failed or faltered, but onward his course
he bare

To Zassamank's land and kingdom; there all men wept that
hero fair,240

Eisenhart, who in knightly service gave his life for a
woman's smile;

Belakané thereto constrained him, sweet maid she, and free
from guile.

(Since her love she never gave him, for love's sake did the
hero die,)
And his kinsmen would fain avenge him, and with force and
with subtlety
Their armies beset the maiden, but in sooth she could guard
her well²⁴⁵
Ere Gamuret came to her kingdom, and her wrath on her
foemen fell.
For the Prince Friedebrand of Scotland, and his host that
against her came
By ship, ere he left her kingdom had she wasted with fire
and flame.

Now hear what befell our hero; storm-driven he was that
day,
And scarce might he win to safety, and his boat in the haven
lay ²⁵⁰
Beneath the royal palace; and the folk they beheld him there,
And he looked around on the meadow, and he saw many
tents stand fair
Around the town, save the sea-coast, and two armies he
thought to see.
Then he bade them to tell the story, and whose that fair Burg
should be?
Since he knew it not, nor his shipmen—And an answer they
straightway gave,²⁵⁵
'Twas Patelamunt; then the townsfolk a boon from the knight
would crave,
And their speech it was soft and friendly—In the name of
their gods they'd pray
He should help them, so great their peril that in danger of
death they lay.

When the young Angevin had hearkened to the tale of their
bitter pain,
He proffered to them his service for such payment as knight
may gain,²⁶⁰

(As it oft shall befit a hero)—They should say for what
 goodly prize
He should dare the hate of their foemen? And they answered
 him in this wise
With one mouth the hale and the wounded—Naught would
 they from him withhold,
But lord should he be of their treasure, of their jewels alike
 and gold,
A fair life should he lead among them!—But such payment
 he little sought,265
For many a golden nugget from Araby had he brought.
And dark as night were the people who in Zassamank dwelt
 always—
And the time it seemed long unto him that he need in their
 midst must stay—
But he bade them prepare a lodging, and methinks it became
 them well
The best of their land to give him, since awhile he with them
 would dwell.270
And the women they looked from the windows, and they
 gazed on the noble knight,
And they looked on his squires, and his harness, how 'twas
 fashioned for deeds of might.
Then they saw how the knight, free-handed, on his shield of
 ermine bare
Full many a pelt of sable; the Queen's Marshal he read it
 fair,
The badge, for a mighty anchor, and little he rued the sight,
 275
If his eye spake the truth unto him ere this had he seen the
 knight,
Or one who bare his semblance—At Alexandria it needs
 must be,
When the Baruch besieged the city—and unequalled in strife
 was he!

So rode the gallant hero, in stately guise and meet;

Ten pack-horses heavy-laden they led first adown the street,
280

And twenty squires behind them; and his people they went
before,

And lackeys, cooks, and cook-boys, at the head of the train
they saw.

And stately I ween his household, twelve pages of lineage
high

Rode next to the squires, well-mannered, and trained in all
courtesy,

And Saracens were among them; and behind them in order
fair 285

Came chargers eight, and a covering of sendal did each one
bear.

But the ninth it bore a saddle, and the shield ye have known
ere now

Was borne by a squire beside it, and joyful his mien, I trow.

And trumpeters rode behind it, for in sooth they must needs
be there,

And a drummer he smote his tambour, and swung it aloft in
air. 290

And as naught had the hero deemed it, this pomp, if there
failed to ride

Men who on the flute were skilful, and three fiddlers were at
their side,

And they hasted not nor hurried; and behind them the hero
came,

And his shipman he rode beside him, a wise man of goodly
fame.

And much folk was within the city, and Moors were both
man and maid.295

Then the hero he looked around him, and, lo! many a shield
displayed,

Battle-hewn and with spear-thrust piercèd they hung on each
wall and door.

And wailing and woe was their portion; for the knight at
each window saw
Many men lie sorely wounded, who to breathe the air were
fain,
And e'en tho' a leech might tend them no help might they
think to gain³⁰⁰
Who were hurt too sore for healing—In the field had they
faced the foe,
And such shall be their rewarding who in conflict no flight
will know—
Many horses were led towards him, sword-hewn and with
lance thrust through;
And on each side stood dusky maidens, and black as the
night their hue.

Then his host gave him kindly greeting—and of joy did he
reap his meed—³⁰⁵
A rich man was he and mighty, and many a knightly deed
With thrust and blow had his hand wrought when his post at
the gate he found;
And many a knight was with him, and bandaged their heads
and bound,
And their hands in slings were holden; yet tho' sorely
wounded still
They did many deeds of knighthood, nor were lacking in
strength and skill.³¹⁰

Then the Burg-grave of the city, with fair words did he pray
his guest
To deal with him and his household in such wise as should
seem him best.
And the host, he led the hero to his wife, and courteously
Did Gamuret kiss the lady, small joy in the kiss had he!
Then they sat them down to the table, and e'en as the feast
was o'er,³¹⁵
The Marshal he gat him swiftly to the queen, and the tidings
bore,

And craved from her goodly payment, as to messenger shall
be due.

And he spake, 'It shall end in gladness, the grief that
erewhile we knew,

We have welcomed here, O Lady, a knight of such gallant
mien,

We must thank the gods who have sent him, for our need
they have surely seen.'320

'Now tell me upon thine honour who this gallant knight may
be?'

'Lady, a dauntless hero, and the Baruch's man is he,
An Angevin he, of high lineage; Ah me! little did he spare
Himself, when his foemen seeking he forth to the field
would fare.

How wisely, with skill and cunning, he avoided the
threatening blow,325

And turned him again to the onslaught! Much sorrow he
wrought his foe—

Ere this have I seen him battle, when the princes of Babylon
Their city of Alexandria had fain from the Baruch won,
And with force from its walls would drive him, and many a
man lay dead

In the overthrow of their army, for their venture was but ill-
sped.330

And such deeds did he do, this hero, that no counsel was
theirs but flight:

And there did I hear his praises, for all spake of this gallant
knight

As one who, without denial, had won him, in many a land,
The crown of true knightly honour, by the strength of his
own right hand.

'Now fain would I speak with the hero, see thou to the time
and way;335

E'en now might he ride to the castle, for peace shall be kept
to-day.

Were it better that I should seek him? He is other than we in
face,
Pray Heaven it not displease him, but our need with the
knight find grace!
I would that I first might know this, ere the rede from my
folk I hear
That I show to this stranger honour—If it pleaseth him to
draw near,340
Say, how shall I best receive him? Shall the knight be so
nobly born
That my kiss be not lost, if I kiss him?' 'Nay, hold me of life
forsworn
If he be not of kings the kinsman! Lady, this word I'll bear
To thy princes, that they shall clothe them in raiment both fit
and fair,
And stand before thee, in due order, ere yet to thy court we
ride, 345
And the same shalt thou say to thy ladies—In the city he
doth abide;
I will ride below, and will bring him to thy palace, a worthy
guest,
For no fair or knightly virtue shall be lacking that noble
breast.'

But little space they delayed them, for the Marshal, with
ready skill,
Strove that all in such wise be ordered as should pleasure his
lady's will.350
But soon did they bear to the hero rich garments, he did
them on,
And this hath the venture told me that their cost should be
hardly won;
And thereon lay the anchors, heavy, and wrought of Arabian
gold,
For so had he willed. Then the hero, who fair payment for
love had told

A charger bestrode that 'fore Babylon a knight rode, for
 jousting fain,355
From the saddle did Gamuret smite him, and I wot it hath
 wrought him pain.

If his host thought to ride beside him? He and his gallant
 knights?
Yea, in sooth they would do so, gladly—So wended they up
 the height,
And dismounted before the palace; and many a knight stood
 there,
And each, as was fit, had clothed him in raiment both rich
 and fair.360
And his pages they ran before him, and each twain they
 went hand in hand,
And in marvellous fair arraying he saw many ladies stand.
And the queen, her eyes brought her sorrow as she looked
 on the Angevin,
So lovely was he to look on that he needs must an entrance
 win
Thro' the gates of her heart, if 'twere anguish or joy that
 within he bore,365
Tho' her womanhood 'gainst all comers had held them fast
 closed before.

Then a space did she step towards him, and a kiss from her
 guest she prayed;
And, herself, by the hand she took him and they sat them,
 both man and maid
In a window wide, that looked forth from the palace upon
 the foe,
And a covering of wadded samite was spread o'er the couch
 below. 370
Is there aught that than day is lighter? Then it likeneth not
 the queen!
Yet else was she fair to look on, as a woman should be, I
 ween,

But unlike to the dew-dipped roses was her colour, yea,
black as night.

And her crown was a costly ruby, and thro' it ye saw aright
Her raven head. Then as hostess she spake to her guest this
word, 375

That greatly she joyed at his coming, 'Sir, Knight, I such tale
have heard

Of thy knightly strength and prowess—Of thy courtesy, hear
me fair,

For fain would I tell of my sorrow, and the woe that my
heart doth bear!'

'My help shall not fail thee, Lady! What hath grieved, or
doth grieve thee now,

I think me aside to turn it, to thy service my hand I vow! 380

I am naught but one man only—Who hath wronged or now
wrongeth thee

My shield will I hold against him—Little wroth shall thy
foeman be!'

Then a prince he spake out courteous, 'The foe would we
little spare,

Did our host not lack a captain, since Friedebrand hence
must fare.

He defendeth afar his kingdom—A king, one Hernant by
name 385

(Whom he slew for the sake of Herlindè) his kinsmen
against him came,

And evil enow have they wrought him, nor yet from their
strife forbear—

Yet he left here full many a hero, and among them, Duke
Heuteger

With his gallant deeds of knighthood, and his army, hath
pressed us sore,

They have skill and strength for the conflict. And many a
soldier more 390

With Gaschier of Normandy came here, and a hero wise is
he.

Many knights hath he brought to this country (and wrathful
guests they be):

Kailet of Hoscurast. All these hath he brought upon our fair
land

With his comrades four, and his soldiers, the Scottish king
Friedebrand!

And there, to the West, by the sea-coast doth Eisenhart's
army lie,395

And their eyes shall be fain for weeping; nor in secret, nor
openly

Hath one seen them, and failed to marvel at their grief and
their sorrow sore,

Since their lord hath been slain in battle with the heart's rain
their eyes run o'er.'

Then the guest courteous spake to his hostess, 'I would, an it
seem thee right,

Thou shouldst say why thy foeman threaten, why they seek
thee with war-like might!400

Thou hast here many gallant heroes, it grieveth me sore to
see

Thy land thus with hate o'erladen, for woe must it bring to
thee.'

'Wouldst thou know? Then, Sir Knight, I will tell thee—A
knight did me service true,

And the fruit of all manly virtue his life as its decking knew,
And gallant and wise was the hero, and his faith as a goodly
tree 405

Was fast-rooted, and none so courteous but were shamed by
his courtesy.

And modest was he as a woman, tho' dauntless and strong, I
trow,

And a knight e'en as he free-handed ere his day never land
might know.

(But they that shall come hereafter, other folk shall their
doings see.)

A fool was he in false dealing, and a Moor, as myself shall
be; 410

And his father's name was Tánkaneis, a king of a kingly
heart,

And his son, he who was my lover, men knew him as
Eisenhart.

That for love's sake I took his service, as a woman I did not
well,

It hath brought me but lasting sorrow since no joy to his
portion fell,

They deem I to death betrayed him! Yet such treason were
far from me, 415

Tho' his folk bring such charge against me; and dear to my
heart was he,

Far dearer than *they* e'er held him. Nor witnesses here shall
fail

To speak to the truth of my saying, if it please them to tell
the tale.

His gods and mine, they know it, the truth—I must sorrow
deep

Since my womanly shame hath brought him a guerdon I
needs must weep! 420

'Thus he won in my maiden service much honour by
knighthood fair,

I thought thus to prove my lover; his deeds did his worth
declare.

For my sake he put off his harness (that which like to a hall
doth stand

Is a lofty tent, the Scotch folk they brought it into this land),
Then e'en tho' he bare no armour his body he little spared,
425

For he held his life as worthless, many ventures unarmed he
dared.

As the matter so stood between us, a prince who my man
should be,
Prothizilas did men call him, a bold knight, from all
cowardice free,
Rode forth in search of venture, and evil for him that day
For there, in Assagog's forest, his death in waiting lay. 430
In a knightly joust he met it, and there too he found his end
The gallant knight who faced him—'Twas Prince Eisenhart
my friend.
For both of the twain were piercèd with a spear thro' heart
and shield,
And I, alas! poor woman, must weep for that fatal field.
And ever their death doth grieve me, and sorrow from love
shall grow, 435
And never henceforth as my husband a man do I think to
know.'

Then e'en tho' she was a heathen Gamuret he bethought him
well,
That a heart more true and tender ne'er in woman's breast
might dwell.
Her purity was her baptism, and as water that washed her
o'er
Was the rain that streamed from her eyelids o'er her breast,
and the robe she wore; 440
All her joy did she find in sorrow, and grief o'er her life did
reign—
Then the queen she looked on the hero, and in this wise she
spake again:

'With his army the king of Scotland hath sought me across
the sea,
For the knight was son to his uncle; yet no ill can he do to
me,
If here the truth be spoken, that is worse than the grief I
knew 445
For Eisenhart's death!' and sorely she sighed that lady true;

And many a glance thro' her tear-drops on Gamuret shyly
fell,
And her eyes to her heart gave counsel, and his beauty it
pleased her well,
(And she knew how to judge a fair face, since fair heathen
she oft had seen,)
And the root of true love and longing it sprang up the twain
between.⁴⁵⁰
She looked upon him, and his glances, they answering
sought her own—
Then she bade them to fill the wine-cup, had she dared, it
were left undone,
And she grieved she might not delay it, since to many a hero
brave
Who spake with the maids this wine-cup the signal of
parting gave.
Yet her body was e'en as his body, and his look did such
courage give⁴⁵⁵
To the maid, that she thought henceforward in the life of the
knight to live.

Then he stood upright, and he spake thus, 'Lady, I weary
thee,
Too long methinks do I sit here, I were lacking in courtesy!
As befitting true knight and servant I mourn for thy woe so
great,
Lady, do thou command me, I will on thy bidding wait. ⁴⁶⁰
Wherever thou wilt, there I wend me. I will serve thee in all
I may!'
And the lady she quoth in answer, 'I believe thee, Sir Knight,
alway!'

Then his kindly host the Burg-grave, of his labour would
nothing spare
Lest the hours of his stay be heavy; and he asked if he forth
would fare,

And ride round the walls of the city? 'The battle-field shalt
thou see,465
And how we would guard our portals!' then Gamuret
courteously
Made answer, he fain would see it, the field where they late
had fought,
And the place where brave deeds of knighthood had by
gallant hands been wrought.

And noble knights rode with him adown from the palace
hall,
Some were wise, some were young and foolish,—So rode
they around the wall470
To sixteen gates, and they told him not one of them might
they close
Since Eisenhart's death called for vengeance—'So wrathful
shall be our foes
Our conflict it resteth never, but we fight both by night and
day,
Nor our portals since then we fasten, but open they stand
always.
At eight of our gates they beset us, true Eisenhart's gallant
knights,475
And evil shall they have wrought us; spurred by anger each
man doth fight,
The princes of lofty lineage, the king of Assagog's ban!'
And there floated before each portal a banner, so pale and
wan,
With a pierced knight upon it. When Eisenhart lost his life
His folk chose to them this symbol, as badge in the coming
strife. 480
'But against these arms have we others, wherewith we their
grief would still,
And thus shalt thou know our banner; 'twas wrought at our
lady's will,
Two fingers in oath she stretcheth, that never such grief she
knew

As Eisenhart's death hath brought her (true sorrow for heart
so true),
And so doth it stand the semblance of our queen, on a samite
white 485
Belakané in sable fashioned,—Since against us they came in
might,
(To avenge him for whom she sorrows) so she looks from
our portals high.
And proud Friedebrand's mighty army doth to eight of our
gates stand nigh,
Baptized men, from o'er the waters. A prince doth each
portal hold,
And forth from the gate he sallies, with his banners and
warriors bold.'490

'From the host of Gaschier the Norman, a count have we
captive ta'en,
And heavy methinks the ransom we may hope from that
knight to gain;
He is sister's son to Kaillet, and the harm *he* to us hath done
His nephew I ween shall pay for! Yet such prize have we
seldom won.
Here have we no grassy meadow, but sand, thirty gallops
wide 495
Betwixt the tents and the trenches; here many a joust we
ride.

And further his host would tell him, 'One knight, he doth
never fail
To ride forth, a fair joust seeking. (If his service shall nought
avail
With her who hath sent him hither, what boots it how well
he fight?)
Proud Heuteger is the hero, of him may I speak with right
500
For since our besiegers threaten there dawneth never a day

But before the gates 'neath the castle, that knight doth his
charger stay.
And oft from that dauntless hero many tokens we needs
must bear,
That he smote through our shields at his spear-point, and
costly their worth and rare
When the squire from the shield doth break them. Many
knights 'fore his joust must fall;505
He would that all men may behold him, and our women they
praise him all.
And he who is praised of women, one knoweth that he doth
hold
The prize in his hand, and his heart's joy in full measure
shall aye be told!'

But now would the sun, grown weary, its wandering rays
recall;
'Twas time that the ride was ended—Then he sought with his
host the hall,510
And the evening meal was ready; and I needs of that feast
must tell,
'Twas laid in a fitting order, and knightly 'twas served, and
well.
And the queen with mien so stately she unto his table came,
(Here stood the fish, there the heron) and she counted it not
for shame
To ride adown from her palace, that herself she might be
aware 515
If they cared for the guest as 'twas fitting, and with her rode
her maidens fair.
Low she knelt (and but ill it pleased him) and cut as it
seemed her best
For the knight a fitting portion; she was glad in her goodly
guest.
And she filled for him the wine-cup, and care for his needs
would take,

And well did he mark, the hero, her mien, and the words she
spake. 520

And his fiddlers sat at the table, and over against the knight
Was his chaplain: with shy looks shamefast, he spake to the
lady bright:

'I looked not to find such welcome as, Lady, thou gavest me,
Too much must I deem the honour! If rede I might give to
thee,

Then to-day I had claimed naught from thee save was due to
my worth alone, 525

Nor adown the hill hadst thou ridden, nor such service to me
hadst shown.

And, Lady, if I may venture to make unto thee request,
Let me live but as best befits me, thou dost honour o'ermuch
thy guest!'

Yet her kindly care she stayed not; for she stept to his page's
seat

And with gentle words and friendly she prayed them to
freely eat, 530

This she did her guest to honour: and the noble lads, I trow,
Bare goodwill to the royal lady. Nor the queen methinks was
slow

To pass where the host was seated and his lady, the Burg-
gravine,

And she raised the golden goblet, and she spake as should fit
a queen:

'Now unto your care I give him, our guest, and I rede ye both
535

Since the honour is yours, to hearken, and do my will
nothing loth!'

And she bade them farewell, and she turned her, and passed
to her guest once more,

Whose heart for her sake was heavy; and such sorrow for
him she bore,

And her heart and her eyes they answered, and they spake to
her sorrow yea!

And courteous she spake, the lady, 'Sir Knight, thou the
word shalt say, 540

And whate'er be thy will, I will do it, for I hold thee a
worthy guest.

Now give me, I pray, dismissal; if here thou in peace shalt
rest,

Of that shall we all be joyful.' Her torch-holders were of
gold,

And four tapers they bare before her, so she rode to her
fortress-hold.

Nor long at the board they lingered—The hero was sad, and
gay, 545

He was glad for the honour done him, yet a sorrow upon him
lay,

And that was strong Love's compelling, that a proud heart
and courage high

Can bend to her will, and gladness shall oft at her bidding
fly.

Then the hostess she passed to her chamber, yea, e'en as the
meal was o'er;

And a couch did they spread for the hero, and love to the
labour bore. 550

And the host to his guest spake kindly, 'Now here shall thy
sleep be sweet,

Thou shalt rest thro' the night that cometh, to thy need shall
such rest be meet.'

Then he spake to his men, and he bade them they should
hence from the hall away,

And the noble youths his pages, their couches around his lay
Each one with the head toward his master, for so was the
custom good; 555

And tapers so tall and flaming alight round the chamber
stood.

Yet ill did it please the hero that so long were the hours of
night,
For the Moorish queen so dusky, had vanquished his heart of
might.
And he turned as a willow wand bendeth, till his joints they
were heard to crack,
The strife and the love that he craved for he deemed he o'er-
long did lack.560
And his heart-beats they echoed loudly, as it swelled high
for knighthood fain,
And he stretched himself as an archer who bendeth a bow
amain.
And so eager his lust for battle that sleepless the hero lay
Till he saw the grey light of morning, though as yet it should
scarce be day.
And his chaplain for Mass was ready, and to God and the
knight they sing,565
For so did he give commandment. Then he bade them his
harness bring,

And he rode where a joust should wait him, and that self-
same hour would ride
A horse that could charge the foeman, and turn swiftly to
either side,
And answer to bit and bridle if its rider would backward
draw.
And the watchers, both man and woman, his helm in the
gateway saw, 570
And the anchor shone fair upon it; and no man ere this might
see
So wondrous fair a hero, for like to a god was he!

And strong spears they bare for his using—How then was he
decked, the knight?
With iron was his charger covered, as should serve for a
shield in fight,

And above lay another covering, nor heavy methinks it
weighed, 575
'Twas a samite green; and his surcoat and blazoned coat
were made
Of Achmardi, green to look on, and in Araby fashioned fair,
And no lie I tell, but the shield-thongs that the weight of the
shield should bear
Were of silk and gold untarnished, and jewel-bedecked their
pride,
And the boss of the shield was covered with red gold, in the
furnace tried.580
He served but for love's rewarding; sharp conflict he held it
light;
And the queen she looked from her window, with many a
lady bright.
And see, there Heuteger held him, who the prize ne'er had
failed to gain;
When he saw the knight draw nearer, in swift gallop across
the plain,
He thought, 'Now whence came this Frenchman? Who hither
this knight hath sent?585
If a *Moor* I had thought this hero, my wit were to madness
bent!'

No whit they delayed the onslaught, from gallop to swifter
flight
Each man spurred amain his charger; and as fitting a valiant
knight
Nor one would evade the other, but would meet him in
jousting fair,
From brave Heuteger's spear the splinters flew high thro' the
summer air,590
But his foeman so well withstood him that he thrust him
from off his steed
Adown on the grass; but seldom might he win for his joust
such meed!

And his foe in his course rode o'er him, and trode him unto
the ground,
Yet he sprang up again, and valiant, fresh lust for the strife
he found,
But Gamuret's lance had pierced him thro' the arm, and he
bade him yield,595
And he knew he had found his master, and he spake from the
foughten field,
'Now who shall have o'erthrown me?' and the victor he
swiftly spake,
'Gamuret Angevin do men call me!' then he quoth, 'Thou my
pledge canst take!'

Then his pledge the knight took, and straightway he sent him
within the wall,
And much praise did he win from the women who looked
from the castle hall.600
And swiftly there came towards him, Gaschier of Normandy,
A proud and wealthy hero and mighty in strife was he.
And Gamuret made him ready, for a second joust he'd ride,
And strong and new was his spear-shaft, and the iron was
both sharp and wide,
And the strangers they faced each other—But unequal their
lot, I trow,605
For Gaschier and his gallant charger full swiftly were they
laid low,
And the knight with his arms and harness he fell in the
shock of strife;
If he thought it for good or for evil, by his pledge must he
win his life.

Then Gamuret quoth, the hero, 'Thou hast pledged unto me
thine hand,
Yet the weapon it well hath wielded! Ride thou to the
Scottish band,610
And bid them to cease from troubling; if they to thy will are
fain,

Thou canst follow me to the city.' Then the knight hied him
o'er the plain.

If he prayed them, or gave commandment, they did at the
last his will,

And the Scottish host they rested, and from conflict they
held them still.

Then Kaillet spurred swift towards him, but Gamuret turned
his rein,615

His cousin he was, and near kinsman, why then bring him
grief and pain?

And the Spaniard cried loudly on him; on his helm he an
ostrich bare,

And so far as I know to tell ye the knight he was decked so
fair

With silken raiment goodly, and long were his robes and
wide,

And the plain rang clear with the chiming of sweet bells as
he o'er it hied.620

The flower he of manly beauty, and his fairness it held the
field,

Save for two who should come hereafter, and his fame unto
theirs must yield;

But Parzival and brave Beaucorps, King Lot's son, they are
not here,

Not yet were they born, but hereafter for their beauty men
held them dear!

Then Gaschier he grasped his bridle. 'Now checked will it be
thy race,625

So I tell thee upon mine honour, if the Angevin thou shalt
face

Who there my pledge hath taken. Sir Knight, thou shalt list
my prayer

And hearken unto my counsel; in Gamuret's hand I swear
From strife aside to turn thee: stay thy steed then for my
sake,

For mighty is he in conflict!' Then aloud King Kaillet spake,
630
'Is he Gamuret my cousin, and son unto King Gandein?
Then I care not with him to battle, no foe shall he be of
mine!
Take thine hand from off my bridle'—'Nay, further thou shalt
not fare
Till mine eyes have first beheld thee, with thine head of the
helmet bare,
For *mine* with blows is deafened!' Then his helmet the
prince unbound.635
And yet, tho' with him he fought not, Gamuret other foemen
found.

And the day had grown to high morning—And the folk who
the joust might see
Were glad at heart, and they gat them to their bulwarks right
speedily,
For he was as a net before them, and none might escape his
hold.
And he chose him another charger, so the tale unto me was
told, 640
And it flew, and the earth it spurnèd, and its work could
aright fulfil,
Bold when the knight would battle, yet its speed could he
check at will.
And what would he do the rider? His valour I praise alway,
For he rode where the Moorish army to the west by the sea-
coast lay.

Thence a prince, Rassalig men called him, forgot not each
coming morn645
(He was Assagog's richest hero, to riches and honour born
Since he came of a royal lineage) to take from the camp his
way
He would fain joust before the city—But his strength it was
quelled that day

By Anjou's dauntless hero; and a dusky maid made moan
(Since 'twas she who sent him hither) that her knight should
be thus o'erthrown.650

For a squire brought, without his bidding, to his master,
brave Gamuret,
A spear, with light reed-shaft fashioned, and its point 'gainst
the Moor he set,
And with it he smote the paynim from his steed down upon
the sand,
Nor longer he bade him lie there than as surety he pledged
his hand.

So the strife it had found its ending, and the hero had won
him fame;655

Then Gamuret saw eight banners toward the city that
onward came,
And he bade the conquered hero the force with his word to
stay,
And follow him to the city. And that word must he needs
obey.

Nor Gaschier delayed his coming; and unto the Burg-grave
told

How his guest sought for further conflict nor his wrath
might the host withhold.660

If he swallowed not iron as an ostrich, nor his wrath did on
stones assuage

'Twas but that he might not find them! Then he gnashed his
teeth for rage,

And he growled as a mighty lion, and the hair of his head he
tare,

And he quoth, 'So the years of my lifetime a harvest of folly
bear,

The gods they had sent to my keeping a valiant and worthy
friend, 665

If with strife he shall be o'erladen, then mine honour hath
found an end;

Sword and shield they shall little profit—Yea, shame he
would on me cast
Who should bring this to my remembrance!' Then swift from
his place he passed,
And he gat him into the portal, and a squire towards him
drew,
And he bare a shield that was painted with a knight by a
spear pierced thro',⁶⁷⁰
In Eisenhart's land was it fashioned; and a helmet his hand
must hold,
And a sword that Rassalig carried in battle, that heathen
bold,
But now was he parted from it whose fame was in every
place;
Were he slain unbaptized I think me, God had shown to this
hero grace!

And e'en as the Burg-grave saw it, ne'er of yore was his joy
so great,⁶⁷⁵
For the coat-of-arms he knew it—So he rode thro' the city
gate,
And without, his guest had halted, young hero he, not yet
old,
As one of a joust desirous, and his bridle the Burg-grave
bold,
Lahfilirost was his name, he grasped it, and he led him
within the wall;
And I wot well no other foeman that day 'neath his spear
must fall.⁶⁸⁰

Quoth Lahfilirost the Burg-grave, 'Sir Knight, thou shalt tell
to me
If thine hand Rassalig hath vanquished?' 'Then our land from
all strife is free;
For he of the Moors is chieftain, the men of true Eisenhart
Who have brought unto us such sorrow—But now shall our
woe depart,

'Twas a wrathful god who bade him thus seek us with all his
host, 685
But his weapons to naught are smitten, and to folly is turned
his boast!
Then he led him in (ill it pleased him) and there met then the
royal maid,
And she loosened the bands of his vizor, and her hand on his
bridle laid,
To her care must the Burg-grave yield it: nor his squires to
their task were slack,
For they turned them about, and swiftly they rode on their
master's track.690
So men saw the queen so gracious lead her guest thro' the
city street
Who here should be hailed the victor—Then she lighted her
on her feet,
'Ah me! but thy squires are faithful! Fear ye lest your lord be
lost?
Without ye shall he be cared for; take his steed, here am I his
host!'

And above found he many a maiden: then her hands of
dusky hue 695
The queen set unto his harness, and disarmed the knight so
true.
And the bed-covering was of sable, and the couch it was
spread so fair,
And in secret a hidden honour they did for the knight
prepare,
For no one was there to witness—The maidens they might
not stay,
And the door was fast closed behind them, and Frau Minne
might have her way.700
So the queen in the arms of her true love found guerdon of
sweet delight,
Tho' unlike were the twain in their colour, Moorish princess
and Christian knight!

Then the townsfolk brought many an offering to the gods
who had seen their woe.
That which Rassalig needs must promise ere he from the
field might go
That he did, in all truth and honour, yet heavy was he at
heart, 705
And afresh sprang the fount of his sorrow for his prince
gallant Eisenhart.
And the Burg-grave he heard of his coming; then loud rang
the trumpet call,
And no man of Zassamank's princes but came to the palace
hall.
They gave Gamuret thanks for the honour he had won in the
field that day,
Four-and-twenty had fallen before him, and their chargers he
bore away, 710
And three chieftains had he made captive. And there rode in
the princes' train
Many gallant knights, in the courtyard of the palace did they
draw rein.
And the hero had slept and eaten, and clad him in raiment
fair,
Chief host was he, for his body fit garments would they
prepare.
And she who afore was a maiden but now was a wife would
take 715
Her lord by the hand, forth she led him, and unto her princes
spake:
'My body and this my kingdom are vassals unto this knight,
If so be that his foemen fearing, resist not his hand of might!'

Then Gamuret spake, and his bidding was courteous, for
hero meet,
Sir Rassalig, go thou nearer, with a kiss thou my wife shalt
greet; 720
And Sir Gaschier, thou shalt do likewise.' Then the Scotch
knight proud Heuteger

He bade on the lips to kiss her (and the wounds won in joust
he bare).

Then he bade them all be seated, and standing, he wisely
spake:

'I were fain to behold my kinsman, if he who did captive
take

The knight shall have naught against it—As kinsman it
seemeth me 725

That I find here no other counsel save straightway to set him
free!'

Then the queen she smiled, and bade them go swiftly and
seek the knight,

And then thro' the throng he pressed him, that count so fair
and bright,

Yet bare he the wounds of knighthood, and bravely and well
had fought;

With the host of Gaschier the Norman the land of the Moors
he sought.730

He was courteous; his sire a Frenchman he was Kailet's
sister's son,

Killirjacac his name; in the service of fair women fair meed
he won,

And the fairest of men they deemed him. When Gamuret
saw his face

(For like were they each to the other, as men of a kindred
race)

He bade his queen to kiss him and embrace him as kinsman
true, 735

And he spake, 'Now come thou and greet me!' and the knight
to his arms he drew,

And he kissed him, and each was joyful that the other he
here might meet:

And Gamuret quoth unto him, 'Alas! cousin fair and sweet,
What doth thy young strength in this conflict? Say, if woman
hath sent thee here?'

'Nay, never a woman sent me, with my cousin I came,
Gaschier, 740
He knoweth why he hath brought me—A thousand men
have I,
And I do to him loyal service—To Rouen in Normandy
I came, where his force was gathered, and many a youthful
knight
I brought from Champagne in mine army; 'neath his banner
we fain would fight.
Now evil hath turned against him what of cunning is hers
and skill, 745
Thou wilt honour thyself if thou free him for my sake, and
cure his ill!
'Thyself shalt fulfil thy counsel! Go thou, take with thee
Gaschier,
I would fain see my kinsman Kaillet, do thou bring him unto
me here!'
So they wrought out the host's desiring, and brought him at
his behest,
And in loving wise and kindly did Gamuret greet his guest;
750
And oft times the queen embraced him, and kissed him with
kisses sweet:
And nothing it wronged her honour in such wise the prince
to greet,
He was cousin unto her husband, by birth was himself a
king.
Then smiling his host spake to him, 'God knows, 'twere an
evil thing,
Had I taken from thee Toledo, and thy goodly land of Spain
755
For Gascony's king, who wrathful doth plague thee with
strife amain;
'Twere faithless of me, Sir Kaillet, since mine aunt's son thou
sure shalt be;
The bravest of knights shall be with thee; say, who forced
this strife on thee?'

Then out spake the proud young hero, 'My cousin Schiltung
bade
(Since his daughter Friedebrand wedded) that I lend to the
king mine aid.760
For the sake of his wife hath he won him, yea even from me
alone
Six thousand chosen heroes, who valour and skill have
shown.
And other men did I bring him, but a part they shall hence
have sailed,
For the Scottish folk came they hither, brave bands who in
strife ne'er failed.
And there came to his aid from Greenland, strong heroes
who bravely fought,765
Two mighty kings, and a torrent of knighthood with them
they brought,
And many a goodly vessel: and they pleased me, those men
of might—
And here for his sake came Morhold, who hath cunning and
skill in fight.'

'But now have they turned them homewards, and that which
the queen shall say
Even that will I do with mine army, her servant am I alway!
770
Thou shalt thank me not for this service, from kinsman 'twas
due, I ween.
Now *thine* are these gallant heroes, if like mine they
baptized had been
And were even as they in colour, then never a monarch
crowned
But if they should fight against him, of conflict his fill had
found!
But I marvel what here hath brought thee? Say, how didst
thou reach this strand?'775
'Yestreen I came, and this morning I am lord o'er this goodly
land!

The queen by the hand she took me, and with love I myself
would shield,
For so did my wit give counsel—' 'Yea, so hast thou won the
field,
Those sweet weapons two hosts have vanquished!' 'Thou
wouldst say, since I fled from *thee*,
So loudly on me thou calledst, say, what wouldst thou force
from me?780
Let us speak of the thing in friendship!' 'Thine anchor I
failed to know,
But seldom mine aunt's brave husband Gandein, did such
token show!'
'But I, I knew well thine ostrich with the snake's head upon
thy breast,
Aloft stood thy bird so stately, nor hid it within a nest!'

'And I saw in thy mien and bearing that that pledge would
have 'seemed thee ill785
Which two heroes afore had given, tho' first had they fought
their fill.'
'E'en such fate as theirs were my portion—But this thing I
needs must say,
Tho' little I like a devil, were he victor as thou this day
For love of his gallant doings the women had deemed him
sweet,
Yea, as sugar were fain to eat him!' 'Now thou praisest me
more than meet!'790
'Nay, of flattery know I little, thou shalt see that I hold thee
dear
In other wise!' Then the hero bade Rassalig draw anear.

And courteous he spake, King Kaillet, 'My kinsman with
valiant hand
Hath made of thee here his captive?' 'Yea, Sire, so the thing
doth stand,
And I hold him for such a hero that Assagog's kingdom fair
795

Should fail not to yield him homage, since the crown he may
never wear,
Our prince Eisenhart! In her service was he slain who shall
now be wife
To thy kinsman, as knight so faithful he gave for her love his
life.
With my kiss have I sealed forgiveness, yet my lord and my
friend I lost!
If thy cousin by knightly dealing will repay of his death the
cost 800
I will fold my hands as his vassal: and wealth shall be his
and fame,
All that Eisenhart from Tánkaneis as his heritage thought to
claim.
Embalmed here the hero lieth, and I gaze on his wounds
each day
Since this spear thro' his true heart piercing, my lord and my
king did slay!'

Then he drew it forth from his bosom by a silken cord so
fine, 805
And the heroes saw the spear-blade 'neath his robe on his
bare chest shine.
And he quoth, 'It is now high morning, if my lord Sir
Killirjacac
My token will bear to my princes, with him will the knights
ride back.'
And a finger-ring he sent them: dark as hell were those
heroes all
And they rode who were there of princes, thro' the town to
the castle hall.810
As his vassals he gave with their banners to Assagog's lords
their land,
And each one rejoiced in the fiefdom he won from his ruler's
hand,
But the better part was his portion, Gamuret's, as their lord
and king.

And these were the first—as they passed hence their homage
they fain would bring
The princes of Zassamank's kingdom, and they came in their
order due,815
And each as their queen had bade them, they took from his
hand anew
Their land, and the fruit it should bear them, as to each man
was fit and right,
And poverty fled from his presence. Now he who was slain
in fight
And in life was a prince by lineage, Prothizilas, he had left
A Dukedom fair, and this country which was thus of its lord
bereft 820
He gave unto him who much honour had won by his strong
right hand,
The Burg-grave, in combat dauntless—With its banners he
took the land.

Then Assagog's noble princes took the Scotch Duke, proud
Heuteger,
And Gaschier, the Norman hero, to their lord did they lead
them there,
And he spake them free for their asking, and they thanked
brave Gamuret.825
Then Heuteger of Scotland with prayers did these knights
beset,
'Now give to our lord the armour, as prize for his deeds so
brave,
That Eisenhart's life took from us, when to Friedebrand he
gave
That which was of our land the glory—Forfeit of joy the
knight,
And dead on his bier he lieth, since no love might his love
requite—'830
And earth knoweth naught so goodly, the helm it was strong
and hard,
Yea even of diamond fashioned, in battle a goodly guard.

Then Heuteger sware unto them, if the land of his lord he
saw
He would pray of his hand the armour, and send it to them
once more.

And this did he swear them freely—Then leave would the
princes pray⁸³⁵
Who stood in the royal presence, and they wend from the
hall their way.
And tho' sorely the land was wasted, yet Gamuret scattered
free
Such royal gifts and goodly as if laden with gold each tree.
And costly I ween the presents that vassal and friend must
share
From the open hand of the hero; and the queen deemed it
right and fair.⁸⁴⁰

Full many a bitter conflict had been fought ere the bridal
feast,
But peace had the foeman sealèd, and the land was from
strife released;
(Nor this song I myself have woven, but so was it told to
me)
And Eisenhart did they bury with honours right royally.
To his grave did his kinsmen bear him, and the gold that his
lands might bring⁸⁴⁵
In a whole year long, did they spend there, of their free will
they did this thing.
And Gamuret bade his kinsfolk his riches and lands to hold
And use as they would; tho' they craved not such boon from
the hero bold.

At dawn from before the fortress the foe would their camp
withdraw,
And those who were there departed; many litters with them
they bore.⁸⁵⁰

And the field was left unsheltered, save for one tent so great
and fair,
And the king he bade his servants that tent to his vessel bear.
And he said to his folk that to Assagog would he take it, and
yet I wot
He did with that speech deceive them, for Assagog saw him
not.

Now that proud and gallant hero, his heart gave him little
rest 855
Since he found there no deeds of knighthood, and gladness
forsook his breast;
Yet his dusky wife was dearer than e'en his own life might
be,
Ne'er knew he a truer lady whose heart was from falsehood
free,
She forgat not what 'seemed a woman, and with her as
comrades good
Went purity untarnished, and the ways of true womanhood.
860

He was born in Seville's fair city whom the knight would
hereafter pray,
When he grew of his sojourn weary, to sail with him far
away;
For many a mile had he led him, and he brought him unto
this place,
And a Christian was he, the steersman, nor like to a Moor in
face.
And wisely he spake, 'Thou shalt hide it from them who a
dark skin bear, 865
Too swift is my barque for pursuing, from hence shall we
quickly fare!'

Then his gold it was borne to the vessel. Now of parting I
needs must tell,
By night did he go, the hero, and his purpose he hid it well;

But when from his wife he sailèd, in her womb did she bear
his child:
And fair blew the wind, and the breezes bare him hence o'er
the waters wild.870

And the lady she found a letter, and 'twas writ by her
husband's hand;
And in French (for she well could read it) did the words of
the writing stand:
'Here one love to another speaketh—As a thief have I stolen
away
That mine eyes might not see thy sorrow—But this thing I
needs must say,
Wert thou, e'en as I, a Christian I ever should weep for thee,
875

For e'en now I must sorely mourn thee. If it chance that our
child shall be
In face like unto one other, then his is a dowry fair,
Of Anjou was *he* born, and Frau Minne for his lady he did
declare.
Yet was he in strife a hailstorm, ill neighbour unto his foe;
That his grandsire hath been King Gandein, this I will that
my son shall know.880

Dead he lay thro' his deeds of knighthood; and his father the
same death won,
Addanz was his name, and unsplintered his shield hath been
seen of none;
And by birth he hath been a Breton, and two brothers' sons
were they,
He and the brave Pendragon, and their sires' names I here
will say;
For Lassalies he hath been the elder, and Brickus was his
brother's name,885
And Mazadan was their father whom a fay for her love did
claim.
Terre-de-la-schoie did they call her, to Fay-Morgan she led
the king,

For he was her true heart's fetters; and my race from those
twain did spring.
And fair shall they be, and valiant, and as crownèd kings
they reign—
If lady, thou'lt be baptizèd thou mayst win me to thee again!
890

Yet had she no thought of anger, but she spake, 'Ah! too
soon 'tis o'er,
Of a sooth would I do his bidding, would it bring him to me
once more.
In whose charge hath my courteous hero left the fruit of his
love so true?
Alas! for the sweet communion that we twain for a short
space knew!
Shall the strength of my bitter sorrow rule body and soul
alway? 895
And she quoth, 'Now his God to honour, his will would I
fain obey,
And gladly I'd be baptizèd, and live as should please my
love!'
And sorrow with her heart struggled, and e'en as the turtle
dove
Her joy sought the withered branches, for the same mind
was hers, I ween,
When the mate of the turtle dieth, she forsaketh the branches
green.900

Then the queen at the time appointed bare a son, who was
dark and light,
For in him had God wrought a wonder, at one while was he
black and white.
And a thousand times she kissed him where white as his
sire's his skin.
And she named the babe of her sorrows Feirefis Angevin.
And he was a woodland-waster, many spears did he shatter
fair, 905

And shields did he pierce—as a magpie the hue of his face
and hair.
Now a year and more was ended since Gamuret won such
fame
At Zassamank, and his right hand the victor's prize might
claim,
And yet o'er the seas he drifted, for the winds vexed the hero
bold.
Then a silken sail red gleaming he saw, and the barque did
hold 910
The men whom the King of Scotland, Friedebrand, sent
upon their way
At the bidding of Queen Belakané: from her would they
pardon pray
That ever he came against her, tho' in sooth he had lost the
more.
And with them the diamond helmet, the corslet and sword
they bore,
And hosen e'en such as the harness, and a marvel it needs
must be 915
That the barque was thus borne towards him, as the venture
hath told to me!
And they gave him the goodly armour, and an oath unto
them he swore
That his mouth it should speak their message, an he came to
the queen once more.
And they parted; and one hath told me that the sea bare him
onward bound
Till he came to a goodly haven, and in Seville his goal he
found. 920
And with gold did he pay his steersman right well for his
guidance true,
And they parted, those twain, and sorrow the heart of that
steersman knew!

BOOK II

HERZELEIDE

ARGUMENT

This Book tells how Gamuret sought for King Kaillet, and found him before Kanvoleis. How the Queen of the Waleis ordered a Tourney to be holden, and of the heroes there assembled. How Gamuret did valiant deeds, and was adjudged the victor; and how two queens laid claim to his love. Of the wedding of Gamuret and Queen Herzeleide and their love to each other. How Gamuret went to the aid of the Baruch, and was treacherously slain before Alexandria. How the news was brought to the land of the Waleis; of the sorrow of Herzeleide; and of the birth of Parzival.

BOOK II

HERZELEIDE

Now there in the Spanish country he thought him the king to
greet,
 His kinsman and cousin Kaillet, and he followed with
footsteps fleet
To Toledo, but thence had he ridden unto deeds of
knighthood fair,
Where many a spear should be splintered, and men thought
not their shields to spare.
Then he thought him to make him ready (so the venture doth
tell I ween)⁵
With many a blazoned spear-shaft, and many a sendal green;
For each spear it bare a pennon, with the anchor in ermine
white,
And well was it wrought, the symbol, and costly in all men's
sight.

And long and broad were the pennons, and e'en to the hand
hung low
When men on the spear-blade bound them, a span-breadth
the point below.¹⁰
And a hundred spears were ready for that true and gallant
knight,
And his cousin's folk they bare them, and with him went
forth to fight;
And honour and loyal service they showed him as fit and
fair,
Nor I think had their lord been wrathful that his kinsman
their love should share.

I know not how long he sought him, till shelter at length he
found ¹⁵
In the Waleis land: 'fore Kanvoleis were pitched on the open
ground
Many tents so fair and knightly; (I speak not from fancy
light
But sooth are the words I tell ye if the tale ye would hear
aright)
Then he bade his folk to halt there, and he sent on before his
face
The chief of his squires, and he bade him to seek them a
resting-place.²⁰
He would fain do his master's bidding, and swift to the town
he sped,
And many a pack-horse laden his comrades behind him led.
And never a house he saw there but its roof was a shield I
trow,
And the walls were hung and circled with spears in a goodly
row,
For the queen of the Waleis country had ordered at
Kanvoleis ²⁵
That a Tourney fair be holden, and they ordered it in such
wise

That a coward had little liked it—for whoever would seek
such strife
At his will doth it chance but seldom! She was maiden, not
yet a wife,
And herself and two lands she offered to him who the prize
should hold;
And many to earth had fallen in whose ear had this tale been
told, 30
And he who such fall must suffer he held that his chance
was o'er.
And many a dauntless hero showed knighthood those walls
before,
And many a horse rushed onward as the knight spurred to
onslaught fierce,
And the sword-blades rang clear on each other, and spears
did the shield rims pierce.

A bridge from the plain was builded that crossed o'er the
river's flow, 35
And 'twas closed by a tower-portal; nor the squire at his task
was slow,
But he opened the gates, unwearied, when one would an
entrance win.
And above it there stood the palace, and the queen sat the
hall within,
And she gazed from the high hall window with many a
maiden fair,
And they looked on the squires beneath them to see what
had brought them there. 40
'Twixt themselves had they taken counsel, and a tent did
they rear on high
For the winning of love ungranted a king wrought it in days
gone by,
('Twas in service of Queen Belakané). The squires laboured
with might and main
Till the burden of thirty pack-steeds they raised on the
grassy plain,

A pavilion rich to look on, and the meadow it was so wide

45

That the silken ropes that held it might stretch forth on either
side.

And Gamuret, their master, ate without in the open air—

And then for his courtly entrance with skill would the knight
prepare,

Nor longer might be delaying—His squires take the spears
straightway,

And they bind them fast together, and five in each band they
lay, 50

And the sixth in their hand they carry, with its pennon and
anchor white;

So proudly into the city came riding this gallant knight.

Then the queen she heard the tidings that a noble guest was
come

From a far-off land and distant, and in sooth was he known
to none.

'And courteous his folk in bearing; both heathen and French
I trow, 55

And Angevin, some among them if their speech I aright may
know;

And their courage is high, and their raiment both rich and
well shaped shall be.

But now was I with his people, and they seem me from
falsehood free,

And they say, 'Who hath lust for riches, if he to our lord
shall seek

He will free him from fear of scarceness!' The while I with
them did speak, 60

I asked them to tell of their master, and they thought not to
hide the thing,

But spake of a true heart freely, 'Of Zassamank is he king.'

'Twas a page who brought the tidings—'Ah me! that pavilion
fair!

Wouldst thou pledge thy crown and thy kingdom not half of
its cost were there!

'Thou needst not to praise so highly, my mouth ne'er shall
say thee nay,65

A rich man shall be its owner, no lack doth he know alway.'
And in this wise she spake, the lady, the fair and gracious
queen,

'Why cometh he not to the castle? For fain I his face had
seen.'

This she bade her page to ask him—Then the hero was fain
to make

Brave entry into the city, and the sleepers must needs awake.
70

Many shields he saw fair shining—The blast of the trumpets
clear

Rang loud and long before him, and two drummers ye needs
must hear

As they tossed and smote their tambours, and the walls
echoed back the sound,

With the notes of the flutes 'twas mingled as the train
through the city wound,

'Twas a march that they played so gaily—Nor forget we how
he must ride75

Their master and lord, he followed with the fiddlers his rein
beside.

Then he threw his leg o'er his charger, that hero so bold and
fair,

And boots did he wear of leather, or else had his limbs been
bare.

And his mouth it was e'en as a ruby, and red, as a fire doth
burn,

And full, not too thin; fair his body wherever the eye might
turn; 80

And fair was his hair and curling, and wherever one saw the
skin

I ween 'twas as costly cover as ever a head might win.
And of samite green was his mantle, and the sable shone
 dark thereon
Tho' white was his vest, and the gazers they came in a
 goodly throng.
And many must ask the question, 'Who was he, the beardless
 knight 85
Who rode with such pomp of riches?' Then the tale it was
 spread aright,
For they spake it as truth who knew it—So they drew to the
 bridge anear
The folk of the town, and his people; and so bright was the
 radiance clear
That shone from the queen that it thrilled him thro' his strong
 limbs, that goodly knight,
And he braced himself as a falcon that plumeth its wings for
 flight,90
And the lodging he deemed it goodly; so thought he that
 hero wise;
And his hostess with joy beheld him, the lady of fair Waleis!

Then the king of Spain he heard it, how there stood on the
 open plain
The tent that at Rassalig's bidding Gamuret as his prize did
 gain
At Patelamunt, and the tidings a knight to his lord would
 bring— 95
Then he sped as a deer, joy's vassal I ween was the gallant
 king!
And thus spake the knight, 'Thy kinsman, and the son of
 thine aunt I saw,
And with pomp and in state as aforetime, so to-day doth he
 hither draw;
There are floating a hundred pennons full fair by his
 knightly shield,
And around his high pavilion they stand on the grassy field,
 100

And green as the grass the pennons, and the hero bold doth
bear
Three anchors of snow-white ermine on every sendal fair.'

'Hath he come here arrayed for battle? Ah! then shall men
see straightway
How he spurreth him swift to the onslaught, how he striveth
in knightly fray!
Long time hath the proud King Hardeiss his anger against
me shown, 105
Here in joust shall Gamuret fell him, and good fortune shall
be mine own!'

Then straightway he sent a message to Gaschier, the Norman
knight,
Where he lay with many a vassal; and Killirjacac the fair
and bright,
For here had they come at his bidding—The twain at King
Kailet's side
Towards the fair pavilion with a goodly following hied. 110
And Zassamank's king was joyful, for he held them dear at
heart:
And the time over-long had seemed them since they must
from each other part,
This they spake of a true heart truly—And the king he was
fain to know
What knights should be here for the Tourney, who valour
and skill should show.
Then spake unto him his kinsmen, 'From distant lands they
came, 115
The knights whom love's power hath brought here, many
heroes of dauntless fame.'

'Here Uther Pendragon fighteth, and with him his Breton
host;
One grief as a thorn doth vex him, his wife hath the hero
lost,

The queen who was Arthur's mother; a clerk who all magic
knew
With him hath she fled, and Arthur doth after the twain
pursue; 120
'Tis now the third year since he lost them, his son alike and
wife—
And here is his daughter's husband, a hero well skilled in
strife,
King Lot is his name, of Norway—swift seeketh he
knighthood's prize,
But slow are his feet to falsehood, the knight so bold and
wise.
And here is his young son Gawain; as yet he too weak shall
be 125
For any deed of knighthood—but now was the boy with me,
And he spake, were he not too feeble a spear-shaft as yet to
break
He were fain to do deeds of knighthood, in the Tourney his
part would take!
His lust for strife waketh early! Here Patrigalt's king hath
brought
Of spears a goodly forest; yet their valour shall be as naught
130
When weighed against the gallant doings of the men of
Portugal,
Yea, *bold* we in truth may call them, and shields do they
pierce right well.
And here are the men of Provence, with many a blazoned
shield;
And here the Waleis, to their onslaught the foemen perforce
must yield,
And they ride at their will thro' the combat, for men of the
land are they.135
Many fight here for love's rewarding whose title I may not
say,
But all whom I here have named thee now lie, and the truth I
tell,

At great cost here within the city, for so the queen deemed it
well.'

'And without on the plain they hold them who deem their
prize lightly won,
Proud Arragon's haughty monarch, and the brave king of
Askalon. 140

Eidegast, he is there from Logrois, and the King
Brandelidelein
(The monarch is he of Punturtois), there too is bold
Lähelein.

And Morhold is there of Ireland, many pledges that knight
hath ta'en;

And many a haughty German doth camp on that battle plain.
To this country the Duke of Brabant hath come thro' the
King Hardeiss;145

The king of Gascony gave him his sister the fair Aleiss,
(Yet his service ere that won payment) wrath against me
those princes drew:

Now I trust *thee* to think of our kinship—For love's sake do
me service true!

Quoth the king of Zassamank, 'Cousin, no thanks would I
have from thee

Whate'er I may do for thine honour, my will e'en as thine
shall be.150

Doth thine ostrich yet stand un-nested? Thou shalt carry its
serpent's head

'Gainst thy foeman's demi-gryphon, *my* anchor shall swift be
sped,

And find in his onslaught landing; himself shall a haven
seek

Behind his steed on the gravel! If our wrath we be fain to
wreak,

And ride one against the other, I fell him, or he felleth me—
155

On my knightly faith as a kinsman this word do I swear to
thee!

Then Kaillet he sought his lodging, and his heart it was gay
and light.

Then arose on the plain a war-cry, 'fore the face of two
gallant knights,

They were Schyolarz of Poitou, and Gurnemanz of Graharz,
On the plain did they meet together; ere the eventide might
pass 160

The knights in their troops they rode forth, here by six and
there by three,

And they did gallant deeds of knighthood—nor otherwise
might it be.

And now it was fully noontide, and the knight in his tent
abode;

Then the king of Zassamank heard this, that o'er all the field
they rode,

'O'er the length and the breadth they gallop, and in knightly
order fight.'165

And thither he rode, the hero, with many a banner bright;
But he rode not in search of conflict, at his leisure he
thought to see

What was done by one side and the other of fair deeds of
chivalry.

On the plain did they spread his carpet, where the knights in
strife would close,

And the shriek of the wounded horses o'er all the tumult
rose. 170

The squires stood round in a circle mid the clash of the
ringing steel,

And the heroes for fair fame battled, and the swords sang for
woe or weal.

There was sound as of splintered spear-shafts, but none need
to question, Where?

And his walls were of meeting foemen, by knightly hands
builded fair.

And so near was I ween the jousting that the maids from the
hall above¹⁷⁵

Might look on the toil of the heroes—But sorrow the queen
did move

Since the king of Zassamank did naught, nor mingled him in
the fight,

And she quoth, 'Ah! why came he hither? I had deemed him
a gallant knight!'

(Now the King of France, whose fair wife brought Gamuret
sorrow sore

When he fought for her sake, lay lifeless, and the queen
sought the wide world o'er¹⁸⁰

To know if from heathen countries he had come to his land
again.

'Twas love's power to the search that drove her, for love did
her heart constrain.)

And many brave deeds were done there of many a poor man
bold,

Who yet for the highest strove not, which the queen for their
prize had told,

Herself and her two fair kingdoms,—they thought not such
prize to gain,¹⁸⁵

But they battled for other booty, tho' their hearts were for
payment fain.

Now clad was Gamuret's body in the harness whereby his
wife

Might bring to her mind forgiveness, and the ending of bitter
strife.

The Scotch King Friedebrand sent it, as a gift, to repay the
woe

That with conflict he heaped upon her, nor shall earth of its
fellow know.¹⁹⁰

Then he looked well upon the diamond—'twas a helmet,
thereon they bound

An anchor, and jewels so precious were within its setting
found;
Nor small were the stones, but costly, and the weight it was
none too light
Of that helmet, and yet he bare it, and decked was the guest
for fight

And what was his shield's adorning? of gold of Araby fair,
195
And the boss it was rich and costly, and heavy the weight he
bare.
And the red gold shone so brightly that mirrored the face
therein,
And an anchor beneath of sable—I were fain to myself to
win
That wherewith the knight was girded, full many a mark its
worth.
And wide was the coat emblazoned, and it reached e'en unto
the earth,200
And I ween that few in battle such raiment shall think to
wear.
And if I have skill to praise it, or its value aright declare,
It shone e'en as when there burneth thro' the night-time a
living flame,
And never a tint was faded, and its shimmer as lightning
came,
A feeble eye had feared it! And with gold was it all
inwrought, 205
That in Kaukasus' distant mountains from out of the rock
was brought
By gryphon claws, for they guarded, and shall guard it unto
this day.
And from Araby came the people who stole it by craft away,
—
Elsewhere shall be none so precious,—and they bare it to
Araby

Where they weave Achmardi and Pfellel, and no vesture like
 that shall be!210
His shield, round his neck he hung it—There stood a charger
 proud,
Well-nigh to the hoof was it armed—and the squires cried
 the war-cry loud,
And he sprang on his steed as he found it; and many a spear
 of might
Did he break with strong hand in the Tourney, and where
 men did the closest fight
There he brake a way thro' the mêlée, and came forth on the
 further side,215
And ever behind the Ostrich the Anchor did close abide.

Gamuret smote from off his charger Poytewin of
 Prienlaskors
And many another hero, their pledge must they yield
 perforce.
But what knight bare the cross he rejoiced him in the hero's
 valiant deeds,
And much did he win by his valour, since he gave him the
 captured steeds.220

Now four banners, with self-same bearing, were led 'gainst
 that gallant knight,
(And bold riders they rode beneath them, and their lord was
 a man of might,)
And on each was the tail of a gryphon; and that hinder part I
 trow
Was e'en as a hailstorm smiting, so rode they in goodly row.
And Gascony's king before them the fore part of that
 gryphon bare 225
On his shield; he was skilled in battle, and his body was
 armed full fair
As women alone might arm him; and he rode forth his
 knights before

Where he saw on a helm the Ostrich, but the Anchor towards
him bore,
And he thrust him from off his charger, the brave king of
Zassamank,
And made of him there his captive. Here close thronged the
knightly ranks, 230
And the furrows were trodden level, and their locks must the
sword-blade know,
And many a wood was wasted, and many a knight laid low

—
And they who thus fell, 'twas told me, they turned their
chargers round
And hied to the back of the Tourney, where none but the
cowards were found.

And so near was I ween the combat that the women might
see aright 235
Who there won the prize of valour; Rivalein that love-lorn
knight
With his spear hewed afresh a token, of Loheneis was he
king,
And the crash of the splintered spear-shaft did aye with his
onslaught ring.
Of a knight did Morhold rob them, for he drew him from off
his steed
And lifted him up before him (unseemly methinks such
deed) 340
And Killirjacac they called him,—and ere this King Lac had
ta'en
Such payment from him as in falling a knight from the earth
may gain—
So his deeds had been fair and knightly; then this valiant
man he thought
He would take him with never a sword-thrust, and the knight
in his arms he caught.
Then the hand of the valiant Kaillet it smote from the saddle-
bow 245

The Duke of Brabant, Prince Lambekain, and the hero was
laid alow.
And what think ye they did, his soldiers? Their swords into
shields they turned,
And with them did they guard their monarch—And ever for
strife they yearned.

Then the King of Arragon smote him Uther Pendragon old,
From his charger adown on the meadow fell the king of the
Bretons bold, 250
And the flowers stood fair around him—Ah! I courteous am
I, I trow,
Since the Breton before Kanvoleis I lay on such couch alow,
Where never the foot of a peasant hath trodden unto this day,
Nay, perchance they may never tread there—'tis the truth
and no lie I say—
No more might he keep his saddle as he sat on his steed of
yore, 255
But his peril his friends forgot not, they fought fiercely the
hero o'er.

And many a course was ridden; and the king of Punturtois
Fell prone in his horse's hoof-tracks on the field before
Kanvoleis,
And low did he lie behind it—'Twas Gamuret dealt the blow
—
'Ride on, on thy course, thou hero, and tread thy foemen
low!' 260
Strife giveth whereon to trample! Then Kaillet, his kinsman
true,
Made the Punturtois his captive, tho' he scarce pierced the
mêlée thro'.
Brandelidelein was prisoner, and his folk they had lost their
king,
In his stead another monarch to their host did they captive
bring.

And hither and thither sped they, the heroes, in armour good,
265
And by blows and by trampling kneaded, of alum I ween
their food;
And dark on their skin the swellings, and many a gallant
knight
Might speak, as he knew, of bruises he had won him in hard-
fought fight.

Now as simple truth I say it, little rest was their portion here,
By love were they forced to conflict, many shields with their
blazon clear,270
And many a goodly helmet whose covering the dust should
be.
And the meadow with flowers was sprinkled, and green turf
ye there might see,
And there fell on it many a hero, who of honour had won
such need—
More modest were my desiring! 'Twould content me to sit
my steed.

Then the king of Zassamank rode forth a space from the
knightly fray275
Where a rested steed did wait him, and the diamond he
loosed away,
With no thought of pride in the doing, but the breezes blew
fresh and cool,
And the squires unbound his vizor, and his lips shone so red
and full.

I have named unto ye a lady—Her chaplain did hither ride,
And with him three noble pages, and strong squires were
there beside;280
And pack-horses twain they led there, and the will of their
queen they'd do,
She was Lady of France, Anflisé—Her chaplain was wise
and true,

And straightway he knew the hero, and in French should his
greeting be,

'Soit le bien venu, mon beau sire' to my lady as e'en to me,
As queen of France she reigneth whom the lance of thy love
doth smite,285

And he gave to his hand a letter, and therein read the gallant
knight

A greeting fair, and a token it held of a finger-ring—
As pledge of the truth of his mission the chaplain the same
must bring

His lady of old received it from the hand of the Angevin—
Then he bowed as he saw the letter. Would ye hear what was
writ therein?290

'Here biddeth thee love and greeting a heart that hath ne'er
been free

From grief since it knew thy service—Thy love is both lock
and key

To my heart, and my heart's rejoicing! For thy love am I like
to die,

If thy love afar abideth, then all love from my heart shall fly.
Come thou, and take from my true hand crown, sceptre, and
kingdom fair,295

It falleth to me as heirdom, and thy love well may claim a
share.

As payment for this thy service rich presents I send to thee,
Four pack-horses' chests well laden—I would thou my
knight shouldst be

In this the land of the Waleis, 'fore the city of Kanvoleis.
I care not if the queen shall see it, small harm may therefrom
arise,300

For fairer am I, and richer, and I think me shall better know
To take the love that is proffered, and love in return bestow.
Wilt thou live in true love as shall 'seem thee? Then here do
I bid thee take

My crown as thy love's rewarding—This I pray for my true
love's sake.'

And no more did he find in the letter—Then his squires once
more they drew³⁰⁵

O'er his head the under-helmet; from Gamuret sorrow flew,
And he bound on the helm of diamond, 'twas harder than
blade might pierce,
For he thought again to prove him, and ride forth to conflict
fierce.

And the messengers did he bid them to lead to the tent for
rest:

And he cleared a space around him wherever the conflict
pressed. ³¹⁰

This was vanquished, and that one victor—Did a knight o'er-
long delay
To win to him fame in battle, his chance might he find to-
day.

Here twain would joust together; in troops would these
others ride;

And the customs of friendly combat for a space did they lay
aside,

And sworn brotherhood nothing counted 'fore the strength of
fierce anger's might,³¹⁵

And the crooked was seldom straightened; nor spake they of
knightly right,

What they captured they kept, uncaring if another's hate they
won,

And from many lands had they ridden who with brave hands
brave deeds had done,

And their hurts but little grieved them. Here Gamuret heard
her prayer,

And e'en as Anflisé bade him, as her knight to the field
would fare;³²⁰

'Twas a letter had brought the tidings—Ah! he giveth his
courage rein,

Is it love or the lust of battle that driveth him on amain?

Great love and strong faith they quicken his strength into life
anew.

Now see where his shield he beareth, King Lot, that hero
true,

His foemen to flight had forced him save for Gamuret's
strong right hand,325

His charger in gallant onslaught brake its way thro' the
threatening band,

And Arragon's king was smitten from his horse with a spear
of reed,

'Schaffilor was his name, and the spear-point which thrust
him from off his steed

Bare never a waving pennon, from paynim lands 'twas
brought,'

And the knight made the king his captive, tho' his folk they
had bravely fought.330

And the inner force drave the outer far back on the grassy
plain.

'Twas a good vesper-play, yea, a Tourney; many spears did
they smite in twain—

Then Lähelein 'gain wax wrathful, 'Shall our honour be reft
away?

'Tis the fault of him of the Anchor! Now one of us twain to-
day

Shall lay in short space the other on a couch that he liketh
ill, 335

For here are they well-nigh victors!' Then they cleared them
a space at will,

And no child's play it was that combat—In such wise with
their hands they wrought

That a woodland was well-nigh wasted; and alike from their
squires they sought

'New spears! New spears! Bring them hither!' Yet Lähelein
he must know

Sorrow and shame, for his foeman thrust him down from his
horse alow,340

And he smote him the length of the spear-iron in a shaft of
reed made fast,
And one read of itself his surety, for the knight to the earth
was cast.
(Yet better I like to read them, sweet pears on the ground
that lie
As thick as the knights lay round him! for his was the
victory!)

And the cry arose from many who had fallen in joust before,
345

'Fly! Fly! For the Anchor cometh!' Then a knight towards
him bore,
(A prince of the Angevin country) and grief was his comrade
true,
For he bare a shield inverted, and sorrow it taught anew
To the King, for the badge he knew it—Ah! why did he turn
aside?

If ye will, I the truth will tell ye, 'twas given in royal pride
350

By Galoes the son of Gandein, Gamuret's brother true,
Ere Love this guerdon gave him that the hero in joust she
slew.

Then he loosed from his head the helmet: nor thro' grass, nor
thro' dust and sand

Did he make him a way to the conflict, but he yielded to
grief's command;

And his thoughts within him battled, that he sought not ere
this to hear355

From Kailet, his friend and kinsman, how it fared with his
brother dear

That he came not here to the Tourney—Alas! tho' he knew it
not,

He had fallen before Monthorie—Sore sorrow was there his
lot,

For to anguish did love constrain him, the love of a noble
queen;
For his loss had she grieved so sorely that death had her
portion been.360

And tho' sorely Gamuret sorrowed, yet had he in half a day
So many spear-shafts broken, were it Tourney indeed this
fray
Then had he a woodland wasted. Did I think me to count
each spear
One hundred in fight had he shattered, each blazoned with
colours clear—
But the heralds, they won his pennons, in sooth were they
theirs of right—365
Then toward the fair pavilion he turned him, the gallant
knight.
And the Waleis squire rode after; and his was the coat so
fair,
All pierced and hewn with sword-thrust, which he did to his
lady bear;
And yet with gold was it precious, and it shone with a fiery
glow,
And right well might ye see its richness. Then joy did the
queen's heart know,370
And she spake, 'A fair woman sent thee, with this knight, to
this distant land!
Now, courteous, I must bethink me lest these heroes
ashamed shall stand
Who have risked their fate in this venture—goodwill unto all
I bear,
For all do I count my kinsmen, since Adam's flesh we share,
Yet Gamuret's hand, I think me, the highest prize hath won.'
375
But by wrath constrained they battled till the shadows of
night drew on,
And the inner host the outer by force to their tents had
brought,

Save for Askalon's king and Morhold thro' the camp they
their way had fought.

Some were winners, and some were losers, and many sore
shame had earned,
While others won praise and honour. Then the foe from each
other turned, 380
Here no man might see—He who holdeth the stakes, if no
light he show,
Who would cast the dice in the darkness? To such sport were
the weary slow!

Men well might forget the darkness where Gamuret did
abide,
'Twas as day—That in sooth it was not, but light shone on
every side
From many small tapers clustered. There, laid on the olive
wood, 385
Was many a costly cushion, and by each couch a carpet
good.
Then the queen, she rode to the doorway with many a maid
of rank,
For fain would they see, those ladies, the brave king of
Zassamank.

Many wearied knights thronged after—The cloth had they
borne away
Ere she came to the fair pavilion; then the host he uprose
straightway, 390
And the monarchs four his captives (and many a prince was
there),
And she welcomed him with due honour, and she saw him,
and deemed him fair.
Then glad spake the queen of the Waleis, 'Thou art host
where we twain do stand,
And I, even so I think me, am hostess o'er all this land,

If thou deem it well I should kiss thee, such kiss seemeth
good to me!'395
'Thy kiss shall be mine if these heroes, e'en as I, shall be
kissed by thee,
But if princes and kings must forego it, 'twere unfit I such
boon should crave!'
'Yea, e'en as thou wilt, so be it, tho' ne'er saw I these heroes
brave!'
Then she kissed, e'en as Gamuret prayed her, these princes
of noble line,
And he prayed her to sit, and beside her sat the King
Brandelidelein!400

Then lightly they strewed, o'er the carpet, green rushes yet
wet with dew,
And he sat him down upon them whose presence brought
joy anew
To the gracious queen of the Waleis; and love did her soul
constrain,
And as Gamuret sat before her his hand did she clasp again,
And she drew him once more towards her, and she set him
her seat beside.405
No wife was she, but a maiden, from whose hand did such
grace betide.
Would ye know the name they called her? Herzeleide the
queen was she,
(And her cousin was hight Rischoydè, King Kaillet should
her husband be,
And *he* was Gamuret's cousin), and so radiant the queen, and
bright,
That e'en though they quenched the tapers, in her presence
'twould still be light!410
(Were it not that a mighty sorrow his joy which aloft would
fly
Had beaten to earth, I think me he had wooed her right
readily.)

And courteous they spake to each other: then cup-bearers
drew anigh,
And from Assagog the vessels, and their cost might no man
deny;
And noble pages bare them, many costly bowls and fair, 415
Of precious jewels wroughten, and wide, none too small,
they were,
And none of them all were golden—'twas the tribute of that
fair land,
Which Eisenhart oft had proffered, when love's need nerved
his knightly hand.
And the drink unto each they proffered in many a coloured
stone,
And of emerald some, and of sardius, and of ruby some
wrought alone.420

Then there drew near to his pavilion two knights who their
word must swear,
(To the outer host were they captive and from thence to the
town would fare.)
And one of them was King Kailet; and he looked upon
Gamuret,
And he saw him sit heavy-hearted, and he spake, 'Dost thou
sorrow yet
For all men they own thy valour; Herzeleide and kingdoms
twain 425
Hast thou won, and all tongues have said it, to thy praises all
men are fain,
Be they Britons or men of Ireland—Who speaketh with
foreign tongue,
If France be their land, or Brabant, with one voice they thy
praise have sung,
That none here both skill and wisdom in strife like to thine
have shown.
True letter it is I read thee! No slumber thy strength hath
known, 430

When these knights thou hast put in peril who surety ne'er
 sware of old,
Brandelidelein the monarch, and Lähelein, hero bold;
And Hardeiss and King Schaffilor; yea, and Rassalig the
 Moor,
Whom thine hand before Patelamunt o'erthrew and he surety
 swore,
Such lesson thou there didst teach him—Yea, this doth thy
 fame desire⁴³⁵
That with every coming conflict it broader shall wax and
 higher.'

'The queen sure will deem thou ravest, if in this wise thou
 praisest me,
Yet I think not that thou shalt sell me, since the buyer the
 flaw shall see;
Thy mouth is o'er-full of praises! Say, how hast thou come
 again?'

'The worthy folk of Punturtois, this knight from fair
 Champagne ⁴⁴⁰
And myself have loosed, and Morhold who this nephew hath
 stolen of mine
Will set him free, if on thy part thou wilt free
 Brandelidelein;
Otherwise are we captive to them, both I and my sister's son,
But such grace thou wilt surely show us—Here such vesper-
 play was run
That it cometh not to a Tourney this while before Kanvoleis,
 ⁴⁴⁵
And in sooth do I know how it standeth! Here sit they before
 mine eyes,
The strength of the outer army—now speak, tell me when
 and how
They could hold the field against us? Much fame hast thou
 won, I trow!'

Then the queen she spake to the hero from a true heart full
tenderly,
'Whate'er be my claim upon thee, I pray thee to let it be. 450
I were fain of thy service worthy—If here I my right shall
claim,
And thine honour thereby be tarnished, I will leave thee nor
mar thy fame!'

Then he sprang to his feet, the chaplain of Anflisé the wise
and fair,
And he quoth, 'Nay, my queen doth claim him, at her will to
this land I fare.
For his love hath she sent me hither, for his love she afar
doth pine,455
And her love layeth claim upon him and *hers* shall he be, not
thine.
O'er all women I ween doth she love him: here as
messengers hath she sent
Three princes, lads free from falsehood; and the one is hight
Lazident
Of noble birth from Greenland, and in Kärlingen doth he
dwell,
And his own hath he made the language; and the second his
name I'll tell,460
Liodarz he, a count his father, and Schyolarz was he hight.
And who was the third? Will ye hearken, his kinship I'll tell
aright:
Belleflur she hath been his mother, Pansamur was his
father's name,
Liahturteltart they called him, of the race of the fays he
came.
Then they ran all three before him, and they spake, 'Wouldst
thy fortune prove?465
(The queen of France doth proffer the chance of a worthy
love.)
Thou shalt play the game, and never a pledge shall be asked
from thee,

Nor thy joy be to sorrow forfeit, as it waxeth still fair and
free!

Then e'en while they spake their errand Kailet he had ta'en
his seat

'Neath a fold of the royal mantle, and she spake to him low
and sweet,470

'Now say, hath worse harm befallen? Methinks I the wounds
have seen?'

In that same hour his wounds and bruises she sought out, the
gracious queen,

With her white hands so small and shapely, which their
wisdom from God must win,

And sore was he cut and wounded on nose and on cheek and
chin.

He had won for his wife the cousin of the queen who such
honour fair475

Would show him, herself would she tend him, and her hands
for his hurts should care.

Then e'en as courtesy bade her she spake unto Gamuret,
'The fair queen of France, it seemeth, her heart upon thee
hath set;

Now honour in me all women, and give what I here may
claim,

Go not till men judge betwixt us, else thou leavest me here
to shame.'480

This he sware unto her, the hero, and leave she from him
would crave,

And she passed thence, and then King Kailet, that monarch
so true and brave,

He lifted her to her saddle; and he turned him about once
more

And came into the pavilion, where his kinsman and friends
he saw.

Then spake he unto King Hardeiss, 'Aleiss thy sister fair 485

She proffered her love, I took it—Now wedded is she
elsewhere,
And a better than I is her husband! No longer thus wrathful
frown,
Prince Lambekein, he hath won her—tho' in sooth she shall
wear no crown,
Yet honour enough is her portion—Brabant and Hennegau
Do her service, and many a brave knight doth unto her
bidding bow. 490
If thy mind it shall turn to greet me let thy favour be mine
once more,
And take thou again my service of a true heart as aye of
yore.'

Then the king of Gascony answered as befitted a hero brave,
'Yea, soft is thy speech, yet if greeting I give thee as thou
dost crave,
Who hath offered to me such insult, men will deem *fear*
such grace hath won, 495
For captive am I to thy cousin!' 'Yet ill shall he deal with
none,
Gamuret, he shall grant thy freedom, that boon my first
prayer shall be:
No man shall thereto constrain thee, yet my service the day
shall see
When thou as thy friend shalt claim me. For the shame, 'tis
enow I wot,
For whate'er *thou* mayst do against me, thy sister, she
slayeth me not!' 500

Then all at his words laughed loudly. But their mirth it was
soon o'erpast
For his true heart the host constrained, and desire held him
once more fast,
And a sharp goad I ween is sorrow—Then the heroes they
saw right well

How he wrestled anew with sorrow and his joy in the
 conflict fell;
And his cousin he waxed right wrathful, and he spake, 'Now
 thou doest ill.'505
'Nay, nay, for I needs must sorrow, and naught may my
 yearning still
For the queen I have left behind me, afar on a heathen shore,
Pure wife and true is that lady, and my heart she hath
 wounded sore.'

'And her purity doth constrain me to mourn for her love so
 sweet,
Vassals and lands she gave me; yet joy for a true knight meet
 510
Belakané of that hath robbed me! yet shame for a wavering
 mind
I think me is right and manly—With such fetters her love did
 bind
That she held me afar from Tourney, nor in search of strife I
 went;
Then I thought me that deeds of knighthood should free me
 from ill-content,
And here have I somewhat striven—Now many a fool would
 say 515
That I, for her colour, fled her, to my eyes was she light as
 day!
For her womanhood true I sorrow; o'er all others her worth
 stood high
As the boss from the shield outstandeth. And another grief
 have I,
And here make I my moan unto ye, my brother's arms I saw,
But the shield on which they were blazoned, with point up-
 turned they bore.'520
(Ah! woe for the words that are spoken, and the tidings of
 grief they bring!)
His eyes they o'erflowed with water, that gallant Spanish
 king,

'Alas! O queen for thy madness, thro' thy love is Galoes
slain,
Whom every faithful woman from her heart shall mourn
amain
If she would that her dealing win her true honour in true
man's thought.525
Ah! queen of Auvergne I think me, tho' small grief it to thee
hath brought,
Yet thro' thee have I lost my kinsman, tho' his ending was fit
and fair,
For a knightly joust hath slain him who thy token in strife
would bear!
And these princes here, his comrades, their heartfelt grief
they show,
As in funeral train their shield's-breadth do they turn to the
earth below,530
For thus hath great sorrow taught them—In this guise do
they knightly deeds,
Heavy-hearted that he, my cousin, serveth no more for true
love's meed!'

He hath won him another heart-grief as his brother's death is
told,
And he spake aloud in his sorrow, 'Now mine anchor hath
found its hold
And its haven in bitter rueing,' and the badge did he lay
aside, 535
And his grief taught him bitter anguish, and aloud the hero
cried,
'Galoes of Anjou! henceforward shall never a man deny
That on earth ne'er was born thine equal for manhood and
courtesy,
And the fruit of a free hand knightly from thine heart did it
bloom amain.
Ah! woe is me for thy goodness!' then to Kailet he spake
again, 540
'How goeth it with Schoettè, my mother, of joy bereft?'

'So that God hath had pity on her! When Gandein this life
had left,
And dead was Galoes thy brother, and thou wert not by her
side,
And she saw thee no more, then death brake her heart, and
she too hath died!'

Then out quoth the Gascon Hardeiss, 'Turn thy will to a
manly mien,⁵⁴⁵
Thou shalt mourn but in fitting measure if true manhood
thine own hath been!'
But too great was the load of his sorrow, and the tears as a
flood must flow
From his eyes—Then all things he ordered that the knights a
fair rest might know,
And he went where he saw his chamber, of samite the little
tent,
And in grief and sore lamentation the hours of the night he
spent. 550

When there dawned another morning the knights together
came,
The inner host and the outer, all who thought there to win
them fame;
Were they young or old, were they cowardly or brave, they
fought not that day.
And the light grew to middle morning: yet so worn were
they with the fray,
And the horses so spent with spurring, that the knights in
battle tried 555
Were yet by weariness vanquished—Then the queen herself
would ride,
And the valiant men from the open would she bring to the
town again,
And the best of the knights within there she bade ride to the
Leo-plain;

And straightway they did her bidding, and they rode in their
knightly ranks,
And they came ere the Mass was ended to the sad king of
Zassamank. 560

Then the benediction spoken, Herzeleide the queen she
came,
And e'en as the folk upheld her, so she laid to the knight her
claim:
Then he spake, 'A wife have I Lady, and than life shall she
be more dear,
Yea, and e'en if I were without her thou another tale shouldst
hear
That afar should drive me from thee, if men here shall list
my right!' 565
But the queen she looked upon him, and she spake to the
gallant knight:

'Thou shalt leave thy Moorish lady for my love; stronger far
shall be
The blessing that baptism giveth! From heathendom set thee
free,
And wed me in Christian marriage, since my heart for thy
love doth yearn.
Or say shall the French queen's message to my shame and
my sorrow turn? 570
Sweet words did they speak her people, and thou heardest
them to the end!'
'Yea, she is in truth my lady. When I back to Anjou must
wend,
Then fair counsels and courteous customs with me from her
land I brought;
Yea, even to-day doth she help me whom from childhood to
man she taught.
She hath fled all that mars a woman—We were children
then, she and I, 575

Yet gladly we saw each other in the days that are long gone
by!

The noble queen Anflisé, in true womanhood hath she share,
From her lands a goodly income she gave me, that lady fair,
(In those days was I still a poor man), yet I took it right
willingly,

As a poor man thou still shalt count me, and Lady, shalt pity
me, 580

He is dead, my gallant brother—Of thy courtesy press me
not,

Turn thy love where thou findest gladness, for sorrow is aye
my lot!

'Nay, let me not longer sorrow; how wilt thou deny my
claim?'

'Thy question I'll gladly answer, here a *Tourney* thou didst
proclaim,

That *Tourney* hath not been holden, as many shall witness
bear' 585

'For the vesper-play hath marred it! The knights who had
foughten there

So well have they tamed their ardour that the *Tourney* hath
come to naught,'

'I did but defend thy city with others that bravely fought;
Thou shouldst force me not to withstand thee, here have
others done more than I,

Mine the greeting that *all* may claim here, other right would
I still deny!' 590

Then, so hath the venture told me, they chose them, both
man and maid,

A judge o'er the claim of the lady, and their cause they
before him laid,

And it drew near to middle morning, and thus did the verdict
run,

'What knight hath bound on his helmet, and hath hither for
conflict come,

And hath fought, and the prize hath holden, then that knight
he shall wed the queen.'595

And unto the judgment spoken the knights gave consent I
ween.

Spake the queen, 'Mine thou art, and I'll yield thee fair
service thy love to gain,

And will give thee of joy such portion that thy life shall be
free of pain!'

And yet bare he grief and sorrow—Now the April sun was
o'er,

And had left behind a token in the garment the meadow
bore, 600

With short green grass was it covered, so that coward hearts
waxed bold,

And won afresh high courage; and the trees did their buds
unfold

In the soft sweet air of the May-tide, and he came of the
fairy race

That aye loveth, or sweet love seeketh, and his friend she
would show him grace.

Then he looked on Queen Herzeleide, and he spake to her
courteously,605

'If in joy we would live, O Lady, then my warder thou shalt
not be,

When loosed from the bonds of sorrow, for knighthood my
heart is fain;

If thou holdest me back from Tourney I may practise such
wiles again

As of old when I fled from the lady whom I won with mine
own right hand;

When from strife she would fain have kept me I fled from
her folk and land!'610

Then she spake, 'Set what bonds thou willest, by thy word
will I still abide.'

'Many spears would I break asunder, and each month would
to Tourney ride,
Thou shalt murmur not O Lady when such knightly joust I'd
run!'
This she sware, so the tale was told me, and the maid and
her lands he won.
The three pages of Queen Anflisé and her chaplain were
nigh at hand, 615
As the judgment was sealed and spoken they must hearken
and understand,
And he spake to the knight in secret, 'To my lady this tale
was told
How at Patelamunt thy valour did the guerdon of victory
hold,
And that there two kingdoms served thee—And she too hath
lands I trow,
And she thinketh *herself* to give thee, and riches and gold
enow!' 620

'As knighthood of old she taught me so must I hold fast
always
By the strength of the knightly order, and the rule of the
shield obey.
Thro' her my shield have I won me, else perchance I had
worn it not,
Here doth knightly verdict bind me, be sorrow or joy my lot.
Go ye homeward, and bear my service, her knight will I ever
be, 625
And for her is my deepest sorrow tho' all crowns were
awaiting me!'
Then he proffered to them of his riches, but his gifts did they
cast aside.
Yet was she not shamed their lady, tho' homeward they
needs must ride!
And they craved not leave, but they rode thence, as in anger
ye oft shall find,

And the princes' sons, her pages, well-nigh did they weep
them blind.630

They who bare their shields inverted their friends spake to
them this word,

'The queen, fair Herzeleide, hath the Angevin for her lord.'
'Say, who from Anjou hath fought here? Our lord is, alas,
elsewhere;

He seeketh him fame 'gainst the heathen, and grief for his
sake we bear!'

'He who shall be here the victor, who hath smitten full many
a knight,635

He who smote and pierced so fiercely, he who bare on his
helm of light

An anchor rare and costly, that knight is the knight we mean,
And King Kaillet he spake his title, Gamuret Angevin—I
ween

Good fortune doth here befall him!' Then swift to their
steeds they sprung,

And their raiment was wet with the tear-drops that grief
from their eye-lids wrung,640

When they came where their lord was seated they gave him
a welcome fair,

And he in his turn would greet them, and sorrow and joy
were there.

Then he kissed his knights so faithful, and spake, 'Ye no
more shall make

Such measureless moan for my brother, his place I with ye
will take.

Turn your shields again as befits them, and as men who
would joyful fare;645

My anchor hath struck its haven; my father's arms I'll bear,
For the anchor it is a symbol that befitteth a wandering
knight,

He who willeth may take and wear it. I must rule my life
aright

As now shall become my station: I am rich now, when shall
I be
The lord of this folk? For my sorrow it worketh but ill to me.
650
Queen Herzeleide, help me that thou and I may pray
The kings that are here and princes for my service awhile to
stay,
Till thou unto me hast yielded that which love from true love
may crave!
Thus both of them made petition, and the heroes their
promise gave.

Then each one went to his chamber, and the queen to her
knight spake low, 655
'Now yield thyself to my tending, and a hidden way I'll
show!'
For his guests did they care as fitting tho' the host was no
longer there,
The folk they were all together, but the knight he alone must
fare
Save for two of his pages only—Then the queen and her
maidens bright
They led him where gladness waited, and his sorrow was put
to flight, 660
And regret was o'erthrown and vanquished—And his heart it
waxed high and brave
As is ever the lot of lovers! and her maidenhood she gave
The queen, fair Herzeleide: nor their lips did they think to
spare,
But close did they cling in kisses; grief was conquered by
joy so fair!

Then courteous deeds were begun there; for free were his
captives set, 665
And the Kings Hardeiss and Kaillet were made friends by
Gamuret.

And such marriage feast was holden that he who had
proudly thought
Hereafter to hold such another much riches thereto had
brought.
For this did Gamuret purpose, his wealth he would little
spare,
But Arabian gold did he scatter mid the poor knights; and
jewels rare⁶⁷⁰
Did he give to the kings and princes who were there with the
host I ween;
And glad were the wandering players, for rich gifts had their
portion been.

Let them ride whom he there had feasted, from the Angevin
leave they prayed.
Then the panther the badge of his father on his shield they in
sable laid;
And a small white silken garment, a shift that the queen did
wear, ⁶⁷⁵
That had touched her naked body who now was his wife so
fair,
This should be his corslet's cover. And of foemen it saw
eighteen
Pierced thro' and hewn with sword-blade ere he parted from
her his queen,
And aye as her love came homeward on her body that shift
she drew:
And many a shield had he shattered; and their love it waxed
strong and true.⁶⁸⁰

And honour enow was his portion ere his manly courage
bore
The knight o'er the seas to conflict, for his journey I sorrow
sore.
For there came unto him true tidings, how the Baruch, his
lord of old,
Was beset by mighty foemen, by Babylon's princes bold:

And the one he was called Ipomidon, and Pompey his
brother's name 685
(For so hath the venture told me), a proud man of warlike
fame.
('Twas not he whom Julius Cæsar had driven from Rome of
yore).
His uncle was Nebuchadnezzar, who in books found the
lying lore
That he himself should a god be, (o'er this would our folk
make sport)
And of noble race these brothers, nor of strength nor of gold
spared aught. 690
From Ninus they came who was ruler ere ever Bagdad might
be,
Nineveh did he found—Now an insult and a shame vexed
them bitterly,
The Baruch as vassals claimed them—So the combat was
won and lost,
And bravely the heroes battled, and on each side they paid
the cost.
Thus Gamuret sailed the water, and aid to the Baruch
brought, 695
And gladly he bade him welcome; tho' I weep that that land
he sought!

How it chanced there, how went the conflict, gain or loss,
how the thing might be
Naught of that knew Queen Herzeleide; and bright as the
sun was she,
And her form it was fair to look on, and both riches had she
and youth,
And more than too much her gladness! I think me in very
truth 700
She had sped past the goal of all wishes—And on wisdom
her heart was set,
And she won from the whole world favour; her fair deeds
with fair guerdon met,

And all men praised Herzeleide, the queen, as both fair and
true,
And the queen of three kingdoms was she, of Waleis and fair
Anjou,
Of these twain was she aye the ruler; and beside them in far
Norgals⁷⁰⁵
Did she bear the crown and sceptre, in the city of Kingrivals.
And so dear did she hold her husband, if never a maid might
win
So gallant a man, what recked she? She counted it not for
sin.

As for half a year he was absent she looked for his coming
sure,
For but in the thought of that meeting might the life of the
queen endure.⁷¹⁰
Then brake the sword of her gladness thro' the midst of the
hilt in twain,
Ah me! and alas! for her mourning, that goodness should
bear such pain
And faith ever waken sorrow! Yea, so doth it run away
With the life of men, and to-morrow must they mourn who
rejoice to-day!

So it chanced that the queen one noontide in a restless
slumber lay,⁷¹⁵
'Twas as if with a start she wakened and by lightning was
borne away,
And towards the clouds it bare her, and they smote her with
mighty force,
The fiery bolts of Heaven, as they sped on their downward
course,
And sparks sprang from her floating tresses mid the fire of
the circling spheres,
And the thunder crashed loud around her, and the rain-drops
were burning tears.⁷²⁰

For a little space was she conscious, then a grip on her right
hand fell,
And, lo! it was changed, the vision, and wondrous things
befell;
For then did she nurse a dragon, that forth from her body
sprung,
And its dragon life to nourish awhile at her breast it hung,
Then it fled from her sight so swiftly she might look on it
never more:725
And her heart it brake for the anguish, and the terror and
grief she bore.

And never methinks a woman in slumber such woe hath
seen,
But now had she been so joyful, alas! all was changed I
ween,
And sorrow should be her portion, and her ill it waxed long
and wide,
And the shadow of coming sorrow did still on her heart
abide. 730

Then she did what afore she could not, for the terror that on
her lay,
She stretched her limbs in her slumber, and moaned in her
grief alway,
And she cried aloud on her people; and many a maid sat by
And they sprang to her side at her summons, and wakened
her speedily.

Then Tampaneis he came riding, of her husband's squires the
chief, 735
And many a page was with him, and joy's goal was
o'erpassed in grief,
And they cried, 'He was dead, their master!' And her senses
forsook the queen,
And she fell aback in her anguish—And the knights spake,
'How hath this been?

Hath our lord been slain in his harness, who ever was armed
so well?'

And tho' sorely the squire must sorrow, to the heroes the tale
he'ld tell:740

'No long life should he have, my master! His helm he put off
awhile,

The heat thereto constrained him—'twas accursed heathen
guile

That stole him from us, our hero—A knight took a he-goats
blood,

And from a long glass he poured it on the helmet of
diamond good,

And softer than sponge grew the diamond. May He Whom
as Lamb they show745

With the Cross in His hold, have mercy on the deeds that are
wrought below!'

'Then when one host met the other: Ah! that was indeed a
fight,

And the knights who were with the Baruch they fought all as
men of might,

And there in the field by Bagdad full many a shield was
pierced,

As they flew each one on the other, and they mingled in
charges fierce,750

And banner was mixed with banner, many fell who had
bravely fought,

And my lord's hand it did such wonders that his foemen
became as nought,

But Ipomidon he came riding, and with death would reward
the knight,

And he smote him down, and I think me many thousands
they saw that sight.'

'For my master, free from falsehood, rode against
Alexandria's king,755

But, alas! for the guile of the heathen, this joust but his death
should bring,
For the spear cut sheer thro' the helmet, and it pierced thro'
my master's brain
(In his head did they find the splinters), yet the hero still
held the rein,
And dying he rode from the combat, o'er a wide plain his
way he'ld take,
And his chaplain he knelt above him, and in few words his
shrift he spake.⁷⁶⁰
And he sent here the shift and the spear-blade that hath
robbed us of our friend,
He died free from sin—us his servants he did to the queen
commend!'

'At Bagdad was the hero buried, and the Baruch the cost
would pay,
With gold is it fair to look on, and rich is the tomb alway;
And many a costly jewel doth gleam where he lies at rest,
⁷⁶⁵
And embalmed was the fair young body (sad was many a
faithful breast);
And the grave-stone it is a ruby, and thro' it he shineth clear,
And they granted us as with martyrs, the cross o'er his tomb
to rear,—
For as Christ by His death hath freed us, and to comfort that
soul so brave,
And for shelter we raised the symbol—And the Baruch the
cost he gave.⁷⁷⁰
For the cross was of emerald wroughten: heathen counsel we
asked it not,
For they know not the Cross, nor the blessing that Christ's
death won for us I wot!
And the heathen they pray unto him as if he were a god in
truth,
Nor they do it the Cross to honour, nor hath Baptism taught
them ruth

(Tho' it looseneth *us* from Hell's fetters when the uttermost
day shall dawn),775
But his knightly faith and honour, who leaveth us here
forlorn,
Have wrought him a place in Heaven where he shineth with
Heaven's light,
And true penitence and confession—for falsehood e'er fled
that knight.'

'And there in his diamond helmet an epitaph did they grave,
And fast to the cross they fixed it o'er the tomb of that hero
brave,780
And thus do they run the letters: '*(Through this helmet a
joust hath slain)*
*This hero who bare all manhood, and Gamuret was his
name,*
*As king did he rule o'er three kingdoms, in each land the
Crown he wore*
Whom mighty princes followed—Anjou's land this hero bore,
And he lost his life for the Baruch at the city of Bagdad
*fair.*785
*And so high did it soar, his honour, that no knight may with
him compare,*
*Howe'er ye may test their dealings. Nor is he of woman
born,*
*(I mean of the knightly order) to whose hand he his strength
had sworn.*
*But help and true manly counsel to his friends did he
steadfast give;*
*And thro' women much grief he suffered, for he would in
their favour live.* 790
Baptized was he as a Christian tho' Saracens mourn him yet,
*(This is truth and no lie)—All his lifetime since his years
were on wisdom set*
*His strength strove for fame and honour, till he fell in his
knightly pride,*

*Wish him bliss who here lieth buried! 'Twas by treason's
hand he died!*

So spake the squire, and the Waleis who heard it must weep
full sore,795

Cause hast they enow for sorrow! A living child she bore
Who of men was left unaided, Herzeleide the gracious
queen,

With death the mother battled: her maidens were crazed I
ween,

Since they thought not to help their lady, for within her
womb she bare

Him who should be flower of all knighthood, if death did
not claim him there.800

Then there came a wise man ancient to weep with his lady's
grief,

And he saw how with death she struggled, and he brought to
her swift relief;

For he forced her teeth asunder, and betwixt her lips they
pour

Water, and at their tending her senses they came once more.

Then she spake, and aloud she mourned him, 'My heart's
dearest, Ah! where is he?805

For in sooth my heart's deepest gladness was in Gamuret's
chivalry,

Yet his valour of this hath robbed me—Now his *mother* am I
and *wife*,

Tho' far younger was I, for within me do I carry his flesh
and life;

The love that we bore to each other hath been of such flower
the root,

And if God shall in truth be faithful, He withholdeth not
here the fruit.810

Already too sore my sorrow for my husband so proud and
brave,

What ill death hath wrought upon me! Her love never
woman gave,

But his heart it rejoiced in her gladness, and sad for her grief
was he,
Thus his true heart it gave him counsel who was aye from all
falsehood free.'

Now hearken yet more the story how the noble queen must
mourn, 815
Within her arms would she hold him, her child who was yet
unborn,
And she spake, 'Now God send me safely the child of my
hero fair,
For this is my heart's petition; God keep me from dark
despair,
'Twere Gamuret's second slaying if I thought myself to slay
While I bear of his love the token who was faithful to me
always!' 820

Then careless of who might see her, the robe from her neck
she tore,
And her fair white breasts she tended with the wisdom of
mother-lore,
To her rosy lips she pressed them, 'Ah, thou food that shall
feed my son,
He hath sent thee before his coming who life from my life
hath won!'

And the queen it nothing vexed her that above her heart it
lay 825
The milk that her child should nourish, and softly she spake
always,
'Twas true love that brought thee hither, if I yet unbaptized
should be
From thee had I won my baptism, and the tears which shall
flow so free,
And openly and in secret will I mourn for my husband dear!'
Then the shift with his life-blood crimsoned she bade them
to bring anear, 830

(Thus clad in the Baruch's army had Gamuret lost his life,
For he chose him a gallant ending in the turmoil and stress
of strife),

And then for the spear she prayed them wherewith was her
husband slain,

From Nineveh's Prince Ipomidon such guerdon he needs
must gain.

And tho' tattered and hewn to pieces yet the queen fain the
shift would wear, 835

As aforetime had been her custom when her lord did from
Tourney fare,

But her maidens who stood around her they took it from out
her hand,

And they carried them to the Minster, the highest from out
her land,

And the spear and the blood they buried as men bury a hero
dead,

And sorrow and bitter mourning thro' Gamuret's kingdom
spread. 840

And when fourteen days were ended a babe lay the queen
beside,

'Twas a son, and so great and goodly that the mother had
well-nigh died.

Now 'tis cast the die of the venture, and here doth my tale
begin,

For now is he born who henceforward this song for his own
shall win.

And now have ye heard the story of his father, his love and
grief, 845

Of his gallant life, and the treason that ended its span so
brief;

And ye know whence he came, the hero of this tale, and how
for long

He was hidden from deeds of knighthood, till his youth it
waxed bold and strong.

When the queen found sight and hearing she was fain on her
child to look,
And her maidens they bare him to her and the babe in her
arms she took;850
And she saw his limbs soft rounded, and she knew she had
born a son,
And her maidens with her were joyful that the earth had a
man-child won.
(As he bare of a man the body, so manly was he of heart,
As a smith did he wield the sword-blade till fire from the
helm would start)
And no joy did she know, the mother, save ever her babe to
kiss, 855
And with soft words she spake to him ever, '*Bon fils, Cher
fils, Beau fils.*'

And e'en as herself she bare him, so herself she his nurse
would be,
At his mother's breast was he nourished who was ever from
falsehood free.
And she thought she had won her husband by her prayers to
her arms again,
She all folly forsook, and meekness and truth in her heart
did reign.860

And musing spake Herzeleide, 'The queen of Heaven high
Gave her breast to the dear Lord Jesu Who a bitter death
would die
As Man on the cross for man's sake, for thus did His love
begin:
Who thinketh light of His anger his soul's peace shall hardly
win,
Tho' he else were brave man and worthy—and this tale do I
know for true!'865
Then the queen of the land she bathed her in heart sorrow's
bitter dew,

And her eyes on the babe rained tear-drops as soft in her
arms it lay,
For hers was the way of women, where a true heart holdeth
sway;
She could laugh and weep together, her heart joyed for her
baby's birth,
Yet the ford of her bitter sorrow had drowned in short space
her mirth.⁸⁷⁰

BOOK III GURNEMANZ

ARGUMENT

In the Introduction the poet speaks of the honour in which he holds all true women, though he be wroth with one who has wronged him. Yet, though women shall count him their friend, he would fain that they should honour him for his knightly deeds, rather than for this his song.

In Book III. he tells of the sorrow and the faith of Queen Herzeleide; of Parzival's childhood; of his meeting with the knights; of his faring forth to seek knighthood from King Arthur; and of the death of Herzeleide. How Parzival met with Jeschuté, and robbed her of her token, and of the wrath of her husband Orilus. Of the sorrow of Siguné, and how Parzival learnt his name and his lineage. How Parzival met with the Red Knight and bare his challenge to the court of King Arthur, and how he craved a boon of the king. Of the shaming of Kunnewaaré; and of the death of the Red Knight. How Parzival came to Gurnemanz of Graharz and was cured by him of his folly and taught all knightly wisdom, and how he rode forth from the land of Graharz.

BOOK III GURNEMANZ

Is there ever a singer among you, who singeth a sweeter
song
Of the favour and love of women, I hold not he does me
wrong!
Full fain am I still to hearken to aught that may give them
joy,
But to one alone among women my homage I still deny.
Nay, ever the fire of my anger doth kindle and flame anew, 5

And the sorrow her treason wrought me, it grieveth me still I
 trow!

I, whom men have named the singer, I, Wolfram of
 Eschenbach,

The words that against a woman I spake, I may ne'er take
 back.

Nay, I hold fast my wrath for ever, and clasp it closer still,
As I think how in soul and body alike hath she wrought me
 ill! 10

How can I do aught but hate her, till death setteth seal on
 life?

Yet it grieveth me sore that others should mingle in this our
 strife;

It grieveth me sore that maidens should say, as they name
 my name,

'Forsooth he hath shamed all women, let it be unto him for
 shame!'

Nay, then, an they reckon for evil the words that in grief I
 spake, 15

I will speak them no more for ever, though my heart should
 in silence break!

But let them beware in their anger, these warlike maidens
 fair,

How they stir from his eyrie the eagle, rouse the lion from
 his lair!

Full well I know how to defend me, full well know I what
 beseems

The maid of a knight's devotion, the maid of the poet's
 dreams! 20

Let a maiden be steadfast-hearted, pure and true in word and
 deed,

And her champion true she'll find me, comes there ever an
 hour of need.

I hold his renown waxeth slowly, and halteth upon the road,

Who, for wrong at the hand of one woman, shall slander all
womanhood:

But if any will look upon me, and hearken to what I sing, 25
Of a sooth I will not deceive them, though my tale over-
strange may ring.

Born was I unto the bearing of knightly shield and spear,
And though sweet be the song of the singer, I hold it not all
too dear:

I had rather my love should love me for my deeds of high
renown,

Than because in the hall of the Wartburg they should crown
me with music's crown! 30

With the shield and the spear of knighthood will I seek for a
knight's reward,

Nor charm, with the harp of the singer, what I failed to win
with the sword!

Nor in praise of fair women only runs this tale that I have to
tell,

Full many strange deeds it holdeth, and marvels that once
befell

Ere the course of this wondrous venture be traced unto its
end; 35

Yet he who heareth shall reckon, if he fain would account
me friend,

That this is no book he readeth, for no maker of books am I!
But a singer of strange adventures, and of knightly prowess
high:

Stripped bare will I be of all honour, naked and reft of fame,
Ere I trust my renown unto letters, and give to a book my
name! 40

It vexes me, soul and body, that so many should bear the
name

And speak with the tongue of women, who reck not of
woman's fame;

That those who have known no falsehood, and those who are
 swift to fall,

Should carry one name in common, be counted as sisters all!

A truth that has faltered never, a faith that has aye withstood,

45

Is the only glory of woman, the crown of her womanhood!

Many will say, 'What good thing can come out of poverty?'

She who for love endures it, she 'scapeth Hell thereby,

And, in the kingdom of Heaven, receiveth a hundredfold

For all she has borne for love's sake, new joys for her

sorrows old!50

Not one have I known in my lifetime, I count it a bitter truth,

Neither a man nor a maiden, who the joy and the pride of

youth,

And all earth's riches and honour, will leave as a worthless

thing

If weighed with the glory of Heaven, and the service of

Heaven's King!

But Queen Herzeleide only, she left her fair estate, 55

In her youth of all joy bereavèd, with sorrow afar to mate.

So holy was she and gentle, so faithful and pure of mind,

That no tongue spake a word against her, and no eye a fault

could find.

Sunlight or shadow, what recked she? the day was to her as

night,

For her heart was the home of sorrow, and dead was the

world's delight.60

And in sorrow and grief she wandered, till she came to

Soltanè's strand,

A woodland wild and lonely afar from her native land:

Fair flowers might bloom and blossom without, on the sunlit

plain,

And be woven in rosy chaplets, but for her they would

bloom in vain!

And there, mid the woodland shadows, she hid with

Gamuret's son, 65

For she willed that her life's last treasure be revealed unto
none:
So she called her folk around her, (who toiled in the upland
field
With oxen and plough, that the furrows their daily bread
might yield,)
And she charged them all, by the service which she as their
queen might claim,
That they hide from the boy his birthright and the fame of
his father's name.⁷⁰
'For the knightly deeds ye vaunt of, and the glory and pride
of war,
Have wrought me but heart's affliction, and trouble and
anguish sore,
So, lest I yet more should suffer, I pray you, my servants
dear,
That ye speak no word of knighthood, lest my son perchance
should hear!'

Then full sore were her people grievèd, for they held it an
evil thing,⁷⁵
And a training that ill beseemèd the son of a mighty king.
But his mother kept him hidden in the woodland valleys
wild,
Nor thought in her love and sorrow how she wronged the
kingly child:
No knightly weapon she gave him, save such as in childish
play
He wrought himself from the bushes that grew on his lonely
way,⁸⁰
A bow and arrows he made him, and with these, in
thoughtless glee,
He shot at the birds as they carolled o'erhead in the leafy
tree.

But when the feathered songster of the woods at his feet lay
dead,

In wonder and dumb amazement he bowed down his golden
head,
And in childish wrath and sorrow tore the locks of his sunny
hair; 85
(For I wot well of all earth's children was never a child so
fair
As this boy, who afar in the desert from the haunts of
mankind did dwell,
Who bathed in the mountain streamlet, and roamed o'er the
rock-strewn fell!)
Then he thought him well how the music, which his hand
had for ever stilled,
Had thrilled his soul with its sweetness, and his heart was
with sorrow filled, 90
And the ready tears of childhood flowed forth from their
fountains free
As he ran to his mother weeping, and bowed him beside her
knee.
'What aileth thee child?' quoth the mother, 'but now wast
thou gay and glad'—
But, childlike, he gave no answer, scarce wist he what made
him sad!

But Queen Herzeleide watched him through the sunny
summer days, 95
Till beneath a tree she saw him stand silent, with upturned
gaze,
And a look of joyful rapture in the radiant childish eyes,
As he listed the bird, that, soaring, sang clear thro' the
cloudless skies;
And the mother's heart was troubled, and her wrath waxed to
fever heat,
She would brook in his love no rival—not even God's
singers sweet! 100
So she sent forth in haste her servants, with many a cunning
snare

To capture the singers whose music made joyful the
woodlands fair.
Then, alas! for the birds, who struggled in the cruel snare in
vain,
Yet some few burst their bonds, and joyful, brake forth into
song again!

Then the boy spake, 'Now sweet my mother, why trouble the
birds so sore? 105
Forsooth they can ne'er have harmed thee, ah, leave them in
peace once more!'
And his mother kissed him gently, 'Perchance I have
wrought a wrong,
Of a truth, the dear God who made them, He gave unto them
their song,
And I would not that one of his creatures should sorrow
because of me.'
But the boy looked up in wonder, 'God, Mother? Who may
God be?' 110
'My son, He is light beyond all light, brighter than summer's
day,
And He bare a Man's Face, that we men might look on His
Face alway!
Art thou ever in need of succour? call on Him in thine hour
of ill,
And be sure He will fail thee never, but will hear thee, and
help thee still.
Yet one there is dwelleth in darkness, and I wot men may
fear him well, 115
For his home is the house of falsehood, and his kingdom the
realm of Hell!
Turn thy mind away from him ever, nor waver betwixt the
twain,
For he who doubteth, his labour shall ever be wrought in
vain.'

Thus his mother read him the riddle, the myst'ry of day and
night,
The dread and the doom of darkness, and the glory and
grace of light!120
Then javelin in hand he hastened thro' the forest pathways
wild,
And the deer sprang up from their thickets, and fled from the
dauntless child;
But clear-eyed and eager-footed he hastened upon their
track,
And full oft with a hornèd trophy, at even he hied him back.
Little cared he for rain or sunshine, summer's storm or
winter's snow,125
And daily in strength and beauty all men might behold him
grow;
Till at length no beast so mighty thro' the forest wild did
roam,
If it fell 'neath his shaft, unaided, on his shoulder he bore it
home!

It chanced thro' a woodland thicket one morn as he took his
way,
And brake from o'erhanging bushes full many a leafy spray,
130
That a pathway steep and winding rose sharply his track
anear,
And the distant beat of horse-hoofs fell strange on his
wondering ear.
Then the boy grasped his javelin firmly and thought what
the sound might be;
'Perchance 'tis the devil cometh! Well, I care not if it be he!
Methinks I can still withstand him, be he never so fierce and
grim,135
Of a truth my lady mother she is o'er-much afraid of *him*!

As he stood there for combat ready, behold, in the morning
light,

Three knights rode into the clearing, in glittering armour
bright;
From head to foot were they armèd, each one on his gallant
steed,
And the lad as he saw their glory thought each one a god
indeed! 140
No longer he stood defiant, but knelt low upon his knee,
And cried, 'God, Who helpst all men, I pray Thee have
thought for me!'

Then wroth was the foremost rider as the lad barred his
further way,
And he spake out, 'This stupid *Waleis* will hinder our work
to-day!'
(Now here would I give to the *Waleis* the fame we Bavarians
hold; 145
They are duller than e'en our people, yet manly in strife and
bold.
And in sooth were one born in both countries such marvel of
strength and skill
Would he hide in himself that I think me their fame he might
well fulfil!)

Then there rode swift with hanging bridle, in costly harness
dight,
With plumed and jewelled helmet another gallant knight;
150
Swiftly he came as thirsting to challenge in mortal fight
The foe who sped far before him, who had done him a sore
despite;
For two knights from out his kingdom a maiden had borne
away,
And he held it a deed most shameful and one he must needs
repay;
For the maiden's sorrow grieved him, and fain would he ease
her pain:155

(And the three knights who rode before him were part of his
warlike train.)

He rode a Spanish war-horse, and his shield had fierce
conflict seen,

And Karnachkarnanz did they call him (he was Ulterleg's
count I ween).

Then he cried to his knights, 'Why loiter? who barreth our
onward way?'

And straight on the lad did he ride there, who deemed him a
god alway,160

For ne'er had he seen such glory; his harness shone fair with
dew,

And on either foot the stirrups with golden bells rang true.

And their length was e'en as fitting, and with bells did each
strong arm ring,

As he stirred himself, or his sword-blade in battle aloft
would swing.

And the hero was swift in seeking the guerdon of knightly
prize, 165

So he rode here, the prince, and had decked him in a fair and
wondrous wise.

Then spake this flower of all knighthood, 'Say, boy, did they
pass thy way?

Two knights who have shamed their knighthood, nay,
robbers I ween are they,

For they bear a maiden with them, and she rideth against her
will!'

Yet the boy, tho' he spake with a man's tongue, as a god must
account him still;170

For he thought how Queen Herzeleide had told him that God
was Light

And dwelleth in Light for ever; and so to his dazzled sight

This knight, in his shining armour in the glow of the
summer's day,

Was the God of his mother's lesson, and he knelt him again
to pray.

But the prince he spake full gently, 'Fain am I to do God's
will, 175

And yet for no God I hold me, but a sinful mortal still.
Nay, wert thou more clear of vision, thou wouldst see, an
thou sawest aright,
No Lord of the host of Heaven, but only a humble knight!'

'Knight?' quoth the boy in answer, 'Nay! I wot not what that
may be,
Is thy strength not of God, but of knighthood, then I would
such were given to me!'180

'Then wend thy way to King Arthur, an thou camest unto his
court,
A noble knight he would make thee, ashamed and afeared
for naught,
For sure, now I look upon thee, thou com'st of a noble
strain.'

Then his knights they turned their bridles, and gazed at the
boy again.
Full well might they look and wonder, at the work that God's
Hand had wrought,185

For they say, who tell this story, that never could human
thought
Have dreamed of aught so goodly, since ever the world
began,
For of all men beloved by women, was there never so fair a
man!

Loud they laughed as the boy spake further, 'Good knight,
what may these be?

These rings that so close around thee, above and below I
see.' 190

Then he handled, with curious finger, the armour the knight
did bear,

His coat of mail close-linkèd as behovèd a knight to wear;
And he spake as he looked on the harness, 'My mother's
maidens string

On their chains, and around their fingers, full many a
 shining ring,
But they cling not so close to each other as these rings that
 here I see,195
I cannot force them asunder, what good are they then to
 thee?'

Then the prince drew forth from its scabbard his shining
 blade so keen,
'Now see, he who fights against me, must withstand my
 sword I ween,
And lest he, on his part, should slay me, it is fit that with
 mail and shield,
I ward me against his spear-thrusts, and the blows that his
 arm may wield.'200
Swiftly the lad made answer, 'Little good would it do the
 deer
An their coats were e'en such as thine is, they would fall still
 beneath my spear.'

Full wroth were the knights and scornful that their lord thus
 long had talked
With this lad with the face of an angel, and the speech as of
 one distraught;
Then the prince he spake full gently, 'God keep thee in His
 good grace,205
I would that my shield's bright mirror might show me as fair
 a face!
Nay, an the Giver of all gifts but gave thee wit enow
To match with a mien so goodly, full rich wert thou then I
 trow!
May He keep all sorrow from thee, and thy life be a
 summer's day—'
And with that he turned his bridle, and wended once more
 his way. 210
Then adown the woodland pathway they rode, till they came
 full soon

Where the carles of Queen Herzeleide toiled hard thro' the
sultry noon:

The fields must they plough and harrow, if a harvest they
hoped to reap,
So they goaded the patient oxen to their toil on the hillside
steep.

Then the prince he gave them 'Good-morrow,' and asked if
there passed that way²¹⁵
A maiden in need and sorrow? and they dared not to say him
nay;

But they answered him e'en as he prayed them, and they
spake 'Yea, at early morn
Two knights and a maiden passed here, and the maiden, she
wept forlorn,
And the knights as they rode beside her, spurred ever her
flying steed.'

Then the prince knew his foe, Meljakanz, and his wrath
waxed hot indeed,²²⁰
On his tracks he followed swiftly, and they who this venture
tell,
Say he won back in fight the maiden ere the shadows of
evening fell.

But sore were the queen's folk troubled that the heroes had
chanced that way,
And they spake, 'God forbid that our queen's son fall in with
these knights to-day!

An he chances to light upon them in the pride of their
warlike gear,²²⁵

It will anger full sore our mistress if by hap she the tale
should hear:

And ill-luck will it bring upon us that, ere ever the dawn of
day,

With us while his mother slumbered, to the woods he stole
away!"

Little recked the boy of their trouble as he chased the flying
deer,
And shouted in youthful gladness, as they fell before his
spear 230
Then homeward he sped to his mother, but ere he his tale
might tell
She was smitten with deadly terror, and low at his feet she
fell.

Then soon as Queen Herzeleide found hearing and speech
once more
Her boy was she fain to question tho' her heart it misgave
her sore;
'Who spake to thee, son, of knighthood? What knowest thou
of such-like rede?' 235
'I met in the woods, sweet mother, four men I deemed gods
indeed,
So light were they all and shining, God Himself ne'er could
brighter be,
And of knighthood they spake and King Arthur, who might
well make a knight of me!'
Then her sorrow of old-time wakened, and the queen in her
heart she sought
For some cunning wile of woman, that her boy from his will
be brought. 240

When the simple lad and gallant would crave from her hand
a steed,
Tho' heavy her heart, she bethought her in naught to gainsay
his need,
'Yet not as he asks will I give him, no mother's gifts be mine,
But ever the worst and the meanest that my skill may aye
divine.'
And she thought her, Queen Herzeleide, 'Many folk thro' the
world shall fare 245
Who love mocking—On his fair body my son shall a Fool's
dress wear,

Then sure when the mockers see him, and to scoff at his
garb are fain,
An he at their hands be smitten, then he cometh to me
again!
Alas! for a woman's cunning, and the cruelty of mother's
love,
She chose from her stores a sackcloth, the coarsest that
might be wove,²⁵⁰
And a garment of this she made him that should reach e'en
unto his knee;
For his sunny hair such covering as on fools men are wont to
see;
And instead of hose she bound him on his limbs so strong
and fair
Leggings of undressed calf-skin—And all wept who beheld
him there.

Then his mother with forethought bade him to tarry till
morning light,²⁵⁵
'Nor from hence would I have thee journey till my rede thou
hast heard aright—
'*Keep thou ever from paths untrodden and ford not the
darkling stream,
Where the waters flow clear and limpid, there safe is the
ford I ween.*
*And be ever fair and courteous, greet all men who pass thy
way.*
*If a wise man old and grey-headed would teach thee, as well
he may,*²⁶⁰
*All courteous ways and fitting, as his word so shall be thy
deed,*
*Nor wax wroth if by whiles he chide thee, but give to my
words good heed.*
*And one thing, my son, would I tell thee, canst thou win from
a maid her ring*
*And her greeting fair, thou shalt take them, and sorrow hath
lost her sting!*

*If a kiss from her lips she will give thee, and thine arms shall
the maid enfold,265*

*Be she pure and true thou art blessèd, and thy strength shall
wax high and bold!'*

'And hearken my son, a proud knight, Lâhelein, do men call
his name,

From thy princes two lands hath wrested, else from them
couldst thou tribute claim.

And Waleis they are and Norgals—and one of thy princes
brave,

Turkentials, hath he slain, and thy people he hath smitten and
doth enslave.'270

'For such wrong will I vengeance, mother, if vengeance be
here God's will,

Be he never so strong with my javelin I think me to wound
him still.'

Then e'en at the daylight's dawning the boy would no longer
stay,

For the thought of King Arthur's glory yet heavy upon him
lay.

Then Queen Herzeleide kissed him, and she sped swift his
steed behind,275

And the sorrow of sorrows smote her when her boy she no
more might find.

(Hence he rode and what heart rejoiceth?) Then the queen
from all falsehood free,

Fell low on the earth, and grief tare her till death must her
portion be!

Yet I wot that her death so faithful it hath saved her from
pains of Hell,

And to be of such son the mother, it repayeth all anguish
well! 280

Thus she, the root of all goodness whence humility's flower
might blow,

Herself on a pilgrimage wended that a goodly goal should
know.
Woe worth us! that none of their children should live still, to
hand us down
In these days when we look on falsehood their honour and
fair renown.
And therefore shall faithful women wish well to this lad so
bold, 285
Who rideth fair ventures seeking, whose journey ye now
behold!

Then the gallant lad rode onward on his way toward
Briziljan's wood,
And he came to a rippling streamlet, and a cock well might
wade that flood!
And flowers in the grass were blooming, yet so darkling ran
the wave
That the lad he thought not to ford it; but as wit the counsel
gave, 290
So he followed its course thro' the daylight, and he passed as
he could the night,
Till he saw once more the morning, and he came to a fair
ford bright.
On the further side was a meadow, and a tent decked the
grass so green,
And tall was the tent wide-spreading, and riches thereon
were seen;
'Twas of samite of threefold colours, on the seams lay fair
ribbons wide, 295
And a leathern covering hung there, 'gainst the rain-cloud to
guard its pride.

('Twas Duke Orilus of Lalande, whose wife he beneath it
found—
She lay there in peaceful slumber with riches happed fair
around,
A Duchess she was, well worthy the love of a gallant knight,

And the venture it tells that Jeschuté was the name of that
lady bright)300

Softly the princess slumbered,—yet weapons of love she
bore;
A mouth so red and glowing, that a knight's heart had
wounded sore,
And e'en as she slept they parted asunder, her lips so bright,
That the fire of love had kindled, (fit venture for gallant
knight)
And even as ivory snow-white, and little, and close the row
305
Of the teeth that gleamed white betwixt them—methinks
that a man were slow
To use himself to such kisses from a mouth that all men
might praise—
I wot that so fair a guerdon but seldom hath crowned my
days!

A covering of richest sable over foot and knee was thrown,
(For the heat she aside hath cast it, whom her lord had thus
left alone)310
And her form it was fairly fashioned, and wrought by a
skilful hand,
Since 'twas God Himself in His wisdom who so fair a work
had planned.
And long was her arm and rounded: on her snow-white hand
a ring
Gleamed golden, and when he saw it the lad to her side did
spring;
For had not his mother told him such jewels were the
guerdon fair 315
That a knight well might crave? and he thought him he fain
would such token bear!

Then the lady awoke in terror as his clasp on her white arm
fell,

And gazed in startled wonder and wrath as beseemed her
 well;
'Who is it, who thus would shame me? Nay, sir, thou art all
 too free!
Go, choose thee some fairer maiden, my favours are not for
 thee!' 320

In vain might she weep and bewail her; he asked not her yea,
 or nay,
But took from her lips unwilling the kiss she would fain
 gainsay;
And the ring of gold from her finger with ungentle hand
 he'ld take,
And the clasp that her shift had fastened from the garment
 he roughly brake:
In vain were her tears and struggles, she was but a woman
 still, 325
And his strength was to hers as an army, perforce must she
 do his will.
Then the lad spake aloud, he hungered, from his hand was
 the lady free,
And she quoth, 'Of a truth 'twere better thou shouldst not
 make meal of me!
If thou wert but a little wiser thou wouldst choose thee some
 other meat,
There stand bread and wine, and two game-birds, of them
 mayst thou freely eat, 330
Methinks when my maiden brought them, 'twas scarcely of
 thee she thought!'
Then he asked not where sat the hostess, but he ate e'en as
 hunger taught,
And he drank his fill; and the lady she deemed all too long
 his stay,
For she thought him bereft of his senses, and she wished he
 were well away,
And for fear and shame the sweat-drops stood thickly upon
 her brow—335

And she spake, 'Thou my ring shalt give me, and the clasp
thou didst take but now,
And get thee away, if he cometh, my husband, then shalt
thou bear
The weight of his wrath, and I think me thou wouldst then
wish thyself elsewhere!'

Quoth the noble youth, 'What care I how fierce thy lord's
wrath may be?
If my presence doth shame thine honour, then from hence
will I swiftly flee.'340
And he stepped to the bedside boldly, and kissed her as there
she lay,
Tho' little it pleased the Duchess, and without leave he rode
away;
And he spake a word of parting as he vaulted upon his steed,
'God have thee in His safe keeping, so my mother she gave
me rede.'

Then the lad he was glad of his booty, and thus did he ride a
while—345
Methinks there was little lacking that from hence he had
gone a mile,
Ere he came of whom I would tell you: on the dew he the
tracks might see
Of one who had sought his lady—The tent-ropes displaced
should be
Where the lad thro' the grass had ridden; then the gallant
Duke and proud
Found his lady within in sorrow, and Orilus spake aloud,
350
'Alas! for the service done thee—for smitten and put to
shame
Is the crown of my knightly honour, since another thy love
can claim!'
Then little, alas! might it profit that with streaming eyes she
swore

No lover had she save her husband,—he would hearken her
tale no more.

Then she spake in her fear and anguish, 'Twas a *fool*, he who
came to me, 355

And yet tho' a fool, of all men I wot he may fairest be!
My ring and my clasp gold-gleaming, he took them against
my will!

'Nay, I doubt not so well he pleased thee, thou didst grant
him more favours still,'

'Now, God forbid! for his fool's garb and his javelin were
e'en too near,

It shameth us both, my husband, such words from thy lips to
hear! 360

Are *queens* wont to love thus lowly, that thou speakest such
words of me?

Thou wrongest our royal breeding, when thou deemest such
things may be!

Then the Duke spake, 'This shame, O lady! alone hast thou
won from me,

Thou dost call thyself *Queen* no longer; tho' thy title shall
Duchess be

Little good hath that bargain brought me—So bold shall my
manhood be, 365

That thy brother, King Lac's son Erec, for that cause beareth
hate to thee:

He is wise, and right well he knoweth that my fame so high
shall stand

That nothing shall stain mine honour, save at Prurein when
his right hand

In knightly joust once felled me, but that have I paid right
well,

In a joust at Karnant I smote him, and behind his steed he
fell, 370

And his pledge did he yield unto me,—thro' his shield I thy
token bare,

I thought not, my wife Jeschuté, with *another* thy love to
share!"

"Thou mayst also well assure thee that the son of King
Gandein,

Proud Galoes, once lay lifeless before this arm of mine;
And thou thyself wast witness when the Knight Plihopleheri
375

Rode swift in a joust against me, nor his strife it hath passed
me by,

My spear from the saddle thrust him that his charger he sat
no more;

Yea, great was the fame that I won me by my prowess in
days of yore,

Many knights have I borne from their chargers,—yet it
profiteth not I ween,

Nor outweigheth the bitter shaming that thro' thee hath my
portion been!'380

And with reason good do they hate me, those knights of the
Table Round,

Since eight of their bravest champions have I borne unto the
ground,

And many fair maidens saw it, when at Kanedig fierce we
fought

For the hawk; there was I the victor, and my hand fame to
thee hath brought

And that didst thou see with King Arthur—At his court doth
she dwell to-day,385

My sister, sweet Kunnewaaré, and grave is her mien alway,
For her lips may not move to laughter till the day that her
eyes shall light

On him who of all shall be reckoned the fairest and bravest
knight.

Would he come unto me, that hero! Ah! then should a strife
be seen

As to-day in the early morning already my lot hath been.
390

I have fought, and a prince hath suffered, for joust he toward
me sped,
But my spear-point so sorely smote him that he lay there
before me, dead!'

'Well I know that in righteous anger for a lesser sin than
thine
Full many had slain the sinner, but I would not such deed
were mine!
For the service of knightly honour that to thee I had offered
fair,³⁹⁵
Henceforth shalt thou know but lacking; nor thy need do I
think to spare—
No more with thy white arms circled in love and in peace I'll
lie,
Those golden days of love's glory have faded and passed us
by,
But pale be thy mouth so rosy, and tear-dimmed thy shining
eyes,
For joy shall be put far from thee, and thy heart's songs be
turned to sighs!'⁴⁰⁰

Then sadly she looked upon him, that princess so fair and
true,
'May it be for the honour of knighthood what seemeth thee
best to do,
Wise art thou indeed and loyal, and I in thy power may be,
And I know well that heavy sorrow and pain thou canst
bring on me:
To the ordeal, I prithee, put me, and do this for all women's
sake,⁴⁰⁵
Thereafter, an I be guilty, for my sin do thou vengeance
take!
If another's hand shall slay me, (for *thee* were such deed un-
meet)
Then gladly I'll die—Dost thou scorn me? then welcome is
death, and sweet!'

Then he broke out in bitter anger, 'If thy pride be still so
great,
It is meet I should meekness teach thee, tho' the lesson be all
too late—410
No more shall we be companions, together no more we'll
eat;
Be our marriage couch forgotten and the hours of
communion sweet.
This garment in which I found thee thy only robe shall be,
And instead of jewelled bridle hempen twist will I give to
thee;
Thy steed be the guest of hunger, and thy saddle once
decked so fair415
Shall be robbed of its goodly trappings!' and with hasty hand
he tare
The samite adown, and he brake it, the saddle she rode
erewhile,
(Nor her gentle ways and seemly might his angry wrath
beguile)
With a hempen cord he bound it—Too soon had she won his
hate!
As he did this he spake, 'Now Lady, 'tis best we no longer
wait, 420
Could I reach him who shared thy favours, then fulfilled
were my heart's desire,
The venture I'd face, though as dragon he were breathing
forth flames and fire!'
Then with weeping instead of laughter she passed from out
the tent
That lady so rich in sorrow, and sadly her way she went;
Yet more than she mourned her shaming she wept her lord's
grief, I ween,425
His sorrow so sorely moved her, e'en death would have
lighter been.
Now of true heart shall ye bemoan her who thus did sore
anguish know,

And tho' hatred I won from all women, still I'd mourn for
Jeschuté's woe!

So rode they upon the traces of the lad who before them
fled,
And, dauntless, he little thought him how a foeman behind
him sped,430
But whoever his eyes might light on, as his pathway they
drew anear,
He gave to him kindly greeting, 'Thus bade me my mother
dear!'

Thus rode he, our lad so foolish, adown a mountain side,
When a woman's voice before him from amid the rocks loud
cried;
'Twas a cry of heartfelt sorrow, for her joy was in ruins laid
— 435
Then swift rode the lad towards her,—Now hear what she
did, this maid:
She tore, the maid Siguné, her plaits of long brown hair
From out her head thro' sorrow; and the lad he beheld her
there,
And he saw Schionatulander, the prince, on her knee lie
dead,
And the maiden she wailed above him, and her joy had for
ever fled.440

('If sad be their mien or joyful, my mother she bade me still
Greet all men, whoe'er might meet me) God keep thee from
greater ill,
For in sooth a sorry treasure have I found on thy knee to-
day!
Who hath wounded this knight?' (For an answer the lad he
would press alway)
'Did one with a javelin slay him? For Lady, he sure is dead;
445

Wilt thou tell me naught? Who hath slain him? If he none
too far hath fled
Methinks I might overtake him, for gladly with him I'd
fight!
Then the lad he laid hold on his quiver wherein lay the
javelins bright,
And still in his hand tight claspèd, the tokens twain he bore
Which he in his thoughtless folly erewhile from Jeschuté
tore. 450
Had he known the courtly customs with his father's life in-
bound,
His shield were better smitten when the duchess alone he
found
Who thro' him must suffer sorrow—for more than a whole
year long,
Her husband withheld his favour, tho' in sooth did he do her
wrong.

Now list to this maid Siguné who her grief would bemoan as
meet, 455
She spake to the lad, 'Thou art courteous, all hail! to thy
youth so sweet,
And thy face so fair; yea blessèd thy lot shall hereafter be!
No javelin pierced this hero, but slain in a joust was he—
From truth wast thou born who truly for another's woe can
grieve!'
Then his name she was fain to hearken, ere the lad her side
might leave, 460
And she spake, God with skill had wrought him—But his
answer was naught but this,
'At home all who know me call me '*Bon fils, Cher fils, Beau
fils!*'

Ere ever the word was spoken, the maiden she knew his
name—
Now hearken aright his title, that hereafter ye own his fame

Who is hero of this my venture, who now standeth the maid
beside— 465

And her red lips they spake unfaltering, 'Thou art *Parzival*,'
she cried,

And thy name it shall mean '*to pierce thro*',' for thy mother's
faithful heart

With furrow of grief was riven when she from her lord must
part:

And I speak not that those shouldst vaunt thee; thy mother
my aunt shall be,

And in truth, with no guile of falsehood, thy race will I tell
to thee!'470

'An Angevin was thy father, thy mother of fair Waleis,
And I know for a truth thy birthplace was the city of
Kanvoleis;

And thou art the King of Norgals, and there in the citadel
As king shalt thou bear the sceptre and crown as beseems
thee well.

For thy sake was he slain, this hero, who thy kingdom for
thee would guard,475

His truth it hath faltered never, tho' in death did he find
reward.

Two brothers have wrought thee evil, two kingdoms from
thee have reft,

And Orilus this thy kinsman in a joust hath lifeless left.

And me too hath he left in sorrow—He served me nor
thought it shame,

This prince of thy land, where my childhood did thy
mother's tending claim.480

Now fair and sweet my cousin wouldst thou hear how he
met his end?

'Twas the fair wove leash of a brachet that brought sorrow
unto my friend—

He hath served us twain, in our service hath he won him but
death alone,

And I, I have won but sorrow, and henceforth for his death
make moan,
For scant of wit was I surely, that I gave not my love afore—
485
So God hath my gladness shattered, and the dead I love
evermore!

Then he spake, 'I must mourn, O cousin, thy grief, and my
bitter wrong,
Of a truth till I may avenge them the time seemeth over-
long!'
Then straight would he ride to battle, but the way did she
falsely show,
For she feared were he slain then henceforward yet sorer
should wax her woe.490
But a road he found that led him straightway to the Breton's
land,
And smooth and wide was that highway—An there met him
on either hand
Afoot or ahorse a merchant or knight, he would greet them
still,
For so was his mother's counsel; and she spake with no
thought of ill.

But great weariness o'ertook him, as darkened the eventide,
495
And a house that was none too stately the youth in his folly
spied.
'Twas a churl he who sat within it, discourteous by birth and
low,
(A fisherman he, little kindness might one at his hand e'er
know)
Then the lad drew rein for he hungered, and craved of him
drink and meat.
But the host quoth, 'Nay, not a half-loaf shalt thou have at
mine hand to eat500

In thirty years; he who waiteth, in the gifts of mine hand to
share,
O'er-long shall delay his journey—For none but myself I
care,
Thereafter perchance for my children—Thou comest not
here to-day,
Hadst thou money or pledge 'twere other, then thine host
would I be straightway!'505

Then Jeschuté's clasp all golden the lad he would bid him
take,
And soon as the peasant saw it, with smiling mouth he
spake,
'Wilt thou stay here, sweet lad? then due honour be thy
portion from all within—'
'Wilt thou feed me to-night and to-morrow wilt help me the
way to win
To King Arthur (for well I love him) then thyself mayst keep
the gold!'510
'Yea, that will I do,' quoth the peasant, 'for ne'er might mine
eyes behold
A face and form so comely—I will thee, as a marvel, bring
To the court, and the good Round Table, and the face of the
noble king!'

So the lad thro' the night abode there, and ere ever the dawn
of day
He roused himself full eager to get on his onward way, 515
And the fisher, he made him ready, and before the lad he ran,
And the boy he rode behind him, and swift were both steed
and man.

(Herr Hartmann von Aue, and thy lady, the queenly
Guinevere,
And thy gallant lord, King Arthur, a guest do I bring ye here;
No tool is he for your mocking, nay, never a harp or lute,
520

Ye shall choose ye some other plaything, such as courtesy
 well doth suit;
Else will I thy lady Enid, and her mother Karnafite
Pass under the mill, and their honour with bitter scorn I'll
 smite—
Tho' I tune my song to mocking, and thy lips with mockery
 seal,
Yet here will I guard my hero lest thy scorn he perchance
 should feel!)525

When the lad with his guide so humble to the city walls
 drew near,
And Nantes might be well discernèd in the morning light so
 clear,
'God keep thee, boy,' said the fisher, 'thou seest where thou
 must ride.'
Quoth the lad yet scant in knowledge, 'Yet nearer must thou
 be guide!'
'Nay, nay, so proud as these court-folk, such folly be far
 from me,530
An' a peasant came nigh unto them, his welcome would
 sorry be!'

So alone the lad rode onward o'er a plain that was none too
 wide,
And the flowers stood fair around him and blossomed on
 every side,
No Kurwenal was his teacher and of courtesy knew he
 naught—
They know it not, the untravelled, till the world hath wisdom
 taught—535
Of hempen twist his bridle, and feeble and faint his steed,
And oft it fell, as stumbling it went o'er the flowery mead.
And nowhere upon his saddle fair leather and new was seen;
And of samite fair and ermine full great his lack had been.
No mantle clasp he needed, nor knightly garb he wore, 540
Of blazoned coat or surcoat; his javelin alone he bore.

He whose deeds were praised of all men, his father so brave
and wise,
Was robed in far other fashion on the carpet 'fore Kanvoleis!

He who ne'er felt the sweat of terror, to him did a knight
draw near;
Then he greeted him, 'May God keep thee! thus bade me my
mother dear.'⁵⁴⁵
'God reward thee, lad, and thy mother,' swift answer the
knight would bring,
(Uther Pendragon reared him, he was cousin unto the king,
And unto the land of Bretagne did the self-same knight lay
claim)
He was Ither of Gaheviess, 'The Red Knight' they called his
name.

All dazzling red was his armour, the eye from its glow
gleamed red;⁵⁵⁰
Red was his horse swift-footed, and the plumes that should
deck its head,
Of samite red its covering; redder than flame his shield;
Fair-fashioned and red his surcoat; and the spear that his
hand would wield
Was red, yea, the shaft and the iron; and red at the knight's
desire
Was his sword, yet the blade's fair keenness was not dimmed
by the raging fire.⁵⁵⁵
And the King of Cumberland, stately, in his mailèd hand did
hold
A goblet, with skill engraven, and wrought of the good red
gold—
From the Table Round had he reft it—All red was his
shining hair
Yet white was his skin, and kindly his speech to the lad and
fair.

'Now hail to thy fair young body, that in sooth a true woman
bare, 560

Yea, blessèd is she thy mother! Ne'er saw I a face so fair,
And the light of thine eyes, I think me, is kindled by love
alone,

And Love shall in thee be victor, as by thee Love is
overthrown!

And in thee is the joy of woman, whose bliss finds in thee its
goal,

And for thee shall the load of sorrow weigh heavy upon the
soul— 565

Now do me this grace I pray thee, an thou wend thee unto
the town

Bear greeting from me to King Arthur, and his heroes of
high renown,

And say that no fleeting vision am I who now speak with
thee,

But here I abide, and await him who thinketh to joust with
me!'

'And never a man will wonder: to the Table Round I came
570

And there, in the heroes' presence to my kingdom would I
lay claim,

And with hasty hand I raised it, this cup, and the wine out-
poured

The robes of the queen besprinkled, as she sat there beside
her lord.

This I did as the custom olden of one who would claim his
right

For better I thought the wine-cup, than the straw-wisp all
alight, 575

For its smoke perchance had soiled me, thus I chose it not'
spake the king,

'Nor for robbery rode I hither, my crown doth forbid such
thing—

Say thou to the queen that the wine-drops, they fell on her
 'gainst my will
Where those heroes sit, nor remember, nor their knighthood
 as meet fulfil.
Whether kings they shall be or princes o'er-long doth he
 thirst their king!580
This cup, why delay to fetch it? Their fame it hath taken
 wing!

Then the lad spake, 'I'll bear thy message, yea, e'en as thou
 biddest me.'
And then unto Nantes fair city he gat him right speedily,
And many a youth they followed to the court of the palace
 fair,
And 'twas filled with a motley gathering, and they thronged
 him and pressed him there.585
Then Iwanet sprang from out them, and this youth from
 falsehood free
He gave him a kindly greeting, and he proffered him
 company.
And the lad he quoth, 'God keep thee, (so my mother she
 bade me speak
Ere yet from home I wended) King Arthur I fain would seek
But here see I full many an Arthur! Who of all these shall
 make me knight?'590
Then Iwanet laughed loud 'I will show thee, not yet hast
 thou seen the right!'

To the Table Round he led him where sat the heroes all
And as best he could for the tumult cried the lad thro' the
 lofty hall,
'God keep ye all ye heroes! I greet ye both queen and king,
For thus did my mother bid me fair greeting to ye to bring.
 595
And all who have won by their valour at the Table Round a
 seat
Ye gallant knights and heroes, ye too did she bid me greet!

But in one thing my skill doth fail me, who is host here I
may not know;
To him do I bear a message from a knight who all red doth
glow,
He waiteth without the portal (methinks he is fain to fight)
600
That he spilt o'er the queen the wine-cup that sorely doth
grieve the knight—
Ah! if I his gear so goodly from the king's hand as gift might
take,
In sooth were I rich in gladness—so knightly and fair its
make!'

Thus spake the youth gay and careless, and the courtiers
they thronged around
And hither and thither pressed him till scarce might he stand
his ground:605
And well did they look upon him, for each for himself might
see
That never in man or maiden might the fruit of love fairer
be.
And in truth it was no ill working that in Parzival God had
wrought,
In whom never a sight of terror had wakened of fear a
thought.

Thus they brought him before King Arthur, he whom God
for a wonder chose,610
And no man might bear him hatred—Then the queen from
her seat arose
And she gazed for a space upon him ere she passed from out
the hall
Where the wine from the golden goblet perforce on her
robes must fall.
Then Arthur he looked upon him—To the simple youth he
spake,
'Now lad to thy kindly greeting a kindly answer take, 615

For this would I do thee service, yea with body alike and
land;
This I speak of a true heart truly, so my will doth toward
thee stand!'

'Would to God that were true! Now I think me it well-nigh a
year shall be

That I fain would be knight, lacking knighthood all else
seemeth ill to me!

Now make thou no more delaying, be knighthood my lot
straightway.' 620

Quoth the king, 'I were fain to do so if worth fail me not
always,

So noble art thou to look on; and goodly gifts and rare
Would I give thee; to do thee service I'll naught of my
treasure spare.

Yea, loath had I been to refuse thee, wait but for to-morrow's
light,

And I myself will dower thee with all that befits a knight.'
625

The lad like a bird new caged, he shook himself to and fro,
And he quoth, 'For naught do I ask thee! But that knight who
as fire doth glow

If thou givest me not his armour no gift will I take from
thee,

My *mother* will not withhold it—For a queen shall she
surely be.'

Then Arthur he quoth, 'That armour so gallant a knight doth
wear 630

That to give thee a gift so goodly methinks I may hardly
dare.

And guiltless I live in sorrow since his homage I must
forego,

It is he of Gaheviess; thro' my joy hath he wrought me
woe.'

'Now my King sure it were ungracious to say to his pleading
 nay,
Thou shalt give him what he desireth, nor think it too great,'
 quoth Kay, 635
'Let him forth to the plain; bid him bring thee the cup if it be
 thy will!
Here hast thou the whip, there the top is, let the child have of
 sport his fill.
The women, forsooth, will praise him, and it seemeth good
 to me
He should learn to take blows an he gives them, many such
 will his portion be.
For the life of the twain what care I? Each of us needs must
 have his day, 640
If thy dogs for the spoil shall hunger, thou must e'en give thy
 dogs their way.'
'I were loath to refuse his pleading, yet I feared lest he here
 be slain,
And to knighthood I fain had helped him.' Thus Arthur he
 spake again.

Thus the lad won the gift he craved for, which many
 perforce must rue,
And young and old they followed, as forth from the hall he
 flew. 645
By the hand would Iwanet lead him, 'fore a bower that was
 none too high,
And backward and forward turning the lad gazed with eager
 eye.
And the bower was so low that within it the lad he both
 heard and saw,
And therefrom did he win a sorrow that vexed him with
 torment sore.

The queen from her bower window to look on the sight was
 fain, 650

And her knights and maidens round her they gazed and they
gazed again.
And the maiden Kunnewaaré she sat there, the fair and
proud,
And never, that man might wot of, had she laughed or low or
loud.
For never she vowed, an she died first, would she laugh ere
her eyes might see
That knight, who of knights the bravest or was, or
henceforth should be.655
As the lad rode beneath the window she brake into laughter
sweet,
And her back was sore from the guerdon—reward for a
maid unmeet!
For Kay the Seneschal seized her, the maiden of fair
Lalande,
By her waving hair, and the tresses he wound fast around his
hand,
Without a band he bound her—Tho' never an oath she sware
660
His staff he laid unknighly on her maiden shoulders fair,
And ere ever the sound of the smiting on the ear had died
away
Thro' white skin and royal raiment had he wounded the maid
that day.

And thus did he speak in his folly, 'Now hast thou thine own
fair fame
Cast aside, and I wot thou hast done it to thine own mending
shame!665
Now see, e'en in flight have I caught it, and I bring it to thee
once more
In such wise thou mayst well remember, and be e'en in the
memory sore:
For I wot well unto King Arthur, to his court and his palace
hall

Many gallant men have ridden, yet hast thou despised them
all,
And ne'er hast thou smiled upon them—And now doth thy
laughter ring⁶⁷⁰
For one knowing naught of knighthood! Unseemly I deem
this thing!

Now whate'er might be done in anger I wot well no king's
decree
Had bid him thus smite the maiden; and her friends mourned
her bitterly.
(Might she bear knightly shield and armour it had helped not
this sore disgrace,
Discourteous the blows were smitten.) She came of a royal
race, ⁶⁷⁵
Had her gallant brothers seen it, Lähelein and Orilus
Far fewer blows had fallen; she ne'er had been smitten thus.

Now Sir Antanor the Silent, who thro' silence a fool was
thought,
(His speech and the maiden's laughter on a self-same thread
were wrought)
For never a word would he utter till she laughed whom Kay
thus did smite,⁶⁸⁰
As clear rang the maiden's laughter, aloud spake the silent
knight,
'Now here before God I tell thee, Kunnewaaré of fair
Lalande
Thou hast wronged for that lad, and thy guerdon awaiteth
thee at his hand,
Nor so weak shall he be, nor so foolish, but he turneth thy
bliss to bale!'
'And thy speech thou hast found but to threaten for joy shall
it naught avail.'⁶⁸⁵
His food would he make full bitter.—Kay smote him upon
the ear

With his fist till naught but a singing and a whispering might
he hear.

And Parzival saw the sorrow of the maiden and Antanor,
And his heart was hot for their shaming, and grief for their
sake he bore,

And he grasped his javelin tightly, but the throng pressed so
close around⁶⁹⁰

That perforce the dart must he lower, lest some other aim it
found.

Thus alone from the court of King Arthur rode the son of
Gamuret,

And he came to the plain where the Red Knight his foeman
awaited yet;

And he bare unto him the tidings how in Nantes was there
never a knight

Whose heart yet yearned for jousting, or who lusted with
him to fight.⁶⁹⁵

'But a gift King Arthur gave me—I spake as thou saidst
before,

That without thy will had it chanced thee the wine o'er the
queen to pour,

Thy discourtesy sorely vexed thee—They think not to fight
with thee.

Now give me the steed thou ridest, and thine harness give
thou to me,

They were given me in the palace, therein shall I be a
knight, ⁷⁰⁰

Wouldst withhold them, I will not greet thee—Yield thou
what is mine of right!'

Then the King of Cumberland answered, 'If Arthur hath
given to thee

Mine armour, my *life* he gave thee, if that life thou canst
take from me,

So well doth he love his kinsmen! Hath he known thee
before to-day,

That so swiftly the service done him with such guerdon he
would repay?'705

'I may win what I will I trow me, of a sooth had he given me
more;
Now leave thou thy claim on his kingdom—'Tis time I a
knight's shield bore
For *squire* will I be no longer!' He laid on the rein his hand
'Thou art Lâhelein, so I think me, who hath taken from me
my land!'

Then the knight he turned his spear-shaft, and he struck with
so true a blow710
That the lad and his sorry charger on the meadow he laid
them low,
And the hero was swift in his anger, and he smote with a
will so good
That there where the spear-shaft struck him there sprang
forth bright drops of blood.
Then Parzival sprang up swiftly and stood wrathful upon his
feet
And he grasped his javelin firmly—Where the helm and the
visor meet715
And betwixt the twain is an opening, there the javelin
swiftly sped
And thro' eye and neck it struck him, and the knight on the
plain lay dead.
Fierce foe had he been to falsehood; women's sighs, true
hearts wounded sore,
Were the fruit of his death, and with tear-drops must many
an eye run o'er.
And they whom his love made joyful their gladness asunder
brake, 720
And their joy to the goal of sorrow o'er a rough road its way
must take.

Then Parzival in his folly turned the dead knight o'er and
o'er,
For fain would he loose his armour, yet was lacking the
needful lore.
He fingered both helm and corslet with his bare white hands
alone,
Yet the fastening he failed to loosen, nor with force might
they be undone⁷²⁵
Tho' oft and again he tried them, who in wisdom was all
untaught.
Then the horses they neighed so loudly that the sound on the
breeze was brought
To Iwanet's ear, and he heard them, by the city moat he
stood,
(To Queen Guinevere was he kinsman, and he did to her
service good)
He heard the cry of the horses, but naught of the riders saw,
⁷³⁰
As his true heart would give him counsel, Parzival did he
seek once more.

And Ither lay dead; and his slayer by his folly was vexed
amain—
Then swiftly he sprang to aid him, and Parzival thanks must
gain
For the honour he here had won him o'er the hero of
Cumberland:
'God reward thee, but give me counsel for skill here doth fail
mine hand,⁷³⁵
How best may I loose this armour which myself I were fain
to wear?'
'Such lore I right well may teach thee,' quoth Iwanet the
proud and fair,
So the armour was reft from the dead man, 'fore Nantes on
the grassy plain,
And they did it upon the living, o'er whose dealings did folly
reign.

Quoth Iwanet, 'These leather leggings fit not with the mailed
gear,740

As a *knight* shalt thou now be clothèd,' and the lad deemed it
ill to hear;

Quoth Parzival, 'What my mother aforetime hath given me
That cometh not from my body, or for good or for ill it be!'
And much did Iwanet marvel, for clever was he i' troth,
Yet he followed perforce his bidding, nor waxed at his folly
wroth.745

And he drew above the leggings the hosen of shining mail,
Nor the spurs with red gold in-wroughten should unto the
harness fail,

And of silk and gold the laces, nor leather might there be
found.

Ere he gave unto him the corslet he bound him with greaves
around,

And tho' o'er-long Parzival deemed it yet the time was
swiftly sped,750

Ere in knightly armour shining he clad him from foot to
head.

Then the lad would have ta'en his quiver, but Iwanet he
spake out free,

'Nay, no javelin will I give thee, unknighly such arms shall
be!'

Then he girt the sharp sword around him, and he showed
how to draw the blade,

And he bade him ne'er fly in battle, nor in conflict to be
dismayed.755

Then nearer he led unto him the charger the dead knight
rode,

And 'twas tall and strong, yet the saddle the youth with one
spring bestrode,

He recked not the weight of his armour, and of stirrups had
little need—

E'en to-day do men speak of his swiftness, and the fame of
his mighty deeds.

Nor o'er-much did Iwanet think it to teach him with fitting
skill 760
To hold his shield and to guard him, while he wrought to his
foeman ill;
And a spear in his hand he gave him—But Parzival turned
aside,
'Nay, nay, what good may that do me?' 'If a joust one with
thee would ride
Thou shalt on thy foeman break it, perchance drive it thro'
his shield,
If thou doest that oft, 'fore the maidens will they praise thee
for well-fought field.'765

And this hath the venture told me,—Not in Maestricht, or
e'en Cologne
Might a painter so fair a picture as this lad and his steed
have shown.
Then straightway he spake to Iwanet, 'My friend and
companion dear,
The boon that I asked have I won me, of that art thou
witness here.
My service bear thou to the city, to Arthur the noble king,
770
And mourn unto him my shaming—This cup thou again
shalt bring,
And tell him a knight hath wronged me, since he smote that
maiden fair
Who looked, and who laughed upon me, and grief for her
grief I bear.
Nor hath it but lightly touched me, it hath pierced to my
inmost heart
This maid's woe all undeservèd—Now do thou in her shame
have part 775
Thro' the friendship that thou hast shown me! God keep thee
in peace alway,
And watch o'er us twain, for I think me no longer I here may
stay!'

And Ither the prince of Gaheviess on the plain had he
 lifeless left,
E'en in death was he fair to look on who was thus of fair life
 bereft.
If in joust by a spear-thrust pierced he thro' knighthood his
 death must gain⁷⁸⁰
Who had mourned for the grief and the marvel? By a javelin
 he here was slain.
Then Iwanet he strewed above him a covering of blossoms
 bright,
And he smote the shaft of the javelin in the ground by the
 fallen knight,
And that lad so true and faithful, he pierced with the crimson
 blade
A bough of wood, and in this wise a cross o'er the dead man
 made. ⁷⁸⁵
Then he gat him again to the city, and the heavy tidings told;
And from many a trembling woman, and from many a hero
 bold
Rose the wail of love and of sorrow; and the dead would
 they fetch in state,
And the Host they bare before her, as the queen passed the
 city gate.

Then o'er Cumberland's prince and hero, who by Parzival's
 hand was slain,⁷⁹⁰
Queen Guinevere spake in sorrow while her tear-drops they
 flowed amain,
'Alas! alas! for broken in twain is King Arthur's might,
For he whom the good Round Table accounted its bravest
 knight
Here slain before Nantes he lieth! His heritage did he claim
Where men gave him death for his guerdon—For naught
 marred his knightly fame;⁷⁹⁵
Here long hath he dwelt among us in such wise that never an
 ear

The tale of a deed unknightly, or wrong he had done, might
hear.

He held him afar from falsehood, to guile was he aye a foe;
The lock and the seal of knighthood all too soon must we
bury low.

His heart wise in courteous wisdom, and steadfast as seal
and sign, 800

Taught him ever the fairest counsel that a man's heart might
aye divine,

Whereby with true love and courage a man woman's love
may woo

And show manhood's truth—Fruit-bearing it seedeth itself
anew

The plant of all woman's sorrow! From thy wounds grief
shall ever grow—

So red was thy hair that the blossoms that bloom here thy
corse below 805

Scarce redder may be with thy life-blood—All laughter hast
thou forbid

To fair women, and joy and gladness by thy death are for
ever hid.'

Thus Ither, beloved of all men, as a king in the grave was
laid,—

With his life must he pay for his armour who taught sighing
to many a maid,

Since Parzival in his folly for the harness his death had
sought, 810

Hereafter, when he won wisdom, he scarcely such deed had
wrought!

NOW this might ye mark in the charger, great labour it held
as naught,

Were it hot, were it cold, no journey the sweat on its coat
had brought;

It sped over stone or tree-trunk, and scarce was there need to
draw

The girth by one hole the tighter if the knight for two days it
bore.815

So fully armed, in his folly yet further he rode that day
Than a wise man unarmed in two days if his steed he
betimes would stay.

And ever it onward galloped, and but seldom would walk or
trot,
How to check its speed by the bridle as yet Parzival knew
not.

Then he saw the roof of a castle rise fair in the evening glow,
820

And the lad he thought in his folly that the towers from the
earth must grow

Since the one roof bare so many—And he thought Arthur
sowed such seed,

And he who could work such marvels were a holy man
indeed!

Then he said, 'While at home I tarried ne'er looked I on
woodland field

That a crop so rich and so stately in growth might ever yield;
825

I think me my mother's people their labour but little know,
For never too dry, I think me, is the soil where their seed
they sow!'—

Now Gurnemanz of Graharz of this mighty Burg was lord:
At his portal a spreading linden stood fair on the summer
sward,

Nor too long nor too wide was the meadow, and the horse
and the road they led830

To where Parzival found him seated who of castle and land
was head.

Now weariness sore constrained him, nor his shield might he
rightly hold

But it backward and forward wavered as beseemed not a
rider bold.

And Prince Gurnemanz sat all lonely, and the boughs of the
linden tree
Gave shade as was meet to its master, the captain of courtesy
— 835
And his life it fled from falsehood—Then e'en as should be
his right
He gave to the guest fair welcome, and with him stood nor
squire nor knight.

Then Parzival made him answer—In his folly he spake
straightway,
'My mother bade me seek counsel from an old man with
locks of grey;
For thy rede will I do thee service, for so did my mother
speak!' 840
'If here thou art come for counsel, and aid at my lips would
seek,
Thy favour thou still shalt leave me whatever my counsel be,
If thou will that thy prayer I hearken, and give rede as seem
best to me!'

Then the prince cast a yearling falcon from his hand and
aloft it flew,
And it winged its way to the castle, and its golden bells rang
true, 845
'Twas a messenger; and the pages came swiftly in garments
fair,
And he bade them to lead the guest in, and lodging as meet
prepare;
And the lad he spake in his folly, 'My mother she told me
true,
An thou follow an old man's counsel his rede shalt thou
never rue!

And the pages they led him straightway where stood many a
gallant knight, 850

And there in the castle courtyard from his steed did they bid
him light.

Spake the youth, and he showed his folly, 'Tis a King who
hath bidden me

Be a knight, and whate'er befall me on this charger my seat
shall be.

My mother she bade me greet ye!' And mother they thanked
and son,

(Both horse and man were wearied) then, the words of
greeting done,855

Full many a time they urged him, but it cost them many a
thought

Ere the lad within the castle, and from off his steed they
brought.

Then they led him to a chamber, and they prayed the
stranger guest,

'Let us loose thine harness off thee, that thy wearied limbs
find rest.'

But scarce had they loosed his armour when lo! there came
to view 860

A garment e'en such as Fools wear, and leggings of calf-skin
new;

Then startled and shamed they turned them, and they
whispered each to all,

And with bated breath the tidings ran swift through the
castle hall,

And the host for shame was speechless—But a knight spake
in courtesy,

'Let that be as it may, one so noble mine eyes they might
never see,865

And Good Fortune hath looked upon him by his mien so
high and fair—

Ah! he whom Love's light hath chosen, who bade him such
garb to wear?

And it grieveth me sore to find thus on the World's Joy such
poor attire.

Ah! well for the mother who bare him, she hath won her full
heart's desire!

And his helmet is decked so costly; ere his harness from him
we took⁸⁷⁰

It became him well, and knightly and noble I ween his look,
And many a bruise and blood-stain the lad on his limbs doth
bear.'

Quoth the host, "Tis perchance a woman who bade him such
garb to wear!"

'Nay, Sire, for so strange his bearing he would know not a
maid to pray

To take from him knightly homage,—Tho' his face is so fair
always⁸⁷⁵

It had fitted him well for Love's service.' Then the host
spake, "Tis best we see

This lad, in whose strange attiring a marvel for sure shall
be!"

Then to Parzival they betook them, and they found that a
wound he bare

From a spear that was never shattered, and the host for his
hurts would care,

And so kindly I ween his tending that a father, whose
heartfelt love⁸⁸⁰

To his children, found no denial, his faith might no better
prove.

And he washed his wounds and bound them, the prince, with
his own right hand,

Ere forth to the hall he led him where the evening meal
should stand.

And food the guest sore needed, and hungry was he alway,
From the house of the fisherman fasting had he ridden at
break of day,⁸⁸⁵

And his wound and the heavy harness which he before
Nantes had won

Wrought him weariness sore and hunger ere ever the ride
was done.

For from Arthur the King of the Bretons the whole day he
needs must ride,

Nor his fast at the Court had broken, and now it was
eventide.

Then the host bade him eat at his table, and Parzival did his
will,⁸⁹⁰

And the food it swiftly vanished, as if one would a manger
fill!

And Gurnemanz was well pleasèd, and ever the lad did pray
To eat as he would, and his hunger and weariness put away.

When 'twas time, and the meal was ended, 'Now weary art
thou, I ween,'

Quoth the host to his guest, 'If this morning betimes thou a-
foot hast been?'⁸⁹⁵

'God knoweth my mother slumbered, so early she ne'er doth
wake.'

Then the host he laughed, and he led him where rest he right
well might take,

And he bade him disrobe, tho' unwilling, he needs must—
An ermine fair

They cast o'er his naked body,—fairer fruit never woman
bare!

By weariness taught to slumber, but seldom throughout the
night ⁹⁰⁰

On his other side did he turn him, he might well wait the
morning light.

Then the prince he bade his servants ere ever 'twas middle
day,

A bath, as was meet, make ready by the couch where the
young knight lay,

And roses they threw within it—And tho' he no call might
hear

The guest awoke from his slumbers, and he stepped in the
waters clear.905

I know not who sent them hither, but maidens richly dressed,
Lovely and sweet to look on, all courteous sought the guest,
They washed his wounds and bound them with their hands
so soft and white,

(Nor should this o'er strange have seemed him who was reft
of wisdom's might)

And both ease he felt and gladness, nor his folly they made
him rue—910

Thus these fair and gentle maidens they tended the lad anew,
And they spake 'twixt themselves, and he hearkened, yet
never a word would say,

Yet too early he might not deem it, for they shone as a
second day,

And their beauty it vied with the morning, yet his fairness
outshone the twain,

For naught to the youth was lacking that favour and praise
might gain.915

Then a linen cloth they proffered, but the lad he took it ill,
An he robed himself before them, their presence should
shame him still.

Perforce must the maidens leave him, nor longer might
linger there

Tho' in sooth they would fain have questioned lest deeper
the wounds he bare.

(For such was the way of woman, and such is true woman's
will, 920

Tho' scatheless themselves yet the sorrow of a friend it doth
work them ill.)

Then he strode to the bed, and he found there fresh raiment
so fine and white,

With a girdle he bound it round him, 'twas of silk and of
gold so bright;

And hosen of scarlet woollen they drew on the fearless
knight,

In sooth they well became him who was comely in all men's
sight. 925

And of ruddy brown well fashioned, (nor lining they thought
to spare)

Were robe alike and mantle, and within was the ermine fair,
And without were they decked with sable, both black and
grey in hue;

Then the gallant youth the mantle around his shoulders
threw,

With a belt so rich and costly he girt him round the waist,
930

And the fastening of the mantle with a golden clasp was
graced.

And his mouth was red and glowing—Then his host he drew
anigh,

And many a proud knight followed, to greet him
courteously,

And e'en as 'twas done the heroes they spake with a great
amaze

'Ne'er saw they a man so goodly!'—And all would the
mother praise 935

Who such son to the world had given—And in truth and in
courtesy

They spake, 'Whatsoever he asketh for his service fulfilled
shall be,

And favour and love await him if his worth win its meed
always,'

And of those who hereafter saw him none were there who
said them nay.

By his hand the host then took him, and forth from his
chamber led, 940

And the prince fain would hear the story how the night hours
with him had sped,

'Were it otherwise, I think me that living I scarce might
wake,

'Twas well that my mother bade me thus shelter with thee to
take

Ere yet from her I had ridden—May God requite ye both,
For mercy Sir Knight, and kindness, hast thou shown to me
nothing loth.'945

So went our hero witless where to God and the host they'd
sing,

And the prince by the Mass would teach him that which
health to the soul shall bring.

He would rede him well of the Offering—How to sign
himself with the Cross,

And thus work on the Devil vengeance, who seeketh for aye
our loss!

Then again to the hall of the castle and the morning meal
they came,950

And the host set his guest beside him, and he ate without
fear or shame.

Then out spake the prince so courteous, 'An it seemeth not
ill to thee,

Fain am I to know thy dwelling, and from whence thou art
come to me?'

Then frankly he told the story how his mother's side he fled,
Of the ring and the clasp so golden, and the winning the
harness red.955

And the prince he knew the Red Knight, and his fate it
pleased him ill,

And the name of his guest he asked not but 'The Red Knight'
he called him still.

Then e'en as the meal was over, were they tamed the ways
so wild,

For the host to his guest he quoth thus 'Thou speakest as
doth a child,

Why hold not thy peace of thy mother, and otherwise turn
thy speech?960

An thou follow henceforth my counsel far wiser the ways I'll
teach!'

'And thus I begin, do thou hearken—From true shame shalt
thou never flee,
A shameless man, bethink thee, what place in the world hath
he?

As a bird that moulteth ever so his honour doth fall away,
And hereafter he hath his portion in the fires of Hell for aye.'
965

'So noble methinks thy bearing, a folk's Lord thou well
mayst be;
If high be thy birth, and yet higher the lot that awaiteth thee,
Then see that thy heart hath pity for the poor and needy man
And fight thou against his sorrow with free gifts as best thou
can,

For a true knight must aye be humble—A brave man who
need doth know⁹⁷⁰

Full often with shame he battles, and sore is that strife I
trow,

For him shall thy help be ready—(Who lighteneth his
brother's need

From Heaven he winneth favour as rewarding for righteous
deed.)

For in sooth his case is harder than theirs who as beggars
stand

'Neath the window, and succour seeking, for bread shall
stretch forth the hand.'⁹⁷⁵

'Thou shalt learn in a fitting measure both rich and poor to
be,

Who spendeth as lord at all times no lordly soul hath he—

Yet who heapeth o'er-much his treasure he winneth methinks
but shame,

But give thou unto each their honour, so best shalt thou
guard thy fame.'

'I saw well as thou earnest hither that thou hadst of my
counsel need—980
Yield not unto ways discourteous but give to thy bearing
heed,
Nor be thou so swift to question—Yet I would not that thou
withhold
An answer good and fitting to the speech one with thee
would hold.
Thou canst hear and see, I wot well full five shalt thy senses
be,
An thou use them aright, then wisdom it draweth anear to
thee.' 985

'In thy wrath remember mercy, and slay not a conquered foe,
He who to thine arms shall yield him take his pledge and let
him go;
Unless he such ill have wrought thee as sorrow of heart doth
give,
An my counsel thou fain wouldst follow, then in sooth shalt
thou let him live.'

'Full oft shalt thou bear thy harness—When thy knightly task
is sped990
Thy hands and face thou shalt cleanse them from the rust
and the iron red,
For such is in truth thy duty, so thy face shall be fair and
bright,
And when maiden's eyes behold thee they shall deem thee a
goodly sight.'

'Be manly and of good courage, so shalt thou deserve thy
fame;
Hold women in love and honour, it shall be to thine own
good name; 995
And be ever steadfast-minded as befitteth good man and
true,

An with lies thou wouldst fain deceive them much harm can
thy dealings do.

If true love be repaid with falsehood then swift shalt the
judgment be,

And a speedy end to all honour and renown shall it bring to
thee.

As beneath the stealthy footsteps of the thief the dry stick
breaks,1000

And the slumbering watcher, startled, to his danger swiftly
wakes

So false ways and dealings crooked in their wake bring but
strife and woe;

Prove this by true love, for true women have skill 'gainst the
hidden foe,

And their wiles can outweigh his cunning—An thou winnest
from women hate,

Then for ever art thou dishonoured, and shame on thy life
shall wait.'1005

'So take thou to heart my counsel—And more would I tell to
thee;

Husband and wife united as one shall they ever be,

As the sun that this morning shineth, and this morn that we
call to-day,

So the twain may be sundered never but *one* shall be held
always.

As twin blossoms from one root springing e'en so shall they
bloom and grow;1010

With wisdom receive my counsel that its truth thou hereafter
know.'

Then he thanked his host for his teaching, nor spake of his
mother more,

But as true man and son so loving in his heart her memory
bore.

Then the prince spake as did him honour, 'Yet more will I
teach to thee,
Thou shalt learn knightly skill and bearing—In such wise
didst thou come to me,1015
Full many a wall have I looked on that the shields might
better deck
Than that shield erewhile became thee, as it hung there
around thy neck.
None too late shall be the morning, we'll hence to the open
field,
And fitting skill I'll teach thee that thine arms thou mayst
rightly wield.
So bring to my guest his charger, and mine shalt thou hither
lead,1020
And each knight shall make him ready, and mount, e'en as I,
his steed.
And pages shall thither follow, and each one shall bear a
spear,
And the shaft shall be strong and untested, and blazoned
with colours clear.'

So the prince and his guest together they rode to the grassy
plain,
And many a feat so skilful was shown by that knightly train.
1025
And the lad he learned how to check him his charger in
seeming flight
With touch of spur, and turn him once more 'gainst the
foeman's might;
His spear to sink as needed, and before him hold his shield
As he rode a joust; 'Thus shalt thou thine arms in future
wield!'

Thus of lack of skill he cured him better than by the bough
1030
That smiteth unruly children and breaketh their skin I trow.

Then he bade swift knights come hither, and a joust with the
stranger ride,
And himself to the ring he led him, and against the foe
would guide;
And the lad in his first joust carried his spear through the
foeman's shield,
And tho' strong was the knight yet he smote him from his
steed on the open field.1035

And they marvelled much who beheld it—Then another to
joust rode near,
And Parzival took unto him a fresh and unbroken spear,
And his youth had strength and courage—The beardless lad
and fair
Was spurred by his inborn manhood, and to Gamuret's skill
was heir—
Then he urged his charger onward full swiftly against the
foe, 1040
And his spear rang true on the four nails, and struck nor too
high nor low,
Nor the host's knight might keep his saddle, but prone on the
sward he fell,
Of the spear-shaft full many a splinter the force of the blow
might tell.
Thus five of the knights were smitten ere the host to the
Burg would ride,
And the victory was his, and hereafter fierce strife might he
well abide.1045

Then they who his deeds had witnessed, the wise men, they
needs must say
That great was the skill and valour he had shown in the joust
that day,
'Our lord may be free of sorrow, and his youth it may bloom
anew
If he give him to wife his daughter, our lady so fair and true.

If we see him wax in wisdom then the sorrow shall be
o'erpast— 1050
The death of his sons a shadow o'erlong o'er his life hath
cast,
But now to his door hath ridden one who maketh amends for
all,
And gladness no more shall fly him, but it seeketh his palace
hall!

Then homeward they turned at even when the board for the
feast was spread,
And the prince bade his daughter hither (for so I the tale
have read)1055
As he saw the maid draw near him the host to Liassé spake,
'To this knight shalt thou do all honour, and a kiss from his
lips shalt take,
With Good Fortune for guide he fareth! And of *thee* would I
pray this thing,
If token perchance she beareth, thou wilt leave to the maid
her ring—
Yet none hath she, nor clasp—Who should give her what
that forest princess wore?1060
For *she* won from the hand of her husband what thine hand
from her raiment tore,
From *Liassé* canst thou take little'—Then the lad he must
blush for shame,
On her lips did kiss the maiden, and her mouth it was red as
flame.
And Liassé was fair to look on, and gentle of heart and pure,
And a hero might well have loved her with a love that
should aye endure.1065

Full long and low was the table, nor many might sit thereat,
At its head was the prince so kindly, and his guest by his
side he set
Betwixt him and his daughter, and the maiden with snow-
white hand

Must carve, as he willed, for the Red Knight, so her father
would give command,
And courteous, she did his bidding, and none did the twain
prevent¹⁰⁷⁰
As shy glances rosy-blushing, they each to the other sent!

The feast over, the maiden left them, but she bade not the
guest 'Farewell,'
For twice seven days in honour Parzival with his host did
dwell.
But within his heart lay a sorrow, 'twas no other I ween than
this,
He would he enough had striven to be worthy of wedded
bliss, ¹⁰⁷⁵
And he thought him a goal so worthy must lead to a guerdon
high
Both in this life and e'en in the other—And these words they
shall be no lie.

One morning for leave he prayed him, from Graharz he fain
would ride,
And his host, sore loth to lose him, awhile rode his steed
beside.
Fresh sprang of grief the fountain as the prince spake, 'I lose
once more¹⁰⁸⁰
A son, Death of *three* hath robbed me, thy loss now shall
make them *four*.
And threefold it was, my sorrow—Who my heart would in
pieces smite
Fourfold and from hence would bear them, in the pain
should I find delight.
One for thee, since thou ridest from me, and *three* for my
three sons slain—
Bravely they fell in battle, such guerdon doth knighthood
gain!' ¹⁰⁸⁵

'And its end is of sorrow woven—One death all my joy doth
lame,
The death of my son so gallant, Schenteflur did they call his
name;
When Kondwiramur her kingdom and herself would
withhold with strife
From Klamidé the king, and Kingron, in her aid did he lose
his life,
And my heart with the thrust of sorrow, as a hedge is it
piercèd thro'.1090
Now all too soon dost thou leave me since no comfort from
thee I drew,
Ah! would Death were here my portion since Liassé, that
maiden bright,
And the land I had deemed so goodly find no favour in this
thy sight!'

'My other son, Count Laskoit, by Idêr son of Noit was slain
Anent a hawk—Little gladness from his death I methinks
might gain—1095
Gurzgrei did they call my third son, to whom Mahaut gave
her heart,
As his wife did he win the maiden from her brother proud
Ekunât.
'Gainst Brandigan on a venture for Schoie-de-la-kurt he'ld
ride,
And the Prince Mabonagrein smote him, and there by his
hand he died.
And Mahaut she lost her beauty, and his mother, my wife,
lay dead,2000
For thro' sorrow and bitter yearning the days of her life were
sped.'

Then the guest saw his host's deep sorrow as he told unto
him his woe,
And he quoth, 'Little wisdom have I, yet if ever the day I
know

When I win knightly fame and honour, so that maiden I well
may woo,
Thou shalt give unto me Liassé, thy daughter so fair and
true. 2005
Thou hast told me of o'er-much sorrow; if thy grief I may lift
from thee
From the load of so sore a burden I gladly will set thee free!

Then leave from the prince so kindly the young knight that
morn would pray,
And from all his gallant vassals; and he rode from their land
away;
And the prince, in the game of sorrow, tho' heavy before his
throw, 2010
Had lost yet more, for from threefold to fourfold his grief
must grow.

BOOK IV

KONDWIRAMUR

ARGUMENT

BOOK IV. tells how Parzival came to Pelrapär, and found it besieged by sea and land, and the folk wasted by famine. How Queen Kondwiramur besought his aid; how he overthrew Kingron, and sent him to the court of King Arthur. How Parzival wedded the Queen; and of the wrath of King Klamidé when he heard the tidings. How the Burgers defended Pelrapär against their foemen; how Klamidé challenged Parzival to single combat, and was overthrown; and how he came to the court of King Arthur at Dianasdron. Of the love of Parzival and Kondwiramur; and how the hero parted from his wife, and went in search of knightly venture.

BOOK IV

KONDWIRAMUR

Thus Parzival parted from them, and courteous he now
 might bear
His knightly garb, and he knew them, the customs of
knighthood fair.
But alas! he full sore was troubled with many a bitter pain,
And the world was too close, and too narrow the width of
the spreading plain,
And the greensward he thought was faded, and his harness
had paled to white;⁵
So the heart the eye constraineth and dimmeth awhile the
sight.

For since he had waxed less simple somewhat of his father's
lore,

The desire of the man for the maiden, in his wakening heart
 he bore;
And he thought but of fair Liassé, that maiden so true and
 sweet,
How never her love she proffered, yet with honour the guest
 would greet.¹⁰
And wherever his horse might turn it he took in his grief no
 heed,
And if slowly it paced or swiftly he thought not to guide its
 speed.

Nor many a field well-fencèd nor wayside cross he found;
Nor chariot-wheel nor horse-hoof had furrowed with tracks
 the ground;
Untrodden the woodland pathway, nor wide was I ween the
 way, ¹⁵
And he knew not the hills and the valleys—Full oft shall ye
 hear men say,
'Who rideth astray, in his wandering the lost axe may often
 find.'
They lay here unnumbered round him, if for *axe* ye have
 trees in mind.
Yet tho' far was the road he journeyed yet he went in no wise
 astray,
And thus from the land of Graharz he rode through the
 livelong day, ²⁰
Till he came to the kingdom of Brobarz thro' mountains wild
 and high—
When the shadows of evening lengthened, and red flushed
 the western sky,
Then he came to a mountain torrent, and the voice of the
 raging flood
Rang clear as its waves rushed foaming round the crags that
 amid them stood.
So he rode adown by the waters till he came to the city fair
 ²⁵

Which a king had bequeathed to his daughter; 'twas the city
of Pelrapär,
And I wot that tho' fair the maiden who bare of that land the
crown,
Great grief and small gladness had they who dwelt in that
noble town!

Like an arrow that swiftly speedeth from the bow by a
strong arm bent,
The waters onward rushing on their downward pathway
went; 30
And a bridge hung high above them with woven work so
fair,
And the stream it flowed swift to the ocean—Well-guarded
was Pelrapär,
As children in swings delight them, and swing themselves to
and fro,
So swung the bridge, yet ropeless, youthful gladness it
scarce might know!

And on either side were standing, with helmets for battle
bound, 35
Of knights e'en more than thirty, and they bade him to turn
him round,
And with lifted swords, tho' feeble, the strife would they
gladly wait,
They thought 'twas the King Klamidé whom they oft had
seen of late,
So royally rode the hero to the bridge o'er the field so wide
—

As thus to the youth they shouted, and with one voice his
arms defied, 40
Tho' he spurred his steed full sharply it shrank from the
bridge in fright,
But ne'er knew he a thought of terror—To the ground sprang
the gallant knight.

And he led his horse by the bridle where the bridge hung
high in air,
Too faint were a coward's courage so bitter a strife to dare!
And well must he watch his footsteps for he feared lest his
steed should fall—45
From the other side of the water the knights had ceased their
call,
And with shield and sword-blade gleaming within the town
they passed,
For they feared lest an army followed, and they closed their
portals fast.

So Parzival crossed the river, and he rode o'er a grassy plain
Where many in search of knighthood must death for their
guerdon gain;50
And he came to the palace portal, and stately the Burg and
high,
And there hung there a ring of iron, and he gripped it right
manfully.
But none to his call made answer, save only a maiden bright
Who looked forth from out her window, and was 'ware of
the gallant knight.
Spake the maiden so fair and courteous, 'An thou comest, Sir
Knight, as foe,55
Little need have we of thine hatred, for heavy enough our
woe,
A wrathful host doth threaten already by sea and land!'
Then he quoth, 'Nay, gentle lady, at thy portals a man doth
stand
Who will, if he can, do thee service! For thy service my
hand is fain,
And never reward save thy greeting as payment I think to
gain.' 60
Then the maiden she went in her wisdom to the queen and
an entrance prayed
For the knight, and in sooth his coming it brought to their
sorrow aid.

So Parzival came to the city; down the roadway on either
hand

The folk who would fain defend them in close groups he
saw them stand,

Soldiers on foot, and slingers, and they who the dart could
throw, 65

He saw as he came towards them, in many a goodly row.

And many a squire so valiant, the bravest from out the land,
Long, sharp, and strong were the lances they bare in each
strong right hand.

There too, so the story telleth, was many a merchant grave,
And the javelin and axe were their weapons, so their lady
commandment gave.70

And their skins, they were loose for hunger—Then the
Marshal of the queen

Made his way thro' their ranks to the castle, and heavy his
task I ween.

And well was that castle guarded, with towers o'er the
chambers high;

And barbican, keep, and oriel in such numbers they met his
eye

That buildings so strong and so many in his lifetime he
never saw, 75

And on horse or afoot from all sides the knights to his
welcome draw.

'Twas a sorry host, for as ashes some were grey, some were
pale as clay,

(My lord the Count of Wertheim sure had starved on such
scanty pay!)

Thro' want full sore they hungered, nor cheese, nor bread,
nor meat

Had they, and their teeth were idle since naught might they
find to eat.80

And their palate knew naught of the flavour of the wine-cup,
or red or white,

And their doublet hung loosely on them, and wasted each
limb of might,
And their skin like wrinkled leather on each rib hung gaunt
and grim,
For hunger their flesh had wasted and driven from every
limb.
Thro' want must they sorely suffer, little grease in their fuel
ran—85
(A hero to this had forced them, the proud King of
Brandigan,
Thus they paid for Klamidé's wooing)—The mead might
they seldom spill,
For small was their store, I think me, the vessel or cup to fill.
In Trühending oft shall ye hearken the hiss of the frying
cake,
In such music, methinks, but seldom the folk might their
pleasure take!90

(And if for such want I'd mock them, then in truth must I
share their shame,
For there where I oft dismount me, where men do me
'*Master*' name,
At home in mine house, with trouble e'en the mice shall their
portion steal,
Nor oft for their food be joyful! Nor need they the bread
conceal,
Unhidden, I scarce may find it—Yea, oft doth it happen so,
95
And I, Wolfram of Eschenbach, oft-times such pleasure and
ease may know.)

But enough of my lamentation, once more ye the tale shall
hear
How the city was full of sorrow, and for gladness they paid
full dear.
How these heroes, so rich in courage, must in need and in
scarceness live,

For so did the manhood bid them, to their need shall ye pity
give—100
For their life stood in pledge, might He free it in Whose
Hand all power shall be!—
Yet more of their grief would I tell ye that ye mourn for
them bitterly,
With shame their guest did they welcome, for they deemed
him so rich and great
That he craved not thro' need their shelter; he knew naught
of their poor estate.

On the grass did they spread a carpet, where a linden was
walled around,105
And trained to a welcome shadow—'Neath its boughs they
his arms unbound,
And the vassals they took his harness; but other than theirs
his face
When he in the streamlet washed it, and cleansed it from red
rust trace;
Nay, the sunlight's rays were shamèd 'neath the glow of his
beauty bright,
And a worthy guest they thought him as they gazed on the
gallant knight.110
Then a mantle rich they brought him e'en like to the robe he
bare,
And new was the smell of the sable wherewith it was
garnished fair.

Then they spake, 'Wilt thou look upon her, the queen, our
lady true?'
And the knight made answer straightway, that thing would
he gladly do.
To the palace they came, and the stairway steep and high to
the portal led,115
And the light of a fair face met him when his footsteps so far
were sped.

Of his eyes should she be the sweetness—There shone from
that lady bright

A radiant glow and dazzling, ere she welcomed the stranger
knight.

Now Kiot of Katelangen and Manfilot, Dukes the twain,
Led hither their brother's daughter who as queen o'er this
land did reign:120

(For the love of God their harness, shield, and sword, had
they put away

These princes true and stalwart, fair of face tho' their hair
was grey.)

Midway adown the staircase all courteous the maid they led,
And she kissed the gallant hero, and the lips of the twain
were red;

And she gave him her hand, and she led him, Sir Parzival, to
the hall,125

And they sat them adown together in the midst of the
courtiers all.

And feeble and faint the maidens, and the knights who stood
there around,

And vassal alike and hostess, small joy in their life they
found.

Yet Kondwiramur, her beauty did high o'er all others stand,
Were it Enid, or fair Jeschuté or Kunnewaaré of far Lalande,
130

Whoe'er men had deemed the fairest when they women's
beauty weighed,

Their fame to the earth was smitten by the glance of this
royal maid.

Yea, even the twain Isoldé, tho' men praise them evermore,
They must yield the crown of beauty to the lady
Kondwiramur.

(And her name in our tongue betokens her shapely form and
fair) 135

And well had they done, the mothers, who had borne such a
goodly pair

As these twain who sat here together, naught did they who
stood around
But gaze on the one and the other—Many friends had our
hero found.

And the thoughts of the knight will I tell ye, '*There Liassé,*
Liassé here,—
God will free me from care since I see here Liassé that
maiden dear¹⁴⁰
The child of a gallant father!'—Yet her fairness was naught I
wot,
'Gainst her beauty who sat beside him, in whom God no
wish forgot.
(The maiden was queen of the country) Yea, e'en as by
morning dew
Refreshed, the rose from its calyx forth buddeth in beauty
new,
And is white and red together—And grief to her guest it
wrought, ¹⁴⁵
To whose courtesy naught was lacking since Gurnemanz'
side he sought,
And his words had from folly freed him; and had bidden him
questions spare
Save only where they were needful—So he sat by that lady
fair,
And never a word his lips spake, tho' he sat close the maid
beside—
Yet to those who know more of woman such silence doth oft
betide. ¹⁵⁰

Then the queen to herself said softly, 'This man disdaineth
me,
He deemeth my fairness faded. Nay, perchance it yet may be
That in this thing he doeth wisely, his hostess in sooth am I,
And he is my guest, the first speech should be mine
assuredly!
Gently he looks upon me tho' never a word we speak, ¹⁵⁵

And courteous hath been his bearing, 'twere well I the
silence break;
Too long have I yet delayed me since here side by side we
sit.'
To her guest did she turn, the maiden, and she spake as it
seemed her fit:

'Sir Knight, it were well as hostess that the first words came
from me,
Since I wot well my kiss as hostess a greeting hath won
from thee, 160
And thou offeredst me thy service, so my maiden hath borne
me word,
Our guests scarce are wont to do so, tho' the tidings I fain
had heard.
Now tell me, my guest, I prithee, since the tale I am fain to
know,
From whence art thou come to my kingdom, and whither
thou yet wouldst go?'
'Lady, at early morning I rode from my host away, 165
A brave knight is he and faithful, yet he sorroweth sore to-
day,
And Prince Gurnemanz do men call him, in Graharz he
holds command,
From thence I to-day have ridden, thence came I unto this
land!'

Then the noble maiden answered, 'Sir Knight, had another
told
This tale, methinks that scarcely for truth I the words might
hold, 170
That thou in one day hadst ridden a journey that scarce in
twain
My swiftest squire could compass, tho' his charger he
spurred amain!
Thy host was my mother's brother; his daughter's youthful
glow,

It hath paled before the sorrow which she, e'en as I, must
know.
For many sad days and mournful, with sad eyes we've wept
our fill 175
I, and the maid Liassé—Wouldst thou show to thy host
goodwill?
Then thou shalt with us, man and woman, this night-tide our
sorrow share,
Thou shalt serve him thereby; and I'll tell thee the want we
perforce must bear.'

Then out spake her uncle Kiot, 'Lady, I send to thee
Twelve loaves of bread, and of shoulders and hams do I give
thee three, 180
And eight cheeses too are with them, and two casks of wine
I trow,
And my brother, he too shall aid thee, of such aid hast thou
need enow!'
And Manfilot spake, 'Yea, Lady, I send thee the self-same
fare.'
And the maiden she sat in gladness, and of thanks she no
word would spare.
Then leave they craved from their lady, and forth would the
old men ride 185
To their hunting-house that was nigh there—But the cell
where they would abide,
Was in Alpine wilds so lonely, there unarmed did they dwell
afar,
And never a foeman vexed them with tumult or strife of war.

And the messenger sped full swiftly, and the fainting folk
were fed,
No Burger within the city but was lacking for other bread,
190
And many were dead of hunger ere food for their need was
found.

Then the queen she bade them share it to the feeble folk
around,
With the cheese, the flesh, and the red wine, as Parzival
counsel gave,
Scarce a morsel was left, yet they shared it, the queen and
her guest so brave.

And swiftly the store had vanished, tho' to many who yet
might live, 195
Nor were slain by cruel hunger this succour fresh life might
give.
Then they bade them a couch make ready for the guest, and
'twas soft his bed,
(Had the Burgers been hawks for the hunting methinks they
were not o'er-fed
As their scanty board bare witness) yea, the folk there, one
and all,
Bare the marks of bitter hunger, save the gallant Parzival.
200

Then leave he prayed of his hostess, he would lay him down
to rest.
Do ye think that for tapers straw-wisps must light so brave a
guest?
Nay, better were they I think me; he betook him, the hero
fair,
To a bed so rich and stately a king well might slumber there,
Nor of poverty bare it token, and a carpet before it lay. 205
Then he prayed the knights to go hence, nor longer there
delay,
And noble lads un-shod him, and straightway he fell asleep,
Till the cry of heart-sorrow woke him, and tears that bright
eyes should weep.

This chanced e'en as I will tell ye; no woman's law she
brake,

For pure was she aye, the maiden of whom this venture
spake. 210
Long stress of war constrained her, and the death of her
champion true,
So heavy her heart with sorrow that sleep from her eyelids
flew,
So she went, this royal lady, (but never such love to claim
As urgeth a gentle maiden to crave of a *wife* the name)
But she sought help and friendly counsel, tho' clad in a
warlike gear, 215
A silken shift, (strife she wakeneth who doth thus to a man
draw near.)
And the maiden she wrapped around her a mantle of samite
long,
And she went as her steps were guided by sorrow and bitter
wrong.

Her maidens and waiting women who lay there around her
bed
She left them slumbering softly, and with noiseless footsteps
sped 220
To a chamber, there, e'en as she bade them, Parzival all
lonely lay,
And around his couch the tapers burnt bright as the light of
day.
To his bed she turned her footsteps, and she knelt low his
couch before,
But no thought of love unlawful the heart of either bore.
Of joy bereft was the maiden, his help she was fain to claim,
225
If awhile they lay there together it brought unto neither
shame.

So bitter the maiden's sorrow that there fell full many a tear
On Parzival, and her weeping thro' his slumbers the knight
might hear,
And waking, he looked upon her, and sorrow and joy he felt,

And he rose up, the youthful hero, as the maiden before him
knelt, 230

And he spake to the queen, 'Say, Lady, wilt thou now make a
mock of me?

To God only, and never to mortal methinks shouldst thou
bow the knee.

But rise thou and sit beside me, or grant me I pray this grace,
Lay thyself down where I was lying, I will seek me some
other place!'

But she spake, '*Thyself* wilt thou honour, and show honour
alike to me, 235

And by never a touch wilt shame me, I will e'en lay me
down by thee.'

Then the knight he spake by his knighthood he would e'en
do as he should say,

So down on the bed beside him in peace the maiden lay.

Tho' well sped were the hours of the night-time no cock did
they hear to crow,

Empty and bare the perches, for the famine had left them so.
240

Then the maiden, grieving sorely, prayed him courteous her
plaint to hear,

"Twill rob thee of sleep an I tell thee, and work to thee ill I
fear.

My foeman the King Klamidé, and Kingron his seneschal,
My castles and lands have wasted, yea, all but this citadel.
My father, King Tampentäre, by his death me, poor orphan,
left 245

In peril and need so deadly, of all hope am I well-nigh reft.
Kinsmen and princes many, and vassals, both rich and poor,
Yea, a mighty army served me, but they serve me now no
more.

One half, nay, far more I think me, in defence of my land are
slain,

Alas! whence shall I, poor maiden, or gladness or succour
gain? 250

In such sore strait do I find me, I am ready myself to kill
Ere my maidenhood and this body I yield to Klamidé's will.
His wife he is fain to make me, yet his was the hand that
slew
My Knight Schenteflur, the hero, whose heart was both
brave and true,
And the flower was he of all manhood, falsehood he ne'er
might know,²⁵⁵
Who was brother unto Liassé, and she too shall share my
woe.'

But e'en as she named Liassé then sorrow awoke anew
In his heart who would fain do service, and his spirit, so
high and true,
Sank, as sinketh a hill to the valley, at the thought of that
maiden dear;
Yet he spake to the queen, 'Say, Lady, how best may I serve
thee here?'²⁶⁰
'Sir Knight an thou couldst but rid me of Kingron the
seneschal;
In knightly joust of my warriors full many before him fell.
With the morning again he cometh, and he thinketh that free
from harm
His lord soon shall lie, my husband, in the clasp of my
circling arm.
My Burg hast thou seen, and thou knowest how lofty its
towers and high,²⁶⁵
Yet down to the moat below them will I fling myself
joyfully,
Ere of maidenhood King Klamidé shall rob me against my
will,
If no better may be, then by dying, his boasting I yet may
still!'

Then he quoth, 'Lady, French or Breton, of what country
soe'er he be,

From Kingron my hand shall shield thee, with what power
may be given to me.'270
The night was spent, with the dawning the queen she arose
again,
Lowly she bent before him, nor from thanks would her lips
restrain.
Then she passed from the chamber softly, and no man might
be aware,
Tho' wise were he else, of her errand, save only the knight
so fair.

Nor Parzival longer slumbered, for the sun was swift to rise,
275
And it pierced thro' the clouds of morning, and smote on his
wakened eyes;
And he heard the sweet bells chiming, as the folk church and
minster sought,
For Klamidé their joy had banished, and their land in sore
peril brought.

Then up rose the young knight also; the chaplain was in his
place
And he sang to God and his lady; and the guest saw the
maiden's face,280
And he gazed till the Mass was ended, and the benediction
o'er.
Then he bade them to bring his harness, and soon was he
armed once more,
A good knight and strong they deemed him, in gallant
armour fair.
Then on came Klamidé's army with banners borne high in
air.
And Kingron, he came full swiftly, he sped far before the
force, 285
And, so hath the story told me, of Iserterre's land his horse.
And there waited before the portal the son of King Gamuret,

And the prayers and the hopes of the townsfolk on the
youthful knight were set.

Nor with sword he ere this had striven—From afar did he
aim his stroke,

And so swift his joust, in the meeting the gear of both
chargers broke,290

And their girths were burst asunder, and each steed to its
knees was brought,

And the heroes who yet bestrode them of their swords must
they needs take thought;

In their scabbards did they find them—And already did
Kingron bear

Wounds in arm and breast, and I wot me that loss was his
portion there.

For this joust brought him loss of the glory that methinks
had been his alway295

Till he met with this knight, and their meeting, of his pride
was the dying day.

And valiant did men account him, six knights had he
prostrate laid

Who rode in one field against him, yet here was he well
repaid

By Parzival's right hand valiant, and Kingron the seneschal
Thought strange was indeed his peril, for *stones* surely on
him fell300

Cast forth from a mighty engine—Other arms wrought his
overthrow,

For a sword clave clean thro' his helmet, and Parzival laid
him low,

And he knelt with one knee upon him, and he bade him
forthwith to give

What he ne'er to a foe had given, his pledge, an he fain
would live.

But he thought not to be his captor who had vanquished him
here in field,305

But he bade him ride hence to Graharz and his pledge to its
lord to yield.

'Nay, Sir Knight, thou hadst better slay me, 'twas I who slew
his son,

'Twas my hand of life that robbed him, Schenteflur—Thou
from God hast won

Great honour, yea, men shall praise thee for the strength that
thou here hast shown,

Of a sooth art thou here the victor, and Good Fortune shall
be thine own.'³¹⁰

Quoth Parzival, 'Yet another is the choice I will give to thee,
Yield thou to the queen whom thy master in his wrath
wronged so grievously!'

'Nay! Then were I lost of a surety, for I wot with their
sword-blades keen

My body they'd hew in pieces, small as dust in the sun is
seen!

Such sorrow of heart, I think me, and grief thro' my hand
they win,³¹⁵

Full many a gallant hero who dwelleth those walls within.'

'Then hence from this plain shalt thou journey to the
kingdom of Brittany,

And bear to a gentle maiden thy pledge and thy fealty.

For she for my sake hath suffered a sorrow she ne'er had
borne,

Had not Kay been of knightly customs, and of courtesy fair
forsworn.³²⁰

Say to her how with me it fareth, that I come not in joy again
Till my spear, thro' his shield sharp-piercing, hath wiped out
her honour's stain.

To King Arthur and to his lady, and the knights of the Table
Round

Bear my greeting, and say in their presence shall I never
again be found

Till the day I from shame have freed me; from the shame
which *I* too must share³²⁵
With the maiden who smiled upon me, and great grief for
that greeting bare.
Say to *her* I am aye her servant, to serve her with service
fain!
So Kingron must swear unto him ere they parted, those
heroes twain.

Thus he came afoot to the city, for thither had fled his steed,
The Burgers' help in battle, from their anguish the folk he
freed. ³³⁰
But the outer host was troubled that Kingron, their chosen
knight,
In this wise had been dishonoured, and broken his dauntless
might.
Then they led Parzival in triumph to their queen so fair and
young,
And the maiden was fain to greet him, and her white arms
around him clung,
And in close embrace she held him as she spake, 'The wide
earth doth hold³³⁵
No man I will have for my husband save him whom these
arms enfold!'
And as here they disarmed the hero her part would the
maiden bear
With ready hand and skilful, nor her service she thought to
spare.

But tho' heavy had been his labour, yet scanty, I ween, the
board.
And the Burgers they came before him, and they sware him
with one accord³⁴⁰
They would have him for lord and master; and the queen in
her turn she spake,
And she said that this knight so valiant for her love and her
lord she'd take

Who had won him a fame so mighty o'er Kingron the
seneschal—

But now from the castle bulwarks two sails might be seen by
all,

A strong wind to the haven brought them, and their lading
must needs make glad³⁴⁵

The folk, they bare naught but victuals,—God's guidance
they surely had!

Then they rushed adown from the ramparts, and swift to the
ships they fled,

The hungry crowd, for the booty, as leaves by the wind are
sped.

With flesh they were not o'erweighted, so wasted and thin
were they,

Nor they strutted with well-filled belly, but bending they
went their way.³⁵⁰

The queen's marshal he swore the shipmen, by the doom of
the hempen cord,

Safe conduct for life and lading, none should touch that
which lay aboard.

Then he bade them to lead these merchants straightway into
the town,

And Parzival for their lading the double he paid them down,
And gladly the merchants took it, for princely they deemed
such pay;³⁵⁵

And the Burgers these welcome viands to their fires did they
bear straightway.

Now fain would I there take service, no man of them all
drank beer,

Wine and food had they there in plenty—Then he did as you
now shall hear,

Parzival, the gallant hero, for first in portions small,
With his own right hand he shared out the viands among
them all, ³⁶⁰

Yea, even unto the nobles; so long had they lacked for bread,

He feared it had wrought them evil if perchance they were
over-fed.

But to each one he gave his portion, and his counsel they
deemed it right,
And more should they win ere nightfall from the hand of this
gallant knight.

To their marriage couch they bade them, 'twas the will both
of king and queen—365

Yet throughout the night so courteous he bare him, in truth I
ween,

He little had pleased those ladies who now, in these latter
days,

In passion's heat forget all that should win for a woman
praise;

Tho' modest they seem to strangers, yet their heart gives
their mien the lie,

And their tenderness worketh sorrow to their friend, tho' in
secrecy.370

But the steadfast knight and faithful guards himself at every
hour,

And well knoweth to spare a woman an she chanceth within
his power.

For he thinketh, and thinketh truly, 'For many a lonely year
For her favours I served this lady; now, behold, the day is
here

When her will is to reward me, and here we twain do lie—
375

Had I touched with bare hand her vesture I were blest to
eternity!

An I vantage take of her slumbers to myself untrue I seem,
Methinks we were both dishonoured did I waken her from
her dream,

For a woman's sleep is holy, and all men shall own its sway.'
Thus the Waleis, who ne'er had feared him, lay still till the
dawn of day.380

Thus he whom men called the Red Knight, a maiden he left
the queen,
Yet surely she deemed in the morning his wife she o'er night
had been,
And for love of her lord her tresses she bound with the
morning light
As matrons are wont to bind them. And he won him, the
gallant knight,
Castles and lands around them from the hand of his maiden
bride, 385
But her *heart* was ere this his guerdon, and in peace did the
twain abide.

Thus glad in their love they held them two days till the third
night fell,
And often he thought might he take her to himself it would
please him well.
Then he thought of his mother's counsel, and how
Gurnemanz spake of yore,
That man and wife should as *one* be, and the doubt vexed his
soul no more, 390
And his wife did he take unto him—Love's custom ever old,
Yet ever new to lovers, to these twain brought joy untold.

'Twas well, not evil, with them—Now hear how the king,
their foe,
As he rode in his might to battle, must tidings of evil know.
'Twas a squire who fain had told them, all crimson his spurs
with blood; 395
'Before Pelrapär on the meadow have they foughten those
heroes good,
'Twas a bitter strife and knightly; thy seneschal fell that day,
Kington, who led thine army, to King Arthur must take his
way.
As he in departing bade them lies the army upon the plain.
Pelrapär shalt thou find well guarded 'gainst thyself and
thine armies twain, 400

There within is a gallant hero, and naught doth he crave but
 strife;
In the camp of thy hired soldiers is many a rumour rife,
They say from the good Round Table cometh Ither of
 Cumberland
To the help of the queen, and knightly and valiant methinks
 his hand!
'Twas his arms that rode forth for jousting, and no man his
 deeds shall blame,⁴⁰⁵
In such wise hath he borne his armour as winneth him meed
 of fame.'

Quoth the king to the squire, 'My lady, the queen, she
 desireth me,
And she and her land so goodly I trow shall my portion be.
And Kingron the seneschal told me, and surely the truth he
 spake,
That famine doth plague the city, and peace they ere long
 must make,⁴¹⁰
And the queen she her love shall proffer'—His wrath must
 the squire abide.
Then the king and his host passed onward, and a knight did
 toward them ride,
And he spared not his horse but spurred it, and told them the
 self-same tale,
And the king deemed the loss o'er-heavy, and courage and
 joy must fail.

Then a prince spake from out the army, 'Tho' Kingron hath
 valour shown,⁴¹⁵
Yet never he fought for *our* manhood, he fought for himself
 alone.
Now let him to death be stricken—Why then should they be
 cast down,
Two hosts, this one, and the army that lieth before the town?'
Then he bade his lord take courage, 'Once more will we try
 our fate,

Let them look to their arms, the conflict shall be for their
strength too great,420
We will make an end of their gladness! Bid thy vassals and
kinsmen hear,
With banners twain before them to the town shall they draw
anear;
Down the hill will we ride upon them, but afoot must we
storm the gate,
For so shall we work them evil, and victory shall on us wait.'
Galogandres, the Duke of Gippones, it was who this counsel
gave, 425
And sorrow he brought on the Burgers—but slain was this
hero brave,
And slain, too, the brave Count Narant, a prince from
Uckerland's shore,
And many another hero whom dead from the field they bore.

Now hear ye another story, how the Burgers would guard
their wall.
Strong stakes of wood sharp-pointed they made fast in tree-
trunks tall;430
(Sore pain thus was wrought the besiegers) and the trunks
were made fast that day
To a rope that by wheel was guided, so they guarded their
walls away.
And all this had they done and tested ere Klamidé would
storm the gate
To avenge the fall of Kingron—There had come to their land
of late
Greek fire, for the ships had brought it that of food brought a
goodly store,435
And it burnt of the foe the weapons, and the engines of
deadly war;
And battering-ram or tortoise in vain 'gainst the walls were
wheeled,
No weapon had they for onslaught but was forced to the
flame to yield!

Now Kingron the seneschal journeyed till he came on to
Breton ground,
In his hunting-house in Briziljan King Arthur at last he
found, 440
And Karminöl did they call it—As 'fore Pelrapär he fought,
So at Parzival's word his surety to the maid of Lalande he
brought,
And glad was fair Kunnewaaré that, faithful, he mourned her
shame
Whom men there knew as the Red Knight, and this knight at
his bidding came.

And soon were the wondrous tidings amid the courtiers
spread, 445
And he stood there before King Arthur, a gallant knight ill-
sped.
Then he spake unto him and his vassals in such wise as he
needs must speak,
And Kay was with terror smitten, and crimson it grew, his
cheek,
And he spake, 'Is it thou, O Kingron? Ah! many a Breton
knight,
Thou seneschal of Klamidé, thy hand hath o'erthrown in
fight! 450
If thy captor ne'er look upon me with favour, thine office
high
Shall turn to thy good; we are rulers of the caldron, both
thou and I,
Of thy wisdom and skill do thou aid me, to win me the
favour fair
Of this maiden Kunnewaaré, and sweet cates for her board
prepare!'

Nor they asked from him other ransom—Now leave we that
tale and hear 455
What had passed since we left the story—So the host to the
town drew near,

To Pelrapär came the King Klamidé, and a bitter strife arose.
The inner host strove with the outer, and in sooth were they
gallant foes,
Fresh strength had they won and courage, and bravely they
held the field;
And Parzival, lord of the country, in the vanguard he bare
his shield.460
And he swung aloft his weapon, thro' the helm clave the
blade so keen,
And the knights he o'erthrew before him found a bitter death
I ween,
For there, where the corslet opened, the Burgers they pierced
them thro',
In such wise would they take their vengeance—this wrought
grief to the hero true,
And Parzival, he forbade them, and they ceased at their
lord's command,465
But of living knights full twenty were captive unto their
hand.

Yet Parzival well had marked it how the king and his bravest
knights
Sought not fame before the portals, but far out in the plain
would fight;
Then forth by a path untrodden the hero a circuit made,
And swiftly he charged where the monarch his banner aloft
displayed.470
And, see! there a mighty slaughter the guard of the king
befell,
And the shields they were hewn in pieces, the Burgers they
fought so well.
And Parzival's shield had vanished 'fore the blows and the
sword-blades keen;
And tho' little his skill rejoiced them, yet all who the strife
had seen,
They spoke but to praise his valour—Galogandres the
standard bare,475

(Well he knew how to wake their courage!) but dead lay the
hero there.

And Klamidé himself stood in peril, and great stress on his
army lay;

Then he bade them withdraw, for the valour of the Burgers
had won the day.

But Parzival, gallant hero, bade them treat their captives
well

Till the dawn of the third day's morning, and fear on his
foemen fell.⁴⁸⁰

Then the young host, proud and joyful, bade the knights on
their oath go free—

'Good friends, when the word I send ye, then wend your way
back to me!'

Their swords and their goodly harness as prisoners they
needs must yield;

Unarmed did they fare from the city to the host on the outer
field.

'For sooth,' spake their comrades mocking, 'from *wine* must
ye needs be red,⁴⁸⁵

Poor souls, since within the city ye have hungered for lack
of bread!'

'Nay! nay! ye may spare your pity,' so spake they, the heroes
good,

'If ye lie here a whole year longer, within is such store of
food,

That by them might ye well be nourished! And the queen
hath the fairest knight

For her husband, that e'er won knighthood, or carried a
shield in fight,⁴⁹⁰

He may well be of lofty lineage, for he lacketh no knightly
skill!'

And the king needs must hear the tidings, and in sooth did
they please him ill,

And heralds he sent to the city, and he bade them this
challenge bear
To him whom the queen had wedded, 'If this knight the strife
shall dare,
And the queen doth hold him worthy herself, and her lands
so wide, 495
To defend in single combat, then in peace may our hosts
abide!'

And Parzival he was joyful at the message the heralds bare,
And his heart was fain for the combat; and out spake the
hero fair,
'Now I pledge me upon mine honour that no man within this
wall
Shall lift his hand for my peril, *alone* will I stand or fall!' 500
So betwixt the moat and the meadow a truce did they swear
that day,
And those smiths of battle armed them as meet for the
coming fray.

On a gallant war-horse armèd sat the King of Brandigan,
'Twas hight Guverjorz—This charger with many a gallant
man,
And many a goodly present, from Gringorz his nephew, king
505
Of Ipotente did Count Narant from the north o'er the deep
seas bring.
And therewith were a thousand footmen, well armed save no
shield had they;
(If the tale speaketh true to the third year the king had made
good their pay.)
And Gringorz sent him knights five hundred, each one with
his helm on head,
And skilled were they all in battle; with Klamidé they hither
sped. 510
And thus had the mighty army, alike both by sea and land,

Encircled the town of Pelrapär, and great need must its folk
withstand!

Forth rode Parzival from the city to the field that should aye
declare

If 'twas God's will his wife to leave him, the child of King
Tampentäre.

Proudly he rode, yet he spurred not his steed to its swiftest
flight,⁵¹⁵

And 'twas armed for need, and its covering was a samite of
red so bright,

And the iron lay beneath it—And the hero himself shone fair
In his harness red, red his corslet, and the shield that he
proudly bare.

And Klamidé began the conflict—A short spear of wood
unwrought,

With that would he fell his foeman, and the joust from afar
he sought;⁵²⁰

And Guverjorz sprang forth swiftly, and the joust it was
ridden well

By those heroes young and beardless, nor one from his
saddle fell,

And never a horse or a rider had foughten a better fight;
And the steam rose in clouds from the chargers on which sat
each gallant knight,

And so fierce was the fight that the horses, out-wearied with
conflict sore,⁵²⁵

Stumbled and fell together, in sooth could they do no more.

And joyful they smote, the heroes, till fire from the helm
must spring,

Small time had they there for leisure, but zeal to their task
must bring;

And the shields were hewn in pieces, and the splinters were
tossed on high,

As shuttlecocks gaily smitten to the winds of heaven fly. ⁵³⁰

Yet Gamuret's son was unwearied, and never a limb did
ache,
Tho' Klamidé deemed that the foemen from the city the
truce would break.
Then he bade his fellow-foeman to look to his honour well,
And stay the hand of the slingers, for the blows heavy on
him fell
As of stones shot forth from an engine—But Parzival made
reply, 535
'Nay, safe art thou from the slingers, my word is thy surety,
Thou hast peace from mine hand, and I swear thee that never
a sling shall break
Head, or breast, or thigh, thou art safe here, were it but for
mine honour's sake!'

All too soon was Klamidé wearied and spent with the deadly
fight,
Who was victor, and who was vanquished, ere long might be
seen aright, 540
And they looked on the King Klamidé, on the grass was he
laid alow,
And Parzival's right hand gripped him till forth streamed the
crimson flow
Of blood from the ears and nostrils, and the green turf was
dyed with red;
And his foeman unbound the helmet and visor, and bared his
head,
The vanquished would face the death-blow, and the victor
spake, 'Here I free 545
My wife for aye from thy wooing! Learn thou what Death
may be!'

'Nay! nay! thou gallant hero, thirty-fold doth thy glory grow
Thro' the valour thine hand hath shown here, since in strife
thou hast laid me low.
What higher fame dost thou look for? Kondwiramur sure
shall say

That Good Fortune hath smiled upon thee, whilst *I* am
 Misfortune's prey;550
Thy land hast thou now delivered—As when one a leaking
 boat
Doth free from the load of water, that it light o'er the waves
 may float,
So lightened am I of honour! Manly honour and joy I trow
Are waxen thin and faded, what profit to slay me *now*?
From children and children's children mine heritage shall be
 shame,555
To do more here methinks were needless—For joy thou hast
 won and fame,
And a living death is my portion, since for ever from her I
 part,
Who fast in love's magic fetters hath held me both mind and
 heart,
Little good it forsooth hath brought me, ah! most wretched
 henceforth am I,
And this land and its lovely lady for aye in thy power shall
 lie!' 560

Now he who was here the victor on Gurnemanz' counsel
 thought,
How mercy should well beseem him who with manhood had
 valiant fought,
And he thought him the rede to follow; and thus to the king
 he spake,
'I free thee not, to the father of Liassé submission make!'
'Nay, Sir Knight, I have wrought him evil, 'twas thro' me that
 his son was slain,565
An ill-fate wouldst thou bring upon me! The hand of thy
 queen to gain,
With Schenteflur I battled, and in sooth had I died that day,
Save that Kingron came to my succour, and his hand did the
 hero slay.
For Gurnemanz of Graharz had sent him to Brobarz' land

At the head of a gallant army; 'twas a fair and knightly band,
570

Nine hundred knights who fought well, and rode upon mail-
clad steeds,

And fifteen hundred footmen all armed for valiant deeds,
For naught but shields should fail them—Too great their
might I thought,

But the seed of such goodly harvest once more their country
sought.

Yet now hath my loss been greater! Of my heroes but few
are left, 575

What more would thine hand take from me, who of gladness
am now bereft?

'An easier way I'll show thee, to Brittany shalt thou ride,
Kingron has gone before thee, there King Arthur he doth
abide,

To *him* shalt thou bear my greeting, and bid him to mourn
always

The shame I bare as my portion when I rode from his court
away. 580

A maiden who smiled upon me for my sake was smitten sore
—

Of all that in life e'er grieved me naught ever hath grieved
me more!

And that maid shalt thou tell of my sorrow; and thy pledge
to her hand shalt yield,

And do even as she shall bid thee—Or die here on this
foughten field!

'So, if here I must choose betwixt them, not long shall my
choice delay,' 585

Spake the King of Brandigan swiftly, 'From hence will I ride
straightway!'

But his oath did he swear ere he parted whom pride had in
peril brought.

Then Parzival, the hero, for his wearied charger sought,

And his foot touched nor horse nor stirrup as he light to the
saddle sprung,
And his steed the hewn shields' splinters around him in
circles flung.590

And the Burgers I ween were joyful—but their foemen were
sad and sore,
For flesh and bone were wearied, and sorrow of heart they
bore.
And they brought King Klamidé wounded to those who
might give him aid,
And the dead on the bier they bare them, and to rest in the
grave they laid.
From many a guest unwelcome the land at last was freed,
595
And the gallant King Klamidé to Löver he rode with speed.

Now it fell at this time King Arthur and the knights of the
Table Round,
And many another hero, at Dianasdron were found.
And in sooth no lie I tell ye when I say that this plain so
good
Bare of tent-poles a greater number than the trees in
Spessart's wood.600
For 'twas ever the wont of King Arthur the high feast of
Pentecost
To keep with his knights and vassals, and of maidens a
goodly host.
There were many a noble banner, and many a warlike shield
With coat of arms emblazoned, and fair tents stood adown
the field;
'Twould be thought of the world a marvel, who should make
all the travelling gear605
For such wondrous host of ladies as those that were gathered
here!
And I think me that never a maiden but had counted it to her
shame

If no knight mid the knights around her she might as her
lover claim!
Came I myself to such gathering, an such youthful knights
were there,
I were loth if my wife beside me thro' such tumult were fain
to fare—610
(Nay, when folk thus come together far liefer were I away)
May be one might speak unto her, and some such words
would say—
'With love of her was he smitten, and ne'er might he healing
know
Save that she herself should heal him. Yea, an but her will
were so,
Her knight would he be for ever, to serve her his whole life
long' 615
I were swift, with my wife beside me, to flee from such
foolish throng!

Yet enough of myself have I spoken—Now hear how King
Arthur's tent
Might be known apart from the others; before it on gladness
bent
He feasted, the king, with his vassals whose hearts never
falsehood knew,
And with many a stately maiden, whose thoughts aye to
jousting flew,620
As if with darts they sported, and their friend 'gainst the foe
would aim,
And if ill befell their hero with sweet words to his aid they
came.

Then the youthful King Klamidé in the ring would he bridle
draw;
His steel-clad limbs and charger the wife of King Arthur
saw,
His helmet and good shield cloven her maidens they saw
right well—625

So he came to the court, (who had sent him small need have
I here to tell.)
So sprang he adown from his charger, and they thronged him
on either hand
Ere he came where she sat whom he sought for, Kunnewaaré
of fair Lalande.

And he spake, 'Art thou she, O Lady, to whom I owe service
fair?
(Yet need doth in part constrain me) from the Red Knight I
greeting bear, 630
He willeth to take upon him the shame that thy lot hath
been;
He prays that King Arthur mourn it—Thou wast smitten for
him I ween,
Here, Lady, my pledge I bring thee, so my victor hath bidden
me,
Else my body to death were forfeit—I will do here as
pleaseth thee!'

Then the maiden Kunnewaaré by his hand led the gallant
knight 635
Where Queen Guinevere was seated, she ate with her
maidens bright;
And Kay uprose from the table as the tidings he needs must
hear,
They brought gladness to Kunnewaaré, but to Kay had they
wrought but fear.

And he quoth, 'What he speaketh, Lady, who thus unto thee
hath sped
He speaketh perforce, yet I think me he greatly hath been
misled! 640
I thought but to teach thee better, yet for this cause thou
hatest me!
Now bid thou this knight disarm him, for his standing o'er-
long shall be.'

Then she bade him put off his helmet and visor, the maiden
true,
And e'en as the bands were loosened Klamidé the king they
knew,
And Kingron he looked upon him, and he saw his lord again,
645
And he wrung his hands in his anguish till as dry twigs they
cracked amain.

Then the seneschal of Klamidé, from the table he sprung
straightway,
And he asked of his lord the tidings; and joyless was he that
day,
For he spake, 'I am born to sorrow; I have lost such a gallant
host,
No man that was born of woman, I think me shall more have
lost. 650
And the load of such bitter sorrow lieth heavy upon my
breast,
And joy is to me a stranger, and gladness a fleeting guest!
And grey am I grown for the anguish she hath wrought me,
Kondwiramur,—
Yea, the sorrow of Pontius Pilate, and false Judas who
evermore
Must grieve for his faithless dealings, who did Christ unto
death betray, 655
What of punishment God layeth on them that woe would I
bear alway—
If so be that the Lady of Brobarz were my wife of goodwill
and free,
And mine arms held her fast, I had recked not what hereafter
should chance to me.
But, alas! for her love is withholden from the ruler of
Iserterre,
And my land and my folk henceforward for her sake shall
sorrow bear. 660

Mine uncle's son, Mabonagrein, for her love long hath
suffered pain;
And by knightly hand constrained in thy court I, O king,
draw rein!
And well dost thou know in my kingdom much harm have I
done to thee,
Forget that, true knight and faithful, from thy hate do thou
set me free
Since here I abide, a captive—And this maiden my life shall
shield, 665
Since I stand in her sight, her servant, and my pledge to her
hand would yield!
Then of knightly heart King Arthur forgave him as he would
pray,
And with faithful words, and kindly, showed favour to him
that day.

Far and wide did they tell the tidings how the King of
Brandigan
Rode hither, and man and maiden in thronging crowds they
ran. 670
Then the king he would crave a comrade, and he spake out
with joyless mien,
'Commend me unto Sir Gawain, if thou deemest me worth,
O Queen!
Well I know that he would desire it, and if he thy word obey,
Then he honoureth thee, and the Red Knight shall win praise
at his hand to-day.'
Then King Arthur he bade his nephew deal well with the
captive king, 675
(Tho' I wot well, without his bidding, Sir Gawain had done
this thing.)
And the conquered knight, in whose dealings no falsehood
had part or share,
From the vassals and gallant heroes won a welcome both fit
and fair.

Then Kingron he spake in sorrow, 'Alas! that I needs must
see
The day when in Breton dwellings my king shall a captive
be! 680
For richer wert thou than Arthur, and of vassals a greater
host
Hath served thee, nor strength was lacking, and of youth
canst thou make thy boast.
Shall men count it to *Arthur's* honour that Kay in his wrath
did smite
A princess whose heart hath shown her the wisdom to
choose aright,
And smile upon one whom henceforward all men may with
truth proclaim 685
Elect to the highest honour and crown of true knightly fame?
The tree of their fame these Bretons may deem to have
waxen high;
Dead lay Cumberland's king, but I wot well be by no deed of
theirs must die!
Nor the fame shall be theirs that, my master, thou didst yield
to that self-same knight,
Or that I myself have been vanquished in fair and open fight;
690
And the sparks sprang bright from our helmets, and our
swords clave the whistling air
As for life and death we battled, and men looked on our
combat fair.'

Then all at the good Round Table, both rich and poor alike,
With one voice spake that Kay did evil when a maiden he
thought to strike.
But now will we leave their story, and fare back unto
Pelrapär 695
Where Parzival reigned as monarch; the waste lands were
builded fair,
And joy was their lot and singing, (and red gold and jewels
bright

King Tampentäre left in the city where awhile he had
 reigned in might)
Then rich gifts he gave till men loved him for his knightly
 hand and free;
New shields and costly banners the pride of his land should
 be, 700

And many a joust and Tourney did he and his heroes ride.
And e'en on the distant borders in gallant deeds he vied,
That hero young and dauntless, and no foeman might e'er
 deny
That on battle-field or in Tourney his hand won the victory.

And now of the queen would I tell ye—What lot might ye
 hold so fair705

As hers, that gentle lady? In earth's joys had she fullest
 share.

Her love it might bud and blossom, nor weakness nor
 wavering show,
For the worth of her lord and husband her heart scarce might
 fail to know.

And each found their life in the other, and each was the
 other's love.

If, as saith the tale, they were parted, what grief must each
 true heart move!710

And I mourn for that gentle lady, her body, her folk, her
 land,

(So he won of her love the guerdon) had he freed with his
 strong right hand.

Thus courteous he spake one morning (and the knights stood
 their lord beside),

'Lady, an it so please thee, give me leave that I hence may
 ride

And see how my mother fareth, if weal be her lot, or woe,
 715

For naught of all that befalls her methinks I for long may
 know.

For a short space would I go thither; and if ventures my skill
approve
Therewith would I do thee service, and be worthy my lady's
love.'
Thus he spake, and the story telleth she thought not to say
him 'Nay,'
For she deemed it well; from his vassals all lonely he took
his way.⁷²⁰

BOOK V

ANFORTAS

ARGUMENT

Book V. tells of the wonderful adventure of the Grail Castle; how Parzival met with the Fisher King, and became his guest; and of the great feast in the hall of Monsalväschr. How Parzival saw the bleeding spear, and all the marvels of the Grail, and how he asked no question. How he in the morning found the palace deserted, and was mocked by the squire as he rode away. Of Parzival meeting with Siguné, and how she reproached him for his silence. Of Orilus and Jeschuté; of the fight between the heroes; and of Parzival's oath. How Orilus and his wife were made friends again, and of their welcome at the court of King Arthur.

BOOK V

ANFORTAS



Now he who would hear what befell him who thus for
ventures sought,

Shall hearken many a marvel ere the tale to an end be
wrought

Let the son of Gamuret ride forth, and all ye good folk and
true

Wish him well, for bitter sorrow this hero hereafter knew,
Tho' honour and joy should crown him—And sorely his
heart did grieve⁵

That the wife he loved so dearly he now for a space must
leave.

For the mouth never read of woman, and never hath tale
been told

Of a fairer wife and truer, and his heart did she captive hold,
And his spirit so high was troubled by thoughts of his wife
and queen—

Had courage not been his birthright he had lost it ere this, I
ween!¹⁰

O'er rock and marshy moorland, with loosened reins the
steed

Dashed free, the rider thought not to guide or check its
speed.

Of a truth the venture telleth, so far did he ride that day
E'en a bird had been outwearied, and its flight were fain to
stay.

An the tale hath not betrayed me, no further the knight did
fare ¹⁵

When Ither he slew, or from Graharz rode swift unto
Pelrapär.

Now hear ye what chanced unto him; he came at the close of
day

To a water fair, and upon it many boats at anchor lay,
And the fishers were lords of the water; to the shore did they
lie so near

That e'en as they saw him riding his question they well
might hear. 20
And one he saw in a vessel all clad in such royal pride
Scarce richer had been his vesture were he lord of the world
so wide;
Of peacock's plumes his head-gear—Then the knight to the
Fisher spake
And he prayed him for knighthood's bidding, and he prayed
him for God's dear sake,
To help him unto a shelter where he might thro' the night
hours rest.25
And the Fisher sad he answered in this wise the stranger
guest;

And he quoth, 'Nay, Sir Knight, I know not for full thirty
miles around,
By land alike or water, where dwelling may yet be found
Save one house, I would bid thee seek it, for it lieth in sooth
anear,
Thro' the livelong day wert thou riding none other thou
findest here.30
Ride there to the high cliff's ending, then turn thee to thy
right hand
Until to the moat thou comest, and thy charger perforce must
stand;
Then bid thou the castle warder to let the drawbridge fall
And open to thee the portals, then ride thou unto the hall.'

Then he did as the Fisher bade him, and leave would he
courteous pray,35
But he quoth, 'I myself will thine host be, an thou fail not to
find the way,
Be thy thanks then as is our tendance—As thou ridest
around the hill
Have a care lest the wood mislead thee, such mischance
would but please me ill.'

Then Parzival turned his bridle, and gaily he took his way,
Nor missed he the path till before him the moat of the castle
lay; 40

And the drawbridge was raised, and the fortress it lacked not
for strength I trow,
As a turner with skill had wrought them stood the turrets in
goodly row.

But with wings, or on winds of heaven uplifted, might ye
have won

To that Burg, an a foeman stormed it little harm he methinks
had done.

And so strong were the towers and the palace that its folk
they had held the hall⁴⁵

And mocked at the foe, if all armies thirty years long beset
the wall.

Then a squire looked forth from the castle, of the knight was
he well aware,

And he asked whence he came? and wherefore he thought to
their Burg to fare?

And Parzival spake, "Tis the Fisher who hath bidden me ride
to thee,

With all courtesy have I thanked him for the shelter he
proffered free,⁵⁰

'Tis his will that the bridge be lowered, and I ride here the
Burg within.'

'Sir Knight thou shalt here be welcome, and thy way to the
Burg shalt win

Since the Fisher so spake—And honour would we shew unto
thee his guest!'

Then the squire he let fall the drawbridge, for so was their
lord's behest.

So the hero came to the fortress, to a courtyard so broad and
wide, 55

By knightly sports untrodden—Nor oft would they Tourneys
ride,

(By short green turf was it covered) and but seldom with
banners bright
As on Abenberg's field did they ride there, as fitting for
gallant knight.
'Twas long since they might disport them in such pastimes of
warlike skill,
For sorrow lay heavy on them, and mirth it beseemed them
ill. 60

But little the guest should rue that, for knights both old and
young,
They welcomed him with all honour, and swift to his bridle
sprung.
And pages of noble breeding laid their hands on his bridle
rein,
And others would hold his stirrup as the knight to dismount
was fain.
And the knights they prayed him enter, and they led him
where he might rest, 65
And with ready hands and skilful of his armour they freed
the guest,
And they looked on the beardless hero, and they saw his
face so fair,
And they spake, of a truth Good Fortune and blessing should
be his share.

Then he bade them to bring him water, and the rust-stains he
washed away
From face and hands, and they saw him as the light of a
second day, 70
So he sat in all eyes lovely—Then a mantle rich they
brought
Of silk of Araby fashioned, and flaw therein was there
naught;
And he laid it around his shoulder, that hero so fair and
bright,

But the clasp did he leave unfastened, and with one voice
they praised the knight.

'Repanse de Schoie, our lady and queen, did this mantle
bear,' 75

Quoth the chamberlain, 'She hath lent it while fit robes they
for thee prepare.

And I feared not this boon to ask her since it seemeth sure to
me

That a gallant man and faithful, Sir Knight, thou shalt prove
to be!'

'God reward thee who lookest on me with such true and
trusting heart,

Methinks, an thou seest rightly, Good Fortune shall be my
part, 80

Yet I wot well such gifts come only from the power of God
on high.'

Then gladly they pledged the hero, and in honour and
loyalty

They who sorrowed with him were joyful; far more had they
there, I ween,

Than at Pelrapär, when his right hand their shelter from grief
had been!

Then sadly he thought, as his harness the squires on one side
would bear, 85

That in knightly joust and Tourney he here might find little
share.

Then one to the host would call him, and fast came his
words and free,

And boldly he spake to the stranger, yea, e'en as in wrath
might be.

With his life had he nigh paid forfeit to Parzival's youthful
pride,

For he laid his hand to his sword-hilt—When he found it not
by his side 90

Then he clenched his fist so tightly that the clasp rung the
blood-drops red

From beneath his nails, and crimson to the sleeve of his robe
they spread.

'Nay, nay,' quoth the knights, 'be not wrathful, for fain would
he make us smile,
He hath licence to jest, and with jesting our sadness would
he beguile.
Show thy courtesy here towards him, nor be wroth for a
foolish word,95
That the Fisher hath come to the castle, naught else shalt
thou here have heard.
Now do thou to our lord betake thee, here art thou an
honoured guest,
And the load of thy heavy anger be banished from off thy
breast.'

To the palace hall they gat them, where a hundred crowns
hung low
With many a taper laden; round the walls shone the tapers'
glow. 100
And beneath stood a hundred couches, with a hundred
cushions fair,
And each of these goodly couches four knights should
between them share.
And betwixt each twain of the couches an open space was
found,
And before each there lay a carpet of cunning work
fashioned round.
Thereto had he wealth in plenty, King Frimutel's son and
heir: 105
And one thing had they not forgotten, nor their gold did they
think to spare,
For within the hall were builded three hearths of marble rare,
With skill and wisdom fashioned, and each hearth stood
four-square,
And the wood was Lignum aloë, and so great a fire, I ween,

Ne'er hath burnt on the hearth at Wildberg—Such things
have aye costly been.110

And the host had bid them lay him on a costly folding bed
'Fore the central hearth; and gladness from before his face
had fled,

And his life was but a dying—Parzival the hero fair
In the hall found kindly welcome from him who had sent
him there.

Then his host bade him stand no longer, but be seated his
couch anear,115

'Yea, here by my side, didst thou seat thee yet further from
me, I fear

'Twere treating thee as a stranger'—In this wise to his gallant
guest

Spake the host thus rich in sorrow, whose heart was by grief
opprest.

And the host he craved thro' his sickness great fires, and
warm robes would wear

Both wide and long, and with sable were they lined and
garnished fair.120

And the poorest skin was costly, and black was its hue and
grey;

And a cap of the self-same fashioned he wore on his head
that day,

'Twas within and without of sable, with bands of Arabian
gold

Wrought around, and a flashing ruby in the centre might all
behold.

Now many brave knights they sat there, and grief passed
their face before,125

For a squire sprang swift thro' the doorway, and a lance in
his hand he bore,

(And thus did he wake their weeping) from the point did the
blood run fast

Adown to the hand of the holder till 'twas lost in his sleeve
at last.
And then thro' the lofty palace was weeping and wailing
sore,
The folk of thirty kingdoms could scarce have bemoaned
them more. 130
And thus to each of the four walls with the lance in his hand
he drew,
Till he reached once again the doorway, and passed him the
portal thro'.
And stilled was the lamentation, and the grief that this folk
must know
When the squire bare the lance before them, and thus bade
them to think on woe.

(An here ye be not outwearied I gladly would tell the tale,
135
How the feast in this Burg was ordered, for in courtesy
naught did fail.)

At the end of the hall a doorway of steel did they open fair,
And two noble children entered—Now hearken what guise
they bare,
An a knight for love would serve them, with love they his
task might pay,
Two fair and gracious maidens as e'er man might woo were
they. 140
And each wore on her hair loose flowing, a chaplet of
blossoms bound
With silken band, beneath it their tresses sought the ground.
And the hand of each maiden carried a candlestick all of
gold,
And every golden socket did a burning taper hold.
Nor would I forget the raiment these gentle maidens ware,
145
For one was Tenabroc's countess, ruddy-brown was her robe
so fair,

And the self-same garb wore the maiden who beside the
countess paced,
And with girdles rich and costly were they girt round each
slender waist.
And behind them there came a Duchess and her fellow; of
ivory white
Two stools they bare, and glowing their lips e'en as fire is
bright.¹⁵⁰
Then they bowed, the four, and bending, the stools 'fore the
host they laid,
Nor was aught to their service lacking, but fitly their part
they played.
Then they stood all four together, and their faces were fair to
see,
And the vesture of each fair maiden was like to the other
three.

Now see how they followed swiftly, fair maidens twice told
four, ¹⁵⁵
And this was I ween their office, four tapers tall they bore;
Nor the others deemed too heavy the weight of a precious
stone,
And by day the sun shone thro' it, and as Jacinth its name is
known.
'Twas long and broad, and for lightness had they fashioned it
fair and meet
To serve at will for a table where a wealthy host might eat.
¹⁶⁰
And straight to the host they stepped them, and they bowed
their fair heads low,
And four laid the costly table on the ivory white as snow,
The stools they had placed aforetime—and courteous they
turned aside,
And there by their four companions stood the eight in their
maiden pride.

And green were the robes of these maidens, green as grass in
the month of May,165
Of Samite in Assagog woven, and long and wide were they.
At the waist were they girt with a girdle, narrow, and long,
and fair,
And each of these gentle maidens ware a wreath on her
shining hair.

Now Iwan, the Count of Nonel, and Jernis, the lord of Reil,
To the Grail were their daughters summoned from many a
distant mile.170
And they came, these two princesses, in raiment wondrous
fair,
And two keen-edged knives, a marvel, on cloths did those
maidens bear.
Of silver white and shining were they wrought with such
cunning skill,
And so sharp, that methinks their edges e'en steel might they
cut at will.
And maidens four went before them, for this should their
office be 175
To bear lights before the silver; four children from falsehood
free.
Six maidens in all they entered and took thro' the hall their
way,
Now hearken, and I will tell ye the service they did that day.
They bowed, and the twain who carried the silver they laid it
low
On the Jacinth, and courteous turning to the first twelve in
order go.180
And now, have I counted rightly, here shall eighteen
maidens stand;
And lo! see six more come hither in vesture from distant
lands,
Half their robes were of silk, gold inwoven, half of silk of
Nineveh bright,

For both they and the six before them, parti-coloured their
robes of light.

And last of those maids a maiden, o'er the others was she the
queen,185

So fair her face that they thought them 'twas the morning's
dawn, I ween!

And they saw her clad in raiment of Pfellel of Araby,
And she bare aloft on a cushion of verdant Achmardi
Root and blossom of Paradise garden, that thing which men
call 'The Grail,'

The crown of all earthly wishes, fair fulness that ne'er shall
fail!190

Repanse de Schoie did they call her, in whose hands the
Grail might lie,

By the Grail Itself elected was she to this office high.

And they who would here do service, those maids must be
pure of heart,

And true in life, nor falsehood shall have in their dealings
part.

And lights both rare and costly before the Grail they bore
195

Six glasses tall, transparent—and wondrous balsam's store
Burnt within with a strange sweet perfume; with measured
steps they came,

And the queen bowed low with the maidens who bare the
balsam's flame.

Then this maiden free from falsehood, the Grail on the
Jacinth laid,

And Parzival looked upon her, and thought of the royal maid
200

Elect to such high office, whose mantle he needs must wear.

Then the seven courteous turned them to the eighteen
maidens fair,

And the noblest they placed in the centre, and twelve on
either side

They stood, but the crownèd maiden no beauty with hers had
vied!

And as many knights as were seated around that palace hall,
205

So to each four was there a server, with golden beaker tall,
And a page so fair to look on who bare a napkin white—
Riches enow, I trow me, had ye seen in the hall that night!
And they bare there a hundred tables, at each table four
knights would eat,
And swiftly they spread them over with coverings fair and
meet. 210

The host himself took water, and heavy at heart was he,
And Parzival, too, he washed him, for so should the custom
be.

A silken towel, bright coloured, a count's son would proffer
fair,

Swift to the guest he gat him, and knelt low before him
there.

And wherever there stood a table there four squires were
ready dight215

To serve the four who sat there, and their service they knew
aright,

For twain would carve, low kneeling, and twain to the
knights would bear

Of food and drink as needful, and thus for their wants would
care.

Now hearken ye greater riches—on wheelèd cars were
rolled

To every knight in order, fair vessels of wroughten gold, 220

And four knights set them on the tables, and with each ye a
steward might see

To aid them, and claim the vessels when the feast at an end
should be.

Now hearken another marvel—to a hundred squires they
spake,
And they bade them in fair white napkins the bread from the
Grail to take.
And straightway they went, and to each knight at each table
the bread they bare;225
As I heard so I tell unto ye, and the truth ye, each one, shall
swear,
'Twas the Grail Itself that fed them, and before the Grail did
stand
What of food or drink desiring, each one might stretch forth
his hand.
(Would I here betray another then in sooth ye shall lie with
me)
Food warm or cold, or dishes that known or unknown shall
be, 230
Food wild or tame—Such riches ye never on earth shall find,
So many have said, yet I think me that folly doth rule their
mind—
For the Grail was the crown of blessing, the fulness of
earth's delight,
And Its joys I right well may liken to the glories of Heaven's
height!

Then they brought in small golden vessels that which every
man should need235
Of sauces, or salt, or pepper—would one sparely or fully
feed,
Yet each found enough—and courteous they bare to each
noble guest;
And red wine and sweet drinks luscious, each one as he
liked him best
Might speak the word, and proffer the cup, and behold! 'twas
filled
By the power of the Grail—Thus the hunger of that gallant
host was stilled,240

And the Grail Itself sustained them, and Parzival wondering
saw
The riches and mighty marvels, yet to question his host
forbore.

And he thought, 'Gurnemanz he bade me, in truth, without
thought of guile,
To withhold my lips from question—If here I abide awhile
Methinks it will then befall me as aforetime in Graharz land,
245

They will tell me, without my question, how here with this
folk it stands.'
Then e'en as he sat thus musing came a squire who a sword
did bear,
And its sheath was a thousand marks' worth, and its hilt was
a ruby rare,
And the blade, it might well work wonders—Then the host
gave it to the knight,
And he spake, 'I full oft have borne it in many a deadly fight
250

Ere God's Hand thus sorely smote me; now with this shalt
thou be repaid
If aught hath in care been lacking—Henceforth shalt thou
bear this blade
Whatever chance befall thee, and when thou its power hast
tried
Thou wilt know thou art fully armèd, whatever strife betide.'

Ah! woe to the guest that asked not, I am sorrowful for his
sake, 255
When his hand clasped the sword 'twas a token that his
silence he well might break.
For the host too my heart is heavy, thus tortured by nameless
woe,
And a question therefrom had freed him, yet to question his
guest was slow.

But now the feast was ended, who the vessels hither bore
Again to their task they turn them, and they bear them forth
once more.260

The cars again they circle; each maid to her task was fain
From last to first; the noblest she turned to the Grail again,
To host and guest all-courteous the queen and her maidens
bend,
What they brought they once more would bear forth thro' the
door at the high hall's end.

And Parzival he gazed after, and lo! thro' the open door 265
Within an outer chamber, on a folding couch he saw
The fairest of old men ancient whom ever his eyes had seen,
Grey was he as mists of morning—Nor o'er rash is the tale, I
ween,

Who he was shalt thou know hereafter, when a fitting time
shall be,
The host, his Burg, and his kingdom, yea, all will I name to
ye, 270
And all shall be clear and in order, no halting my tale shall
know;
Methinks that I then shall show ye the bowstring without the
bow.

'Tis a symbol good, the bowstring, for swift as ye deem the
bow,
Yet the shaft that the bowstring speedeth findeth swifter its
aim, I trow!
And not without thought I said it, for the string, it seemeth
me, 275
Is like to the simple story wherewith men well-pleased shall
be;
For it goeth straight to its ending, while he who aside shall
stray,
Tho' his goal at last he reacheth findeth all too long his way.
When unbent the bow thou sawest, then straight was, I
ween, the string,

From the straight line thou erst must draw it, ere the shaft to
its goal may wing.280

But he who his story aimeth at the ear of a fool shall find
His shaft go astray, for no dwelling it findeth within his
mind.

Too wide is the road, I think me, and that which he chance to
hear

Ere yet he may know the meaning flies out at the other ear.
Far rather at home I 'ld bide me than in such ears my story
tell, 285

A beast, or a stock, I think me, as a hearer would serve as
well.

But further I fain would tell ye of this people so full of woe
To whom he had come, our hero, glad song might they
seldom know,

Or sound of dance or of Tourney; so heavy were they at
heart

That never a thought of gladness might find in their life a
part, 290

And oft shall the folk be fewer yet of joy shall have fuller
share,

But here every nook was crowded, nor space in the court to
spare.

The host to his guest spake kindly, 'Methinks they thy couch
have spread,

Art thou weary? then list my counsel, and get thee, my
guest, to bed.'

(Now here might I raise my war-cry at the parting betwixt
the twain,295

For I wot well that bitter sorrow each must from the venture
gain.)

To the side of his host he stepped him, Parzival the fair of
face,

And the Fisher a fair night wished him—Then the knights
stepped each from his place,
And a part drew near towards him, and they led the stranger
guest
Straightway to a sleeping chamber, and goodly should be his
rest. 300
'Twas richly decked for his honour, and the couch it was
spread so fair
That my poverty sorely grieves me since the earth doth such
riches bear.

And that bed knew, I ween, no lacking, and a rich silk above
it lay,
Bright-coloured its hue, and glowing as tho' fire-light did on
it play;
Then Parzival prayed the heroes to get them again to rest,
305
For he saw there but one couch only, and they passed hence
at his behest.

But he lacked not for other service—His fair face and tapers
light
Gave challenge unto each other—What day e'er might shine
so bright?
And before his couch was another, thereon would he take his
seat
While pages drew them nearer, and proffered him service
meet. 310
And they bared his white feet comely, and they laid his robes
aside,
And of noble birth were these children, and fair in their
youthful pride.
Then there passed thro' the open doorway four maidens fair
and bright,
They would know if they well had served him, and if soft
lay the stranger knight.
And so the venture telleth, a squire a taper bare 315

Before each gentle maiden—Parzival, that hero fair,
Sprang swift to his couch; then the maidens with gentle
voice they spake,
'Sir Knight, we fain would pray thee for our sake awhile to
wake'—
Yet as children sport with each other had he hidden him
from their sight
Ere yet they might hear his greeting, yet their eyes had
found swift delight,320
And their heart's desire was quickened at the sight of his red
lips' glow
That for youth were as yet unhidden, for no hair did upon
them grow.

Now hear what they bare, these maidens, three in their hands
so white
Brought syrups sweet, and red wine, and the fourth, that
maiden bright,
Bare fruit that e'erwhile had ripened in the garden of
Paradise 325
On a cloth fair and white, and she knelt low before him that
maiden wise,
And he bade her sit, but she answered, 'Nay, Sir Knight, so
is it best
For else were I sure unworthy to serve such a gallant guest.'
Then he drank and would eat a little, and he spake to them
soft and sweet,
And he laid him adown, and the maidens craved leave of
him as was meet.330
Then down on the costly carpet the squires set the tapers
bright
When they saw that he slept, and swiftly they gat from the
gallant knight.

Yet Parzival lay not lonely, for until the dawn of day
Heart-sorrow would lie beside him, nor passed with the
dawn away.

And every coming anguish its heralds before would speed,
335

E'en so that the fair youth's vision out-weighed e'en his
mother's need

When she dreamed ere the death of her husband. As a carpet
unrolled his dream,

The centre of fair jousts woven, while the edge was with
swords agleam.

And in slumber his foemen pressed him, and would swiftly
upon him ride;

So fearful his dream that, wakened, thirty times had he
rather died.340

Thus fear and unrest awoke him, and the sweat streamed
from every limb;

The daylight shone fair thro' the windows, yet no voice had
called on him.

Then he spake, 'Where are now the pages, who stood before
me of late?

Who shall hand unto me my garments?' Then awhile would
he patient wait

Till slumber again o'ercame him; none spake, none aloud
would cry, 345

Vanished the folk—When he wakened the noon-tide sun was
high.

Then he sprang up, and lo! before him on the carpet his
harness lay,

And two swords, his host's gift, and the other from Prince
Ither he bare away.

Then he spake to himself, 'Now wherefore was this done? I
these arms will take,

In sleep I such anguish suffered, methinks that I surely wake
350

To-day to some task of knighthood—If mine host doth some
foeman fear

Then his will will I do right gladly, and faithful her prayer
will hear

Who of true heart this mantle lent me—If my service she
think to take
Then I were for such service joyful; yet not for her sweet
love's sake,
For my wife hath a face as lovely as ever this castle's queen,
355
Nay more, an the truth be spoken she is fairer far I ween!'

Then he did e'en as seemed him fitting, and he armed
himself for fight
From foot to head, and beside him he girded those swords of
might.
Then forth went the gallant hero, and his steed to the palace
stair
Was bound, shield and spear stood by it, and he joyed as he
found them there.360

Then ere Parzival, the hero, his charger would mount again,
He sought thro' many a chamber, and he called on the folk
amain,
But none might he see or hearken, and it vexed the knight
full sore,
And wrathful he grew—Yet seeking, the hero he came once
more
To where he at eve dismounted when first he the castle
found, 365
And the earth and grass were trampled, and the dew brushed
from off the ground.

Then, shouting, he turned, the young knight, once more to
his charger good,
And with bitter words he mounted—Wide open the gateway
stood,
And the track led across the threshold; nor longer he thought
to stay
But he turned his rein, and swiftly to the drawbridge he
made his way,370

But a hidden hand drew the rope taut, and the forepart it rose
on high
And well-nigh had his charger fallen, then he turned him
right speedily
For fain would he ask the meaning, but the squire cried
aloud in scorn,
'Goose that thou art, ride onward, to the sun's hate hast thou
been born!
Thy mouth hadst thou thought to open, of these wonders
hadst asked thine host, 375
Great fame had been thine—But I tell thee now hast thou
this fair chance lost!'

Then the guest cried aloud for his meaning, but answer he
ne'er might win,
For the squire made as if he slumbered, and the portal he
barred within.
Too early for peace his parting, and the hour it hath brought
him woe,
And he payeth in joy the tribute, nor longer may gladness
know; 380
And doubled the throw of sorrow since here he had found
the Grail,
With his eyes, not his hand, had he cast it, and dice to the
throw should fail.
If by grief he be now awakened such was never his wont of
yore,
For naught had he known but gladness, nor sorrow of heart
he bore.

On the track that he saw before him would Parzival ride
apace, 385
And he thought, 'They who go before me to-day will a
foeman face
And fight for their master's honour; an they knew it, their
ring of might

Methinks would be little weakened if I in their ranks should
fight!

I would waver not, but would aid them whate'er be their
need to-day,

Thus my bread would I earn, and this fair sword, the gift of
my host, repay,³⁹⁰

Undeserved as yet do I bear it—Sure they hold me for
coward knight!"

Then he turned him, the free from falsehood, where the
hoof-tracks still met his sight,

(And sorely I rue his parting—Now the venture doth grow
apace,)

They had parted who rode before him, and their track he
might scarcely trace,

What aforetime was broad waxed narrow till he lost it nor
found it more³⁹⁵

And tidings he heard, the hero, that wrought to him sorrow
sore.

For the young knight, rich in courage, heard a woman's
voice make moan.

(On the grass lay the dew of morning.) On a linden there sat
alone

A maiden, whose truth wrought her sorrow, for between her
arms so white

Embalmed did she lifeless hold him who living had been her
knight. 400

Were there one who saw her sorrow and mourned not for her
bitter woe

Then false of heart must I hold him, one who true love might
never know!

Then he turned his steed towards her, tho' as yet unknown
was she,

(Tho' the child of his mother's sister)—As the wind that
fleeteth free

Is all earthly faith to her true love—Then Parzival greeting
spake,⁴⁰⁵

'Lady, methinks that sorrow I must bear for thy sorrow's
sake,
An thou needst in aught my service, would it free thee from
further ill,
Then look thou on me as thy servant, thy grief were I fain to
still!'

Then sadly her thanks she bade him, and asked him,
'Whence camest thou here?
He were ill-advised who his journey should take thro' this
woodland drear.⁴¹⁰
To them who know not its pathways great evil might here
betide.
Yea, oft have I seen and hearkened how men in this wood
have died,
For death was in strife their portion—Turn hence then, thou
gallant knight,
An thou lovest life—Yet tell me in what shelter didst pass
the night?'
'But a mile from here stands a castle, there I thro' the night
abode,⁴¹⁵
And naught have I seen like its riches, from thence in short
space I rode.'
Then the maiden she looked upon him, and she spake, 'Now,
methinks, 'twere ill
With falsehood to thus betray them who trust thee with right
goodwill.
From thy shield art thou here a stranger, and canst naught
but woods have found,
An here thou hast ta'en thy journey from planted and builded
ground,⁴²⁰
For thirty miles round have they never, for a dwelling, hewn
wood or stone,
Save but for one Burg, in this region that Burg it doth stand
alone.
'Tis rich in all earthly riches, yet he who that castle fair

Would seek, he may never find it, tho' many that quest shall
dare.

Unawares must they chance upon it, for I wot in no other
wise 425

Shall that Burg and all that it holdeth be looked on by mortal
eyes.

Sir Knight, *thou* hast never seen it; Monsalväschr I ween its
name,

Terre de Salväschr the kingdom where its lord the crown may
claim,

And Titurel once bequeathed it to his son King Frimutel,
So they called him, the dauntless hero; much fame to his
portion fell, 430

In a joust was he slain at Love's bidding, and four children
fair he left,

And three, they have store of riches, yet are they of joy
bereft.

And poor is the fourth, for penance hath he chosen this lot I
trow,

Trevrezent is his name—Anfortas, his brother, hath grief
enow,

He can neither stand, nor be seated, nor walk, but must aye
recline, 435

At Monsalväschr he hath his dwelling, the head of that noble
line.'

Then she spake, 'If indeed thou camest to that folk who so
sore doth mourn

Then perchance is their king released from the burden he
long hath borne?'

Out spake the Waleis, 'I saw truly great marvels, and many a
maid

Of beauty rare'—she knew him by his voice ere the words
were said. 440

And she quoth, 'Now indeed I know thee, for in sooth art
thou Parzival!

Didst thou see the mournful monarch? Didst thou see the
wondrous Grail?
Ah! tell me the joyful tidings, may his woe at last be stilled?
Well is thee that the blessed journey thou hast ta'en, now
shall earth be filled,
As far as the winds of heaven may blow, with thy fair
renown; 445
Naught on earth but shall do thee service, fulfilment each
wish shall crown!

Then Parzival spake in wonder, 'Say, Lady, whence knowest
thou me?'
And she answered, 'I am that maiden who erewhile made her
plaint to thee,
I am she who thy name first told thee, near of kin to that
gracious queen
Thy mother, of all earth's blossoms the fairest flower, I
ween, 450
Tho' a flower that the dew ne'er nourished! May God reward
thee well
Who didst truly mourn my hero who in knightly combat fell.
See, here in my arms I hold him, now think thou upon the
woe
God hath laid for his sake upon me who too short a life must
know;
Rich was he in all manly virtues, his death it has wrought me
pain, 455
And day by day as it dawneth reneweth my plaint again!

'Alas! is it thou, Siguné? Say, where are thy lips so red
That gave me to wit so truly who I was? From thy youthful
head
Have thy locks so brown and waving been shorn since I saw
thee last;
Then wert thou still fair to look on, tho' sorrow might hold
thee fast, 460

Now pale art thou waxed and feeble, such friendship,
methinks with woe
Had vexed me too much, hear my counsel, and bury this
dead knight low!'

Great tears bedewed her garments, for ne'er to that maiden
fair
Had any given such counsel as Lunete to her lady bare.
(This rede did she give to her lady, 'Let him live who thy
lord hath slain, 465
Thou shalt in his love hereafter amends for thy sorrow
gain.')
Not such was the will of Siguné, as maidens of wavering
mind,
(On their names I had best keep silence) here the tale of true
love ye'll find.
Then she spake, 'If joy e'er befall me that shall be when I
know relief
Is his, who so long hath suffered, when is lightened his load
of grief. 470
If thro' *thee* he hath found this succour then in truth shall all
praise be thine;
Methinketh e'en now at thy girdle do I see his sword to shine

—
If its magic spell thou knowest then to strife mayest thou
fearless fare,
For its edge is keen—Its maker a noble name doth bear,
Trebuchet's hand hath wrought it; by Karnant there flows a
spring, 475
And '*Lac*' from the name of that streamlet methinks is he
named, the king.
The sword will withstand the first blow, at the next it will
break in twain,
An thou to these waters bring it from their flow 'twill be
whole again.
Yet where at its source the streamlet flows forth from its
rocky bed,

Shalt thou seek those healing waters ere the sun stand high
overhead.480

Lac is the name of that fountain—If unsplintered shall be the
blade

Then press thou its halves together, from the waters shall it
be made,

Not whole alone, but stronger the blade and the edge shall
grow,

Nor their brightness and fair adorning be dimmed by the
water's flow.

Yet a spell thou first must master, ere thou draw that sword
of might,485

Thou hast left it behind, I fear me! Hast thou learnt its words
aright,

Then in truth all earthly blessings shall blossom and bear for
thee—

Believe me, dear my cousin, what of marvels thou there
couldst see,

To thine hand shall they all do service; the crown of
blessings fair

Uplifted o'er all earth's noblest henceforward thine head
shall bear.490

And thine is desire's fulfilment, and none with thy wealth
and might

May measure himself, if the question hath won at thy lips its
right!'

Then he quoth, 'Nay, I asked no question!' 'Alas I' cried the
mournful maid,

'That ever mine eyes have seen thee, who to question wast
sore afraid!

Such marvels they there have shown thee, yet no word might
they win from thee,495

When thou sawest the Grail, and those maidens who serve
It, from falsehood free,

Fair Garschiloie, and yet fairer Repanse de Schoie the
queen.

Thou hast seen the knives of silver, thou the bleeding spear
hast seen—
Alas! wherefore hast thou sought me? Dishonoured, accurst
art thou
Who bearest wolf's fang empoisoned! And deep in thine
heart I trow 500
Is it rooted, the plant of falsehood, and afresh doth it ever
spring!
Thou shouldst have had pity on him, Anfortas, their host and
king,
And have asked of his bitter sorrow, on whom God hath a
wonder sped,
Now thou livest, and yet I tell thee to bliss art thou
henceforth dead!'

Then he spake, 'Nay, gentle cousin, show kindness to me I
pray, 505
If in aught I have sinned, repentance my sin sure shall put
away!'
'Little good may repentance do thee,' quoth the maiden, 'for
well I know
That thy knightly fame and honour at Monsalväsche were laid
alow.
And never a further answer or word shalt thou win from me.'
Then Parzival turned his bridle and left her right mournfully.
510

That his lips were so slow to question when he sat by the
mournful king,
To the heart of the gallant hero must sorrow and rueing
bring;
And thus thro' his heavy trouble, and the heat of the
summer's day,
Great sweat-drops stood on his forehead as he rode on his
lonely way.
For the sake of the air he loosened his helmet and visor
band, 515

And his face shone fair thro' the iron-rust as he carried them
in his hand.

Then he saw a fresh track, and before him short space did
two horses fare,
A war-horse was one, well harnessed, but unshod was, I
ween, the mare,
And it bare on its back a woman—Behind her he took his
way,
And he looked on her steed, to hunger o'er-long had it been a
prey;520
Thro' its skin might its ribs be counted, a halter of hemp its
rein,
Its colour was white as an ermine, to the hoofs hung the
untrimmed mane;
The eyeballs were sunk in the sockets, the hollows were
deep and wide,
And I ween that this lady's palfrey by famine had oft been
tried.
'Twas lean and dry as touchwood, 'twas a marvel it yet could
go, 525
For little should she who rode it of the care of a charger
know.

Narrow and poor the trappings that lay on that charger's
back,
The saddle and bells were shattered, and much did the
harness lack;
And the lady was sad, not joyful, and her girth was a
hempen cord,
Yet, I ween, was her birth too noble in such guise to ride
abroad. 530
By twigs and thorny branches tattered her shift and torn,
And the rags had she knit together where'er it had been out-
worn,
But beneath her skin gleamed spotless, white as the swan's
white wing;

And naught but rags was her clothing—where they might
some shelter bring
There her skin was fair to look on, but elsewhere 'twas by
sunburn dyed.535
Yet her lips were red, tho' sorrow and want she must long
abide,
And so glowing and bright their colour a fire had ye kindled
there,
And where-e'er one would ride beside her on that side had
ye found her bare.
Yet of base degree to hold her were to do her a wrong, I
ween,
Tho' little had she upon her, yet guiltless she aye had been—
540
(Of your courtesy shall ye heed me, she forgot not her
womanhood)
Of her poverty have I told ye, yet wherefore? If ye deem
good
Then this will I say, that ragged and bare I this dame would
take
O'er many a well-clad maiden, were it fitting my choice to
make.

As Parzival bade her greeting, she saw him, and red she
grew, 545
Of all men was he the fairest, small marvel his face she
knew.
Then she quoth, 'Once before have I seen thee, great grief
have I won thro' thee:
God grant to thee greater honour than thou hast deserved
from me!
Far other hath been my raiment when thou sawest me last, I
wot,
Hadst thou ne'er in that hour come near me then honour
were still my lot!'550

Then he spake, 'Now bethink thee, Lady, who thus should
thy hatred claim,
For never my hand, I think me, hath brought to a woman
shame,
(So had I *myself* dishonoured) since ever I bare a shield,
Or thought upon deeds of knighthood, or hath striven in
battle-field;
Yet else am I sad for thy sorrow!' Then forth brake the tear-
drops bright,⁵⁵⁵
And ran fast adown her bosom, and over her breasts so
white,
So fair, and so softly moulded, that never might turner's
skill,
Tho' swiftly he wrought and rounded, his task in such wise
fulfil.
And so lovely was she in her sorrow his heart was to pity
fain,
And with hands and arms a cover from his glance did she
strive to gain.⁵⁶⁰

Then Parzival spake, 'Now, Lady, of true service from
mocking free,
In God's Name take thou here my surcoat, a covering 'twill
be for thee.'
'Nay, Sir Knight, I may never take it, e'en tho' bliss I thereby
should gain,
Ride swift on thy way, I pray thee, an thou wouldst not we
both were slain;
Tho' my death it would little grieve me, if I fear me, 'tis for
thy sake!'⁵⁶⁵
'Say, Lady, who thus would wrong us? Who thinketh our life
to take?
'Twas God's hand that gave it to us—Nay, were they an
armèd host
Who here for our life were thirsting, I would face them nor
fear the cost!'

Then she spake, "Tis a dauntless hero, so gallant in strife is
he
That heavy would be their labour if *six* should his foemen
be;570
(I would thou wert not beside me) I aforetime his wife had
been,
Yet so poor am I now and wretched, for his slave were I all
too mean,
Thus his wrath doth he wreak upon me.' To that lady he
spake again,
'Say, who rideth here with thy husband? For if I to fly were
fain,
As here thou dost give me counsel, thyself sure wouldst
deem it ill,575
Ere of flight I have learnt the lesson I would die with a right
good will!'

Then out spake the Duchess sadly, 'Alone with my lord I
fare,
But yet that may little serve thee, nor shall victory be here
thy share.'
And in rags was all her vesture, and naught but the hem
untorn,
Yet the crown of woman's honour in her poverty had she
worn, 580
And her ways were ways of goodness, and falsehood afar
had fled—
Then he bound afresh his visor and the helmet upon his head
As one who to battle rideth—Then his charger aloft would
rear,
It was 'ware of the steed beside it, and its neigh rang out
loud and clear;
And he who a space before them on the woodland way
would ride, 585
He hearkened the sound, and would see him who rode there
by his lady's side.

Then he turned his bridle wrathful by the side of the narrow
way,
And with lance in rest for jousting Duke Orilus rode that
day,
And manly, I ween, his bearing, from Gaheviess came his
spear,
And weapon alike and harness of one colour were blazoned
clear. 590

His helmet, Trebuchet wrought it; the shield in distant Spain
Was welded fair for the hero, King Kailet in that land doth
reign,
And strong were the rim and the centre—In Alexandria's city
fair
Was the costly pfellel woven that for surcoat and coat he
ware.
The covering of his charger at Tenabroc was it made 595
Of rings of steel close welded—And thus he his pride
displayed,
For over the iron cover lay a pfellel so fair to see,
And all men who saw bare witness that costly its worth must
be—
And gorget, and greaves, and headgear, tho' rich, yet their
weight was light,
And many a plate of iron it guarded this gallant knight; 600
In Beàlzenan was it fashioned, chief city of fair Anjou.
(But she who rode bare behind him far other her garb to
view,
For in sooth might she find none better) from Soissons his
breastplate came,
But he won his gallant charger from the far-off lake
Brimbane,
In the mountains of Monsalväsich—Lähelein, his brother
bold, 605
In a joust o'erthrew the rider, and the steed as his prize
would hold.

And Parzival too was ready—his charger in onward flight
'Gainst Orilus of Lalande bare swiftly the gallant knight;
And he saw on his shield a dragon, yea, e'en as it were alive,
And another upon the helmet fast bounden did upward
strive. 610

And many small golden dragons on surcoat and robe he
bare,
Enriched with many a jewel, and with red eyes of ruby fair.
From afar would they make their onslaught, these dauntless
heroes twain,
No need to renounce their friendship, nor thro' kinship from
strife refrain,
Aloft flew the spears in splinters—Methinks I might vaunt
me well 615

If I such a joust had witnessed as here in this wood befell!

Thus they rode at swiftest gallop not one joust alone, I ween,
And Jeschuté at heart bare witness fairer jousting she ne'er
had seen;
So she stood, and her hands she wrung them, this lady of joy
bereft,
Nor harm did she wish to either, that one should be lifeless
left. 620

In sweat were they bathed, the chargers, and the knights they
strove for fame,
And sparks sprang bright from the sword-blades, and forth
from the helm flashed flame,
And the blows fell fierce and mighty, and far flashed the
light of strife,
None were better than they in battle, and they met here for
death or life,
And tho' willing and swift the chargers that the heroes would
here bestride, 625
They forgot not their spurs, and their sword-blades bright-
glancing they deftly plied.
And Parzival won him honour, for here hath he rightly
shown

How before a hundred dragons one man well might hold his
own.

And ill did it fare with one dragon, and sore were its wounds
that day,

'Twas the crest that aloft in glory on Orilus' helmet lay, 630
And so clear that the light shone thro' them were the costly
jewels bright

That fell when the helm was smitten by Parzival's sword of
might;

'Twas on horse, not afoot, that they fought thus—The love of
her angry lord

Was won back again for Jeschuté by the play of the
glittering sword.

Then they dashed again on each other so close that they
smote away, 635

With their knees, the rings of iron—So valiant in strife were
they!

I will tell ye why one was wrathful; that his lady of royal
race

Ere this had been shamed; her guardian, from him might she
look for grace;

Yet he deemed that with wandering fancy her heart from her
lord had strayed,

And that she, in the love of another, her honour had lowly
laid. 640

And he would for such wrong have vengeance, and his
judgment on her was done

In such wise, save were *death* her portion no woman such
woe had won,

And yet she in naught had wronged him—If his favour he
would withhold,

What man e'er might think to hinder? For ever from days of
old

The man hath power o'er the woman, the husband shall rule
the wife. 645

Yet Parzival the hero, he thought him to win with strife

For Jeschuté her husband's favour—Methinks one should
 pray such grace
In courteous wise, but flattery it here found but little place.
And both they were right, I think me—He who ruleth the
 ways of life,
Or straight they may be or crooked, 'twas His so to rule their
 strife650
That never to one nor the other the joust death for guerdon
 brought,
Harm enow had they done to each other the while they so
 fiercely fought.

Now hotter it waxed, the conflict, each hero would fain
 defend
His knightly fame 'gainst the other; Duke Orilus of Lalande,
He fought with the skill and cunning his hand had learnt of
 yore, 655
For I ween none like him had battled—he had courage and
 strength in war,
And therefore had he been victor on many a foughten field,
Tho' other were here the ending—His foe would he force to
 yield;
And he threw his arms around him, the hero so proud and
 bold,
But Parzival, little daunted, on his foeman made good his
 hold, 660
And he drew him from off his saddle; as a sheaf from the
 field ye reap
So beneath his arm he swung him, and light from his horse
 did leap.
O'er a fallen tree he held him, for here was he overthrown
Who never of need or peril such fortune before had known.
'Now do penance for this thine anger that hath wrought to
 thy lady woe,665
An thy favour be yet withholden, then death shalt thou
 surely know!'

'Nay, nay, not so swift,' quoth his foeman, Duke Orilus of
Lalande,
'Tho' o'erthrown, I am not so vanquished that I may not thy
will withstand!'

Then Parzival, strong and valiant, his foeman he gripped
amain,
And forth thro' the visor gushing streamed the blood in a
crimson rain,670
And the prince, I ween, was vanquished, he could win from
him what he would,
To die was he all unwilling, and he spake to the hero good,
'Alas! thou bold knight dauntless, who evil on me hath sped,
Say how have I earned this peril, to lie here before thee,
dead?'

Then Parzival quoth, 'Right gladly, Sir Knight, will I let thee
live,675
If favour and love to thy lady thou swearest again to give!'
'That I will not! Her sin against me I trow all too great shall
be.

Rich in honour she was; she hath injured herself, and she
plungeth me,
Her lord, in yet deeper sorrow. In all else thy will I'll heed,
An thou thinkest my life to leave me—'Twas God gave it me
indeed, 680

Now thine hand is become His servant, to give it to me
anew,
And I to thy valour owe it'—In this wise spake the hero true:

'For my life will I give fair ransom, for kingdoms twain, I
trow,
My brother with might hath won him, of riches he hath
enow.
Thou shalt ask as it best may please thee: if from death thou
wilt set me free,685
He loveth me, and will loose me whatever the cost may be.

And my Dukedom again as thy vassal will I take from thy
valiant hand,
Thy fame it shall gain new lustre, since I might not thy
power withstand.
Now release me, thou hero dauntless, from forgiveness of
her, my wife;
Whatever shall be for thine honour, by that will I buy my
life, 690
But with her, my dishonoured Duchess, at peace will I never
be,
Nay, not for all pain or sorrow that shall otherwise fall to
me!'

Quoth Parzival, 'Folk or kingdoms, or riches or jewels rare,
All these they shall nothing profit—Thy pledge thou to me
shalt swear
In naught to delay thy journey, but to haste thee to Brittany
695
Where dwelleth a gentle maiden—One hath smitten her sore
for me,
And I will on that man have vengeance, an his safety she
shall not pray—
Thy pledge and my loyal service bear thou to that maid
straightway,
Or here, without fail, I slay thee—To King Arthur and to his
queen,
To both shalt thou bear my greeting; well paid hath my
service been, 700
If they for that blow ill-smitten the maiden do well entreat.
But first will I see that thou givest to this lady thine homage
meet,
And that without guile—Dost withstand me, and thinkest my
will to dare,
On a bier, and no more on a charger, from hence shalt thou
lifeless fare!
Now mark thou my words, for their doing a pledge shalt
thou straightway give, 705

And thy surety swear unto me, if longer thou fain wouldst
live!

To King Parzival spake his foeman, Duke Orilus, 'Helpeth
naught

'Gainst this thy will, I will do it, for fain I my life had
bought!'

In the fear for the life of her husband Jeschuté, that lady fair,
Mourned sore for his woe, yet the foemen to part might she
little dare.⁷¹⁰

Then Parzival bade him rise up, and speak to his lady bright
The words of peace and of pardon; and thus quoth the
vanquished knight,

'Lady, since this my shaming in strife hath been for thy sake,
So be it, the kiss of forgiveness from my lips shalt thou
herewith take.

Thro' thee have I lost much honour—What boots it? I
pardon sware!'⁷¹⁵

Then swift from her steed on the meadow sprang the lady
with white limbs bare,

Tho' the blood that ran from his nostrils had dyed his mouth
with red,

Yet she kissed him e'en as he bade her, so was Parzival's
bidding sped.

Then the three rode on together till a hermit's cell they saw
In the rocky wall, and our hero his bridle was fain to draw;
⁷²⁰

For he saw there a shrine so holy, and a spear with fair
colours blent

Stood beside the shrine; 'twas the dwelling of the hermit
Trevrezent.

There Parzival dealt with honour—On the relic an oath he
sware,

Himself laid the oath upon him, and he spake and they
hearkened fair;

'If I have worth or valour, as 'seemeth a gallant knight— 725
If I have it or not let those witness who have looked on my
shield in fight;

Yea, let them approve my knighthood, for knighthood's
power may claim,

As the shield-bearer oft shall tell us, high guerdon of praise
and fame,

And the name of knight is honoured—My body to shame for
aye

Will I give, and my fame and honour henceforth shall be put
away; 730

(With these words I my bliss would pledge here in the Hand
that shall highest be,

And that Hand is God's Hand, I think me)—All loss, bitter
mockery,

In this life and the next be my portion from His power, if
this lady fair

E'er did thee wrong when it chanced her that the clasp from
her robe *I* tare—

(Of a token of gold I robbed her)—A *fool* and no man was I,
735

Not yet had I waxed to wisdom—And sore did she weep
thereby,

And anguish and grief she suffered; yea, guiltless was she
that day—

And forfeit my bliss and mine honour if the words be not
truth I say!

Now see, dost thou hold her guiltless thou shalt give her her
ring again,

From the clasp I in such wise parted that my folly must bear
the blame!"740

Then the Duke took the ring, and the blood-stains he wiped
from his lips away,

And he kissed her, his heart's best treasure—And a covering
she won straightway;

The ring he placed on her finger, with his surcoat her shame
would hide,
Tho' hewn by the hand of hero, of rich silk was it fashioned
wide.
But seldom in coat emblazoned mine eyes have a woman
seen, 745
And this one was marred in combat. No war-cry was hers, I
ween,
That should summon the knights to Tourney, and never a
spear she brake
Whatever her garb—In Tourney far better the part they'd
take,
Lambekein, methinks, and the good squire, if together they
thought to fight—
But now was the lady pardoned, and her sorrow had taken
flight. 750

Quoth Orilus, 'Now, thou hero, the oath thou didst freely
swear,
Great joy and small grief hath brought me; tho' shaming I
needs must bear,
Yet gladness therefrom I win me—In all honour I will repay
This lady true for her sorrow when I put her in shame away.
And since all alone I left her she was guiltless did aught
betide; 755
Yet so did she speak of thy beauty, methought there was
more beside.
But now may God reward thee, thou hast shown her from
falsehood free,
I have done her a wrong—Thro' the young wood have I
ridden in search of thee
Afar from Briziljan's forest.' Then Parzival took the spear,
Wild Taurian, Dodine's brother, erewhile had he left it here.
760
Now say where the heroes rested, or how they would pass
the night—

Helmet and shield had suffered, they were shattered and
hewn in fight.

Then Parzival to the lady, and her husband, a farewell bade;
The Duke to his hearth would bid him, 'twas in vain
howsoe'er he prayed.

So here, as the venture telleth, they parted, those heroes
twain, 765

And the Prince Orilus he sought him his pavilion and folk
again.

And glad were his faithful people with one mind when at
last they saw

Their lord and his gracious lady dwell in peace and in love
once more.

Nor longer was there delaying, the Duke he aside would lay
His arms, and the rust and blood-stains from his face did he
wash away;770

By her hand he led the Duchess where atonement he fain
would make,

Weeping she lay beside him for joy, not for sorrow's sake.
For such is the way of women, know ye not the saying well?
'Tearful eyes make sweet lips,' of such lore methinks I yet
more might tell!

For Love knoweth joy as sorrow, and he who the twain
would weigh 775

In a balance shall find them equal an he testeth the scales
alway!

At peace were they now, full surely, forthwith to the bath
they went,

Twelve fair maidens they waited on her, with them had she
shared her tent,

They had tended her since, all guiltless, the wrath of her love
she bare;

(At night might she lie well covered, tho' by day she ill-clad
must fare)780

And joyful they bathed their lady—But now are ye fain to
hear
How Orilus won him tidings that King Arthur would now
draw near.

For thus spake a knight to his master, 'On a grassy plain I
saw
In fair and knightly order a thousand tents, yea, more,
For Arthur the noble monarch, the King of the Breton's land
785
With a wondrous fair host of maidens his court holdeth nigh
at hand;
Methinks scarce a mile are they distant, nor shout of knights
shall fail,
On either side Plimizöl's waters their camp lies adown the
vale.'

Then the Duke in haste and gladness forth from his bath he
stept—
Would ye know how she fared, Jeschuté? No longer the lady
wept, 790
But she went, the fair and gentle, from her bath to her couch
straightway,
And far fairer, I ween, her garments than she ware for many
a day.
And closely they clung together, the prince and the princess
wise,
And Love came to the aid of gladness, and joy here hath
won the prize.
Then the maidens they clad their lady, but the knights their
lord's armour brought, 795
And much had ye praised the vesture of Jeschuté, 'twas
fairly wrought
And birds caught in snares they brought them, on their
couch did they sit the twain,
And joyful they ate; many kisses from her lord did Jeschuté
gain!

Then they brought to the lovely lady a palfrey, so strong and
fair,

'Twas bridled, and richly saddled, and a lady right well
might bear,800

And they lifted her to the saddle, with her brave lord she
hence would ride;

But his charger was armed, as for battle the knight would his
steed bestride,

And the sword he that morn had wielded hung the saddle-
bow before.

Then from foot to head well armèd he came forth to his
steed once more,

And there, where his lady waited, to the saddle he sprung,
the knight,805

He would ride forth without delaying, with Jeschuté his lady
bright.

But his folk should fare back to Lalande, save one knight
who should show the way

To the camp and the court of King Arthur, so he counselled
his folk that day.

Soon came they anear King Arthur, and his tents they right
well espied,

For the space of a mile they stretched them adown by the
water's side.810

The knight who had led him hither he bade to his folk repair,
No comrade he'ld have save Jeschuté, his lady so true and
fair.

And Arthur, the brave and humble, he sat where at eve he'ld
eat,

On a plain with his vassals round him, in order due and
meet.

Duke Orilus rode to their circle, and none might his blazon
know, 815

So hewn were both shield and helmet—'twas Parzival dealt
such blow!

From his horse sprang the gallant hero, Jeschuté she held his
rein;
Swift sprang the squires to aid them, and thronged close
around the twain,
And they spake, 'We will care for the horses,'—Orilus, on
the grass he laid
His shield so marred and splintered, and he asked of the
gracious maid⁸²⁰
For whose sake he had ridden thither, and they showed him
the lady's seat,
Kunnewaaré she was of Lalande, and her mien for a maid
was meet.

Then, armed, he drew near unto them—King and queen
bade him welcome fair,
He thanked them, and to his sister his pledge was he fain to
swear,
But the maiden, right well she knew him by the golden
dragon's shine,⁸²⁵
And she spake, 'Thou art sure my brother, Orilus, or
Lähelein,
And pledge will I take from neither, for both of ye aye were
fain
To render to me such service as I from your hands would
gain.
I were dead to all truth and honour if I dealt with thee as a
foe,
My courtesy sure were shamèd by my own hand, and laid
alow.' ⁸³⁰

Then the prince knelt before the maiden and he spake, 'Thou
the truth hath said,
I am Orilus thy brother; the Red Knight this oath hath laid
On me that my pledge I yield thee, for so must I buy my life,
Wilt thou take it, then have I done that which I sware after
bitter strife.'

Then his pledge, who had borne the dragon, in her white
hand the maid must take,835
And she set him free, and he rose up, and thus to his sister
spake:

'Now to sorrow shall faith constrain me, alas! who hath
smitten thee?
The blows perforce must wound me—He who lusted thereto
might see,
If this were the hour for vengeance, that grief I with thee
must share;
And the bravest of men mourneth with me that ever a
woman bare, 840
He calleth himself the Red Knight—O king! he doth bid me
greet
Both thee and the queen thy lady, he doth offer ye service
meet,
As he fain would serve this my sister—His service ye will
repay,
If ye kindly entreat this maiden that her shaming be put
away.
And I, too, had fared far better at the hand of this dauntless
knight,845
Had he known the maid for my sister, and her blows on my
heart must light.'

Now Kay, he hath earned fresh hatred from all who would
there abide,
Both knights and gentle ladies, by Plimizöl's flowing tide,
From Iofreit the son of Idöl, from Gawain, and the
vanquished king
Klamidé, of whose sore peril I of yore unto ye would sing.
850
And from many another hero whose names I right well had
told,
But o'er-long would it be my story—So they thronged round
the hero bold,

And, courteous, he took their service—his wife would they
nearer bring,
She sat as yet on her palfrey, and they welcomed her, queen
and king.

Then the women they kissed each other, and thus spake the
king so true,⁸⁵⁵

'Thy father, King Lac of Karnant, for a gallant man I knew,
For his sake I mourned thy sorrow when first men the tale
did bear,

Methinks that thy lord should have spared thee for the sake
of thy face so fair!

For the prize was thine at Kanedig thro' the light of thy
beauty's ray,

And the hawk didst thou win for thy fairness, on thine hand
did it ride away.⁸⁶⁰

If Orilus wrong hath done me, yet I wished unto thee no ill,
And never I liked his judgment; and so doth it please me still
To see thee restored to favour, and clad in these garments
fair,

As fitting thy state, O Lady! since woe thou o'er-long didst
bear.'

And she quoth, 'Now may God reward thee, O Sire! for
these words so true,⁸⁶⁵

That thy fame may wax the higher, and may blossom and
bloom anew!'

Then Jeschuté and her husband, the twain, she took by the
hand,

And forth from the circle led them, the maiden of fair
Lalande.

And near to the royal pavilion, where a stream from the
meadow sprung,

Stood her tent on the plain, and above it a wingèd dragon
hung; ⁸⁷⁰

Half an apple it held in its clutches, and four ropes did it
draw on high,

E'en as if the tent it lifted, and aloft to the clouds would fly.
And Orilus thereby knew it, for the self-same arms he bare,
And beneath it would they disarm him—Then his sister so
true and fair,
She gave him due care and honour, and the vassals, each one
they spake, 875
How the Red Knight's valour dauntless would Fame for its
comrade take.

As thus aloud men praised him, in Kingron's ear spake Kay,
And he bade him do Orilus service—(Well he might, whom
he thus did pray,
For oft had he done such service for Klamidé in Brandigan.)
And for this Kay would give his office to the hand of
another man, 880
His ill-star had bid him smite her, the prince's sister fair,
So hard with his staff, 'twas fitting from their service he
should forbear.
Nor pardon she found for his trespass, this maiden of royal
race;
But viands he sent, and Kingron, he set them before their
face.

Kunnewaré, the wise and gentle, with her slender hands
and white, 885
Would cut the food for her brother, at his side sat his lady
bright.
And Jeschuté of Karnant bare her with courteous and
comely mien,
And Arthur the King forgat not, for fain he the twain had
seen,
And he came where they sat together, and ate with right
friendly will,
And he spake, 'Be good service lacking, then for sure it shall
please me ill, 890
For ne'er hath a host received ye, I trow, with a will so good,

And a heart so free from falsehood!' And he spake in kindly
mood,

'My Lady Kunnewaaré, see thou well to this gallant knight,
And the blessing of God be on ye, and keep ye till morning
light!'

Then Arthur to rest betook him, and a couch for the twain
they spread,⁸⁹⁵

And till daylight in peace they slumbered, and sorrow afar
had fled.

BOOK VI ARTHUR

ARGUMENT

BOOK VI. tells how King Arthur sought for the Red Knight; and how he took an oath of his heroes to refrain from fighting. Of the blood-stained snow, and the love-trance of Parzival; and how, unknowing, he overthrew Segramor, and took vengeance on Kay. How Gawain led Parzival to the court of King Arthur; and how he was made a knight of the Round Table. Of the coming of Kondrie, and Kingrimursel, and the shaming of Parzival and Gawain. Of Parzival's wrath and despair, and how he rode forth to seek the Grail. How the knights went forth to the venture of Château Merveil; and how Gawain rode to Askalon; and of the scattering of this goodly company.

BOOK VI ARTHUR



Now perchance it were well I should tell ye, how, as this his
folk did pray,
From Karidöl and his kingdom, King Arthur had ridden
away.
And now the venture telleth, on his own and on stranger
ground
For eight days long had they ridden, nor yet had the Red
Knight found.
For in truth 'twas for him they were seeking, to honour his
hand were fain,⁵
From sorrow had he released them, who had erst Prince Ither
slain;

And Klamidé the king, and Kingron, in a welcome hour had
sent
To the court of the Breton Monarch: for on this was King
Arthur bent,
He would make him one of his circle, a knight of the Table
Round,
No labour too great he counted, so the hero at last he found!
10

Thus o'er mountain and vale they sought him—All who
knightly shield might bear,
King Arthur now called around him, and in this wise he bade
them swear:
What deeds so e'er of knighthood they should see, by this
their oath,
They should on no conflict venture, but faithful still keep
their troth,
As they sware unto him, their monarch, and fight but as he
thereto 15
Should give them leave—He spake thus, 'Now, 'tis well!
Since we needs must go
Thro' many a stranger country, where many a stranger spear,
And many a gallant hero are waiting us, I fear,
If ye, like hounds untrained whose leash shall have slipped
the hand
Of him who was late their master, shall roam free o'er all the
land, 20
Much evil might there befall ye, and such chance should but
please me ill,
And by this your oath, I think me, such rashness I best may
still.
Be ye sure and need ariseth, your king ne'er will say you
Nay,
Till then, as I here command ye, ride peaceful upon your
way.'

Now the oath, ye shall well have heard it—Now hear ye
how Parzival,²⁵
The Waleis, rode near unto them: thro' the night did the
snow-flakes fall,
Light they fell, yet lay thickly on him, yet if well I the tale
may know,
And the singer aright hath sung it, it was never the time of
snow;
For whate'er men have sung or spoken of King Arthur, at
Whitsuntide,
Or when May-blossoms deck the meadow, these marvels did
aye betide. 30
For sweetly the springtide bloometh, and many a garb, I
ween,
Shall it bear this song of my singing, tho' snow-clad it now
be seen.

The falconers from Karidöl, as the shadows of evening fell,
Rode, hawking, by Plimizöl's waters, when an evil chance
befell,
For the best of their hawks flew from them, nor stooped to
the lure again,³⁵
But all night in the dusky shadows of the woodland it did
remain.

With Parzival it sheltered; to the twain was the woodland
way
A road unknown, sharp the frost stung, in the far east uprose
the day,
And, lo! all around the hero, the snow-flakes lay thick and
white:
Thro' the forest paths untrodden, in ever waxing light, 40
Rode our hero by hedge or thicket, by rock and by fallen
tree,
Till clear grew the shadowy woodland, and its depths he
well might see,

And a mighty tree of the forest had fallen where he would
ride,
(The falcon yet followed after) 'mid its clustering boughs he
spied
A flock of wild-geese from the Northland, their hissing he
first had heard,⁴⁵
Swift swooped the falcon upon them and struck to the earth
a bird:
And scarce might it fly the clutches of its foe, and fresh
shelter take
'Neath the shade of the fallen branches; in its flight from the
wounds there brake
Three blood-drops, all glowing crimson, and fell on the
spotless snow,
As Parzival's eyes beheld them, swift sorrow his heart must
know! 50

Now hear ye his love so loyal—As he looked on these
blood-drops bright,
That stained with a stain of crimson the snow-flakes that lay
so white,
He thought, 'Say what hand hath painted these colours that
here I see?
Kondwiramur, I think well, these tints sure shall liken thee!
And white snow and blood-drops crimson, do ever thy
likeness share, 55
For this favour I praise God's working, and the world he
hath wrought so fair!
For in this wise I read the vision,—in this snow that so
spotless lies,
'Gainst the blood-drops, that ruddy-gleaming, glow crimson
beneath mine eyes,
I find ever thy face so gracious, my lady, Kondwiramur,
Red as blood-drops and white as the snowdrift, it rejoiceth
me evermore!'⁶⁰
Then her sweet face arose before him, in that night she first
sought his side,

When on each cheek a tear-drop glistened, and a third to her
chin did glide.

And so true was his love and steadfast, little recked he of
aught around,

But wrapped round in love and longing, saw naught but the
blood-stained ground.

Frau Minne with force constrained him, as here on his wife
he thought,⁶⁵

And by magic of colours mystic, a spell on his senses
wrought.

So held he him still, as sleeping—Would ye know who
found him there?

The squire of fair Kunnewaaré would forth unto Lalande
fare,

And as on his way he journeyed, by the woodland green he
saw

A helmet all battle-dinted, and a shield which yet traces bore
70

Of many a bitter conflict that was foughten for lady fair;
And a knight there abode in armour, and his lance he aloft
did bear

As one who here patient waited the joust that he fain would
ride.

The squire swiftly turned his bridle and back to the camp he
hied.

Yet in sooth had he seen the stranger, and his lady's
champion known,⁷⁵

He had ne'er been so swift to decry him, nor had wished he
were overthrown,

Nor e'en as he were an outlaw, set the heroes upon his track:
The squire he of queen unfaithful, small wonder he
knighthood lacked!

And in this wise he called upon them, 'Fie! Fie! on ye,
coward knights!

Hold ye not Gawain for a marvel? Have ye not in a hundred
fights 80

Won honour and fame as heroes, who fight for a hero king?
Know now that ye stand dishonoured, and broken your
goodly ring!

Ah! then there arose a clamour, and none but was fain to
know

Of the deed of knightly prowess, that should shame their
honour so.

When they heard how but one knight dared them, that but
one knight a foe did wait, 85

Then sorely they mourned the promise that they sware to
their king of late.

Then Knight Segramor sprang swiftly from amid the angry
throng,

He ran, for in sooth he walked not, and ever his heart did
long

To be in the midst of conflict, where conflict might chance
to be,

An they failèd with cords to bind him, in the thick of the
fight was he! 90

And nowhere the Rhine's swift waters may flow so strong
and wide,

Tho' the stream should run swift between them, an men
fought on the further side,

He stayed not to test the waters, if the current be hot or cold,
But straightway the stream he breasted, as fitted a swimmer
bold!

Swift-foot to the tent of the monarch, the eager youth he
sped, 95

For the day was but yet in its dawning, and the king he lay
yet abed.

Then straight thro' the lists he hied him, and he gat him thro'
the door,

And the covering all of sable, with hasty hand he tore

From the twain who lay warm beneath it, and slumbered a
 slumber deep,
Yet his haste moved them but to laughter, tho' he waked
 them from out their sleep!100
And loudly he cried on his cousin—'Queen, Lady,
 Guinevere,
Since the world knoweth well our kinship, thou must do me
 this service here,
Speak thou for me to thine husband, and pray thou of him
 this grace,
Since a knightly venture nears us, my lot *first* the foe to
 face!'

Yet Arthur spake, 'Now bethink thee of the oath thou didst
 swear to me,105
In all things my will to follow, nor rashly to venture thee;
For if thou a joust now ridest, hereafter shall many a knight
Crave leave at mine hand to ride forth, and seek for fame in
 fight,
And 'twere ill thus our force to weaken, for know thou that
 near at hand,
Anfortas of Monsalväsich with a mighty host doth stand. 110
This wood of his he guardeth, and since we but little know
Where he and his force shall hold them, such chance well
 might work us woe!'

Yet Guinevere wrought so wisely Segramor was well-nigh
 fain
To die of joy, from King Arthur, his lady this grace did gain.
And on fame and honour only was the gallant youth intent,
 115
Nor for gold had he sold the venture on which his heart was
 bent.

Now the hero young and beardless, well armed his steed
 bestrode,

And over the fresh young greensward his charger at full
speed rode;
And the bushes were bent beneath him, and the golden bells
rang clear
On trapping alike and armour; and I deem well an need were
here 120
To seek for the magic pheasant mid thicket and thorny
brake,
He who fain this knight had followed, the bells for his guide
might take!
Thus rashly rode the hero, to him whom Frau Minne's spell
Fast fettered in magic fetters, and no blow at the first there
fell,
For the peace by his word was broken—There held fast by
threefold might,125
And the power of red blood-drops threefold stood ever the
stranger knight.

(Yea, well I myself have known this, how Frau Minne with
power may hold,
And holding, the senses scatter, and with passion of grief
untold
Shall fill the heart to o'erflowing—"Twas a woman who
wrought this ill,
And vanquished, she doth condemn me, and refuseth me
comfort still.130
Thus draweth she guilt upon her, for the sin shall be hers, I
ween,
And afar must I fly from the presence, that of old time my
joy hath been.)

Thus Segramor quoth unto him, 'Now it seemeth but ill to
me
That thus near our army lieth, and our presence rejoiceth
thee!
And thou holdest his fame too lightly, whom with pride we
may hail our king,135

And 'tis meet thou for this do penance,—or the death-chime
for me shall ring!
Thus armed, all too near thou ridest; yet first would I
courteous pray
That thou yield thee at this my bidding, or my wrong will I
here repay,
And my blow shall be swift, and thy falling shall scatter
these snow-flakes white!
And I call on thee here to yield thee, ere I put thee to shame,
Sir Knight!'140

Yet Parzival still kept silence—for Frau Minne, so fair and
young,
In a sorer conflict held him—Then his steed Segramor
swung
Aside, as for jousting ready, round wheeled him the war-
horse good
On whose back the gallant hero yet sate in mystic mood,
And ever he gazed on the blood-drops; as his charger turned
him round145
Awhile from his eyes they vanished, and fame in their stead
he found!
For swift as the blood-drops crimson thus passed from his
dazzled sight,
He hearkened the voice of the foeman, and braced him anew
for fight.

Then as Segramor rode against him, Parzival sought afresh
the spear
That he found by the woodland chapel, with blazon of
colours clear;150
For tough was the shaft, and he gripped it, and he held the
point full low,
As his foeman dashed fair against him, his shield rang with
the ringing blow.
Then he spurred him anew to the onslaught, and the joust he
so well repaid,

That the knight in his golden armour was low in the
snowdrift laid!
Yet still was the spear unsplintered, tho' it bare him from off
his horse;155
And Parzival still kept silence, and he wheeled him upon his
course,
And his eyes sought once more the blood-drops, and e'en as
they met his sight
Frau Minne with fetters bound him, and held him in cords of
might,
And he spake never word, nor question, but gazed ever upon
the ground,
And, dreaming, he lost the knowledge which he for a space
had found!160

But affrighted, the gallant charger had fled back into its stall,
And its rider arose, little comfort might he find, though he
soft might fall!
Outstretched had he lain in the snowdrift, in such wise e'en
as men shall go
To rest, yet but ill he sleepeth, who sleepeth on couch of
snow!
And such bed had sorrow brought me! for he to whom ill
betides 165
Hath but mocking for his bedfellow, but the lucky doth
God's hand guide.

So near was King Arthur's army, that right well might
Parzival
Be seen of all men, and the wonders, and the conflict that
then befell.
The victor by Love was vanquished, by Love that in days of
old
Did the king of all kings the wisest, King Solomon, captive
hold! 170
Short space, then, ere back to the army once more Knight
Segramor came,

An with praise or with blame they should greet him, he
counted it still the same.
And sharp words he flung among them, with mocking
tongue and bold,
Tho' vanquished, yet not dishonoured, must they ever the
hero hold!

And he quoth, 'Have ye never heard this, that strife bringeth
loss as gain?175
And never a joust, I wot me, but the victor doth one remain,
While one aye shall be the vanquished: The best ship in
storm may sink,
And I wot that ye ne'er have heard me to speak, for I ne'er
did think,
An he knew of my shield the blazon, he had faced me not as
a foe!
Much evil, in sooth, hath he wrought me, and yet doth he
wait below180
All those who would ride against him, for he seemeth for
conflict fain,
An a knight should in joust o'erthrow him, such chance
might he count for gain.'

Then straightway unto King Arthur Sir Kay did the tidings
bring,
How his knight, Segramor, had fallen, and his victor,
without their ring,
A young knight, for jousting ready, yet waited with ill intent
— 185
'Nay, I think an this stranger warrior of so many unpunished
went,
A burden both sore and shameful on our honour such lack
would lay;
Now, my king, an thou hold me worthy, do thou grant me
this grace, I pray,
I would ride hence to ask his meaning, who thus in the
presence fair

Of our Queen Guinevere and her maidens his lance-point
aloft doth bear;190
But if thou shouldst this boon refuse me, then know, not
another hour
I abide here as this thy servant; for I hold that the knightly
power
And the fair fame of thy Round Table are stained if we delay
To arm ourselves 'gainst the stranger who dareth our strength
to-day!
Now, I prithee, give leave to fight him—For tho' blind and
deaf were we,195
Yet 'tis time that we should defend us'—'As thou willest, so
let it be!'

Then swift did the seneschal arm him, and I ween in fierce
anger's fire
A woodland he fain had wasted 'gainst the foe, who with
strong desire
And love was thus sorely burdened; for Frau Minne a magic
spell
Had wrought with the snow-flakes spotless, and the blood-
drops that crimson fell.200
And his knighthood he sorely shamèd, who thought here to
work him harm,
Since he faileth true Love to honour, who denieth of Love
the charm.

Frau Minne, say, why dost thou make glad the souls that
mourn
With bliss that too swiftly fleeting, but leaveth them more
forlorn?
And how canst thou, Frau Minne, true worth and knightly
fame, 205
And manly strength and courage, thus vanquish and put to
shame?
For the least is to thee as the greatest, and the earth shall no
hero boast,

Who thinketh to scorn thine empire, but he learneth unto his
cost
That thou canst, an thou wilt, o'erthrow him; yea, all men
thy power obey,
For thy sceptre we own as mighty, and wide as the world its
sway. 210

Yet this one thing it doth thee honour, tho' thou rulest all else
but ill,
Joy maketh her dwelling with thee, and for this would I
praise thee still!

Frau Minne, alas! of old time full false were thy ways, I
ween,
Nor hast thou thy dealings mended, nor to-day hast thou
truer been,
Thou hast many a maiden shamèd, who love forbidden
sought; 215
Thro' thy dealings, upon the vassal, his lord hath sorrow
brought;
And the friend shall false and faithless to the friend of his
bosom prove,
And the servant betray his master; such deeds do but shame
thee, Love!
And I would that it were far from thee, the body to yield to
lust,
In such wise that the soul ashamèd is stricken with sorrow's
thrust, 220
And that with force compelling, the young thou makest old,
Though their years but few be counted, this must we for
treason hold!

Such speech, I ween, beseems not the man who in serving
thee
Hath comfort found! If succour thine hand ever brought to
me,

I had been less slow to praise thee, but sorrow and loss alone
225

Hast thou counted to me as guerdon, and such glamour thine
art hath thrown

O'er mine eyes, that, methinks, henceforward I trust thee
never more,

Though small profit it brought unto thee, the bitter grief I
bore!

And yet too high above me art thou, that whate'er my wrong,
I should e'en as a fool upbraid thee with bitter words and
strong: 230

For thy spear too sharply pierces, and scarce may we bear
the weight,

Thou layest at will upon us—Methinks he who sang of late,
'Neath a tree, of thy mystic dealings, and thy wondrous ways
of old,

Had better done had he told us how we thy grace might
hold!

(Heinrich of Veldeck was he, and he taught us, I ween, right
well 235

Of the winning of Love, of its guarding, alas! he failed to
tell.)

For oft one thro' folly loses the prize that he late did win;
Yea, to me hath such fate befallen, yet Frau Minne, *thine*
was the sin!

Since all wisdom shall be thy portion, since against thee nor
spear, nor shield,

Nor charger, nor guarded fortress their vaunted power can
wield, 240

I know not what shall withstand thee, nor on earth, nor on
the sea!

He who feareth to face thy conflict, say whither shall he
flee?

'Twas thy mystic power, Frau Minne, that dealt thus with
Parzival,

And reft him awhile of knowledge, and wrought with him as
a fool.

For fair was the queen and gracious who reigned in far
Pelrapär, 245
And she thought on her lord and husband, and she made thee
her message bear.
And for this cause Kardeiss her brother, hast thou for thy
payment slair,
And since thou such tribute askest, 'tis well that I ne'er have
ta'en
From thine hand aught of good, since in such wise thou dost
for thy debtors care—
This I spake for the sake of all men—List ye now how Sir
Kay did fare:250

Now he rode forth in knightly armour to the strife that he
sore did crave,
And Gamuret's son, right willing, to his wish fulfilment
gave.
And wherever fair maids compelling, their voices uplift in
prayer,
And the grace they shall ask be granted, let them pray here
for his welfare,
Since it was thro' a woman's beauty, that the spell of a
woman wrought255
Love's magic, of senses robbed him—Then his charger to
halt Kay brought;
And he spake to the gallant Waleis, 'Sir Knight, since thou
thus our king
Hast shamed, thou shalt hear my counsel, for wisdom
perchance 'twill bring;
Thou shalt hang thee a hempen halter around thy neck
straightway,
For so may I lightly lead thee, and take thou with me thy
way. 260
Nor think thou, thou canst escape me, but with me unto my
lord
Shalt thou go, as befits a captive, else worse may be thy
reward!'

By love constrained, the Waleis nor word nor answer spoke,
Kay gripped his spear-shaft tightly and he smote with a
mighty stroke

On the hero's head, till the helmet rang loudly beneath his
hand; 265

And he quoth, 'Now will I awake thee! Dost think here to
take thy stand,

And standing sleep unsheeted? Nay, other shalt thou fare,
Low on the snow I'll lay thee! The ass that is wont to bear
The sack from the mill would rue it, did one smite him in
such wise,

As here I think now to smite thee, and thy sloth and thy
sleep chastise!' 270

Frau Minne, now bethink thee, for sore this shameth thee,
For an one should wrong a peasant, in this wise his speech
will be,

'My lord will sure repay thee!' Vengeance from thee he'd
seek

Methinks, this gallant Waleis, an thou wouldst let him speak!
Now let him from out thy circle, and loose him from thy
ban, 275

This stranger guest shalt prove him, a true and valiant man!

Swift rode Sir Kay unto him, and he turned his bridle round,
And no more his longing glances their joy and their sorrow
found,

The white snow and blood-drops crimson, that mystic
likeness bare

To the queen of his love and his longing, the Lady of
Pelrapär; 280

He knew all that passed around him—His charger Sir Kay
addrest

To jousting, he spurred him onward, and his spear he laid in
rest.

In the joust, that which Kay had aimed at he smote, for his
spear did pierce
The Waleis' shield, yet swift payment was his, for in
onslaught fierce
The seneschal of King Arthur fell prone on the fallen tree,
285
Where the geese erewhile had hid them, and hurt full sore
was he,
And dead lay his gallant charger—"Twixt a stone and the
saddle-bow,
Right arm, and left leg had he broken—so mighty his
overthrow
That all that had decked his charger, girths, saddle, bells of
gold,
By the force of the fall were shattered, thus the stranger his
payment told, 290
And with one blow, for twain repaid him—the one that erst
for his sake,
A maiden had borne and the other, which he from Kay's
hand must take.

Thus he who knew naught of falsehood was guided of truth
to know
Her message in blood-drops threefold, on the white of the
drifted snow.
'Twas tear-drops, not blood, that he saw there, and well
might his senses fail, 295
And the thoughts of his heart wax heavy, as he mused on the
wondrous Grail,
And sorely the semblance grieved him that spake of his wife
and queen.
Yet tho' o'er the twain he sorrowed, the greater woe, I ween,
Was the woe that Frau Minne wrought him, for there liveth
not heart so strong,
But longing and love united break its power, ere the time be
long. 300

Count we here those twain as ventures? Nay, 'twere better
methinks to hold,
That they were naught but pain and sorrow, that vanquished
the hero bold.

Now ye unto whom I tell this, I rede ye to mourn Kay's woe,
For full oft as his manhood bade him, he many a strife did
know.

And in many a land they speak thus, that Kay, Arthur's
seneschal, 305

Was a firebrand, hell-born, yet I wot well far other the tale
I'd tell.

From reproach would I gladly free him, tho' few but should
say me nay,

Yet a gallant man and a worthy, I swear was this knight, Sir
Kay.

And my mouth to this truth beareth witness, and more would
I tell to thee;

Unto Arthur's Court came strangers in many a company, 310
And their manners and ways were diverse, nor all there
might honour claim,

But Kay an he saw false dealing, he counted such ways as
shame,

And his face he turned from the sinner, yet he who dealt
courteously,

And true man with true men would hold him, Kay served
him right heartily.

And one who fall well discernèd the manner of men was
Kay, 315

Thus he did to his lord good service, for his harsh words
drave far away

The men who would falsely vaunt them good knights and
true to be,

Ill was he to them as a hailstorm, sharp as sting of an angry
bee.

Small wonder that these deny him his honour and knightly
fame,
True servant and wise they found him, and for this cause
upon his name³²⁰
Their hatred doth still heap slander—Prince Herman,
Thuringia's lord,
Thou with vassals that crowd around thee, and strangers
who seek thy board,
Good service might Kay have done thee, since so free art
thou aye of hand,
That true men and men dishonoured, side by side in thine
hall they stand;
And therefore Knight Walter singeth, 'Now greeting to all I
bring, ³²⁵
Men evil and good!' And I trow well, where a singer such
song may sing,
There the false are too highly honoured—Nay, far other Sir
Kay had taught,
(Yea, and Heinrich of Rispach also)—Now hearken ye in
what sort
On Plimizöl's plain men bare them; from the field Sir Kay
was borne
To the tent of his king, and around him, o'er his ill-fate his
friends did mourn;³³⁰
And maiden and knight they stood there; to the tent where
his comrade lay
Came Gawain, and he quoth in sadness, 'Alas! for the
woeful day
That so ill a joust was ridden that hath robbed me of a
friend!'
Then out spake Kay in his anger, 'Now make of thy moan an
end,
If comfort thou here wouldst bring me, do not as the women
do, ³³⁵
Since thou art my monarch's nephew! I would do to thee
service true,

As of free heart I ever did it, in the day that God gave me
power,
Nor long for my aid hadst thou prayed me! There cometh,
perchance, an hour
When I, as of old, may serve thee: now cease thou thy moan
I pray,
For tho' mine be the pain, yet my monarch shall ne'er find
another Kay,340
And I wot that for mine avenger art thou all too nobly born;
An yet hadst *thou* lost a finger I had counted myself
forsworn
An I risked not mine head to pay it! Let that be as it may,
Believe me or not, as shall please thee, yet sooth are the
words I say!

'No joust shalt thou ride at my urging, for roughly he greets
his foe,345
Who holdeth without his station, and rideth nor swift nor
slow.
And I think me, of maidens' tresses, tho' frail be such cord
and fair,
Enough from such strife to bind thee, the chain of a single
hair!
And the man who shall show such meekness, he well doth
his *mother* love,
Since his *sire* would fain in the conflict his knightly mettle
prove.350
But follow thou aye thy mother, Sir Gawain, list well her
rede.
Turn thou pale at the glancing sword-blade, and shrink from
the manly deed!"

And thus on the gallant hero the bitter words he spake
Fell sharply, he looked not for them, nor on Kay might he
vengeance take,
Full seldom a knight may do so, since shame on his lips
setteth seal,355

But they who thus speak discourteous, such shame shall they
never feel.

Then Gawain he quoth in answer, 'Where men knightly
sword might bear,
And have foughten, and I fought with them, then no man
beheld me there,
And saw that my cheek waxed paler at sight of wound or
blow.
I was ever thy friend—'twas needless that thou shouldst
reproach me so!'360
Then he strode from the tent, and he bade them bring hither
his charger good,
Nor spur on his heel he buckled, unarmed he his steed
bestrode.

So came he unto the Waleis (whose sense was of love held
fast),
And his shield to all eyes bare witness of three spears thro'
its circle passed,
For three jousts of late had he ridden, and he rode them with
heroes twain,365
Of Orilus too was he smitten—Then gently uprode Gawain,
And he spurred not his steed to gallop, nor conflict nor strife
he sought,
For he rode but in love and in kindness, to seek him who
here had fought.
Fair spake Gawain the stranger, to greeting deaf was he,
Frau Minne yet held him captive, how other might it be? 370
True son of Herzeleide, to this lot was he born,
To lose himself for love's sake; such passion as had torn
The hearts of these his parents, afresh in his heart awoke,
And but little his ear might hearken what the mouth of
Gawain spoke.

Quoth King Lot's son unto the Waleis, 'Sir Knight, here thou
doest ill375

In that thou withholdest greeting—tho' patient I wait thy will
Far otherwise can I bear me! Know thou that to friend and
king,
Yea, to all whom I count my fellows, thy deed doth
dishonour bring,
And our shame ever waxeth greater; yet prayed I for thee
this grace,
The king of free heart forgives thee, if now thou shalt seek
his face.³⁸⁰
So hearken, I pray, my counsel, and do thou as I shall say,
And ride thou with me to King Arthur, nor too long shalt
thou find the way.'

Nor threatening nor prayer might move him, this fair son of
Gamuret:
Then the pride of King Arthur's knighthood his memory
backward set,
And he thought of Frau Minne's dealings, and the time when
the knife's sharp blade³⁸⁵
He drave thro' his hand unwitting, thro' the love of a
gracious maid.
And that time when from death's cold clutches, a queen's
hand had set him free,
When of Lâhelein was he vanquished, and captive in joust
was he,
And a queen in the day of his danger must pledge her fair
life for his,
And her name shall of men be praised, Queen Ingus of
Bachtarliess. ³⁹⁰
Thought Gawain, 'It may be Frau Minne dealeth so with this
goodly man,
As she dealt with me of old time, so claspeth him in the ban
Of her magic spells fair-woven, that his spirit within the
snare
She holdeth fast entangled'—Then his eyes on the snow-
flakes fair

He cast, and he knew the token, and swift from the spell-
bound sight³⁹⁵

With cloth of fair silk and sendal, he covered the blood-
drops bright.

The blood-stained snow was hidden, nor longer its spell was
seen,

And his sight and his sense unclouded she gave him, his
wife and queen;

Yet his heart did she hold in her keeping, and its dwelling
was Pelrapär,

And he cried aloud in his sorrow thro' the silent summer air;
⁴⁰⁰

'Alas! who of thee hath robbed me, who erewhile wast my
queen and wife,

For thy love, thy crown, and thy kingdom my right hand
hath won in strife.

Say, say, am I he who saved thee from Klamidé the warrior
king?

Yea, sorrow and bitter sighing, and grief that the heart doth
wring

Are the guerdons I won in thy service, and now from mine
eyes be-dazed⁴⁰⁵

Art thou reft, and thy place I know not, tho' but now on thy
face I gazed.'

Then he quoth, 'Now, where shall my spear be, since I wot
well I brought it here?'

Quoth Gawain, 'A joust hast thou ridden, and splintered shall
be thy spear.'

'With whom should I joust?' quoth the Waleis, 'thou bearest
nor sword nor shield,

And little had been mine honour, an thou to my hand didst
yield! ⁴¹⁰

Yet bear I awhile thy mocking, nor will I thy friendship pray,
Tho' many a joust have I ridden, yet my saddle I kept away.

An thou be not for jousting minded, and I find not in thee a
foe,
Yet the world lieth wide before me, and hence on my way I
go;
For labour and strife am I seeking and fain would I win me
praise, 415
Be anguish or joy my portion; nor unfruitful shall be my
days.'

Quoth Gawain, 'What I spake aforetime I spake of true heart
and free,
Nor my thoughts were the thoughts of evil, for well would I
deal with thee;
And the boon that I crave will I win me, my monarch with
many a knight
Lieth here at hand with his army, and with many a lady
bright, 420
An it please thee, Sir Knight, to betake thee to our goodly
company,
From all strife shall this right hand guard thee, and gladly I'll
ride with thee.'
'I thank thee, Sir Knight, fair thou speakest, yet say ere with
thee I ride,
Who the monarch may be whom thou servest? and who
rideth here at my side?'

'A man do I hail as master, thro' whose fame much fame I
won, 425
Nor here shall my mouth keep silence on the things he for
me hath done.
For dear hath he ever held me, and as true knight did me
entreat:
(His sister King Lot hath wedded, and the twain I as parents
greet.)
And the good gifts God gave unto me, to his service I yield
them all,

For my hand and my heart he ruleth, whom men do King
Arthur call. 430
Nor mine own name need here be hidden, nor a secret shall
long remain,
For the folk and the lands that know me, they call on me as
Gawain:
And fain would I do thee service, alike with my hand and
name,
If thou turnest here at my bidding, nor bringest upon me
shame!'

Then he quoth, 'Is it thou, O Gawain? too little I yet have
done 435
That thou shouldst as a friend entreat me; yet hast thou this
honour won
That all men thou gently treatest—and thy friendship I here
will take,
Yet not for mine own deserving, but repayment I fain would
make.
Now say where thine army lieth, since so many tents I see
That stand fair by the brink of the river? If King Arthur in
truth shall be440
So near, then must I bemoan me, that in honour I may not
dare
To enter his royal presence, or look on his queen so fair.
Since 'tis meet that I first avenge me of a foul and
discourteous blow,
For which, since the day I left them, I sorrow and shame
must know.
For a maiden as she beheld me, laughed sweetly, the
seneschal 445
For my sake smote the maid so sorely, 'twas a wood that
upon her fell.'

'Rough vengeance thou here hast taken! (Gawain to the
Waleis spake)

Since thou in a joust hast felled him, and right arm and left
leg he brake.

Ride here, see his charger lifeless, that lieth the stone below;
On the snowdrift behold the splinters of the spear that hath
dealt the blow!450

'Tis the spear thou but now wast seeking!' Then the truth
knew Sir Parzival,
And straightway he spake unto Gawain, 'Now, if this be the
seneschal,
And the man who so sorely shamed me, if thou swear me
that this was he,
Thou mayst ride where thou wilt, and gladly will I ride in
thy company!'

'Nay, never a lie do I tell thee,' quoth Gawain, 'thou hast
overthrown455
Segramor, who ere now in battle was ever as victor known,
He fell ere yet Kay had met thee: great deeds hast thou done
to-day,
Since o'er two of our bravest heroes the prize thou hast
borne away.'

So rode they, the one with the other, the Waleis and Knight
Gawain,

And the folk, both afoot and on horseback, with honour
would greet the twain,460

Gawain and his guest the Red Knight, this did they of
courtesy,

And the twain to his fair pavilion they gat them right
speedily.

And the lady, fair Kunnewaaré, whose tent by Gawain's did
stand,

Rejoiced, and she joyful greeted the hero, whose strong right
hand

Had failed not to wreak stern vengeance for the ill that Kay
wrought that day;465

Then her brother and fair Jeschuté she led by the hand
straightway,

And Parzival looked upon them as the three to his tent drew
near,
And his face, thro' the rust of his armour, it shone ever fair
and clear,
As roses dew-dipped had flown there: his harness aside he
laid,
And he stood before Kunnewaaré, and thus spake the gentle
maid: 470

'To God shalt thou first be welcome, as welcome thou art to
me,
Since thy manhood thou well hast proven, and the faith that
I had in thee!
Ere the day that my heart beheld thee, nor laughter nor
smiles I knew,
And Kay, who in that hour smote me, with stern hand my
gladness slew.
But now hast thou well avenged me! With a kiss I thy deed
would pay, 475
If I of thy kiss were worthy!' 'Nay, so had I thought to-day
To crave of thy lips my payment,' quoth Parzival, 'if thou
still
Wilt give me such gracious greeting, right gladly I'll do thy
will!'

Then she kissed him, and down they sate them, and the
princess a maiden sent
And bade her to bring rich raiment; so sped she unto the
tent; 480
And the garments they lay there ready, of rich silk of
Nineveh,
For her prisoner, King Klamidé, had she fashioned them
cunningly.
Then the maiden who bare the garments, full sorely must she
bewail
That the mantle was yet unfinished, since the silken cord did
fail.

Then the lady, Kunnewaaré, from her side drew a silken
band 485
From the folds of her robe, in the mantle she wove it with
skilful hand.

Then courteous her leave he prayed him, the rust would he
wash away,
And fair shone his face, and youthful, and his lips they were
red that day.
And robed was the gallant hero, and so bright and so fair
was he,
That all men who there beheld him, they sware he for sure
must be 490
The flower and the crown of manhood, a knight without
shame or fear;
And they looked upon him, and they praised him and his
colour waxed bright and clear,
And right well did his garb become him; an emerald green
and rare,
The gift of fair Kunnewaaré, as clasp at his neck he bare;
And a girdle beside she gave him, all wrought in a cunning
row 495
With mystic beasts, bejewelled, that burnt with a fiery glow,
And its clasp was a red-fire ruby—How think ye the
beardless youth
Was seen when thus richly girded? Fair was he in very
sooth,
For so the story runneth—the folk bare him right goodwill,
Men and women who looked upon him, they counted him
worthy still. 500

Forthwith, as the Mass was ended, came Arthur the noble
king,
And the knights of his Table with him, a goodly following.
No man there whose lips spake falsehood. Yea, all heard the
word that day,

'With Gawain the Red Knight dwelleth!' the king thither
took his way.

Then the knight who so sore was beaten came swiftly, Sir
Antanor, 505

For, fain to behold the Waleis, his feet sped the king before,
And he asked, 'Art thou he who avenged me, and the lady of
fair Lalande?

Now vanished shall be Kay's honour, for it falleth unto thine
hand,

And an end hast thou made of his threatening, and the days
of his strife are o'er,

For his arm it is weak, and his vengeance I fear for it never
more!' 510

And so fair was the knight and radiant, that all men beheld
his face

As an angel from heaven, that wingless, abideth on earth a
space.

And well did King Arthur greet him, and his knights were no
whit behind,

And all they who looked upon him, naught but love in their
hearts might find,

And their lips to their heart made answer, and all spake to
his praises, 'Yea,' 515

And no man gainsaid the other, so lovely his mien that day!

Then Arthur spake fair unto him, 'Thou hast wrought me
both joy and pain,

Yet ne'er from the hand of a hero such honour I thought to
gain

As the honour that thou hast brought me! yet no service I did
to thee,

An I did, then thy fame had repaid it, tho' no other thy deeds
should be 520

Than the deed thou hast done in the winning for Jeschuté her
husband's grace!

Nor Kay's guilt had been unavengèd, if ere this I had seen
thy face
Myself had, unasked, chastised him.' Then Arthur in this
wise spake,
'Since so far they had come, and their journey had they taken
but for his sake,
They all with one voice did pray him, to swear to them
brotherhood,525
And be one of the gallant Table, a comrade both true and
good.'
And their prayer it seemed good unto him, and joyful at
heart was he,
And he sware them the oath that they asked for, and their
knight would he gladly be.

Now hear ye, and speak the verdict, if on this day the Table
Round
Its right, and its due observance had here, as aforetime
found; 530
Since for many a day King Arthur in this wise had ruled his
court,
No knight should break bread before him, if there came of
fair venture naught.
But enough should have chanced this morning, and to Table
they well might go,
Though from Nantes might they never bear it, yet they here
would its semblance show.
Wide enow was the flowery meadow, nor hindered them tree
or tent, 535
As they did here their monarch's bidding—for this was his
heart's intent,
Fair honour to give the Red Knight, and his valour, as meet,
reward—
Then a silk in Acraton woven, they laid on the grassy sward,
'Twas brought from far lands of paynim, and 'twas shapen
both wide and round;

For ever this courteous custom mid these gallant knights was
found,540
No high seat had they of honour, but all men were equal
there;
And thus had King Arthur willed it, both the knights and
their ladies fair
At the Table Round were welcome, yea, an they might
honour claim,
Knight, lady, or gentle maiden, at his court all should fare
the same!

And there, with her maiden following, came fair Guinevere
the queen,545
And many a noble princess amid her train was seen,
And none but was fair to look on, and the ring it was spread
so wide
That within, without strife or crowding, each maid sat her
knight beside.
And Arthur, who ne'er knew falsehood, led the Waleis by the
hand,
And Kunnewaaré she walked beside him, the lady of fair
Lalande, 550
From sorrow the knight had freed her—Then, with kind and
friendly eyes,
Looked Arthur upon the hero, and he spake to him in this
wise:

'My queen will I bid to kiss thee, who art fair both of form
and face,
For ne'er, in this court, of lady I ween wouldst thou crave
this grace,
Since from Pelrapär thou hast ridden, and wert thou on
kissing bent555
From lips of all lips the fairest, hast thou there thy full
heart's content!
Yet this one grace will I pray thee, if ever there dawn the day

That I find 'neath thy roof abiding, this kiss I may then
repay!'
'In sooth, will I do thy bidding,' quoth the Waleis, 'both there
and here!'
Then unto the gallant hero stepped the Lady Guinevere, 560
And fair on the lips she kissed him, and she quoth, 'Here I
pardon thee
The ill thou aforetime didst me, and the sorrow thou gavest
me.
Thou didst leave me sorely grieving, when from hence thou
didst ride away.
By thy hand and thy dart my kinsman Prince Ither was slain
that day!'

And all tear-bedewed were the eyelids of the Lady
Guinevere, 565
For Prince Ither's death wrought sorrow unto many a woman
dear.
Now must King Klamidé seat him, on the bank by Plimizöl,
And beside him sate Iofreit, who was son unto King Idöl;
And 'twixt Klamidé and Gawain must the Waleis have his
place—
And they know who tell the venture, none sate here of royal
grace, 570
None who woman's breast had suckled, whose fame stood so
high and fair,
For courage and youthful beauty did the Waleis, as jewels,
wear.
And they owned, who there looked upon him, that many a
maiden bright
Saw herself in a darker mirror than the lips of this fair young
knight.
And on cheek and on chin his colour might well as fetters be
575
For those who should need such fetters, whose fancy flitteth
free.

Here might there be naught of changing—(of women my
rede I trow
For some they are ever wavering, and ever new friendships
know!)

But his look ever constant held them, till I wot well that thro'
their eyes
His entry he gained triumphant, and made of their hearts his
prize!580

Thus maiden and man beheld him, and his honour all men
did praise,
Till he found here the goal of sighing, and the end of his
joyous days.
For hither came one I must tell of, and faithful was she in
truth
Tho' discourteous her ways, and for sorrow, I ween, had she
little ruth!
And the folk for her message sorrowed—Now hear how the
maid must ride,585
Her mule it was tall as a war-horse, and branded on either
side;
And its nostrils were slit as is custom in the far land of
Hungary,
Yet her harness and bridle were costly, with rich work
broidered cunningly.
Soft and slow paced her mule, yet the maiden was not as a
maid, I trow.
What sought she? She came as 'twas fated, and sorrow must
Arthur know.590
And of wisdom forsooth this maiden might boast her a
wondrous store,
No tongue but she spake, French, Latin, and Paynim: in all
such lore
As men read in the highest heavens, Dialectics, Geometry,
In all was she courteous trained, and her name it was called
Kondrie.

'The sorceress' did men name her, nor her speech halted on
its way,595

Too ready her tongue, since rejoicing she smote into grief
that day.

This maiden, so rich in wisdom, bare little of maiden grace,
No lover e'er praised her beauty, no tongue spake her fair of
face.

A tempest she, joy destroying, yet of bridal cloth from Ghent
Did she wear a mantle, bluer than azure the soft tints blent.

600

As a cap was it fairly fashioned, such as maidens in France
shall wear,

And beneath it, around her body, a silken robe she bare.

And a hat of the English peacock, with silk of orient lined,
And new was the hat, and the fastening, and it hung low the
maid behind.

And like to a bridge her message, that sorrow o'er joy had
crossed,605

And shame enough did she bring them, till laughter in tears
was lost.

In a thick plait above her headgear had she flung her tresses
back,

And adown on the mule were they hanging, so long, and so
coarse, and black,

Nor softer to touch than the bristles, which swine on their
backs shall show.

And her nose as a dog's was shapen, and from out her mouth
did grow610

Two tusks as had 'seemed a wild boar, a hand's-breadth long
were they;

And above her eyes the eyebrows as thick as plaits they lay.

And I speak but the truth, as I needs must, tho' my words
lack in courtesy

Since I speak of a maid, yet, for such cause, none other
reproacheth me.

And ears as a bear had Kondrie, and never the eye might
trace 615
A shy glance of love, or of longing, I ween in that wondrous
face.
And a scourge did she bear, and the handle was a ruby, of
silk the cord;
And the hands of this winsome maiden like a lion's were
sharply clawed,
And the skin as an ape's was dusky, and the nails they were
not too light,
And I ween, for her maiden favours, but seldom would
heroes fight! 620

So rode she unto the circle, and her coming did sorrow
bring,
And fair joy did she put in peril—Then turned she unto the
king,
(And Kunnewaaré sat beside him, his table-mate was she,
And fair Guinevere, his consort, a queen bare her company.)
Thus in royal state King Arthur as monarch sat that day—
625
To the Breton king rode Kondrie, and in French did she
speak alway;
And tho' I in another language than hers shall the venture
tell,
Yet I rede ye to wit that the telling it pleaseth me none too
well!

'Thou son of high Pendragon, thyself, and thy Breton host,
By thy deed hast thou shamed—From all lands the noblest
that they might boast 630
Once sat here a gallant circle, but poisoned is now their
fame,
And thy Table Round dishonoured by traitor, and brought to
shame.
King Arthur, o'er all thy fellows, thy praises of old stood
high,

But it sinketh now, thy glory, and thy fame, that did swiftly
fly,

Henceforward goeth halting; thine honour doth seek the
ground 635

Since it showeth stain of falsehood—The fame of thy Table
Round

It suffered for the friendship ye with Parzival did swear,
Tho' I wot well the outward token of a spotless knight he
bear.

"The Red Knight" ye here do call him, the name of one who
lay

Dead before Nantes, yet I tell thee unlike in their life are
they! 640

For no mouth hath read of a hero whose fame knew nor fault
nor flaw,

As his!' From the king she turned her, and did rein by the
Waleis draw,

And she quoth, 'Now sore shalt thou rue it, since I, for thy
sake deny

My greeting unto King Arthur, and the knights of his
company.

May thy fair face be dishonoured, and thy manhood I look
on here. 645

Of forgiveness and joy were I merchant, in sooth shouldst
thou buy them dear!

And I deem thou art but a monster, and myself shall far
fairer be!

Speak, Sir Parzival, as I bid thee, and this riddle read thou to
me,

When thou sawest the fisher sit there, joyless, of comfort
reft,

Why didst thou not loose his sighing? Why was he in
bondage left?' 650

'For he showed thee of his sorrow—Oh! thou false and
faithless guest,

For hadst thou had pity on him, his anguish had gotten rest.
I would that thy mouth might perish, yea, the tongue thy
mouth within,
For e'en as the heart the tongue is, in thine *heart* is the root
of sin.
To Hell shalt thou be predestined, by the Ruler of Heaven
high, 655
And this be on earth thy portion, that true men thy face shall
fly.
And ban hast thou won for blessing, and for bliss shalt thou
find but bale,
For too late dost thou strive for honour, and thy striving shall
naught avail.
And so feeble shall wax thy manhood, and thy fame it shall
be so weak,
That never shall soul's physician the promise of healing
speak. 660
An one to the oath should drive me, on thine head were I
fain to swear,
That never a darker treason was wrought by a man so fair.
Thou hook in fair feathers hidden, bright serpent with
poisoned fang,
Who ne'er of the sword was worthy, which thine host at thy
side did hang!
The goal of thy sins, this thy silence, of Hell's horde art thou
now the sport, 665
And dishonour upon thy body, Sir Parzival, hast thou
wrought.
Saw'st thou not how they bare before thee the Grail, and the
bleeding spear,
And sharp silver? Thy joy's destruction, and thy shelter from
grief were here!'

'Yea, hadst thou but asked at Monsalväscher; afar, in a heathen
land,
Rich o'er all earthly riches, doth the town of Tabronit stand;
670

Yet the riches thy speech had won thee had been greater far,
I ween—
And with gallant strife of knighthood the hand of that
country's queen
Feirefis Angevin hath won him: no fear doth his manhood
stain;
One father, I ween, hath borne ye, yet unlike shall ye be, ye
twain.
And thy brother is strange to look on, for both white and
black his face,⁶⁷⁵
And at Zassamank he reigneth o'er the folk of his mother's
race.'

'And my thoughts to thy sire are turning; his country was fair
Anjou,
And he left thee far other heirdom (for his heart never
falsehood knew,)
Than the heritage thou hast won thee, and the crown of an
evil fame!
And could I but think thy mother had wrought here a deed of
shame ⁶⁸⁰
I had said that *his* child thou wert not! Yet her faith it but
wrought her woe,
And of her naught but good be spoken! And thy father, as all
men know,
In his manhood was true and steadfast, and in many a distant
land
He won for him meed of honour, and his praise o'er all men
did stand.
For great heart and little falsehood as a roof did defend his
breast,⁶⁸⁵
A dam 'gainst the flood of evil, and a home for his love to
rest.
And in manly strength and courage was his honour for aye
held fast,
But *thy* truth it is turned to falsehood, and thine honour to
earth is cast!

Alas! for the day I heard it, alas! for the mournful tale,
That the child of fair Herzeleide in knighthood and faith
should fail.'690
She herself was the prey of sorrow, and her hands did she
wring amain,
While the teardrops they chased each other down her cheeks
like a shower of rain.
And her eyes they gave faithful witness to the grief that her
bosom filled,
For of true heart she spake, the maiden, nor e'en then was
the sorrow stilled.

Then unto the king she turned her, and she spake 'Is there
here a knight695
Who yearneth for love's rewarding, and for honour and fame
would fight?
For I know of four queens, and maidens four hundred, and
all are fair,
In Château Merveil is their dwelling; and like to the empty
air
Shall be all knightly ventures to the venture that Burg
within,
Yet he who shall face its peril, from true love shall his
guerdon win.700
And tho' far be that Burg and distant, and weary and rough
the way,
Its walls must I seek if haply I reach them ere close of day.'
And sad was the maid, not joyful, nor courteous she bade
farewell,
But weeping she gazed around her, and she cried as the
teardrops fell,
'Ah! woe unto thee, Monsalväsch, thou dwelling and goal of
grief, 705
Since no man hath pity on thee, or bringeth thy woe relief!'
Thus had the sorceress Kondrie, that maiden fierce and
proud,

Wrought evil upon the Waleis, and his fame to the earth had
bowed.

Naught they helped him, his bold heart's counsel, his
manhood and knightly fame,
And high o'er all other virtues, the virtue of knightly shame.
710

(For falsehood he ne'er had hearkened,) and true shame doth
rewarding bring,
And it crowneth the soul with honour as the circlet doth
crown a king.

And he who true shame doth cherish his work shall for ever
stand—

Then she lifted her voice o'er the maidens, the maiden of fair
Lalande,

And she wept for the words of Kondrie, and the sorrow of
Parzival, 715

For the fairest of men did she deem him; and swiftly the
teardrops fell

From the eyes of many a woman, for the sake of that hero
bold,

And they sorrowed at heart, and their weeping must many a
knight behold!

Now sorrow had Kondrie brought them; and e'en as her way
she went

Another must ride towards them on a warlike errand bent;
720

A knight of a haughty bearing, and his harness was fair to
see,

From his foot to the goodly helmet, and royal its cost must
be,

And richly plumed was the helmet; and, e'en as the man, the
steed

Was clad in such glittering armour as serveth for knightly
need.

And he found them, both man and maiden, heavy and sad at
heart, 725

As he rode nigh unto the circle; hear ye how he bare his part

—

Tho' his mien it was high and haughty, yet his heart it was
full of woe,
Of the twain shall ye learn the reason; thro' his manhood he
pride must know,
Yet grief to his heart taught mourning—Thus rode he unto
the ring,
Were it well he should come within it? Then squires to his
aid did spring,730
And the gallant knight they greeted, yet were he and his
shield unknown,
Nor he doffed from his head the helmet, and sorrow was his
alone;
And his hand bare a sword unsheathèd, and he asked for
those heroes twain,
'Where are they whom I fain would speak with, King Arthur
and Knight Gawain?'

Then straight thro' the ring he passed him, and a costly coat
he bare,735
And 'twas wrought of silk all shining, in Orient woven fair;
And before the host he halted as he sate there within the
ring,
And he spake aloud, 'God's favour be on thee, thou gracious
king,
And upon these knights and ladies—To all whom mine eyes
here see,
I offer, in greeting, service, yet be *one* from my greeting
free;740
For ne'er will I do him service, nay, rather I choose his hate,
If ill-will he beareth to me, mine ill-will with his may mate!'

'And 'twere well that I name him to ye. Alas! alas! woe is
me!
My heart he so sore hath wounded, mine anguish o'er-great
shall be!

And here doth he sit, Sir Gawain, whom all men were wont
to praise, 745
High standeth his fame, yet dishonour it ruleth, methinks,
his ways;
Since avarice to this betrayed him, in greeting my lord he
slew,
The kiss once by Judas given, it taught him such guile anew.
Many thousand hearts hath he wounded—'Twas murder
base, abhorred,
And he, upon whom he wrought it, erewhile was my dearest
lord. 750
An Sir Gawain would here deny it, true answer our strife
shall yield,
Forty days from to-day shall he meet me, and face me on
battlefield,
Before Askalon's king and ruler, in the city of Schamfanzon;
Thus I bid him in honour face me, and for conflict his
armour don.'

'And this grace shall he not refuse me, but thither his shield
shall bear; 755
And yet further shall he bethink him, by the helmet he
weareth fair,
And the life that a knight beseemeth, who two treasures in
pledge doth hold,
True shame, and a faith unwavering, and their fame shall be
new, as old.
But from shame may Gawain ne'er free him, if a knight of
the Table Round,
Whose heroes stand here before me, he thinketh he may be
found. 760
For its honour and fame are vanished, if false knight sit its
board beside—
Methinks ye have heard mine errand, and ye know I came
not to chide,
For here would I not blame, but battle, and death shall my
guerdon be,

An it be not a life of honour, that Good Fortune shall hold
for me!'

Then sad was the king and silent, yet answer at last he gave,
765

'Know, Sir Knight, that Gawain is my nephew, and myself
would the conflict brave

Ere his bones should lie dishonoured—If Good Fortune by
Gawain stand

In strife shalt thou well acknowledge, 'neath the might of his
strong right hand

That his body in faith he keepeth, and falsehood afar doth
hold.

If another hath done thee evil methinks art thou over-bold,
770

His shame dost thou speak too loudly, who never hath done
thee ill—

If he winneth, perchance, thine homage, and thou ownest
him guiltless still,

Yet hast thou in short space spoken such words of a
blameless knight

As have shamèd for aye thine honour, if this folk read the
thing aright!'

Then upsprang the proud Knight Beaucorps, brother to
Gawain he, 775

And he spake in his wrath, 'Wouldst thou fight him? Then
myself his pledge will be,

For thou speakest false of Gawain; and know that thy words
of shame

Have kindled anew within me fierce wrath's devouring
flame.

An thou speakest not Gawain guiltless of all dishonour, I
Stand here to fight his battle, and to be his surety. 780

Think not by thy words of scorning to lower his lofty fame,
Unstained is Gawain's honour, and thy words are but words
of shame!'

Then he turned him to his brother, and he spake of true heart
and free,

'Bethink thee now, my brother, of all thou hast done for me,
Thou hast helped me unto the winning of fame, for thy toil's
reward⁷⁸⁵

Bid me here to be hostage for thee, and bid me thine honour
guard.

If Good Fortune be here my portion, and I win here my
meed of fame,

Then *thine* be the crown of honour, and thy foeman hath
naught but shame.'

By his knighthood and love as a brother he besought him
right earnestly;

Quoth Gawain, 'Now in sooth, my brother, too wise shall I
surely be⁷⁹⁰

To hearken to thee, and to grant thee what thou askest of
right good-will;

What meaneth this strife, I wot not, and of fighting have had
my fill,

Of good-will would I ne'er deny thee what boon thou from
me shouldst crave,

Yet shame must I bear for ever if this conflict I fail to brave!'

Yet Beaucorps he prayed him straitly—then out spake the
stranger knight,⁷⁹⁵

'A man whom I ne'er have heard of now lusteth with me to
fight!

I spake not of *him*, and no evil, methinks, hath he done to
me.

Strong, gallant, and fair to look on, and faithful and rich is
he,

And well might he be my hostage, yet against *him* no wrath I
bear—

My lord and my kinsman was he for whose death I this strife
declare,⁸⁰⁰

And brothers twain were our fathers, as comrades and
kinsmen true;

And were he a crownèd monarch against whom my sword I
drew,
By my birth might I give him battle, and vengeance of right
demand,
Of a royal race, and a princely, was I born in a distant land.
And Askalon is my country, I am Landgrave of
Schamfanzon, 805
Kingrimursel do they call me; if Gawain's fame be not
outrun
No otherwise may he free him, but conflict with me must
dare.
Yet safe-conduct throughout my kingdom, from all save my
hand, I swear,
In peace may he ride, and safety, to the field where I
vengeance claim;
God keep in His grace those I leave here, save one, and ye
know *his* name!'810

So passed he, the gallant hero, from the plain of Plimizöl,
And e'en as his name was namèd, all men knew
Kingrimursel,
For the fame of this knight so valiant was known thro' the
far lands wide,
And it seemèd them well that to Gawain might ill thro' this
strife betide
When they thought of the strength and the manhood of this
knight who rode swift away.815
And many must sorely vex them that no honour he won that
day;
Yet full often a message cometh, I myself shall such venture
know,
Of such wise, that the guest who bears it, of his host must
ungreeted go!

From Kondrie they heard the tidings of Parzival's name and
kin,

How a queen, she had been his mother, and his sire was an
Angevin. 820
And they spake—"Twas at fair Kanvoleis, and the story we
know full well,
He served her with deeds of knighthood, and many a joust
befell,
And there by his dauntless manhood he won him that lady
bright;
And the noble Queen Anflisé, she taught him, that gallant
knight,
Such courtesy as befitted a hero of lineage high; 825
And no Breton but shall rejoice him, that his son now
draweth nigh,
For of him, e'en as of his father, may this tale of a truth be
told
That honour is his yoke-fellow, as she was of his sire of old.'

Thus joy alike and sorrow came to Arthur's host that day,
And mingled, the life of the heroes, since the twain they
must have their way. 830
Upstood they all as one man, and all with one voice they
wept,
And the bravest knights among them within the circle stept,
And they looked on Gawain and the Waleis where each by
the other stood,
And they wove them fair words of comfort to pleasure the
heroes good.

But Klamidé the king bethought him that the loss which
should be his share 835
Was greater than that of another, and too sharp was his pain
to bear,
And to Parzival he quoth thus, 'If the Grail thee for lord must
own,
Yet still would I mourn my sorrow, and of true heart my woe
make known.
For the kingdom of Tribalibot, and Kaucanus' golden strand,

Whatsoe'er shall be writ of riches in Christian or paynim
land, 840
Yea, even the Grail and its glory, they had failèd the hurt to
cure
Which at Pelrapär was my portion, or the grief that I here
endure!
Ah me! Of all men most wretched am I since thy valiant
hand
Of joy and of blessing robbed me!—See the princess of fair
Lalande,
Know thou that this noble lady she keepeth such faith with
thee, 845
That no service else she craveth, and none other knight will
she;
Yet well might she crown his service who served her for
love alone!
And that I am so long her captive, methinks may she well
bemoan.
If my joy thou to life wouldst quicken, then give me thine
aid, I pray,
And teach her herself to honour in such wise that her love
repay 850
In a measure the ill thou didst me, and that which thro' thee I
lost,
When the goal of my joy fled from me and my pathway by
thee was crossed,
But for thee, I, methinks, had reached it, and if thou art
foeman true
Thou wilt help me with this fair maiden, and my gladness
shall wax anew!

'Right gladly will I,' quoth the Waleis, 'if so be she will grant
my prayer, 855
For fain would I bring thee comfort, since *mine* is that
maiden fair
For whose sake thou sore didst sorrow, my wife and my
queen is she,

Kondwiramur, the fairest of all women on earth that be!
Then the heathen Queen of Ianfus, King Arthur, and
Guinevere,
Kunnewaaré of Lalande, and Jeschuté of Karnant, who these
words must hear, 860
Came near with sweet words of comfort—what would ye
they should do more?
Kunnewaaré they gave to Klamidé, who yearned for her
love so sore,
And he gave her, as her rewarding, himself, his body fair,
And a queenly crown and golden henceforth on her head she
bare!

Quoth the heathen unto the Waleis, 'Kondrie a man hath
named, 865
Whom thou as in truth thy brother, rejoicing, might well
have claimed;
For far and wide he ruleth in the power of a double crown,
And alike by land and water men in fear to his hand bow
down.
And Assagog is one kingdom, Zassamank shall the other be,
Two mighty lands and powerful from fear and from
weakness free. 870
And naught shall be like his riches save those the Baruch
doth own,
Or those of far Tribalibot, he is worshipped as God alone!
A marvel his skin to look on, and like unto none his face,
For 'tis black, and 'tis white, as his parents, who sprang of a
diverse race.
Thro' one of his lands I journeyed as hither I took my way,
875
And full fain had he been my wanderings in a far-off land to
stay.
Yet but little his will prevailed, tho' I am his near of kin,
The cousin unto his mother, and *he* is a mighty king!
Yet hear thou more of his prowess; his saddle no man may
keep

Who rideth a joust against him, and fame doth he richly
reap. 880

And no gentler knight or truer e'er lay on a mother's breast,
And falsehood it fleeth from him, and truth in his heart doth
rest.

Yea, true and fair in his dealings is Feirefis Angevin,
And women he serveth duly, tho' he pain thro' his service
win!'

'Tho' all men to me were strangers, yet hither I came to
know 885

What ventures of gallant knighthood a Christian land might
show;

And of all Heaven's gifts the highest, I ween, shall thy
portion be,

And Christendom winneth honour thro' the praise it doth
give to thee.

And thine is a noble bearing, and fair is thy form and face,
And in thee beauty mates with manhood, and strength doth
thy youth embrace!'890

(Both rich and wise was the heathen, and of wisdom she
token gave,

In the French tongue her speech was holden.) Then out
spake the hero brave,

And he quoth, 'God reward thee, Lady, who thinkest to
comfort me,

Yet sorrow it fast doth bind me, and the cause would I tell to
thee,

For the shame that has here befallen think not I shall lightly
bear,895

And here many sin against me, who give to my plaint no ear,
The while I must list their mocking!—No joy shall my
portion be

Or long or short be my wanderings, till the Grail once again
I see!

For my soul's unrest constrains me, and it driveth me on my
way,

Nor so long as my life endureth shall my feet from their
wanderings stay!'900

'If a courteous and knightly bearing but bringeth rewarding
still

In shame, and in this world's mocking, then methinks I was
counselled ill!

For 'twas Gurnemanz who bade me of questions rash
beware,

And from words and ways unfitting a courteous knight
forbear.

Here standeth full many a hero, I pray ye give counsel true,
905

By your courtesy and knighthood, that your grace I may win
anew.

Here hath judgment been passed upon me with bitter words
and strong—

Who withholdeth from me his favour, I deem not he doth me
wrong;

If perchance, in the days hereafter, fame and honour my lot
shall be

Then according to those my dealings, I pray ye to deal with
me; 910

But now must I haste far from ye—An oath have ye sworn
me here

While I stood in the strength of mine honour; of that oath do
I hold ye clear

Till the day I have won me payment for my fresh joy waxed
wan and pale;

And my heart shall be home of sorrow, nor tears to mine
eyes shall fail,

For the day that at far Monsalväsch my labour I left undone,
915

And myself from all joy I severed, and woe for my guerdon
won.

Ah God! they were fair, those maidens! and ne'er was there
wonder tale

That men told, but as naught its marvels to those of the
wondrous Grail!
Yet torment so sore, and sighing, are the lot of Its king, alas!
Small good hath my coming done thee, thou hapless
Anfortas!' 920

Nor longer the knight might linger, but part they must alway,
So turned he unto King Arthur, and leave he fain would pray
Of him, his knights, and ladies, with their favour would he
depart,
And none, I ween, but sorrowed that he rode hence sad at
heart.

Hand in hand King Arthur sware him, if henceforth his land
should bear⁹²⁵
Such woe as Klamidé brought him, then the shame he with
him would share,
And he spake that full sore it grieved him that crowns and
kingdoms twain,
With the riches that were their portion, Lähelein from the
knight had ta'en.
And service both true and faithful many sware unto him that
day,
Ere yet from the court of King Arthur, sorrow-driven, he
passed away.⁹³⁰

Then the fair maid Kunnewaaré, she took the hero bold,
And hence by the hand she led him, and in this wise the tale
is told,
Sir Gawain he turned and kissed him, and he spake out in
manly wise
To the hero strong and gallant: 'Now thou ridest in warlike
guise,
And thy feet shall be swift to battle—God guide thee upon
thy way,⁹³⁵
And give me such strength to serve thee as my heart shall be
fain alway.'

But Parzival cried, 'Woe is me! Who is He, this mighty God?
Had He power, then methinks our portion had ne'er been this
shame abhorred!

Small power shall be His! I served Him from the day I first
knew His grace,
Henceforth I renounce His service; doth He hate me, His
hate I'll face!940

And, friend, in thine hour of peril, as thy shield may a *wife's*
love stand,

Dost thou know her for pure and holy, then the thought of
her guide thine hand,

And her love from all evil guard thee,—as I wish, may it be
to thee,

For little I wot of the future, if thy face I again may see!'

And their parting it brought them sorrow, for comrades in ill
were they.945

With the maiden Kunnewaaré, to her tent must he take his
way.

And she bade them bring his harness; with her hands so soft
and white,

She bound the armour on him who had served her as faithful
knight.

And she spake, "'Tis my right to do this, since it is thro' thy
deed alone

That Brandigan's gallant monarch now claimeth me as his
own. 950

For otherwise thy valour but bringeth me grief and pain,
Art thou not against sorrow armèd, then thy loss shall
outweigh my gain!'

For battle decked was his charger, and his sorrow must wake
to life,

And fair was the knight to look on; and the harness he bare
for strife

Knew never a flaw, but was costly, and as sunshine 'twas
white and fair,955

And radiant with gold and jewels the corslet and coat he
 ware,
But the helmet alone was lacking—ere he bound it upon his
 head,
In the self-same hour he kissed her, Kunnewaaré, the
 gracious maid.
And this of the twain was told me, that the parting was sore
 to see
'Twixt those two who loved each other in all honour and
 loyalty. 960

So hence let him ride, our hero, and what ventures a man
 may tell
He shall measure them not with the ventures that to
 Gamuret's son befell.
Yet hear ye awhile of his doings, where he journeyed and
 whence would ride—
He who loveth not deeds of knighthood, if counsel he take
 of pride
For awhile will forget his doings—On thee, Kondwiramur,
 965
On thy fair face and lovely body, thy lover thought
 evermore.
What ventures he dared in thy service as knightly the Grail
 he sought!
Nor tarried he in the seeking but onward his way he fought,
The child of fair Herzeleide, and knew not that he was heir
To the glories that he rode seeking, to the Grail and Its
 palace fair!970

Then forth went full many a vassal on a toilsome and weary
 way,
To gaze on the wondrous castle where in magic fetters lay
Four hundred gracious maidens, and four queens, right fair
 to see.
Château Merveil was the castle; and no hate shall they earn
 from me,

I grudge them naught they may win there! No woman
rewardeth me, 975
For she to whom I do service, from payment hath set me
free!

Then out spake the Greek, Sir Klias, 'Yea, there was I
overthrown!'
(And thus in the ears of all men did he frankly the truth
make known)
'For the Turkowit he thrust me from my charger unto my
shame;
And four queens who there lie captive the knight unto me
did name; 980
And old are the twain, and the others as yet they shall
children be,
And the first maid is called Itonjè, and the second shall be
Kondrie,
And the third she is named Arnivè, and Sangivè the fourth is
hight!'
Then fain to behold the wonders of that castle was many a
knight,
Yet their journey brought little profit, for sorrow o'ertook
them there.985
Yet I mourn not o'ermuch for their sorrow; for he who would
labour bear,
And strife, for the sake of a woman, for guerdon shall
gladness know,
Tho' grief shall be mixed with his gladness, and his joy shall
be crossed with woe.
And I know not the which shall be stronger, or if sorrow
shall joy outweigh,
But so runneth the world for ever, where Frau Minne she
holdeth sway!990
Now Gawain he must make him ready, and he girded his
armour on,
For the strife that afar should wait him, in the kingdom of
Askalon.

And sad was many a Breton, and ladies and maidens fair
Of a true heart did they bemoan them that Gawain must to
conflict fare.

And orphaned and reft of glory henceforth was the Table
Round. 995

Then Sir Gawain he well bethought him, since victor he
would be found,

And he bade the merchants bring him good shields both hard
and light,

And little he recked their colour so they served his need in
fight.

On laden mules they brought them, and methinks that they
sold them dear;

And three did he take as his portion—and the hero he chose
him here1000

Seven chargers well fit for battle, and he chose him as
friends so good

Twelve spears of sharp steel of Angram, and the hilts were
of hollow wood.

They were reeds grown in heathen marshlands, Oraste
Gentesein their name.

Then Gawain he prayed leave, and rode forth, dauntless, to
seek him fame,

And with royal hand, for his journey, King Arthur he gave
the knight1005

Red gold, and rich store of silver, and jewels gleaming
bright,

And heavy the weight of his treasure—Then the hero rode
swift away,

And I ween 'twas towards sore peril that his pathway must
lead that day.

Then she sailed to her distant kingdom, the young Queen
Ekuba,

I speak of the heathen princess; and they scattered to lands
afar 1010

The folk who awhile abode there, on the fair plain of
Plimizöl;
And King Arthur and all his courtiers they gat them to
Karidöl.
Yet first they prayed leave, Klamidé and Kunnewaaré of fair
Lalande,
And Duke Orilus and his lady, Jeschuté of Karnant.
Yet till the third day with Klamidé in the plain did the twain
abide, 1015
And the marriage-feast was holden ere yet from the place
they ride.
Yet small was the pomp; in his kingdom, I ween, should it
greater be.
And free was his hand and knightly, and he dealt right
courteously,
For many a knight at his bidding henceforth must his man
remain,
And many a wandering minstrel did he gather within his
train, 1020
And he led them into his kingdom, and in honour, rich gifts,
and land
He gave unto them, nor churlish would any refuse his hand.

Now Duke Orilus and Jeschuté, to Brandigan the twain
would fare
For the love that unto Klamidé and Kunnewaaré they bare.
For they thought them that fitting honour to their sister they
scarce had done 1025
Till as queen they had seen her crownèd, and set on the royal
throne.
Now I know well if wise the woman, and true of heart she
be,
Who seeth this story written, of a sooth will she own to me
That better I speak of women than I spake of *one* erewhile;
For true was fair Belakané, and free from all thought of
guile, 1030

For dead was her love, yet lifeless he still o'er her heart did
reign.

And a dream filled fair Herzeleide with torment of fear and
pain.

And Queen Guinevere bewailed her full sorely for Ither's
death,

(And little I grudge her mourning, for no truer knight e'er
drew breath).

And I wot when King Lac's fair daughter rode forth such a
shameful ride¹⁰³⁵

Then sorely I mourned the sorrow that, guiltless, she must
abide.

Sore smitten was Kunnewaaré, and torn was her golden hair;
Now the twain they are well avengèd, and glory for shame
they bear!

And he who doth tell this story, he weaveth his ventures fair,
And he knoweth right well to rhyme them, in lines that
break and pair.¹⁰⁴⁰

And fain were I more to tell ye, an she give to my words
good heed

Who treadeth with feet far smaller than the feet that shall
spur my steed!

BOOK VII

OBILOT

ARGUMENT

The poet will now for a while recount the adventures of Gawain; whom many have held to be as valiant a knight as Parzival.

Book VII. tells how Gawain fell in with the army of King Meljanz of Lys, who would fain avenge himself on Duke Lippaut, whose daughter had scorned his love. How Gawain came to the beleaguered city of Beausosch; how Obie scorned him; and how Obilot besought him to be her knight. How the heroes fought before the walls of Beausosch, and of the valiant deeds of Gawain and the Red Knight. How Gawain took Meljanz of Lys captive; how Obilot made peace betwixt Obie and Meljanz, and how Gawain rode forth from Beausosch.

BOOK VII

OBILOT

Awhile shall this venture follow the knight, who to fly was
fain
From shame, nor with guile had dealings, that hero bold,
Gawain.
For many a one hath held him for as brave, yea, for braver
knight
Than Parzival, who the hero of this wonder-tale is hight.
Yet he who his friend would ever with his words to the
heavens upraise
Is slow to speak well of another, or to yield him his meed of
praise;
But him shall the people follow whose praises with truth are
wrought,

Else whatever he speak, or hath spoken, shall ne'er under
roof be brought.
Who shall shelter the word of wisdom if wise men their aid
withhold?
But a song that is woven of falsehood is best left in the outer
cold,¹⁰
Homeless, upon the snowdrift, that the mouth may wax chill
and sore
That hath spread for truth the story—such rewarding hath
God in store
As all true folk must wish him whose guerdon in toil is told
—
Who is swift to such deeds, I wot me, but blame for reward
shall hold,
And if good men and true shall praise him, then folly doth
rule their mind;¹⁵
He will flee such who true shame knoweth, and in
knighthood his rule would find.

And true of heart was Sir Gawain, for courage as sentinel
Had guarded his fame, nor shadow of cowardice across it
fell.
But his heart in the field of battle was strong as a mighty
tower,
Steadfast in sharpest conflict, yet foremost in danger's hour.
²⁰
And friend and foe bare witness to the fame of his battle-cry;
Fain was Kingrimursel to rob him of his glory thus waxen
high—
Now far from the court of King Arthur for many a weary
day,
I know not their tale to tell ye, did the valiant Gawain stray;
So rode he, the gallant hero, from out of a woodland shade,
²⁵
And his folk they were close behind him as he wended
adown the glade,

And there on a hill before him he was 'ware of a goodly
sight
That would teach him fear, yet fresh courage it brought to
the gallant knight.

For the hero he saw full clearly how a host on their way
would fare
With pomp of warlike pageant, and banners borne high in
air. 30
Then he thought, 'I too far have journeyed this host in the
wood to wait'—
And he bade them prepare the charger that was Orilus' gift
of late,
And red were its ears, and Gringuljet, I think me, they called
its name,
Without a prayer he won it—The steed from Monsalväsche
came,
Lähelein, in a joust he took it, when lifeless its rider fell 35
By the Lake of Brimbane—Hereafter Trevrezent would the
story tell.

Thought Gawain, 'He who cowardly flieth ere the foe on his
track shall be
Flieth all too soon for his honour—this host would I nearer
see
Whatever may then befall me; they have seen me ere this I
trow,
And, for aught that may chance unto me, wit shall counsel
me well enow.' 40
Then down he sprang from his charger as one who his goal
hath found.
Countless I ween the army that in troops was toward him
bound,
And he saw many robes fair fashioned, and shields with
their blazon bright,
But he knew them not, nor the banners that danced on the
breezes light.

'Strange shall I be to this army,' quoth Gawain, 'strange are
they to me,45
If they count this to me for evil then a joust shall they surely
see,
And a spear will I break with these heroes ere yet on my
way I ride!'
Gringuljet too was ready when his master would strife abide,
In many an hour of peril he the hero to joust had borne,
As Gawain had well bethought him when the steed he would
ride that morn.50

There Gawain saw many a helmet, costly and decked full
fair,
And new spears white, unsplintered, in sheaves to their goal
they bare;
To the pages hands were given those blazoned with colours
clear,
And the badge might ye read on the pennons that floated
from every spear.

And the son of King Lot, Sir Gawain, he saw there a
crowded throng, 55
There were mules with harness laden; heavy wagons with
horses strong,
And they hasted them, fain for shelter; and behind them a
wondrous store
Of goods, borne by travelling merchants as was ever the way
of yore.
And women were there in plenty, and of knightly girdle
bright
The twelfth might some wear, the payment and pledge of
love holden light.60
Not *queens* were they hight, I think me, *Vivandierès* was
their name—
And young and old behind them a rabble onward came,
And they ran till their limbs were weary; and a rope had fit
guerdon been

For many who swelled this army, and dishonoured true folk
I ween!

So they rode, and they ran, that army, and Gawain stood
beside the way,65

So it chanced they who saw the hero deemed him part of
their host that day.

And never this side of the water, or in lands that beyond it
lie,

So gallant a host had journeyed, great their strength and their
courage high.

And close on their track there followed, spurring his steed
amain,

A squire of noble bearing, with a led horse beside his rein;
70

And a fair new shield he carried, and ever his spurs he plied,
Nor thought to spare his charger, but swift to the strife
would ride,

And his raiment was fairly fashioned—Then Gawain his
pathway crossed,

And, greeting, he asked him tidings, who was lord of this
goodly host?

Quoth the squire, 'Sir Knight thou mockest, were I lacking in
courtesy,75

And have chastisement earned, then I pray thee that my
penance shall other be

That shall wound not so sore mine honour—For God's sake
lay thine hate aside,

Methinks thou right well shalt know them, these knights that
before us ride,

Why askest thou me? Of a surety to each other shall ye be
known

As well, nay, a thousand times better, than I unto thee had
shown!' 80

Then many an oath he sware him, he knew not the race or
name
Of the folk who went there before him, 'My journey hath
won but shame,
Since in truth must I make confession that never before to-
day
Mine eyes have beheld these heroes, tho' mine aid men right
oft would pray!
Then the squire he quoth unto Gawain, 'Sir Knight, *mine* the
wrong hath been,85
Thy question I should have answered, here my wisdom hath
failed I ween!
Now pass judgment on me, I pray thee, of thy friendly heart
and true,
Hereafter I'll gladly tell thee, first must I my folly rue.'
'Then, lad, by thy words of repentance, sure token of
courtesy,
The name of this gallant army I prithee to tell to me!' 90

'Sir Knight, he who rides before us, and no man his way
doth bar,
Is King Poidikonjonz; and beside him Duke Astor he rides to
war,
Of Lanveronz is he ruler—and there rideth beside the twain
One whose roughness and ways discourteous Love's
payment have sought in vain.
He beareth the brand unknighly, Meljakanz that prince is
hight, 95
He wooeth nor wife nor maiden, but their love will he take
with might,
And, methinks, men for that should slay him—Poidikonjonz'
son is he,
And here will he fight with his army, and he fighteth right
valiantly,
And dauntless his heart; but such manhood it profiteth
naught, I trow—

An ye threaten, perchance, her sucklings, she fighteth, the
mother sow!100

And never a voice shall praise him whose strength lacketh
knighthood fair,

And methinks to the truth of my speaking many men will
their witness bear.'

'Now hearken to greater marvels, and mark thou the words I
say,

One with a mighty army doth follow upon our way
Whom folly doth drive to battle—The young King Meljanz
of Lys, 105

Scorned love wrought in him fierce anger, and pride vexed
him needlessly,'

And courteous he spake to Sir Gawain. 'What I saw, I Sir
Knight will say:

The sire of the young King Meljanz, as he on his death-bed
lay,

He bade them draw near unto him, the princes from out his
land,

For his gallant life lay forfeit, a pledge in stern Death's cold
hand,110

And to Death he needs must yield him—In grief o'er his
coming end

To the faith of the princes round him his son would the king
commend,

And he chose out one from among them, the chief of his
vassals true,

And his faith was proved and steadfast, and from false ways
afar he flew.

And he gave the lad to his keeping, and he quoth, 'Now, with
hand and heart,115

True service henceforward show him, bid him aye act a
kingly part

To vassal alike and stranger; bid him list to the poor man's
prayer,

And freely give of his substance.' Thus he left him unto his
care.'

'And Prince Lippaut did as his monarch, dying, of him did
pray,
Nor failed in aught, but true service he did to his lord alway.
120

And he took the lad to his castle, and the prince had two
children fair,
He loved them well, and I think me, e'en to-day they his love
shall share.

One maiden in naught was lacking, save in age, that a knight
might crave

Her love for his love's rewarding; Obie was the name they
gave

To this maid; Obilot, her sister; and the elder maid, I ween,
125

Hath wrought ill, for she, and none other, the cause of this
strife hath been.'

'It so fell that one day the young king for his service reward
would pray,

'Twas an ill thought, she quoth, and she asked him why his
wits he had cast away?

And she spake unto him, 'I think me, e'en if thou so old
shouldst be,

That 'neath shield thou the hours hadst counted that in
worthy strife might flee;130

With helmet on head hadst mingled in knightly venture bold,
Till the tale of thy days, if reckoned, full five years more had
told;

If there thou hadst won thee honour, and hither hadst come
again,

And bowed thyself to my bidding, if a yea I to speak were
fain

To that which thou now desirest, all too soon should I grant
thy prayer—135

Thou art dear, I will ne'er deny it, as Galoes to Annora fair;
For death did she seek, and I think me that her seeking was
not in vain,
When she lost him, her well belovèd, and her knight in a
joust was slain.'

'Now sore doth it grieve me, Lady, that love worketh so in
thee,
That thine anger with words of scorning thus venteth itself
on me. 140
For true service,' quoth he, 'winneth favour, an love thus be
well approved;
O'er-weening thy pride thus to taunt me that madness my
speech had moved!
Small wisdom in this thou showest, 'twere better thou hadst
bethought,
How thy father is but my vassal, and save of my grace hath
naught!'

'For that which he holds can he serve thee,' she spake,
'higher is my aim, 145
For fief will I hold of no man, none shall me as vassal claim!
And so high do I prize my freedom that no crown it shall be
too high,
That an earthly head e'er weareth!' Then he spake out
wrathfully,
'Methinks thou hast been well tutored, that thy pride shall
have waxed so great,
An thy father such counsel gave thee, then penance on
wrong shall wait—150
'Tis meet that for this I arm me, some wounded shall be,
some slain,
An they call it or war, or Tourney, many spears shall they
break in twain!'

'Thus in anger he left the maiden, and all did his wrath
bemoan,

Yea, full sore it grieved the lady—Her father must well
atone,
Tho' he sware as his lord reproached him, guiltless of wrong
was he,155
(Or straight were his ways or crooked, his peers should his
judges be,
All the princes in court assembled)—that he to this strait
was brought
Thro' no sin of his own—And eager the prince from his lord
besought
His favour and love as of old time, but in vain he for peace
might pray,
For anger it ruled the monarch, and his gladness was reft
away.' 160

'Tho' hasty the prince they counselled a prisoner to make his
lord,
His host had he been, and such treason of a true knight were
aye abhorred.
Farewell, the king ne'er bade him, but he rode forth in wrath
and pride,
And his pages, the sons of princes, aloud in their sorrow
cried.
Long time with the king they dwelt there, and goodwill they
to Lippaut bare,165
For in truth did he aye entreat them, nor failed them in
knighthood fair.
'Tis my master alone who is wrathful, tho' he, too, Lippaut's
care might claim,
A Frenchman, the lord of Beauvais, Lisavander they call his
name.
And the one alike and the other, ere a knight's shield they
thought to bear,
Must renounce the prince's service, and war against Lippaut
swear; 170
And some shall be prince's children, and some not so highly
born,

Whom the king to the ranks of knighthood hath lifted, I
ween, this morn.'

'And one who in strife is skilful and bold doth the vanguard
lead,
Poidikonjonz of Gros, and with him hath he many an armed
steed.
And Meljanz is son to his brother; and haughty of heart the
twain, 175
The young as the old, I think me discourtesy here doth
reign!'

'Thus these two kings, moved by anger, will forth unto
Beaurosche ride,
Where with toil he would win the favour that the maid to his
love denied.
And there with thrust and onslaught shall be broken many a
spear;
Yet so well is Beaurosche guarded that, tho' twenty hosts
were here, 180
Each one than our army greater, it ne'er to our force would
yield!
The rear-guard knoweth naught of my journey, from the
others I stole this shield,
Lest perchance my lord should find here a joust, and with
onslaught fierce
And clash of the meeting chargers the spear thro' his shield
might pierce.'

Then the squire he looked behind him, and his lord on his
track did ride, 185
Three steeds and twelve spears unsplintered sped onward his
rein beside.
And I ween that his haste betrayed him, he would fain in the
foremost flight
The first joust for his own have challenged, so read I the tale
aright.

Then the squire he spake unto Gawain, 'Thy leave I, Sir
Knight, would pray,'
And he turned him again to his master—What should
Gawain do alway 190
Save see how this venture ended? Yet awhile he doubted
sore,
And he thought, 'If I look on conflict, and fight not as aye of
yore,
Then methinks shall my fame be tarnished; and yet if I here
delay,
E'en tho' it may be for battle, then in sooth is it reft away,
My meed of worldly honour—To fight not, methinks, were
best, 195
First must I fulfil my challenge.' But afresh doubt vexed his
breast,
For he deemed that his warlike errand but little might brook
delay,
Yet how could he take his journey thro' this army that barred
his way?
And he quoth, 'Now God give me counsel, and strengthen
my manhood's might,'
And on to the town of Beaurisch rode Gawain as gallant
knight. 200

So before him lay Burg and city; fairer dwelling no man
might know;
Already it shone before him with its turrets in goodly row,
The crown of all other castles—Before it the army lay
On the plain 'neath the walls of the city; thro' the lines must
he take his way,
And right well he marked, Sir Gawain, many tents in a
goodly ring, 205
And strange banners waved beside them, which strange folk
to the fight would bring;
And doubt in his heart found dwelling, by eagerness cleft in
twain—

Then straight thro' the host encamped there rode the gallant
knight Gawain.

One tent-rope it touched the other, tho' the camp it was long
and wide,
And he saw how they lay, and he noted the task which each
one there plied.210
Quoth they, '*Soit bien venu*' then '*Gramercy*' the knight for an
answer gave—
And troops from Semblidag lay there, hired soldiers both
strong and brave;
And closely they camped beside them, the archers from
Kahetei—
And strangers are oft unfriendly; As King Lot's son he
passed them by
No man of them all bade him tarry, so he rode o'er the grassy
plain,215
And toward the beleaguered city Sir Gawain he turned his
rein.

Then he thought, 'Must I e'en as a smuggler, in hiding-place
bestow
My goods, then the town is safer, methinks, than the plain
below,
Nor on gain shall my thoughts be turnèd, for this be my care
alone,
An Fate will so far befriend me, to guard that which is mine
own!' 220
To the city gate he rode thus, and he found that which
worked him woe,
None too costly the Burgers deemed it, but their portals
against the foe
Had they walled up; well armed the watch-towers, and he
saw on each rampart high
Archers, with cross-bow bended that their bolts 'gainst the
foe might fly.

For defence and defiance ready on the battlements they
stood. 225

Up the hillside toward the castle he turned him, that hero
good.

Tho' little he knew the pathway to the Burg came the gallant
knight,

And straightway his eyes beheld them, full many a lady
bright,

For the prince's wife had come there, from the hall abroad to
gaze,

And daughters twain stood by her, bright as the sunlight's
rays. 230

Then they spake in such wise as Gawain right well their
words might hear—

'Now, who is this,' quoth the mother, 'who doth to our aid
draw near?

Where goes he with pack-horse laden?' Spake the elder
daughter fair,

'Nay, mother, 'tis but a merchant!' 'Yet he many a shield doth
bear.'

'Such shall oft be the wont of merchants!' Then the younger
sister spake, 235

'Thou sayest the thing that is not, and shame to thyself
shouldst take,

For surely he is no merchant! My knight shall he be
straightway,

If his service here craveth guerdon, such debt I were fain to
pay!'

Now the squires they saw how a linden and olive-trees stood
fair

Beneath the walls, and they thought them how a welcome
shade were there. 240

What would ye more? Then King Lot's son he straight to the
ground did spring

Where the shade was best, and his servants, they swift to
their lord would bring
A cushion fair and a mattress, and the proud knight he sat
thereon;
From on high gazed a crowd of ladies—Then, as he his rest
had won,
They lift adown from the pack-steeds the chests, and the
harness bright,²⁴⁵
And beneath the trees they laid them who rode here with the
gallant knight.

Spake the elder duchess, 'Daughter, what merchant think
thou would fare
In such royal guise? Thou wrongest his rank who now sitteth
there!'
Then out quoth the younger sister, 'Discourteous she aye
shall be,
With pride and scorn did she treat him, our king, Meljanz of
Lys, ²⁵⁰
When her love he besought—unseemly such words and
ways I trow!'
Then spake Obie, for anger moved her, 'I see naught in that
man below!
There sitteth, methinks, a merchant, and he driveth a goodly
trade;
He would that they well were guarded, the chests that his
steeds do lade,
And like to a brooding dragon, O foolish sister mine, ²⁵⁵
O'er his treasure-chest he watcheth, this gallant *knight* of
thine!'

And each word that they spake, the maidens, fell clear on
Gawain's ear—
Leave we their speech, of the city and its peril ye now must
hear.

A water that ships had sailed on 'neath a bridge of stone
 flowed past,
And the land here was clear of foemen, nor its flood held
 their armies fast.260
A marshal came swiftly riding 'fore the bridge on the plain
 so wide,
And a goodly camp had he marked out ere his lord to the
 field should ride.
And he came e'en as they were ready, and with him came
 many more—
I will tell ye their names who, for truth's sake, and the love
 they to Lippaut bore,
Here rode to his aid—His brother, men called him Duke
 Marangliess,265
And two swift knights came with him from the land of
 Brevigariez;
King Schirniel, the gallant monarch who ware crown in
 Lirivoin,
And with him there rode his brother, the monarch of
 Avendroin.

Now when the Burgers saw well that help drew anigh their
 wall
They deemed that an evil counsel which aforetime seemed
 good to all—270
Then out spake their lord, Duke Lippaut, 'Alas! for the
 woeful hour
That Beausosch must seal its portals against the foeman's
 power!
Yet if I against my master in open field had fought,
Then mine honour, methinks, were smitten, and my courtesy
 brought to naught.
His grace would beseem me better, and gladden me more, I
 ween, 275
Than the hatred which now he showeth, of such hate have I
 guiltless been.

A joust that his hand had smitten but little would grace *my*
shield.
Or if *his* of the sword bare token that I 'gainst my king
would wield.
Methinketh, tho' wise the woman, she were shamed an she
praised such deed—
Yea, say that my king were captive in my tower, I my lord
had freed,280
And myself had become his prisoner—what had pleased him
best to do
Of evil, I'd gladly bear it, as befitted a vassal true,
And I thank my God of a true heart that I here, a free man,
stand,
Tho' spurred by love and anger my king doth invade my
land!'
Then he quoth again to the Burgers, 'Now may wisdom with
ye be found285
To counsel me in the perils that compass my path around.'

Then many a wise man answered, 'Thou hast wrought in no
wise amiss,
Might innocence win its guerdon, then thou never hadst
come to this.'
Then all with one voice they counselled that the gates be
opened wide,
And that he should bid their bravest forthwith unto jousting
ride. 290
And they quoth, 'So to fight were better than thus our
ramparts high
To defend 'gainst our king, and the armies twofold that
around us lie,
For the most part they are but children who ride with their
king to-day,
And 'twere easy to take a hostage, so wrath oft is turned
away.
And the king he shall be so minded, that if here knightly
deeds be done,295

He shall free us perchance from our peril, and the ending of
wrath be won.

Far better in field to seek them than forth from our walls be
brought

As their captives—Nay, e'en to their tent-ropes, methinks,
we with ease had fought

Were it not for the King Poidikonjonz, 'neath his banner the
bravest fight;

And there is our greatest peril, the captive Breton knights,
300

Duke Astor it is who leads them, and foremost in strife are
they;

And the king's son is there, Meljakanz; higher his fame to-
day

Had Gurnemanz been his teacher! Yet never he feareth fight;
But help have we found against them,'—Now their rede
have ye heard aright.

Then the prince he did as they counselled, the portals he
open brake,305

And the Burgers who ne'er lacked courage their way to the
field would take.

Here one jousted, and there another; and the armies they
made their way

With high courage towards the city, right good was their
vesper-play.

On both sides the troops were countless; manifold was their
battle-cry,

And Scotch and Welsh might ye hearken, for in sooth here I
tell no lie.310

And stern were their deeds of knighthood as fitting so stern a
fight,

And bravely those heroes battled, till weary each gallant
knight.

And they were little more than children who with the king's
army came,

And they took them as pledge in a corn-field, who thought
there to win them fame,

And he who had ne'er won token of love from a lady fair,
315

Might never more costly raiment on his youthful body bear;
Of Meljanz the venture telleth that in harness bright he rode,
On high flamed his youthful courage—A charger the king
bestrode

That Meljakanz won when in jousting his foe from his steed
he swung,

'Twas Kay, and so high he smote him that aloft from a bough
he hung;320

There Meljakanz won the charger that Meljanz would ride
that day,

And foremost of all the heroes he strove in the knightly fray.
And Obie beheld his jousting, and watched him with eager
eye,

As she stood there among her maidens, and gazed from the
palace high.

So quoth she unto her sister, 'See, sister mine, thy knight 325
And *mine*, unlike do they bear them, for thine hath no will to
fight,

He thinketh for sure this city and castle we needs must lose.
An here we would seek defenders, other champion we needs
must choose!'

And the younger must bear her mocking—then she spake,
'Yet I trust my knight,

He hath time yet to show his courage, and thy mockery put
to flight.330

For here shall he do me service, and his gladness shall be my
care,

An thou holdest him for a merchant, with me shall he trade
full fair!'

As with words they strove, the maidens, he hearkened, the
Knight Gawain,

Yet he made as tho' he heard not as he sat on the grassy
plain.
And if knightly soul should hearken, nor feel in the hearing
shame,335
'Twould but be that death had freed him from burden of
praise or blame.

Now still lay the mighty army that Poidikonjonz had led,
Save one gallant youth with his vassals, who swift to the
combat sped,
And Lanveronz was his dukedom—Here came Poidikonjonz
the king,
And the old man wise one and other again to the camp
would bring, 340
For the vesper-play was ended—In sooth had they fought
right well,
And for love of many a maiden full many a deed befell.

Then out spake the King Poidikonjonz to Lanveronz' gallant
knight,
"Twere fitting to wait for thy leader, an thou lusted for fame
to fight.
Dost think thou hast borne thee bravely? See the brave
Knight Lahduman,345
And here is my son Meljakanz,—Came these two in the van,
And I myself, then, I think me, that a fair fight thou sure
shouldst see
Wert thou learnèd enow in combat to know what a fight
should be!
I come not again from this city till of strife we have had our
fill,
Or man and woman yield them as prisoners to my will!' 350

Quoth Duke Astor, 'The king, thy nephew, O sire fought
before the gate
With his army of Lys—Should thine army here slumber o'er-
long and late

The while these others battled? Say when didst thou teach
such lore?
Must I slumber while others battle then I'll slumber as ne'er
of yore!
Yet believe me, had I not been there then the Burgers had
won them fame,355
And a fair prize their hand had taken—I have guarded thee
here from shame;
In God's Name be no longer wrathful! Such valour thy folk
have shown,
They won more than they lost,—I think me fair Obie the
same will own!'

Yet Poidikonjonz was wrathful with his nephew, Meljanz the
king,
Tho' of many a joust the token the young knight from the
field must bring,360
And youthful fame ne'er mourneth such pledge of strife, I
ween—
Now hear ye again of the maiden who the cause of this strife
had been.

Hate enow did she bear to Gawain who was guiltless of ill
intent,
And shame would she bring upon him—A servant the
maiden sent
Below, to Gawain as he sat there, 'Now ask thou, without
delay, 365
If his steeds be for sale—In his coffers, perchance, he doth
bear alway
Goodly raiment that we may purchase; say thou if it so shall
be,
Then we ladies above in the castle will buy of him readily.'
So the serving man went, and his greeting was wrath, for Sir
Gawain's eye

Taught fear to his heart, and in terror the lad from his face
would fly,370
And he asked not, nor gave the message his lady had bid
him bear.
Nor Gawain held his peace, 'Thou rascal, from hence shalt
thou swiftly fare,
For many a blow will I give thee if again thou dost dare
draw near!'
Then the lad hied him back to his lady; what she did shall ye
straightway hear:

For she bade one speak to the Burg-grave, Scherules they
called his name,375
Saying, 'This shall he do at my bidding for the sake of his
manly fame;
'Neath the olive-trees by the Burg-moat stand seven steeds, I
trow,
In them shall he find his guerdon, and riches beside enow.
A merchant will here deal falsely—I pray he prevent such
deed.
I trust in his hand; none shall blame him, if the goods he
doth hold for meed.'380

The squire went below as she bade him, and his lady's plaint
he bare;
'From knavery must we guard us,' quoth Scherules, 'I forth
will fare.'
So he rode where Gawain was seated whose courage might
never fail,
And he found there all weakness lacking, high heart that for
naught would quail,
And a face so fair to look on—Scherules he saw him well,
385
And his arms and hands so skilful that a knightly tale might
tell.
And he spake, 'Thou art here a stranger, Sir Knight, sure
good wit we need

Since here thou hast found no lodging; as sin shalt thou
count such deed.
I will now myself be marshal, folk and goods, all I call mine
own
That freely shall do thee service; nor host to his guest hath
shown³⁹⁰
Such favour as I would show thee.' 'Thy favour,' quoth
Knight Gawain,
'As yet shall be undeservèd, yet to follow thee am I fain.'

Then Scherules, of honour worthy, he spake of a true heart
free,
'Since the office hath fallen to me, thy guardian 'gainst loss
I'll be,
If the outer host would rob thee, thou shalt call to thine aid
mine hand,'³⁹⁵
Then, smiling, he spake to the servants whom he saw round
their master stand,
'Now load ye again your harness that never a piece shall fail,
For hence must we ride, and shelter shall ye find in the
lower vale.'

With the Burg-grave he rode, Sir Gawain, nor Obie her
wrong would own,
But she sent a minstrel maiden whom her father right well
had known,⁴⁰⁰
And she bade her bear the tidings, a false coiner had passed
that way,
'And goodly and rich is his lading; by his knighthood my
father pray,
Since many a hireling serves him for steed, and garb, and
gold,
That he here let them take their payment, 'twere enow, were
they sevenfold.'

To the prince did she tell, the minstrel, all that his daughter
said—⁴⁰⁵

Now to win so rich a booty that his hirelings may be well
paid,
The need right well he knoweth who hath ridden forth to
war,
And Lippaut, the prince so faithful, by his soldiers was
pressed full sore—
Then he thought, 'I must win this treasure or by love or by
force to-day.'
And swiftly he rode; but Scherules, he met him upon his
way, 410
'Now whither dost ride so swiftly?' 'A knave would I here
pursue,
A false coiner is he, I think me, if the tale I have heard be
true!
Now guiltless in sooth was Gawain, 'twas but thro' his steeds
and gold
That suspicion on him had lighted—Then loud laughed the
Burg-grave bold,
And he quoth, 'Nay, sire, they misled thee, they lied who
thus told the tale' 415
Were it wife, or man, or maiden—Nor knighthood my guest
shall fail,
Far otherwise shalt thou judge him, no die he methinks shall
hold;
Ne'er bare he the purse of the changer, if the tale shall aright
be told.
Look thou on his mien, and hearken his word, in my house
is he,
An knighthood aright thou readest then thou knighthood in
him shalt see, 420
And ne'er was he bold in falsehood—Whoever hath done
him wrong,
An my child it were, or my father; whose wrath waxeth
fierce and strong,
An my kinsman it be, or my brother, then the rudder of strife
shall turn

'Gainst myself, for I will defend him from the wrong that he
ne'er did earn,
If I with thy will may do so. The knight's garb would I
gladly change⁴²⁵
For the hermit's robe of sackcloth, and afar thro' the wide
world range
In a land where none may know me, than here thou shouldst
reap thee shame!
Methinks it would better fit thee to welcome such guests as
came,
Who have heard the tale of thy sorrow, than to rob them of
goods and gold;
'Twould better beseem my master as treason such deed to
hold!' ⁴³⁰

The prince spake, 'I fain would see him.' 'Methinks 'twill not
harm my guest.'
So he rode where he looked on Gawain, and two eyes and a
heart confessed
(The eyes and the heart of Lippaut) that the stranger was fair
to see,
And knighthood and manly virtue the mate to his mien
should be.

Whosoe'er, by true love constrained, hath felt of true love
the pain,⁴³⁵
Then his heart, as right well ye know it, doth forfeit to Love
remain,
And so doth she change and rule it that no mouth can the
wonder speak,
Be it heart of man or of maiden on which she her will would
wreak,
And the wise doth she bend to folly. Now the twain they
were lovers true,
King Meljanz and maiden Obie—His anger ye needs must
rue, ⁴⁴⁰

Since in wrath he had ridden from her; of sorrow such load
she bare
That her spirit was moved to anger unfitting a maiden fair.
And, guiltless, must Gawain suffer, and others must feel her
pain;
She had womanly ways forsaken when she gave to her wrath
the rein.
Whene'er she beheld the hero as a thorn was he to her sight,
445
For her heart was fain that Meljanz be held for the bravest
knight,
And she thought, 'Doth he bring me sorrow, then sorrow I'll
gladly bear,
O'er all the world do I love him, my hero, so young and fair,
And my heart for his love aye yearneth.' Oft anger from love
doth grow,
Nor blame ye o'er-much the maiden if her love she by wrath
would show.450

Now list how he spake, her father, as he looked on the
Knight Gawain
And bade him a kindly welcome—In this wise he spake
again,
'Sir Knight, it may be that thy coming the dawn of our bliss
hath been;
Thro' many a land have I journeyed, but no face have I ever
seen
So fair to mine eyes as thy face. In this our day of grief 455
Thy coming shall bring us comfort, thro' thee may we find
relief.'
Then he prayed him take part in the conflict—'If harness
shall lack to thee
All thou needest will I prepare thee, so here thou wilt fight
for me.'

Then out quoth the gallant Gawain, 'That would I of right
goodwill,

I am strong, and well armed for battle, yet from strife must I
hold me still,460
Nor fight till the hour appointed; or else would I gladly fare
As thou farest, the fate of battle with thee were I fain to
share.
But now must I needs forego it, for 'tis fitting I first should
fight
With the foeman to whom I pledged me on mine honour as
faithful knight.
By the favour I claim from all true knights my fame must I
there defend465
Or die on the field—To this conflict, Sir Knight, I my way
would wend!'

Then a grief were his words to Lippaut, and he quoth, 'By
thy knightly fame,
And thy courtesy, do thou hear me, for free shall I be from
blame.
Two daughters have I, and I love them, and dear to my heart
are they,
In the joy God in them hath given would I live to my dying
day. 470
Yea, well is me for my children, tho' sorrow thro' them I
win,
And the one of my two fair daughters methinks hath her
share therein,
And unlike, tho' alike, we share it—for thro' Love doth my
lord and king
Work sorrow to her, and thro' Hatred his forces 'gainst me
would bring.
And thus do I read the riddle, my lord worketh ill to me, 475
Since a *son* I lack, but I wot well that my *daughters* shall
dearer be.
What, then, if for them I suffer? Then my woe do I count for
weal—
Who hath never an heir save his daughter, tho' the sword
ne'er her grip may feel,

Yet other defence may she bring him, she may win him a son
and heir;
And such is my hope!'—Quoth Gawain, 'God grant thee this
favour fair!'480

Then Lippaut he sorely pressed him, 'In God's name give thy
pleading o'er,'
Spake the son of King Lot, 'I pray thee, of thy courtesy ask
no more,
Nor let me betray mine honour—Yet this will I do, Sir
Knight,
I will think the thing o'er, and my answer shalt thou have ere
it draw to night.'

Then he thanked him, the prince, and he rode forth; in the
courtyard he found alway485
His child with the Burg-grave's daughter; with rings did the
maidens play.
'Now, daughter mine, whence camest thou?' thus to Obilot
he spake,
'Father, I came from the castle, to the strange knight my way
I'd take,
I would pray him as knight to serve me, methinks he will
hear my prayer,
And do for my sake such service as winneth rewarding fair!'
490
'Nay, I fear me, my little daughter, for he saith me nor yea,
nor nay,
But plead thou as I have pleaded.' To the guest did she run
straightway.

So came she to Gawain's chamber, he greeted her
courteously,
At her fairy feet he sat him, and thanked her that, maidenly,
She spake for him to her sister; and he quoth, 'Now if ever a
knight495

Had fought for so small a maiden, I were ready for thee to
fight!'

Then the little maiden tender spake out so frank and free,
'Sir Knight, as God is witness, the first man thou eye shalt be
With whom I have held free converse; if in this my maiden
shame

And my courtesy I wrong not, then joy as reward I claim!
500

For ever my mistress taught me how speech is the crown of
thought,

And I pray thee, Sir Knight, to help us—Thro' sorrow thine
aid I sought;

An thou wilt, all our need I'll tell thee, nor do thou be wroth
with me,

For I do as befits a maiden, and my prayer to *myself* shall be.
For altho' our name be diverse, yet methinks that *thou* art
I,505

Take thou my name, and maiden and knight art thou verily.
This grace from us both do I pray here, and if I from hence
must go

Ashamed, and my prayer unanswered, then, Sir Knight, I
would have thee know

That thy knightly fame must answer to thy knightly
courtesy,

Since my maidenhood sought for shelter in vain in thy
chivalry. 510

But if thou indeed wilt hearken, and do me this thing I ask,
With a true heart true love I'll give thee as rewarding for
knightly task.'

'And art thou true man and courteous, then surely thou'lt do
my will,

For see, wilt thou serve a maiden, I am worthy thy service
still.

'Tis true that my father kinsman and cousin for help hath
prayed, 515

But for that shalt thou not refuse us, for my love shalt thou
give thine aid!'

Then he quoth, 'Thy lips, sweet maiden, would bid me my
word forswear,
Wouldst have me my pledge to forfeit? On my knightly
honour fair
I pledged my word—An I fail me, 'twere better methinks to
die.
Yet, e'en an I did thee service for thy love, still long years
must fly⁵⁹⁰
Ere yet thou shalt be a woman, and my service might well
approve.'
Then he thought how Parzival trusted less in God than in
woman's love,
And the words he spake bare the message of the maid unto
Gawain's heart;
And he vowed to the little lady to bear arms on her father's
part,
And, laughing, he spake, 'My sword-blade thy little hand
must guide,⁵²⁵
If my foeman a fair joust seeketh, then thou must against
him ride;
And for me shalt thou strive in conflict, for tho' men think
they see *me* fight
Yet *thou* in my stead shalt have battled,—so keep I my
pledge aright.'

Then she spake, 'That will I, right gladly, thy shelter and
shield I'll be,
Thine heart, and thine heart's best comfort, since from grief
thou hast set me free.⁵³⁰
Thy friend will I be and comrade, and whatever chance
betide,
A roof 'gainst misfortune's stormcloud, safe dwelling
wherein to hide.

True peace this my love shall give thee, Good Fortune to
thee I'll bring;
That-thy strength may by naught be vanquished, I'll guard
thee 'gainst host and king.
Host am I alike and hostess—To combat I'll ride with thee,
535
An thou keepest my words in remembrance strength and
bliss shall thy portion be.'

Then out quoth the gallant Gawain, 'Yea, maiden, the twain
I'll share,
Since my life I vow to thy service, thy love and thy comfort
fair.'
And the hand of the little maiden the while in his strong
clasp lay—
Then she quoth, 'To fulfil mine office I must hence to the
Burg away,540
Wouldst thou fare forth without my aiding, and without my
token fight?
Nay, for that all too dear I hold thee—My part will I play
aright,
And my token I will prepare thee, and if thou my pledge
shalt bear
Then I wot well that o'er all others thy glory shall blossom
fair.'

Then they went forth, the little maidens, and Gawain, the
stranger guest,545
They thanked with sweet words and kindly, and thus he his
speech addrest,
'When older ye twain shall be waxen, were they spears,
every woodland bough,
And the forest bare naught but spear-shafts, then too poor
were the crop, I trow!
If your childhood shall thus be powerful, what then of your
maidenhood?

For your favour brave knights shall shatter both strong
shield and spear-shaft good!'550

Then forth sped the little maidens, and their hearts they were
glad and gay;
And she spake, the Burg-grave's daughter, 'Lady, I prithee
say
What wilt give to thy knight for a token, since naught but
our dolls have we?
An mine were but somewhat fairer I would give it right
willingly
Nor be wroth with thee for the taking, we should strive not
o'er that I ween!'555
Then Lippaut the prince o'ertook them half-way on the
hillside green,
And he saw Obilot and Clauditté, as up towards the Burg
they sped,
And he bade them stand still, and await him, and his
daughter towards him fled.

'Father, I never needed thy help as I do to-day,
Now give me I pray thy counsel, for the knight he hath said
me yea.'560
'Whate'er be thy will, little daughter, an I may, I will give it
thee,
For happy the day whose dawning brought thee, a fair gift to
me,
Then Good Fortune smiled sweetly on me.' 'I will tell thee,
my father dear,
But the thing that so sore doth vex me thou must it in secret
hear,
So hearken, and do as I pray thee!' Then he bade them to lift
the maid565
On his charger, 'But what of my playmate?' Many knights
round their leader stayed,
And they strove which of them should take her, for each one
well pleased would be,

Then one as his prize he claimed her, for Clauditté was fair
to see.

Then riding, he spake, her father, 'Now Obilot tell to me
How dost thou need my counsel? What is it that vexeth
thee?' 570

'I have promised my knight a token, and my wits were I
ween astray,
If nothing I find to give him then worthless my life to-day;
Since he vowed unto me his service then in sooth must I
blush for shame,
If I give him naught—Never hero truer love from a maid
might claim!'

Then he quoth, 'Trust to me, little daughter, and thy token I
will prepare, 575
If service from him thou winnest thou shalt give him his
payment fair,
If thy mother she too be willing—God grant he may bring us
aid,
That gallant knight and worthy; what trust I on him have
laid!
Tho' never a word to the hero had I spoken before to-day,
Yet last night in a dream I saw him, as asleep on my couch I
lay.' 580

Then Lippaut he sought the Duchess, and with him he led
the maid,
And he quoth, 'Now lady, help us, for we twain sorely need
thine aid;
And my heart would shout for gladness that God gave me
this maiden fair,
And parted me from the sorrow that I all guiltless bare.'
Then out spake the Duchess, 'Tell me, what wilt thou of my
grace?' 585
'Lady, since thou wilt hearken, this maid craves a better
dress,

And she deems she of right may ask it, since a knight will
her token bear,
And he asketh her love, and he offers to do for her service
fair.'
Then out spake the maiden's mother, 'Ah, good and gallant
knight!
Of the stranger I ween thou speakest, as May-tide his glance
of light.'590

Then samite of Ethnisé the wise mistress she bade them bear
And rich stuffs as yet unsevered, and silk of Tabronit fair
From far Tribalibot's kingdom—Red the gold on Kaucanus'
strand,
And fair is I ween the raiment which the heathen, with
cunning hand,
Wrought from silk, with the gold inwoven—And Lippaut,
the prince, he bade595
That therefrom for his little daughter fitting garments should
straight be made.
Nor the best would he grudge to the maiden, and they
shaped her a garment fair,
Of silk that with gold was heavy; but one white arm they left
yet bare,
And a sleeve that the arm had covered from the vesture they
cut away,
This should Gawain win for his token and badge in the
coming fray. 600
So this was the gift that she gave him, a rich silk of Orient
bright,
That was brought from the land of the paynim, and had
covered her arm so white.
But they sewed it not to the garment, nor wrought it at all
with thread,
And Clauditté to Gawain bare it, when home from the Burg
she sped.

And free from all care was the hero; and three were his
shields so bright,605
And on one straightway he bound it, and glad was the
gallant knight;
And fairest thanks he gave her, and oft would he praise the
road
On which the maid had trodden when she sought him in his
abode,
And so gently bade him welcome, and with sweet words and
maiden wile
Had made him rich in gladness, and made joy on his path to
smile. 610

Now the daylight had waned, and the night fell,—many
valiant knights and good,
A mighty force, lay on each side,—the besiegers were e'en a
flood.
Were they less, for the folk of the city their army enow
should be.
And now by the light of the moonbeams they would fain to
their outworks see;
Nor terror nor cowardice moved them, they were ready ere
break of day,615
Twelve breast-works wide, and a deep moat before every
earth-work lay.
Thus they shielded them well from onslaught, and to every
earth-work wide
Were barbicans three, that the army might forth to the
conflict ride.

And at four of the gates the Marshal, Kardefablet of Jamore,
With his army bravely battled, as men well at the dawning
saw. 620
And the rich Duke fought full knightly; he was brother to
Lippaut's wife,
And stronger in heart than others who yet bear them well in
strife,

And for men of war are reckoned—In conflict he grief
would bear—
With nightfall his host drew nearer, from far land would he
hither fare,
For but seldom from stress of battle or conflict he turned
aside, 625
And four of their gates he guarded right well in his warlike
pride.

The force from beyond the river passed o'er it ere morning
light,
And entered the walls of Beaurisch, as Lippaut should deem
it right.
But they of Jamore had ridden o'er the bridge before the
gate,
And every door was guarded, and warlike their foes they
wait, 630
Ere ever the day had dawnèd—Scherules one door would
ward,
Which he and the brave Knight Gawain would let not from
out their guard.
And there had ye heard lamentation from the lips of many a
knight,
And the best they were who mourned thus, they had failed
here to see the fight,
For the vesper-play was ended ere yet they a joust might
share. 635
Yet needless their lamentation, for countless they proffered
there
To all who had lust for battle, and to joust in the field would
ride.
In the streets saw ye many a hoof-track, and there drew in on
every side
Full many a tossing banner by the light of the moonbeam's
ray.
And many a costly helmet would they wear in the joust that
day, 640

And spears with bright colours blazoned—A Regensburg
silk, I ween,
Had been held of little value 'fore Beausosch on the meadow
green.
For many a coat emblazoned had ye looked upon that day,
Whose goal had methinks been higher in the cost that its
lord would pay.

And the night, as of old her custom, had yielded her place to
day, 645
Nor by song of the lark might they know it, for they
hearkened far other lay,
Whose voice was the voice of warfare with the crash of the
splintered spear,
As a cloud that is cleft and riven when the thunderbolt
falleth near.
And the King of Lys' young army sought the host of
Lirivoin,
And there, with his warriors, battled the monarch of
Avendroin; 650
And many a joust rang loudly, e'en as when one is wont to
throw
Chestnuts within the furnace that burst in the fiery glow.
Ah, me! how they strove together that morn on the grassy
plain,
How the knights spurred their steeds to jousting, and the
Burgers they fought amain.

Now Gawain, and his host the Burg-grave, since it health to
their souls might bring, 655
And yield them a meed of blessing, bade a priest a Mass to
sing;
And he sang unto God and the heroes—And the prize of
their fame waxed fair,
For this was their pious bidding—Then they would to their
post repair,

But their rampart ere this was guarded by many a gallant
knight,
The followers they of Scherules, and well would those
heroes fight.660

And what should I tell ye further? Poidikonjonz was proud I
ween,
And he came with such host, if in Schwarzwald each bough
had a spearshaft been
I had looked on no greater forest than here on this field ye
saw.
And six banners they bare, and early to battle would nearer
draw,
With ringing blasts of trumpet e'en as thunder that wakeneth
fear, 665
And drums strove amain with the trumpets, and smote on the
listening ear.
If a grass blade were left untrampled by the conflict I knew
it not—
E'en now shall the Erfurt vineyards show such tokens of
strife, I wot!

Then hither he came, Duke Astor, and he fought with the
men of Jamore,
And for sharp joust the spears they whetted, and many a
knight they bore670
From his saddle down on the meadow, and for combat they
aye were fain;
And clear rang the stranger war-cries—And masterless o'er
the plain
Sped many a gallant charger, and afoot went the fallen
knight,
For I ween he had learnt the lesson how one oft is
o'erthrown in fight.

Then he saw, the gallant Gawain, how out on the plain afar
675

The host of both friend and foeman were mingled in deadly
war;
And he spurred him swift towards them; nor 'twas light in
his steps to tread,
Tho' little they spared their chargers, those knights who
behind him sped,
Scherules and his vassals—Gawain gave them pain, I trow,
Ah, me! for the spears he shivered and the knights that he
laid alow.680

Had God given him not such valour, this knight of the Table
Round,
Then in sooth had one made petition for the fame that he
there had found.
'Twas all as one, both armies, 'gainst the twain did he set his
hand,
That of Gros as of Lys—Many chargers did he win from
each knightly band,
And straightway the hero brought them where his host's
banner waved on high,685
And he asked who was there who should need them? And
many swift reply;
Then he gave them e'en as they answered, and rich were
they all, I trow,
Thro' this brother-in-arms whose friendship they here for a
space should know.

Then there came a knight fast spurring, nor spears did he
think to spare
The Lord of Beauvais and Gawain they rode 'gainst each
other there,690
And the young knight, Lisavander, midst the flowers of the
field he lay,
From his saddle behind his charger did Gawain thrust the
prince that day.
For the sake of his squire shall this grieve me, who yestreen
so courteous spake,

And told to Gawain the tidings, and whence all this woe did
wake.

He dismounted, and bent o'er his master, and Gawain he
knew his face,695

And he gave him the steed he had won there, and the squire
thanked his hand of grace.

Now see ye how Kardefablet himself on the ground doth
stand

From a joust that was ridden against him, and aimed by
young Meljanz' hand;

From the ground his warriors lift him, and loud rings the
battle-cry

'Jamore!' and the clashing sword-blades to the challenge
make swift reply.700

And closer the fight draws round him, onslaught on
onslaught pressed,

And the blows ring loud and deafening that fall on each
knightly crest.

Then Gawain called his men around him, and swift to his aid
he sped,

And he covered the knight with the banner of his host that
flew high o'erhead,

And many brave knights had been felled there—Tho'
witness I never knew,705

Yet in sooth ye may well believe me for the venture it telleth
true!

Then the Count of Montane rode 'gainst Gawain, and a
goodly joust they ran,

And behind his horse, on the meadow, lay the brave Knight
Lahduman,

And the hero, proud and gallant, his pledge unto Gawain
gave.

And nearest of all to the ramparts fought Duke Astor with
heroes brave,710

And many a joust was ridden, and many a spear was
crossed;
'Nantes! Nantes!' came the war-cry pealing, the cry of King
Arthur's host,
Firm they stood, and no whit they yielded, the captive
Breton knights,
And hirelings from Erec's kingdom and men spake of their
deeds of might—
The Duke of Lanveronz led them—So well did they fight
that day 715
That Poidikonjonz well might free them, since his captives
they were alway;
At the mountain Cluse from King Arthur, in the days that
were long gone by,
As his prisoners did he win them, when they stormed him
right valiantly.
And here, as was aye their custom, where'er they might
chance to fight,
They shouted 'Nantes' as their war-cry, 'twas the way of
these men of might;720
And many had waxed grey-bearded, and on every Breton
breast
Or high on their helmet gleaming stood a Gampilon for their
crest.
For as Ilinot's arms they bare it, who was Arthur's gallant
son—
And Gawain he sighed as he saw it (small fame he 'gainst
these had won).
And his heart awoke to sorrow for the blazon right well he
knew, 725
And it filled him again with anguish for the death of his
kinsman true.
And his eyes ran o'er with tear-drops, and he passed them
upon the field,
Nor with them would he fight—Thus to friendship a hero
full oft shall yield!

Then he rode on to Meljanz' army, whom the Burgers with
might withstood,
And their rightful meed of honour they won from the
warriors good; 730
Tho' perforce 'gainst o'er-mastering numbers they had failed
to hold the field,
And backward within their trenches awhile to the foe must
yield.

And he who the Burgers challenged his harness glowed red
as flame,
'The Nameless Knight' they called him for none knew from
whence he came;
And I tell it to ye as I heard it, to Meljanz he rode, this
knight, 735
But three days back, and the Burgers must mourn it in
coming fight
That he swore his aid to their foeman—Twelve squires unto
him he gave,
To serve him as meet in the jousting, and to follow to
onslaught brave.
And the spears their hand might proffer those spears he right
swiftly brake,
And clear rang his joust o'er the tumult, when he did as his
captives take 740
King Schirniel and his brother; nor he would from his
pledge release
The knight whom he here had vanquished, the Duke of
Marangliess.
And bravely they fought mid the foremost, and he
vanquished them as they stood,
Yet their folk still held them valiant tho' reft of their leaders
good.

And there fought the young King Meljanz, and all were they
friend or foe, 745

They owned greater deeds of valour a young knight might
seldom show;
By his hand were the strong shields cloven—Ah! the spears
that he brake in twain
As the forces together mingling dashed swift o'er the battle-
plain.
And his young heart for conflict lusted, and none gave him
of strife his fill.
And it vexed him sore, till Gawain would joust with him at
his will.750

Then Gawain took a spear of Angram, that he won him at
Plimizöl,
And twelve were those spears—The war-cry of Meljanz was
'Barbigöl!'
Of his kingdom of Lys 'twas chief city—Gawain aimed his
joust so true,
And Oraste Gentesein taught sorrow to the king since it
pierced him thro'
That strong shaft of reed; his shield piercing, it brake in his
arm of might—755
And a fair joust again was ridden, and Gawain smote the
King in flight;
And the hinder bow of the saddle it brake, and those heroes
twain
They stood on their feet, and valiant, they battled with
swords amain.
'Twere more than enough such labour for two churls on the
threshing-floor,
And each one bare the sheaf of the other, and each smote the
other sore.760

And a spear must Meljanz carry that had smitten him thro'
the arm,
And thro' conflict fierce the hero in blood and sweat waxed
warm.
Then Gawain by force he drave him within a portal wide,

And he bade him his pledge to swear him, nor the young
king his will defied;
Were he not so sorely wounded then so swiftly he ne'er were
known, 765
To yield himself to a foeman, but his prowess had longer
shown.

Then Lippaut the prince, the land's host, his valour might not
restrain
With the monarch of Gros he battled; and alike must they
suffer pain,
Both man and steed from the bow-shots, for their skill they
were fain to show,
They of Semblidag, and Kahetines, for they fled as they bent
the bow.770
And the Burgers must well bethink them the foe from their
lines to hold,
But foot-soldiers had they, and sheltered by their ramparts
they battled bold.
And he who of life was forfeit for the wrath of a maid must
pay,
For her folly and scorn on her people brought sorrow enow
that day.
But what part therein had Lippaut? I think me his lord of
old, 775
King Schaut, ne'er had thus beset him! Now faint waxed
those heroes bold.

But Meljakanz still fought bravely—Do ye think it was
whole, his shield?
Not a hand's-breadth wide was the fragment—Then he bare
him across the field
Duke Kardefablet, and I think me the Tourney it came to
stand
On the meadow fair and flowery, for fast locked was either
band. 780

Then Gawain he rode swiftly to them, and he pressed
 Meljakanz so sore,
E'en Launcelot, gallant hero, ne'er wrought him such grief
 afore
When the sword bridge he crossed to battle—Her captivity
 pleased him ill,
The Queen Guinevere, and he thought him by the sword-
 blade to free her still.
King Lot's son he rode full gallop—Meljakanz, what could
 he do 785
But spur his steed towards him? And many that joust must
 view.
Who lay there behind his charger? He whom the gallant
 knight
Of Norroway had smitten to earth with his spear of might.
And many a knight and lady they looked on this joust so fair,
And they spake in praise of Gawain, and his fame would
 aloud declare.790
And the maidens right well might see it as they looked from
 the hall on high.
Underfoot was Meljakanz trampled; many steeds did o'er
 him fly,
And tare with their hoofs his surcoat, who fodder might taste
 no more,
And they covered the prostrate hero with rain of sweat and
 gore.
'Twas a day of doom for the chargers, but the vultures at will
 might feast;795
And Duke Astor he came to the rescue, and from them of
 Jamore released
Meljakanz, or else was he captive, and he raised him from
 off the ground—
And the Tourney was o'er, and the combat methinks had its
 ending found.

Now who had as knight best ridden, or best for a maiden
 fought?

Nay, I know not, an I would name them small leisure such
task had brought.800
For Maid Obilot's sake with the townsfolk a knight valiant
deeds had dared;
Without, a Red Knight fought bravely, and the fame 'twixt
those two was shared.

When the guest of the outer army had learnt he no thanks
might win
From the king he had served, since Meljanz was captive the
town within,
He rode where his squires were waiting, and thus to his
prisoners spake,805
'Sir Knights, ye your word have pledged me; ill-chance doth
me here o'ertake,
For King Meljanz of Lys is captive—Now if ye such grace
can find
With his captors, that for *your* freedom *his* fetters they will
unbind,
Such service I'd gladly do him!' To the King of Avendroin
He spake, and to Duke Marangliess, and King Schirniel of
Lirivoin. 810
And this oath must they swear unto him, ere they rode the
walls within,
To loose Meljanz, or if they failed here, to help him the Grail
to win.
But never a word could they tell him of where It was hid, the
Grail,
Save 'twas guarded by King Anfortas, but further, their lore
must fail.

When thus they spake, quoth the Red Knight, 'Then if it
shall still betide
That my wish find not here fulfilment, ye to Pelrapär shall
ride,
And unto the fair queen yielding say, "He who in days of
yore

Faced Kingron for her and Klamidé, for the Grail now
sorroweth sore,
As he yearneth for her, his lady, and after the twain in
thought
And deed is he ever striving." To her be this message
brought 820
And ye heroes bear it truly, and as on your way ye ride
God have ye in His safe keeping, for the world and its ways
are wide.'

Then they prayed his leave, and they rode hence—And the
knight to his squires he spake,
'Here is booty none may gainsay us, of these steeds ye at
will may take;
But leave me one for my riding, since sore wounded mine
own shall be.'825
Spake the Squires, 'Sir Knight, we must thank thee for the
grace thou hast shown us free,
For our lifetime hast thou enriched us.' Then he chose in his
charger's stead,
With the close-cropped ears, Ingliart, the same that from
Gawain fled,
When Meljanz he made his captive, and the twain they must
fall in field,
And the Red Knight's hand had caught it, when hewn was
many a shield.830

Then Farewell the hero bade them—Full fifteen steeds they
tell,
To the squires he left, unwounded, in sooth might they thank
him well.
And they prayed him to linger with them, and abide with
them yet a space,
But far hence lay the goal he was seeking, and the road he
was fain to trace.
So he turned him about, the hero, to where ease should be
bought full dear835

For naught but strife was he seeking—In the days that ye
read of here
No knight e'en as he had battled—Then the outer host would
ride
To where they might find a lodging, and in peace for a space
abide.

And within, Lippaut spake, and asked them how matters had
gone that day?
That Meljanz was taken captive, that tale did he know alway.
840

And all was as he would have it, and comfort the hour would
bear—

And Gawain loosed the sleeve full gently from his shield,
lest perchance it tear,
For he deemed it o'er good for tearing, and Clauditté she
held it fast,
And 'twas slashed in the sides and the centre with the spears
that had thro' it passed;
And he bade her to Obilot bear it, and glad was the little
maid, 845

On her bare white arm soft-rounded the tattered sleeve she
laid,
And spake, 'Who hath done this for me?' whene'er she her
sister saw,
And wrathful her elder sister her maiden mischief bore.

Then, as weariness it bade them, the knights they craved for
rest—

Then Scherules took Count Lahduman, and Gawain his
gallant guest 850

And many a knight whom he found there, whom Gawain
with valiant hand

Had o'erthrown on the field of battle tho' strife they might
well withstand.

And the Burg-grave rich he bade them to sit them in order
fair,

And he and his wearied vassals would stand 'fore their
monarch there
Till Meljanz his fill had eaten—And they treated him
courteously, 855
But Gawain, o'er-much he deemed it, and he spake out,
frank and free,

'Methinks an the king allow thee, Sir Host, thou shouldst
take a seat.'
Thus spake Gawain in his wisdom, as his courtesy found it
meet.
But the host gave his prayer denial, 'The king's man is that
gallant knight
My master, this were his office if the king had but deemed it
right860
To take, as of old, his service—My lord thro' his courtesy
Will not see the face of his monarch while exiled from grace
is he.
An it pleaseth God of friendship to sow here the seed once
more,
Then joyful we'll do his bidding with one will, as in days of
yore.'

Then spake the youthful Meljanz, 'Yea, courteous knights
and true 865
Were ye, when I dwelt among ye, nor your rede did I ever
rue.
An I now had thy counsel followed, this even had seen me
glad;
Now give me thine aid Count Scherules, for the trust that I
ever had
In thy faith, with this knight my captor, and with him my
second sire
Duke Lippaut—for well I think me they will do as thou shalt
require—870
Yea, pray them to show me favour, for friends had we been
to-day

Had not Obie such jest played on me as no maiden I ween
should play!'

Then out spake the gallant Gawain, 'Afresh shall be knit a
band
That naught but death can sever'—Then they came whom
the Red Knight's hand
Without had taken captive, on the height would they seek
their king,⁸⁷⁵
And they told him all that befell them; and Gawain must list
the thing,
And they told of the arms of the hero, how their strength
before his must fail,
And how he their pledge had taken, and had bidden them
seek the Grail;
And he thought how the knight of this venture was none
other than Parzival,
And his thanks uprose to high Heaven that no evil did there
befall,⁸⁸⁰
But that God apart had held them, and they met not in strife
that day.
And courteous I ween were those heroes that they tore not
the veil away,
But both of them there were nameless, and none knew from
whence they came,
Yet I wot well the world around them rang fair with their
warlike fame.

To Meljanz he spake, Scherules, 'Now, Sire, wilt thou list to
me? ⁸⁸⁵
Look thou again on my master, and such rede as is given to
thee
By friends on both sides shalt thou hearken, and thine anger
shalt thou recall;'
And all deemed it good, the counsel, so they rode to the
royal hall,
The inner force of the city, as the Marshal was fain to pray.

Then Gawain took the Count Lahduman, and the captives he
made that day,890
And he gathered them all around him, and the pledge that to
him they gave
When he erst on the field o'erthrew them, must they yield to
the Burg-grave brave,
And gladly they did his bidding—To the palace the heroes
fare,
And rich garments as fit for a monarch did the wife of the
Burg-grave bear;
And a veil did she give unto Meljanz that should serve him
for a sling895
For the arm that Gawain had wounded, when his spear
smote the youthful king.

And Gawain by the mouth of Scherules, Obilot his lady
prayed;
Fain would the hero see her, his life in her hand he laid,
And would crave from her lips dismissal—and further the
hero spake,
'I leave the king here, her captive, and I pray her such
thought to take900
That she may in such wise entreat him, that her honour shall
wax apace!'
And Meljanz spake, 'Well I know this, Obilot is of maiden
grace
And maiden worth the glory; and joyful am I at heart
If her captive I be, for in gladness methinks shall I have my
part,'
Then out quoth the gallant Gawain, 'Her prisoner art thou
alone, 905
'Tis *she* who hath captive made thee, and *my* glory is here
her own.'

Before them rode Scherules—As was fitting for royal court,
Nor man was there nor maiden but had robed them in such
sort

That one, in poor guise and scanty, might scarce have been
seen that day—
They who sware their pledge to the Red Knight with
Meljanz must take their way.⁹¹⁰
And there in the hall of the castle they sat in their order four,
Lippaut, his wife, and his daughters, as the guests passed
within the door.

Up sprang the host and hastened his lord and king to greet,
And close pressed the crowd around them as friend with foe
did meet;
By Gawain's side stood Meljanz. 'Now, an it were here thy
will, ⁹¹⁵
Thy friend of old, the Duchess, with kiss would she greet
thee still.'
And Meljanz to his host made answer, 'Two ladies I think to
see
From whom I'll take kiss and greeting—but the *third* naught
shall win from me.'

And the parents wept; but the maiden, Obilot, was glad and
gay,
And they greeted their king with kisses; and two beardless
kings that day⁹²⁰
They kissed, with the Duke of Marangliess, and the gallant
Knight Gawain.
And they brought him his little lady, and the fair child he
clasped again,
And e'en as a doll he held her so close to his manly breast,
As joy and delight constrained him, and to Meljanz his
speech addrest:
'Thine hand hath surety pledged me, of that shall thou now
be free,⁹²⁵
In my right arm I hold my lady, *her* captive thou now shalt
be.'

Then Meljanz he stept him nearer, and she held fast to
Gawain's hand,
And she took the pledge of her monarch mid the knights
who did round them stand.
'Sir King, 'twas ill-done I think me, if a *merchant* he be my
knight
As my sister hath said, to yield thee as his captive on field of
might!'930
Thus spake Obilot, the maiden; then to Meljanz she gave
command,
He should yield his pledge to her sister, and swear it hand
clasped in hand;
'Thou shalt have her for Love, for thy knighthood, as her
Love and her Lord art thou
Henceforward, of true heart gladly, and ye twain to my will
shall bow!'

God spake by the lips of the maiden, her will it was done
straightway,935
And Frau Minne with power and wisdom again o'er their
hearts held sway,
And knit afresh the meshes, and fettered the twain anew;
From the folds of her flowing mantle her small hand Obie
drew,
And she touched the arm of her lover, and weeping, her lips
so red
Kissed the wound he had won in jousting, since it was for
her sake he bled.940
And his arm was bathed in the tear-drops that flowed from
her eyes so bright—
How waxed she thus bold 'fore the people? 'Twas Love bade
her claim her right;
And fulfilled was the wish of Lippaut, and naught of his
bliss should fail,
Since God had willed that his daughter henceforth as his
queen he hail!

How the wedding feast was holden, ask them who took their
share 945
Of wedding gifts, or wandering, to Beauschans had thought to
fare.
If they fought, or were fain to rest them, of that I no word
may tell,
But they say in the hall of the palace Sir Gawain would bid
farewell
To her for whose leave he came there, and sore wept the
little maid
And spake, 'Now take me with thee,' but Gawain her wish
gainsaid, 950
And scarce might her mother tear her from the knight—
leave he prayed them there,
And Lippaut he proffered service for the good-will he
towards him bare.
And his gallant host, Scherles, with his folk he would not
delay
To ride awhile with the hero; and he wended a woodland
way,
And they gave him guides for his journey, and food lest he
ill should fare, 955
And he bade them farewell, and sorrow Gawain for the
parting bare.

BOOK VIII

ANTI-KONIE

ARGUMENT

Book VIII. tells how Gawain came to Schamfanzon, and how King Vergulacht committed him to the care of his sister Antikonie. How Gawain wooed the maiden, and of the wrath of her people. Of the adventure of the chess-board, and how Kingrimursel came to the help of Gawain. How Antikonie reproached King Vergulacht, and how the nobles counselled their monarch. Of the oath Gawain swore to the King, and how he rode forth to seek the Grail.

BOOK VIII

ANTI-KONIE

Whosoe'er at Beausosch had battled, methinks that Gawain
had won
The highest fame in both armies, save but for one knight
alone;
And none knew his red harness glowing, and none knew
from whence he came,
But high as a banner waveth, so high did it rise, his fame.
Yet of honour alike and good fortune had Gawain in full his
share— 5
Now hence must he ride, for the moment of strife which he
sought drew near,
And far and wide stretched the woodland thro' which he
must wend his way—
No conflict he shunned, tho' all guiltless of the sin men on
him would lay.

But, alas! his charger failed him, Ingliart, with the close-
cropped ear,
In the land of the Moors at Tabronit no better the steeds they
rear.¹⁰
And diverse the wood around him, here a bush and there a
field,
And so narrow at whiles, that pathway, it scarcely a space
might yield
For tent, or for knight's pavilion. Then fair dwellings met his
eye,
'Twas Askalon, and he prayed them if Schamfanzon at hand
did lie?
But many a marsh and moorland and many a steep hillside
¹⁵
Must he traverse, ere fair before him in the setting sun he
spied
A fortress stand so stately, it gleamed in the sunlight's rays,
And he turned his steed towards it who rode here on
unknown ways.

Now list ye awhile the venture, and mourn ye awhile with
me
The sorrow that fell on Gawain—And if old ye shall chance
to be ²⁰
Or young, yet of this your friendship I pray you his grief to
weep;
Alas! were it best to tell ye, or silence a space to keep?
Nay, better to tell the story, how he whom Good Luck did
call
Her friend, was by her forsaken, and how grief to his lot
must fall.

So proudly uprose the fortress that never did Carthage seem
²⁵
So fair to the eyes of Æneas, when Dido, as failed her dream
Of love, turned to death and, seeking, found rest in his cold
embrace.

Would ye know what countless turrets those stately halls did
grace?

Scarce more had Akraton boasted, that city whose walls so
wide,

An man may believe the heathen, with Babylon only vied;
30

So high rose the circling ramparts, and where to the sea they
fell

No storm might they fear, but defiance could they bid to
their foes right well.

'Fore the city a plain outstretching lay fair for a mile or
more.

As Sir Gawain rode across it, five hundred knights he saw,
Yet one, o'er all the others, gallant and fair to sight; 35

Gaily they rode towards him all clad in raiment bright,
For so the venture telleth—With their falcons soaring high
Would they chase the crane, or other fair game that should
wingèd fly.

A tall steed from Spain's far kingdom, King Vergulacht
bestrode,

And his glance was as day in the night-time—Aforetime his
race abode40

Where Mazadan reigned as monarch, by Fay Morgan's
mystic mount,

And amid the roll of his fathers he many a fay might count
—

And even as in the spring-tide the May blossom bloometh
fair

So rode the king in his beauty, and Gawain he bethought
him there,

As he saw him ride so stately, 'twas another Parzival, 45
Or Gamuret, as he came to Kanvoleis, as this venture
erewhile did tell.

Now into a pond so marshy a heron had taken flight

As it fled from before the falcon, and the king, as beseemed
a knight,
Sought not for the ford but followed as he saw his falcon's
need,
And wet he won in the aiding, and lost was his gallant steed,
50
And lost too his royal raiment, tho' safe was I ween the bird.
The falconers took his garments, for this, so the tale I've
heard,
Was their right, and they needs must have them, and no man
might say them nay.
Another horse they brought him, for lost was his own for
aye,
And fresh garments they put upon him, since such was the
chance of fate⁵⁵
That his falconers won the vesture that had decked their king
of late.

Then Sir Gawain, he rode towards them, and knightly and
worshipful
The greeting they gave unto him, not such as in Karidöl
Once fell to the lot of Erec, when after his well-fought fight
He had fain drawn near to King Arthur, and with him his
lady bright,⁶⁰
Fair Enid, who graced his coming—But the dwarf
Maliklisier
With a scourge full hardly smote him, 'neath the eyes of
Queen Guinevere.
At Tulmein he took his vengeance, where, within the ring so
wide
To win the hawk, the heroes in deeds of valour vied.
'Twas Idêr, the son of Noit, a hero true and bold ⁶⁵
Whom he else had slain, whom Erec did there in surety hold.

But leave we all other venture, and hearken awhile to me,
For in sooth never fairer welcome shall it fall to your lot to
see.

Yet, alas! for ill it wrought him, Gawain, King Lot's brave
son—

An ye will I will cease my story ere the tale to its end be run,
70

And for pity's sake keep silence—Yet perchance it were best
to tell

The ill that thro' others' treason on a gallant spirit fell.

And if I yet further pray ye this story strange to heed

Then in sooth, e'en as I, right truly will ye mourn for its
hero's need.

Quoth the king, 'Sir Knight, thus I think me, thou shalt to the
castle ride,75

Thine *host* will I be right gladly, tho' scarce may I be thy
guide;

Yet if this on my part shall vex thee the chase will I gladly
leave!

Quoth Gawain, 'As it best may please thee, that do, nor for
my sake grieve,

Whate'er thou shalt do shall be well done—No grudge do I
bear thee, Sire,

But of right good-will I gladly will do as thou shalt require.'
80

Quoth the king of Askalon further, 'Schamfanzon thou well
mayst see

Sir Knight, there my sister dwelleth, who as yet but a maid
shall be;

And she hath in fullest measure such beauty as poets sing—

An thou as a grace shalt hold it, my knights unto her shall
bring

Such word she shall well entreat thee in my stead, till I come
again.85

And whenever I come, I think me, 'twill be sooner than thou
art fain

To look on my face, for gladly wilt thou spare me when thou
shalt see

My sweet sister, nor e'er bemoan thee, tho' my coming o'er
late shall be!

'Nay, gladly again I'll see thee, and gladly thy sister greet,
Tho' as host never queen has done me such service as host
finds meet'90

Thus spake the gallant Gawain—Then a knight bare the
king's behest

To his sister, that she, as fitting, should so care for the
stranger guest

That however long his absence the hours should as minutes
fly—

(An ye will, I will cease my story that now runneth but
mournfully!)

Nay, further I'll tell the venture,—Steed and pathway the
hero bore95

Where as one were both Burg and palace, and he held him
before the door.

And he who shall e'er have builded a house, he shall better
know

To tell of this mighty castle, and the strength of its walls to
show.

Yea, indeed 'twas a Burg, none better might this earth on its
bosom bear

And around it, far outstretching, the ramparts towered high
in air.100

Leave we the praise of the castle, and speak of the castle's
queen,

A maiden fair, for of women I shall better speak I ween,
And as fitting I'll sing her praises—Was she fair to the eye?
'Twas well;

Was she true of heart? Then gladly will men of her praises
tell.

And so both in mind and manner might she vie with that
lady true, 105

The Margravine, who from Heitstein afar o'er her marches
threw
A light,—Well for him who dwelleth as friend in her
presence fair,
Such pastime as there his portion he findeth not other-
where!
For I praise but a woman's virtue, as I see, and shall surely
know,
True and pure must she be, the maiden, on whom I shall
praise bestow.110
And he whom this venture singeth is a gallant man and true,
For no dealing have I with falsehood, or with one who his
deeds shall rue,
As repentance, slowly piercing, but turneth his bliss to bale,
And his soul knoweth wrath and sorrow, or ever his life-days
fail.

To the castle court rode Gawain, and the goodly company
115
To whom the king had sent him, who shamed for his sake
should be.
Then the knight to his lady led him, as she sat in her beauty's
glow,
Queen Antikonie—Could the merchants a woman's fame
bestow,
Of such goods had she made rich purchase; 'gainst falsehood
she set her face,
And hers was the crown of honour, and a maiden's maiden
grace. 120
Ah! woe's me for him of Veldeck, that death thus cut short
his days,
None is there of all men living who so well could have sung
her praise.

Then Gawain, he looked on the maiden, and the messenger
spake the word

E'en as the king had bade him, and the queen his message
heard.
Then gently she spake to the hero, 'Come thou near unto me,
Sir Knight, 125
Thyself shalt be my master in courtesy, as is right;
And gladly I'll do thy bidding—If well it shall please thee
here,
'Twill be even as thou shalt order—Yea, since my brother
dear
Hath bid me well entreat thee, I'll kiss thee, if so I may.
I'll do, or leave it undone, e'en as thou the word shalt say!'
130

Courteous she stood before him, quoth Gawain, 'Thy lips so
red
In sooth were made for kissing, be kiss and greeting sped!'
So full and warm and rosy were the lips that Gawain
pressed,
No stranger sure had kissed her as kissed this stranger guest.
Unchecked he sat him by her, and sweet words passed
between, 135
Soft spake they to each other; and oft renewed, I ween,
His prayers and her denials, yea, sorely grieved was he,
And fain to win her favour—Then she spake as I tell to ye:

'Bethink thee, Sir Knight, thou art wise else, with this I
enough have done,
For I ween at my brother's bidding mine uncle Gamuret won
140
Less welcome from Queen Anflisé than the welcome *I* gave
to thee,
An our tending were weighed together methinks hers would
lighter be.
Nor know I, Sir Knight, whence thou comest, nor e'en what
shall be thy name,
That, after such short approving, thou shouldst to my love
lay claim!'

Then out spake the gallant Gawain, 'Then know here
assuredly 145

O! queen, of my father's sister the brother's son am I;
Wilt thou give me sweet love's rewarding, for my birth shalt
thou not delay,
Hand in hand, and to equal measure, it paceth with thine
always!

The maiden who filled the wine-cup she had passed from
out the hall,

And the women who sat beside them must now to their mind
recall 150

The task that elsewhere did wait them; nor longer the knight
stood there

Who erst to the queen had brought him—As Gawain was
now aware

That no man was here beside them, he thought how a mighty
bird

Is oft trapped by a little falcon—nor further he spake a word,
But he passed his arm around her beneath her mantle's fold,
155

And love laid such stress upon them, the maid and the hero
bold,

That belike a thing had chanced there, and no eye had been
there to see,

Of one mind were the twain—yet heart-sorrow drew near to
them speedily.

For straight stepped within the doorway an old and grey-
haired knight,

And loudly he called on Gawain, and shouted a shout of
might, 160

For well did he know the hero, and fiercely his cry did ring,
'Alas! alas! woe upon us, since the hand that hath slain our
king

Is fain now to force his daughter!' At the sound of his battle-
cry

The folk that within the castle abode to the hall did hie,

So it fell out—Then quoth Sir Gawain to the queen, 'Now,
Lady mine,165
Say thou how we best may ward us 'gainst this wrathful folk
of thine,
For sure they will come against us—An I had but my sword
at hand!'
Then out spake the gentle maiden, 'Their might shall we best
withstand
An we to yon tower betake us that riseth my bower beside,
Perchance they will then bethink them, and the storm shall
we override.'170

Here a knight, and there a merchant, already the maid must
hear,
With the cry of the angry townsfolk, as the twain to the
tower drew near;
And sore was her friend beset there, tho' she prayed them
from strife to cease,
So loud rose the angry tumult none hearkened her words of
peace.

'Gainst the portal the foe pressed onward, Gawain stood
within the door,175
And held off the angry rabble; an iron bolt he tore
From its fastenings wherewith to arm him, and before his
strong right hand
Full oft fled his evil neighbours, they durst not his blows
withstand.
While the queen, with flying footsteps, hither and thither
sought
To find, perchance, some weapon 'gainst the foe that so
fiercely fought.180
At length did she chance on some chess-men, and a chess-
board, wide and fair,
That hung by a ring of iron; to Gawain she brought it there,
As a shield four-square it served him; yea, many a game was
played

On that board ere 'twas hewn in battle—Now hear of the
royal maid;

Were it king, or queen, or castle, she hurled them against the
foe,185

Heavy and large the chess-men, and in sooth I would have
ye know

They who by her shaft were stricken must ever a fall abide.

Right bravely the queen so gracious now fought by her
hero's side,

And she bare herself so knightly, that never the Burger
maids

Of Tollenstein at Shrove-tide such dauntless skill displayed.
190

And yet they but fight for folly, and weary themselves for
naught—

An a woman bear trace of battle, on her womanhood shame
is brought,

(For I know what befits a woman,) unless love shall have
bid her fight

To prove her faith—Now faithful and true was that lady
bright,

As Schamfanzon might bear witness—Yet, tho' high of heart
was she,195

Many tears that conflict cost her; for in sooth shall it ever be
That Love is brave as steadfast, yet tender and true of heart

—

Would ye know how in such fierce conflict Sir Gawain
would bear his part?

When the strife but leisure gave him to gaze on the maid
aright,

Her lips so red and glowing, her eyes so soft and bright—
200

More slender was she and shapely than ever a lowland hare
That ye truss on the spit, so graceful her limbs, and her form
so fair;

Full well might her charms awaken desire in the heart of
man.
And smaller, I ween, the maiden, where her golden girdle
ran
Around her waist, than ants are, and their slender shape ye
know— 205
The sight wrought in Gawain courage his foemen to
overthrow,
For she shared his need; his chastising none other than death
should be,
And help was there none—Then his anger flamed high and
wroth was he
As he looked on that gentle maiden, and no fear was his but
hate,
And sorely his foemen rued it who met at his hand their fate.
210

Came King Vergulacht, and he saw well how his folk 'gainst
Gawain did fight;
Nor do I in this deceive ye, nor can I account him right
That not as a host he bare him, when he saw his gallant
guest
Thus stand, as one man against many—But straight thro' the
throng he pressed,
In such wise, I must mourn for Gandein, the monarch of
Anjou fair, 215
That his daughter, so true a lady, so faithless a son must bear.
From the strife his folk he called not, short space must they
stay their hand
While the king would don his armour, he lusted to lead the
band.

Too mighty the force for Gawain, nor I ween shall ye count
it shame
That he closed the door upon them—Then in wrath and
haste there came 220
The knight who to battle bade him 'fore Arthur at Plimizöl

But short time back—They called him the Landgrave
Kingrimursel,
And sore did Gawain's need vex him, he wrung his hands
amain,
For in sooth had he pledged his honour his foe should in
peace remain
Till *one* man alone o'ercame him—Old and young from the
tower he drave, 225
Yet the portal would they force open, as their king
commandment gave.

Then the Landgrave he cried on Gawain, 'Sir Knight, I
would in to thee
As a friend, that this bitter conflict I may share, if it so must
be,
For then must my monarch slay me, or leave thee in life to-
day.'
Peace Gawain would swear unto him, and he made to the
tower his way—230
Then doubtful, the foemen thronging, their hand for a space
must hold,
For their Burg-grave he was, and his bidding had they
hearkened both young and old.
Then, as ceased the noise of battle, thro' the doorway he
sprang, Gawain,
And the Landgrave, he stood beside him, swift and bold
were those heroes twain.

Quoth King Vergulacht, 'Why tarry? Why stand we here as
on guard, 235
When of foemen but *two* shall dare us, and none other the
tower gates ward?
Much my cousin doth take upon him, when he dareth to
shield my foe,
Yea, *himself* should wreak vengeance on him, if his faith he
were fain to show!'

Of true heart then they chose a true man, and unto the king
 he spake,
'Now, Sire, upon our Landgrave no vengeance we think to
 take, 240
Nor shall harm at *our* hand befall him—May God so turn
 thy mind
That, instead of shaming, honour thou shalt from this
 venture find.
For shame shall it bring upon thee, and an ending to thy fair
 fame,
If he who as host doth hail thee shall here at thine hand be
 slain.
And thy kinsman is he, this other who hath brought him into
 this land;245
So, lest cursing and shame be thy portion, we pray thee to
 stay thine hand,
And grant thou a truce thro' the daylight, and the fleeting
 hours of night,
Then bethink thee for shame or honour, and do as shall seem
 thee right!'

'And our queen who hath ne'er known falsehood, thy sister,
 Antikonie,
See there as she standeth by him and weepeth full bitterly.
 250
Canst thou see such sight without rueing, since one mother
 bare ye both?
And bethink thee, sire, thou art wise else, thou didst send
 him, nothing loth,
Alone to this gentle maiden, nor further a guardian gave;
For *her* sake it were well to spare him!' Then the king bade
 those warriors brave
To call a truce—He'ld bethink him how vengeance he best
 might take255
For his father's death—Yet all guiltless Gawain, for another's
 sake,

Must he bear the shame; with a lance-thrust by Ekunât was
he slain
As to Barbigöl Prince Iofreit, a prisoner, he would have
ta'en,
Who had ridden erewhile with Gawain—In such wise the
chance befell
That they deemed that *Gawain* had slain him—So men do
the venture tell.260

And scarce was the truce bespoken ere of men was the field
bereft,
Each betook him unto his lodging, nor one on the ground
was left.
Then the queen threw her arms around him, and with many a
kiss so sweet
She gave to her gallant cousin such rewarding as seemed her
meet,
Since so bravely he stood by Gawain, and sheltered the
twain from wrong,265
And she spake, 'Now art thou my cousin, nor unfaith shall to
thee belong.'

Now hearken and I will read ye that word which I spake of
late,
How a true heart sore was darkened—I ween 'twas an evil
fate
That led Vergulacht to Schamfanzon; such deed he ne'er did
learn
From sire or aye from mother, with shame did the young
knight burn,270
And torment sore and suffering his better self must know
As his sister 'gan upbraid him, small mercy the maid would
show.

And thus spake the noble maiden, 'Now had it but been
God's will,

That I, a man born, might sword bear, and knightly tasks
fulfil,
To strive with me hadst thou come here, methinks thou hadst
come too late,—275
But now am I all defenceless, a maiden, and no man's mate.
And yet a shield I carry, and fair its device shall be,
And honoured of all—Its blazon would I read here, Sir
King, to thee,
That thou henceforth mayst know it—Pure heart and upright
mind,
That true man beneath its cover a shelter may ever find. 280
And that, o'er the gallant hero whom thou sentest unto my
care,
Did I hold, and 'gainst thee, his foeman, I did, as beseemed
me, bear,
For none other armour had I—And if thou repent the ill
Thou hast done to thy guest, me, thy sister, hast thou
wronged more deeply still;
For this is the right of woman, so ever 'twas told to me, 285
That if ever unto the shelter of a maiden a knight shall flee,
Then they who as foemen follow shall straightway leave
their chase—
In such wise they ever bear them who would not their shield
disgrace—
Now, Sir Vergulacht, that thy guest fled to *me* as his hope of
life,
Hath loaded with shame thine honour, since thou aided, nor
checked, the strife!' 290

Then Kingrimursel quoth sternly, 'Yea, Sire, 'twas at *thy*
command,
That on Plimizöl's plain I bade him, Sir Gawain, to seek this
land.
On thy royal word safe conduct I swear him, that should he
ride
Hither we twain were pledged him no evil should here
betide,

Save but from *one* foeman only—Now, Sire, thou hast here
done ill295

In that, spite of thine oath so knightly, thy word thou didst
not fulfil.

And here shall my fellows hearing give judgment betwixt us
twain,

If thus thou wrongest *princes*, what as *king* mayst thou hope
to gain

From us of faith and honour?—If honoured thou fain
wouldst be,

Then, courteous, make confession that near of kin are we;
300

True cousin am I, no bastard, and e'en if such chance had
been,

Even then, in this thy dealing, thou hadst done me a wrong, I
ween!

A knight am I in whom no man hath found a taint of shame,
And I think me that free from falsehood, yea, to death will I
guard my fame,

For in God have I ever trusted, and, methinks, He holds not
in store305

Such fate for the days of the future as I knew not in days of
yore.

Yet they who shall hear the story, how the nephew of Arthur
rode

To Schamfanzon 'neath my safe-conduct, where'er shall be
his abode—

An he come from the land of the Breton, or from France, or
from Provence fair,

Burgundian he, or Gallician, or the arms of Punturtois bear
— 310

When he hear of the grief of Gawain then *my* fame shall be
swiftly sped,

And shame be my meed for the danger that threatened that
knightly head.

At the tale of this strife shall my glory wax narrow, and
blame grow wide;

And, as joy in the past dwelt with me, so henceforward shall
shame abide.'

As he made an end of speaking stood a vassal the king
before, 315

And, as Kiot himself hath told us, Liddamus was the name
he bore.

And I speak here of Kiot the singer, and so sweet was I ween
his song

That none wax of the hearing weary, tho' the days of their
life be long.

And I rede ye to wit that Kiot of old was a Provençal,
Who found writ in a book of the heathen this story of
Parzival. 320

And in French again he sang it, and I, if no wit shall fail,
Would fain in his footsteps follow, and in German would tell
the tale.

Quoth the Prince Liddamus in his anger, 'Now say, what
doth he do here

In the house of my lord, who his father hath slain, and hath
brought anear

The brand of shame? My king's courage is known thro'
many a land, 325

'Twould better beseem his honour to avenge him with his
own hand;

One death for the other payeth—and the need waxeth here
as there.'

And Gawain he stood in sore peril, and fear for his life must
bear.

Quoth Kingrimursel, 'Who to threaten is swift, he as swift
should be

To mingle in strife, yet but lightly thy foeman he holdeth
thee! 330

An wide were the field or narrow, yet Sir Liddamus, I know
well

This man were safe from thine onslaught e'en tho' shame at
his hand befell,
For ne'er wouldst thou dare to avenge it, who yet dost so
loudly boast—
And swifter were we to hearken if ever in battle host
We had seen thee ride the foremost! But strife ever wrought
thee pain,335
And afar from the field of battle to linger thou aye wast fain.
Yea, *more* hast thou learnt—The beginning of strife didst
thou ever see,
Then hence wouldst thou fly as swiftly as a maiden is wont
to flee.
And the prince who thy counsel hearkens, and doeth as thou
shalt say,
Shall find that the crown he weareth but loosely shall sit
alway!' 340

'And fain, in a joust so knightly, were I to have faced
Gawain,
Nor feared me aught, for such combat had we sworn fast
betwixt us twain.
And here had we fought, as fitting, 'neath the eye of the king
my lord,
And wroth am I now, for dearer, methought, had he held his
word!
Now swear thou to me, Sir Gawain, when a year from this
day be past,345
To meet me again in combat—If thou 'scape my lord's wrath
at last,
And thy life for a prey he leave thee, yet we twain must fight
our fight.
At Plimizöl first I bade thee; at Barbigöl, if it seem thee
right,
Before Meljanz, the youthful monarch, the strife shall
methinks be fought;
And around my heart till the day come shall sorrow's wreath
be wrought,350

And gladly I'll hail that dawning, and face thee, thou hero
bold,
Tho' the guerdon be but of sorrow, that shall there by thine
hand be told.'

So there, as the Landgrave bade him, the hero Gawain
swore,
And his oath, and his pledge so knightly, he plighted as erst
of yore.
But Duke Liddamus, he bethought him of words that he fain
would say,355
And with cunning skill and wisdom his speech did he weave
that day.

Thus he spake for all men to hear him, for the time of speech
was come,
'Now if strife ever call upon me, if the battle be lost or won,
If I fight as beseems a hero, or fly as a coward flies,
If the meed of my warlike bearing be honour in all men's
eyes, 360
Then reward me I pray, Sir Landgrave, with rewarding as I
shall win;
But if honour or praise be withholden I count it not me for
sin!'

Nor here did his speech find ending. 'If *Turnus* thou fain
wouldst be,
Then good, thou shalt find me *Tranzes*; thou mayst well
wreak thy will on me,
If so be thou hast aught against me, but 'tis *thou* who dost
boast too loud,365
Yea, e'en an thou wert the highest of my peers, these princes
proud;
For Prince am I too, and Landgrave, and I have in Galicia's
land
Many Burgs so fair and stately that e'en far as Vedrun stand.

And tho' thou and this Breton stranger were minded to work
me ill,
Yet not even a fowl for thy threatening would fly, but abide
thee still!'370

'He came from the land of the Breton whom thou hither for
strife didst hale.
Take *thou* vengeance for king and kinsman, if such
vengeance may aught avail;
With *him*, not with *me*, thy quarrel, avenge thou thine uncle's
life
On him who of life hath robbed him, it toucheth me not, this
strife,
For I wot well in naught I wronged him, and none for such
wrong makes moan.375

What need to bewail thine uncle? His son sitteth on his
throne,
And I ask for no higher ruler, since Fleurdamur, the queen,
Was his mother, his sire Kingrisein, and his grandsire
Gandein hath been.
And still in my mind it dwelleth how Galoes and Gamuret,
Those heroes twain, were his uncles, nor lie I, nor truth
forget. 380
And I think me that in all honour my castles and lands so
wide
I may take from his hand, with their banners, and serve him
whate'er betide!'

'Let him fight who hath lust for fighting, for weary of strife
am I,
Tho' I know well who fame in battle doth win, for his
victory
Hath reward from the lips of women, yet for never a
maiden's sake 385
Will I evil entreat this body, or bid it such ill-road take.

Nay, why should I be a Wolfhart? Since barred is the battle
way,
And no lust of strife hath beguiled me that I know not the
thing I say.
If thou shouldst for aye despise me, yet Rumolt I'll take as
guide,
Who gave counsel unto King Gunther, ere yet to the Huns he
hied. 390
For he bade him in Worms abide still, where was plenty and
e'en to spare,
And content his soul with the flesh-pots and the riches of
Rhineland fare!

But ready of wit was the Landgrave, and he spake, 'Yea, the
tale be told
E'en to day, and no man shall marvel, for we know well thy
ways of old.
Thou wouldst urge me to strife, yet thy counsel is e'en what
a cook once gave 395
To the Nibelung lord, little recked he such counsel, the hero
brave.
For he and his, little doubting, went boldly to meet their fate,
And avenged was the death of Siegfried, and sated was
Kriemhild's hate!
And Sir Gawain, I ween, must give me my death, or himself
must feel
The weight of my bitter vengeance as we battle for woe or
weal!' 400

'Thou dost well,' Liddamus made answer, 'yet I think me of
treasure fair,
All that Arthur might hold, or India, if one such to my feet
should bear,
And say 'twas mine own, he might have it ere I fought e'en
for such a prize.
An thou wilt, win thee fame and honour, I, I think me, am all
too wise.

God knoweth, no Segramor am I, whom men must with
fethers bind 405
So keenly for strife he lusted, far other was aye my mind.
Yet mine be my monarch's favour, for Sibeck ne'er drew a
sword,
But ever he fled with the flying, yet men hearkened well his
word;
And many for counsel prayed him, and great gifts and lands
enow
The hand of Ermenrich gave him, tho' no helmet e'er felt his
blow. 410
And Sir Kingrimursel, I rede thee, thou shalt mark me with
never a scar!
Then out spake King Vergulacht sternly, as he ended their
wordy war:

'Peace, peace, nor so loudly wrangle, Sir Knights, all too
bold are ye,
For too near is your monarch's presence, and of speech are
ye both too free;
And that thus ye should strive before me, tho' your strife be
of *word*, not *deed*, 415
Ill beseemeth both king and vassal, so hearken my word, and
heed.'

This befell in the hall of the palace, 'neath the eyes of his
sister fair,
And Gawain stood beside the maiden, and heroes and
knights were there.
Quoth the king to his gentle sister, 'Now take thou with thee
thy guest
And the Landgrave, while I bethink me the word that shall
'seem me best. 420
And all ye who wish well unto me, shall follow and give me
rede.'
Quoth the maid, 'Of good faith seek counsel, for better 'twill
serve thy need!'

Gat the king to his council-chamber; the king's daughter had
comrades three,
Cousin, and guest, and beside them black care bare them
company.
Gawain, as right well beseemed her, by the hand to her
bower she led.425
And she quoth, 'Now shall all lands rue it if here thou shalt
be ill-spel!'
And the son of King Lot, Sir Gawain, with the maiden went
hand in hand,
And none thought them shame, for so gracious was the
custom of that fair land.

So passed they unto her chamber, the queen and those heroes
twain,
And that none 'gainst her will should enter was the care of
her chamberlain.430
Only her bower maidens as befitted them there might be,
And the queen, in all love and honour, her guest tended
royally.
And the Landgrave in naught gainsaid her, for belike did he
bear a part
In the fear for her guest's well-doing that lay dark on the
maiden's heart.
So the twain with the queen abode there till the strife of the
day was o'er,435
And the night and the hour of feasting had come in their
course once more.
Then the slender maidens bare them sweet drinks, and the
wine so red,
And with fish and fowl in plenty, I ween, was the table
spread.
Fair and white was the bread to look on, and the Landgrave
and Knight Gawain,
Who had passed thro' such deadly peril, to taste of the food
were fain.440

And each as the queen might bid him ate that which should
 please him best,
And no lack did they find, for right queenly the maid did
 entreat her guest,
And vainly the heroes prayed her to cease from her kindly
 care.
Of the many who knelt before them no maid but was young
 and fair;
Yea, fair with the opening beauty of the rose that is yet
 unblown, 445
And soft lay their locks as the feathers of a falcon the knight
 hath flown.

Now list, ere they close the council, to the rede they would
 rede the king
And wise were the men who, wisely, good counsel in need
 should bring;
And each spake as his mind should bid him, and that which
 his heart deemed best,
And they turned the thing hither and thither, till the king thus
 his speech addrest:450

And he spake, 'One of late fought with me, as on venture
 bent I rode
In the wood Læhtamreis—too proudly, perchance, I my
 steed bestrode,
For a knight, who o'er great my fame deemed, in joust smote
 me such a blow
That, behind my gallant charger, on the greensward he laid
 me low.
And this oath must I swear unto him, in search of the Grail
 to ride,455
And my knightly pledge I gave him, were it other, I there
 had died.
Now give me, I pray, your counsel, for 'gainst death was no
 other shield

But to swear as my victor bade me, and, as knight, to a
knight to yield!'

'Yea, mighty and strong that hero,—nor sware I that oath
alone,

But he bade me, as true man truly, when a year should have
come and gone,460

And the Grail I still were seeking, to ride unto Pelrapär
To the queen who the crown there weareth, the child of King
Tampentäre.

And there, as I looked upon her, I should yield me unto her
grace;

And from him should I bear this message in the day that I
sought her face.

He would say, "An she thought upon him 'twas his joy and
his labour's meed,465

His hand from the King Klamidé aforetime her land had
freed.'"

Then the speech to the end they hearkened; and Liddamus
spake this word,

'Give me leave to speak, ye shall follow, Sir Knights, when
my rede is heard,

For the oath that perforce thou swarest, its fulfiller shall be
Gawain,

And he, captive, his wings shall flutter in the snare wherein
thou wast ta'en.470

For here, where we stand to hearken, shall he swear us the
Grail to win,

And then of free will let him ride hence; for I deem men
would count it sin

Were he slain in thine house—Nay, me-seemeth 'twere better
to let him live,

For but ill would it please thy sister an thou didst not her
knight forgive!

Sore stress at our hands hath he suffered, and he now to his
death shall ride;475

For far as the far sea's water shall circle the earth so wide
There standeth no Burg so mighty as Monsalväsch, its
towers shall fear
No foeman, and strait the pathway that wendeth its walls
anear,
And sore dangers that road encompass—Let him slumber in
peace this night,
And the word that we deem the wisest shall be told him with
morning light!'480
Right well did the counsel please them, and ended, I ween,
the strife,
And Gawain, so the venture telleth, thus won at their hands
his life.

So they tended the dauntless hero right well thro' the hours
of night;
From the Mass came the folk on the morrow when the
noontide hour waxed bright,
And the hall was thronged and crowded with townsfolk and
warriors good,485
When before the king, as they counselled, his foeman, Sir
Gawain, stood.
To naught other would he compel him than to that which ye
late did hear.
Now see ye the gentle maiden as she drew with her knight
anear,
And her uncle's son came with her, and many a hero brave
Of the king's men were fain to follow, and thus fair escort
gave. 490
Then the queen led Gawain to her brother with slender hand
and white,
And a chaplet of fair flowers woven she bare on her locks of
light,
Fair the flowers, yet the maid was fairer, and no blossom
around her head
But waxed pale and dim, if 'twas mated with her lips of
glowing red.

And he whom of true heart gently she kissed, as beseemed a
maid, 495
Such lances for her had broken as had wasted a woodland
shade.

Now hearken to me and heed me, as with gracious words I'd
greet
Antikonie, free from falsehood, a maiden pure and sweet.
In such wise did she ever bear her that never a doubting
word,
Were one fain to sing her praises, from the lips of men was
heard; 500
For no heart but wished her gladness, and no mouth but
spake her free
From all thought of guile—Far-reaching, as a falcon's eye
can see,
Shone the light of her gracious presence, as the light of a
balsam rare
That burneth, and sheddeth perfume, and sweeteneth the
scented air.
And her will was ever gracious, as the will of a maid should
be, 505
And she spake to her royal brother of a true heart right
maidenly:

'I bring here to thee, my brother, the guest thou didst bid me
tend,
And I would thou shouldst well entreat him, as befitting my
knight and friend—
For better shall that become thee, to bear thee as brother
true,
Than to feel the world's hate, or to teach me to hate thee,
who hate ne'er knew.'510

Quoth the king, 'Nay then, my sister, an I may, so stands my
will,

Thou shalt give me here thy counsel, for I think me I did but
ill,

And stained thereby mine honour, and dimmed my knightly
fame;

And I deem me but little worthy that thou shouldst me as
brother claim.

E'en if all lands should do my bidding at thy prayer would I
yield them all,⁵¹⁵

Lest that sorrow of sorrows greatest, thine hatred, on me
should fall!

And honour and joy were ended an I said to thy pleading,
Nay—

Sir Gawain, I here entreat thee, since for fame thou didst
ride this way,

An thou knightly fame wouldst honour, so help me, that I
may win

Anew from my sister favour, and forgiveness for this my sin.
⁵²⁰

Far liefer were I to pardon the wrong thou hast done to me
Than to lose her, my sweetest sister—Now list what thy task
shall be,

Do thou swear to me here that truly thou wilt strive, as I erst
was fain

To strive, for the Grail's fair kingdom, and the honour thou
there shalt gain.'

In such wise the strife was ended, Sir Gawain far hence must
ride, ⁵²⁵

And with sword and spear do battle, and woe for the Grail
abide.

And the Landgrave forgave his monarch the wrong that he
did his word

When he brake his pledge unto Gawain—and no prince of
the land but heard.

Then their swords they ungirt, and they hung them in their
place on the castle wall—

And the squires of Gawain came swiftly, and, joyful, he
hailed them all,530
For not one in strife was wounded—for a man of the Burger
folk,
Ere the battle waxed hot, had claimed them, and wise were
the words he spoke,
And their peace he prayed from the foemen, and he held
them awhile in ward,
Were they French, or from land of the Breton, till again to
their rightful lord
He might send them in peace—Some were children, and
some were lads strong and young—535
And glad were their hearts when they saw him, and awhile
on his neck they hung,
And weeping they kissed Sir Gawain, yet no sorrow I ween
was there,
But from joy sprang the crystal tear-drops that ran o'er their
faces fair.

And one came from the land of Cornwall, Count Laiz he,
and Tinal's son;
And a noble lad was with him whose father his death had
won 540
At Schoie-de-la-Kurt, Gandelus, the son, and Gurzgrei, the
sire—
(Thro' that venture full many a maiden must weep for her
heart's desire)
And his aunt was the maid Liassé, and fair was the lad of
face
And of feature, for Love had touched them, and had wrought
them with hand of grace,
And fain were all men to see him—Six were there those
twain beside,545
Eight lads, all of noble bearing and birth, with Gawain did
ride.
And as kinsmen right well they loved him, and they served
him for payment fair;

What payment gave he? Meed of honour their guerdon, and
tender care!
Then Gawain quoth unto the children, "Tis well, for I now
have seen,
Fair kinsmen, that ye had mourned me, if slain I perchance
had been,550
(And well might he see their sorrow, for as yet they mourned
full sore,)
Where were ye in hour of battle? Much sorrow for ye I bore.'
Then they answered, and none spake falsely, 'As thou sat'st
in the high hall place
A hawk flew astray, and we ran thence, and joined for
awhile the chase.'

Then all they who sat or stood there, nor ceased for awhile
their gaze,555
Saw well that Gawain was a true knight, and a man whom
all men might praise;
Then the king gave the leave he prayed for, and he spake
unto all farewell,
Save the queen alone, and the Landgrave, he whom men
called Kingrimursel.
For the queen took the twain, and the children who followed
as Gawain's squires,
And she led them where gentle maidens should serve as she
should require,560
And in peace, as became fair maidens, each maid did her
lady's will,
And fair were the hands and gracious that did gracious tasks
fulfil.

Straightway when the meal was ended Gawain from the
feast uprose,
Thus Kiot hath told the story—and as blossom from root up-
grows,
So afresh from a true heart's true faith did sorrow spring
forth amain—565

Quoth the hero unto the maiden, 'Now, Lady, an God be fain
To leave to me life and wisdom, wherever my way I take
True service, true knight befitting, will I do for thy gentle
sake.

The rede did I hear and hearken that spake thee of falsehood
free,

And thy fame o'er the fame of all maidens shall high as the
heavens be.570

And Heaven Itself shall bless thee, and thy gifts all be gifts
of God!

Now, Lady, thy leave I crave here, since 'tis time on my way
I rode.

Give me leave, then, and let me ride hence, for I ween for
the future days

Shalt thou be thine own best defender, and thy virtue shall
crown thy praise!'

Then sorrow of heart was her portion that the knight thus her
side must leave,575

Sore she wept, and her gentle maidens awhile with her grief
must grieve.

And the queen she spake out freely, 'An more I had done for
thee,

Then my joy had o'ercome my sorrow, yet better it might not
be;

Little peace for thee here might blossom—but, believe me,
be ill thy share,

Or should deeds of knighthood lead thee where sorrow thou
needs must bear,580

Then, Sir Gawain, my heart findeth portion in thy lot, be it
loss or gain!'

On his mouth, with her red lips glowing, the maiden she
kissed Gawain.

Then joy fled afar from the hero, and sorrow hath pierced
his heart,

Too early the twain they deemed it, from each other for aye
to part.

Meantime had his squires bethought them, and his steed to
the palace brought,585
Where the boughs of a mighty linden might shadow the
outer court;
And the Landgrave's folk they sought him, and together they
took their way
Without the walls; ere they parted this grace would Sir
Gawain pray,
Since his squires might no more fare with him, that the
Landgrave with them in ward
Should ride forthwith unto Beausosch, 'There Scherules the
Burg doth guard,590
Thou shalt pray him that these fair children to Dianadron he
bring
Where many a Breton dwelleth, and shall yield them unto
the king
Or to Guinevere, his Lady'—So sware him Kingrimursel,
And, with kindly words and courteous, to Sir Gawain he
bade 'Farewell.'
Short the space ere both steed and rider were clad in their
mail of might,595
Kinsmen and squires, he kissed them, and alone rode that
gallant knight,
For, as this his oath had bade him, to the Grail must his
pathway wend,
And many a pain and peril must he know ere his task should
end.

BOOK IX

TREVREZENT

ARGUMENT

Book IX. In the opening the spirit of adventure craves admission to the heart of the poet, who would fain learn from her tidings of Parzival. The venture telleth how the hero had ridden long in doubt and despair, and knew not the days of his wanderings. How he met again with Siguné and came to the forest of Monsalväsch, where he fought with a Knight of the Grail. How, on Good Friday, Parzival met with a pilgrim knight who reproached him for bearing arms at that Holy Tide, and bade him seek the hermit Trevrezent.

How Parzival came to the hermit's cell, and spake of his wrath against God, of his sorrow for his wife, and of his search for the Grail. How Trevrezent told him wherein he had sinned, and showed him the way of salvation.

How the hermit farther revealed to him the mysteries of the Grail, of the Bleeding Lance, and the knives of silver; how he told him of the wound of Anfortas, of the race of the Grail Kings, and how Parzival himself was nephew to Anfortas and Trevrezent. How Parzival confessed that it was he who came to the Grail Castle and failed to ask the question; how Trevrezent spake to him words of comfort and counsel, and absolved him from his sin; and how the two parted in sorrow.

BOOK IX

TREVREZENT



'Ope the portal!' 'To whom? Who art thou?' 'In thine heart would I
find a place!'

'Nay! if such be thy prayer, methinketh, too narrow shall be the
space!'

'What of that? If it do but hold me, none too close shall my presence
be,

Nor shalt thou bewail my coming, such marvels I'll tell to thee!'

Is it thou, then, O Dame Adventure? Ah! tell me of Parzival, 5

What doeth he now my hero? whom Kondrie, to find the Grail

Hath driven, with words sharp-pointed, and sore wept the maidens
fair

That the path of his far wayfarings the knight from their side must
bear.

So he passed from the court of King Arthur, where shall he abide to-
day?

Ah! hasten the tale to tell us, where now shall his footsteps stray? 10

Say, if fame to himself he winneth, or be ever of joy bereft,

Shall his honour as fair and spotless as of old so to-day be left?

His renown is it broad as aforetime, or waxeth it small and thin?

Ah! tell us, nor stay the story, of the deeds that his hand shall win.

Hath he seen once again Monsalväs, and Anfortas, the mournful
king, 15

Whose heart was with sorrow laden? Of thy pity swift comfort bring,

And say if his woe be ended—Speak, speak for we tidings pray

Of him whom alike we serve here, dwells Parzival there to-day?

Declare unto me his doings, how fares it with Gamuret's son,

And the child of fair Herzeleide, is the tale of his wanderings done?

20

Since he rode from the court of King Arthur has joy been his lot, or
woe?

He hath striven, but rides he ever thro' the wide world nor rest doth
know?

Or loveth he now, outwearied, to linger o'er-long at ease?

I were fain to know all his doings, so speak thou, as thou shalt
please!

And this hath the venture told me—He hath ridden many a land, 25

And hath sailed many a water; and ever, before his hand,

Were he man of the land or kinsman who would joust with him, he
fell,

Nor abode his mighty onslaught, and all men of his praises tell.

And ever when in the balance the fame of his foe must lie,

'Twas outweighed by his fame, and his glory uprose to the stars on
high,³⁰
And all others paled before it—In many a mighty strife
With sword and lance was he victor, and guarded full well his life.
And they who would fame win from him, for such thinking they paid
full dear—
The sword that Anfortas gave him, as ye once in this tale did hear,
Sprang asunder onewhile, yet 'twas welded afresh in the mystic
spring³⁵
By Karnant, and much fame and honour the blade to its lord did
bring!

Who believeth me not, he sinneth, for now doth the venture tell
How adown a woodland pathway, on his way rode Sir Parzival,
(But the hour of his riding I wot not, if in waxing or waning light,)
When a hermitage, newly builded, uprose to his wondering sight, 40
And a stream flowed swift beneath it, for 'twas built o'er the
brooklet's wave
Then in search of some worthy venture to its door rode the hero
brave,
Nor knew that of grace 'twas the portal, and his footsteps of God
were led.
But the dweller therein was a maiden, and the days of her joy were
sped,
For the love of God had she offered her youth, and the joys of
earth,⁴⁵
And the root of her old-time sorrow brought ever fresh grief to birth.

For he found here Schionatulander, and Siguné, his faithful love,
Dead and buried he lay, the hero, and the maid wept his tomb above.
Tho' but seldom Siguné the Duchess might hearken the Holy Mass,
All her life was a prayer, in God's service her nights as her days
she'd pass.⁵⁰
And her lips, erst so red and glowing, had faded as life-joys fade,
And alone would she mourn such sorrow as never had mourned a
maid.

Thus denial of love's fulfilling made Love, with her love, to die,
And dead, as she living loved him, did she cherish him tenderly.
And in sooth had she once his wife been, then ne'er had Lunete
braved⁵⁵
Her wrath, and had given such counsel, as she once to her lady gave.

And today may we look upon women, who never a willing ear
Had turned to Lunete, and such wisdom but little had brooked to
hear.

For this do I know, that a woman who, for love of her lord alone,
And thro' virtue of gentle breeding, doth never strange service
own,60

But aye, while her husband liveth, shall be to him wife as true,
Heaven giveth in her such blessing as bloometh for ever new!
And never shall prayer or fasting robe her with a robe as fair!
And I, if the time were fitting, this word naught but truth would
swear.

Be he dead, she may do as best please her, but if faithful she still
abide,65

Then far fairer such faith than the circlet she beareth at feasting tide!

Shall I joy compare with the sorrow that her faith to Siguné brought?
Nay, 'twere better I speak not of it—O'er rough stones, and a road
unwrought

Rode Parzival to the window (he deemed well he rode too near).
He would ask of the woodland pathway, and the goal of its windings
hear.70

And he thought him, perchance, the hermit might tell of the
unknown way,

'Doth one dwell here?' the voice of a maiden it was that made
answer, 'Yea!'

As he knew 'twas the voice of a woman, swift turned he his steed
aside

On the greensward beside the pathway, for he deemed he too near
did ride,

And sooner had he dismounted had he known that a maiden dwelt 75
Within such a lowly dwelling, and shame, as was meet, he felt.

Then his horse and his shield, all splintered, he bound to a fallen
tree,

And he loosed his sword from beside him, for a courteous knight
was he.

Then he stepped him unto the window, and asked of the place and
road,

And the cell of all joy was empty, and bare, as 'seemed grief's
abode.80

He spake, would she come to the window? and the maiden from
prayer arose,

She was tall as a virgin lily, and pale as a faded rose,
And he deemed not as yet that he knew her—A shirt woven rough of
hair,
Next her skin, 'neath a flowing garment of grey, did the maiden wear,
And sorrow was her heart's treasure, and fallen her courage high, 85
And the guerdon she won for her service must be paid her in many a
sigh!

Then the maiden she stepped to the window and the knight did she
courteous greet,
In her hand did she hold her psalter, and her voice it was low and
sweet.
And Parzival saw on her white hand the gleam of a ring of gold,
For truly she bare the token she won from true love of old. 90
And the stone set within the circlet was a garnet, whose slumbering
light
Flashed red mid the dusky shadows, as mid ashes the sparks glow
bright.
And the band that her head encircled was black as a mourning band
—

Then she spake, 'Sir Knight, 'neath the window a bench shalt thou
see to stand,
Thou canst sit there, an it so please thee, and thy journey will brook
delay, 95
God reward thee for this thy greeting Who hath led thee to me this
day!'

Then the hero did as she bade him, and he sat 'neath the window
small,
And he prayed her, 'Sit thou within there!' 'Nay! ne'er did such
chance befall
That here by a man I sat me!' Then he asked her, what did she here?
That, so far from the home of men-folk, thou dost dwell in this desert
drear 100
Seemeth me all too great a wonder, say, Lady, how shalt thou live,
Since no man abideth by thee who succour or food can give?'

Then she quoth, 'Tis the Grail that doth feed me, and It feedeth me
well I ween,
From Its marvels the sorceress Kondrie, (of her own will the task
hath been,)
Doth bring me each Sabbath vigil what serveth me for the week.' 105

A little space she kept silence, then further the maid did speak:
'An it otherwise were with me as I would, I need little care
For the food, since the Grail doth feed me I never too ill shall fare!'

But he deemed that she lied unto him, and with false words would
speak him
fair, And, mocking, he spake, 'Now, who gave thee that ring which I
see thee wear?' 110

For ever 'twas told unto me that hermit, or man, or maid,
Must forswear all love!—'Now I think me, if in truth thou these
words hast said,
For false maiden thou sure dost hold me! Yet if falsehood I ever
learn,
And thou shalt be near to witness, 'twere time *then* with wrath to
burn!

God knoweth, ill ways I hated, and falsehood I never knew; 115
This troth plight that here thou seest I had from a lover true,
Tho' never was love's fulfilment our portion while he might live,
'Twas the heart of maiden bade me the love of a maiden give.
And he lieth in death beside me, and his token I ever wear
Since the day that Duke Orilus slew him—and grief for his sake I
bear—' 120

'And true love will I truly give him, thro' my sorrow-laden days,
Such love as I sware unto him, when he, whom, all knights must
praise,
With sword, and shield, and helmet, and prowess of knightly deed
Sought my love, and in true love's service won death for his glory's
meed!

Yet tho' ever a spotless maiden, my husband he, in God's sight, 125
Shall be, and if thoughts God counteth as deeds then is woven aright
The bond that shall ever bind us, true husband and wife as true,
For his death wrought my life such sorrow as waxeth for ever new.
And this ring shall, I ween, be my witness when I stand in the sight
of God

Of a marriage vow and the tear-drops that bedew it are tears of
blood.' 130

'Yea, 'tis I indeed, and none other, and the hero who here doth lie
Is my knight, Schionatulander, and the maid of his love am I!
Then he knew 'twas the maid Siguné, and her sorrow it wrought him
pain,

And he lifted his helmet's visor ere he spake to the maid again.
And she saw his head uncovered, and she saw his face gleam white
135

Thro' the rust of the iron harness, and she spake to the gallant knight:
'Is it thou, Parzival, my kinsman? Dost thou seek for the Grail to-
day?
Or its mighty power hast thou proven? Say, whither dost wend thy
way?'

Then he spake to the noble maiden, 'Alas! for my joy is fled,
And the Grail hath but wrought me sorrow, and mischance in fair
fortune's stead.140
For the land that as king had crowned me must I leave, and yet more,
I ween,
The fairest of wives, and the sweetest, that ever a man hath seen.
For no lovelier form I think me on earth of mankind was born,
And I yearn for her tender greeting, and full sore for her love I
mourn!
And yet know I a deeper sorrow and I strive for a higher prize, 145
For the day when the Burg of Monsalväsich, and the Grail shall
rejoice my eyes!
Now, Siguné, dear my cousin, thou wast all too wroth with me,
For heavy indeed my sorrow, yet thou fain wouldst my foeman be!'

And she quoth, 'From henceforth, my cousin, mine anger will I
forswear,
For too much of thy joy lieth forfeit since the question thou didst
forbear!150
And I would not too sorely grieve thee—Alas I that thou didst
withhold
The word that had brought thee honour, and the tale of his griefs had
told
Who sat there as thine host beside thee—nor thine host alone was he,
Anfortas, for joy and blessing his presence had brought to thee!
And thy question great bliss had brought thee, and thy silence had
wrought thee woe,155
And thy spirit shall fail, and heart-sorrow as thy comrade thou well
shalt know.
And yet had it been far from thee, nor, a stranger, had sought thy
side,
Hadst thou asked of that Burg the marvels, and what ill did its host
betide!'

'Yea, I did there as one who wrongeth himself; yet my cousin dear
I prithee here give me counsel, since in sooth are we kinsmen
near.160

And tell me, how fares it with thee? I would sorrow for this thy woe
Were my sorrow not all too heavy! Greater grief man may never
know!'

Then she quoth, 'May His Mercy help thee, Who knoweth of all
men's woe,

Perchance it may yet befall thee that His finger a way shall show
That shall lead thee once more to Monsalväscher, and thine heart's
bliss afresh shall spring.165

'Tis but short space since Kondrie left me, and I would I could
tidings bring

Of whither she went, but I asked not if she rode to the Burg again,
Or passed elsewhere; but when she cometh by that streamlet she
draweth rein,

Where, from cleft in the high rock riven, the waters flow fresh and
clear.

It may be, if thou follow swiftly, that she rideth as yet anear, 170
And, perchance, thou shalt overtake her.' Then the knight he made no
delay

But farewell did he bid to the maiden; and he followed the woodland
way,

And fresh were the tracks before him, but such pathway the mule
must choose

Thro' the depths of the dusky thicket that its traces he soon must
lose.

As the Grail he had lost of aforetime, so he lost It again to-day, 175
And joy and delight fled with It—Yea, had he but found the way,
And reached once again Monsalväscher, for better than erst of old
Had he known how to ask the question—thus in sooth is the venture
told.

So now let him ride, but whither? Lo, a knight with uncovered head,
And blazoned coat o'er his shining harness, full swiftly towards him
sped!180

And to Parzival thus quoth he, 'Sir Knight, I must deem it ill
That thus thro' the woods of my monarch thou takest thy way at will!
Begone! or receive such token thou shalt wish thyself far from here!
Monsalväscher doth never brook it that men ride thus its walls anear,
And here must thou strive in battle, and win here a victor's fame, 185

Or such penance be thine, as without there, in the open, men *Death*
shall name!

And he bare in his hand a helmet, and its bands were of silken sheen,
Sharp-pointed his spear, and the spear-shaft was of wood new and
strong I ween!

And wrathful he bound his helmet on his head, not in vain should be
His threat, for his blows should enforce it! Now ready for joust was
he;190

But many a spear as goodly had splintered 'fore Parzival,
And he thought, 'Now, it well had chanced me, that death to my lot
should fall

If I rode thro' the corn upstanding—*then* reason had he for wrath,
But *now* hath he none, since I ride here on naught but a woodland
path,

And I tread here but fern and heather! An mine hand shall not lose its
skill195

I will leave him such pledge for my journey as, I think me, shall
please him ill!

Then they rode at full speed their chargers, and they urged them with
spur and rein,

As the bolt from the bow of the archer so swift flew those heroes
twain,

And the first joust they rode unwounded; but many a knightly fray
Unscathed had Parzival ridden, and e'en so should it chance to-
day.200

(Unto skill and the lust of battle must his father's son be heir.)
His lance-point upon the fastening of his foeman's helm struck fair,
And it smote him where men in jousting their shield are wont to
hold,

And down from his gallant charger did he bear him, the Templar
bold.

And the knight of the Grail fell headlong down the side of a rocky
dell,205

Tho' couch he had found, I think me, he slumbered not over well.

But the victor's steed sped onward, and in vain would he check its
flight

Ere it fell, and well-nigh in falling had borne to his death the knight.
A cedar o'erhung the chasm, its bough Parzival gripped fast,
(Nor think ye scorn of my hero, that, as chanceth a thief at last, 210

He hung, for none spake his judgment, he hung there by his own
hand)

His feet, for a foothold seeking, on the rock found at last their stand:
Far out of his reach, beneath him, his gallant steed lay dead,
Up the further side of the valley the Templar for safety fled.
Think ye that he much might pride him on his token from Parzival?

215

Far better at home in Monsalväscher had he fared with the wondrous
Grail!

To the plain once more climbed our hero, there the steed of the
Templar stood,

For down to the ground hung the bridle and fettered the war-horse
good.

As the knight in his flight forgot it so it stood where its master fell,
Swift Parzival sprang to the saddle, such booty might please him
well.220

Of a truth his spear had he shattered, yet more than he lost he won—
Nor Lâhelein, nor Kingrisein a better joust e'er had run!
Nor King Gramoflanz nor Count Laskoit (the son he of Gurnemanz).
Onward he rode, yet wandering, nor further befell mischance,
Nor strife, from the knights of Monsalväscher, yet one grief must vex
his soul,235

He found not the Grail—Ever further he rode, further fled the goal!

Now he who my song will hearken, he shall hear that which yet
befell,

Tho' the tale of the weeks I know not, that had flown since Sir
Parzival

Had met with the maid, and had ridden on venture as aye before—
One morning the ground was snow-clad, and tho' thin was the cloak
it bore230

Yet so thick it was that men, seeing, had deemed it the time of frost;
As he rode thro' the depths of a woodland by a knight was his
pathway crossed,

And old was the knight, and grey bearded, yet his face it was bright
and fair,

And his lady who walked beside him like mien to her lord did bear.
And each on their naked body wore a garment of horse-hair grey,

235

For penance and pilgrimage minded they wended afoot their way.
And their children, two gentle maidens, such as men's eyes are fain
to see,

In like garments they followed barefoot, e'en as pilgrims are wont to
be.

Then our hero the old knight greeted as he passed on his lowly way,
And good was the rede, and holy, that he heard from his lips that
day.240

And a prince of the land he seemed him—By each maiden a brachet
ran,

And with humble mien and reverent paced master alike and man.
For both knight and squire they followed on this holy pilgrimage,
And some, they were young and beardless, and some were bent low
with age.

But Parzival, our hero, he was clad in far other wise, 245
In fair raiment, rich and costly, he rode in right knightly guise,
And proudly he ware his harness, and unlike were the twain I ween,
The old man in his robe of penance and the knight in his armour's
sheen!

Then swiftly he turned his bridle and held by the pathway side,
For fain would he know of their journey, and friendly the knight
replied.250

But a sorrow the old man deemed it that one to this Holy Tide
Should have failèd to give due honour, but in warlike gear should
ride.

For better would it befit him unarmèd this day to greet,
Or like them to walk barefooted, and in garb for a sinner meet!

Quoth Parzival, 'Nay, I know not what the time of the year may be,
255

Or how men the tale may reckon of the weeks as they swiftly flee,
How the days shall be named I know not, long have I forgot such
lore!

Of old time I served a master, and *God* was the name He bore.
But He bare unto me no favour, and for guerdon He mocking gave,
Tho' ne'er had my heart turned from Him—Men said, 'If from God
ye crave260

For succour, He sure will give it;' but I deem well they spake a lie,
For He who they said would help me, did help unto me deny!'

Quoth the grey-haired knight, 'Dost thou mean Him who was once of
a Maiden born?

Dost believe that a Man for men's sake He died on the cross this
morn,

And this day for His sake we hallow? Then such garb becomes thee
ill!265

For to-day all men call Good Friday, and the world it rejoiceth still
O'er the day that her chains were riven; tho' she mourneth her
Saviour's pain.

Speak, knowest thou of faith more faithful than the faith God hath
kept with men,
Since He hung on the cross for men's sake? Such woe as He bare for
thee,

Sir Knight, sure must work thee sorrow, since baptized thou shalt
surely be!270

For *our* sin His life was forfeit, or else had mankind been lost,
And Hell as his prey had held us, and Hell's torments had paid sin's
cost.

Sir Knight, if thou be not heathen, thou shalt honour this Holy Day

So do thou as here I counsel, ride thou on this woodland way,
For near here a hermit dwelleth, as thy speech, so his rede shall
be,275

And if ruth for ill deed thou showest of thy sin will he speak thee
free!'

Then out quoth the old man's daughter, 'Nay, father, but speak not so,
For too chill and cold is the morning, thou shalt bid him no further
go.

Far better to bid him warm him his steel-clad limbs, for strong
And fair shall he be to look on, and the way is both cold and
long.280

Methinks were he thrice as mighty he would freeze ere his goal he
reach,

And here hast thou tent for shelter, and viands for all and each.
Came King Arthur and all his vassals thou wouldst still have enough
I trow,

So do thou as host so kindly, and good-will to this young knight
show!'

Quoth the grey-haired sire, 'My daughters, Sir Knight, here give
counsel good,285

Each year, with tent of pilgrim, I wend thro' this lonely wood.

If warm or cold be the season I care not, as year by year

The time of our dear Lord's Passion draweth once more anear,

He rewardeth His servant's service—Sir Knight, what I, for His sake,

Brought here, as my guest, right willing, I pray thee from me to
take!'290

And kindly they spake, the maidens, and they bade the knight to stay,
And with gracious mien they prayed naught might drive him from
them away.

And tho' cold was the frost and bitter, and it wrought not as
summer's heat,

Yet Parzival saw their lips glow so red, and soft, and sweet.
(Tho' they wept for the death of the Saviour, such sorrow became
them well.)295

And here, had I cause for vengeance, an such happy chance befell,
I never would speak them guiltless, but a kiss should their penance
be,

Nor against their will would I take it, of good-will should they give it
me!

For women shall aye be women, and tho' brave be the knight, and
strong,

Yet I ween is he oft the vanquished, nor the strife it endureth
long!300

With sweet words, and ways so gentle, they ever the knight would
pray,

Children alike and parents, and fain would they have him stay:
Yet he thought, 'It were best I leave them, for e'en if I turn aside
All too fair methinks are these maidens, 'twere unfitting that *I* should
ride

While *they* by my side walk barefoot—And 'tis better that we should
part,305

Since ever I bear Him hatred Whom they worship with lowly heart,
And they look for His aid, Who ever hath turnèd His face from me,
Nor from sorrow hath He withheld me, but hath wrought with me
heavily!

'Knight and Lady,' he quoth, 'I think me 'twere better I leave should
pray,

May good fortune be yours, and blessing, and fulness of joy alway,
310

And may you, ye gentle maidens, find reward in your courtesy,
Since so well ye had thought to serve me, fair leave would I pray
from ye!

He greeted them, low they bowed them, and greeted the knight
again,

Nor might they withhold their sorrow, for parting aye bringeth pain!

So the son of Herzeleide rode onward, well taught was he 315

In all manly skill and courage, in mercy and purity;

And his mother had aye bequeathed him her faithful heart and true—

Yet ever his soul waxed sadder, and there sprang up thoughts anew
Of the might of the Maker of all things, Who hath made this earth of
naught,

How He dealeth with all creation, and still on His power he
thought 320

'How might it yet be if God sent me that which brought to an end my
woe?

If ever a knight He favoured, if ever a knight might know

His payment for service done Him—if He thinketh His aid they earn

Who dauntless shall wield their weapons, and ne'er from a foeman
turn,

Let Him aid me, who bear unstained shield and sword as befits a
man, 325

If to-day be His Day of Redemption, let Him help me, if help He
can.'

Backward he turned his bridle on the road he had ridden before,

And the knight and his children stood there, and mourned for the
parting sore.

And the maidens, true and gentle, gazed after the passing knight,

And his heart spake, he fain had seen them once more those maidens
bright. 330

Then he spake, 'Is God's power so mighty that He guideth upon their
way

The steed alike and the rider, then His hand may I praise to-day!

If God sendeth help from heaven, then let Him my charger show

The goal which shall bless my journey, so shall I the token know.

Now, go thou as God shall lead thee!' and bridle and bit he laid 335

Free on the neck of his charger and spurred it adown the glade.

Towards Fontaine-Sauvage the road led, and the chapel where once
he sware

The oath that should clear Jeschuté—A holy man dwelt there,

And Trevrezent men called him, and ever on Monday morn

Poor was his fare, and no richer it waxed as the week wore on. 340

Nor wine nor bread he tasted, nor food that with blood was red,

Fish nor flesh, but his life so holy on the herb of the ground was fed.

And ever his thoughts, God-guided, were turning to Heaven's land,
And by fasting the wiles of the Devil he deemed he might best
withstand.

And to Parzival the mystery of the Grail should he now reveal— 345
And he, who of this hath asked me, and since silence my lips must
seal

Was wroth with me as his foeman, his anger might naught avail,
Since I did but as Kiot bade me, for he would I should hide the tale,
And tell unto none the secret, till the venture so far were sped
That the hidden should be made open, and the marvel of men be
read.350

For Kiot of old, the master whom men spake of in days of yore,
Far off in Toledo's city, found in Arabic writ the lore
By men cast aside and forgotten, the tale of the wondrous Grail;
But first must he learn the letters, nor black art might there avail.
By the grace of baptismal waters, by the light of our Holy Faith, 355
He read the tale, else 'twere hidden; for never, the story saith,
Might heathen skill have shown us the virtue that hidden lies
In this mighty Grail, or Its marvels have opened to Christian eyes.

'Twas a heathen, Flegetanis, who had won for his wisdom fame,
And saw many a wondrous vision, (from Israel's race he came, 360
And the blood of the kings of old-time, of Solomon did he share,)
He wrote in the days long vanished, ere we as a shield might bear
The cross of our Holy Baptism 'gainst the craft and the wiles of Hell,
And he was the first of earth's children the lore of the Grail to tell.
By his father's side a heathen, a calf he for God did hold, 365
How wrought the devil such folly, on a folk so wise, of old?
And the Highest Who knoweth all wonders, why stretched He not
forth His Hand
To the light of His truth to turn them? For who may His power
withstand!

And the heathen, Flegetanis, could read in the heavens high
How the stars roll on their courses, how they circle the silent sky,370
And the time when their wandering endeth—and the life and the lot
of men
He read in the stars, and strange secrets he saw, and he spake again
Low, with bated breath and fearful, of the thing that is called the
Grail,
In a cluster of stars was it written, the name, nor their lore shall fail.

And he quoth thus, 'A host of angels this marvel to earth once
bore,375
But too pure for earth's sin and sorrow the heaven they sought once
more,
And the sons of baptized men hold It, and guard It with humble
heart,
And the best of mankind shall those knights be who have in such
service part'

Then Kiot my master read this, the tale Flegetanis told,
And he sought for the name of the people, in Latin books of old, 380
Who of God were accounted worthy for this wondrous Grail to care,
Who were true and pure in their dealings and a lowly heart might
bear.
And in Britain, and France, and Ireland thro' the chronicles he sought
Till at length, in the land of Anjou, the story to light was brought.
There, in true and faithful record, was it written of Mazadan, 385
And the heroes, the sons of his body, and further the story ran,
How Titurel, the grandsire, left his kingdom to Frimutel,
And at length to his son, Anfortas, the Grail and Its heirdom fell:
That his sister was Herzeleide, and with Gamuret she wed
And bare him for son the hero whose wanderings ye now have read.
390
For he rideth upon a journey that shall lead him a road unknown,
Tho' the grey knight but now had wended his way from the fountain
lone.

And he knew again the meadow, tho' now the snow lay white
On the ground that erst was blooming with flowers of springtide
bright.
'Twas before the rocky hillside where his hand must wipe away 395
The stain from Jeschuté's honour, and her husband's wrath allay.
Yet still the road led onward, to Fontaine-Sauvage, the name
Of the goal that should end his journey and his hermit host he came.

Then out spake the holy hermit, 'Alas, why doest thou so,
Sir Knight? at this Holy Season 'tis ill thus armed to go. 400
Dost thou bear perchance this harness thro' strife and danger dared?
Or hast thou unharmed ridden, and in peace on thy way hast fared?
Other robe had beseeemed thee better! List not to the voice of pride,
But draw thy rein here beside me, and with me for a space abide.

Not all too ill shalt thou fare here, thou canst warm thee beside my
fire.405

Dost thou seek here for knightly venture, and dost guerdon of love
desire,

If the power of true Love constrain thee, then love Him who Love
may claim!

As this day to His Love beareth witness, be His service to-day thine
aim,

And serve for the love of fair women, if it please thee, another day;
But now get thee from off thy charger, and awhile from thy
wanderings stay.'410

Then Parzival, e'en as he bade him, sprang lightly unto the ground;
Humbly he stood before him, as he told how he folk had found
Who had told of the hermit's dwelling, and the counsel he wisely
gave,

And he spake, 'I am one who hath sinnèd, and rede at thy lips I
crave!'

As he spake the hermit answered, 'Right gladly I'll counsel thee, 415
But, say, what folk hast thou met with? Who showed thee thy way to
me?

'In the wood I met with an old man grey-headed, and fair he spake,
And kindly, I ween, were his people, he bade me this road to take,
On his track my steed came hither.' Then answered the hermit old,
"Twas Kahenis, and his praises shall ever by men be told. 420

A prince of the land of Punturtois, and his sister Kareis' king
Hath taken to wife—Fairer maidens no mother to earth did bring
Than those maidens twain, his daughters, who met thee upon thy
road,

Of a royal house, yet yearly he seeketh this poor abode!'

Then Parzival spake to the hermit, 'Now say, when thou saw'st me
here,425

Didst thou shrink from my warlike coming, didst thou feel no touch
of fear?'

Quoth the hermit, 'Sir Knight, believe me, far oftener for stag or bear
Have I feared than I feared a man's face, in sooth shalt thou be aware
I fear me for no man living! Both cunning and skill have I,
And tho' I were loath to vaunt me, yet I ne'er to this life did fly430
For fear, as beseems a maiden! For never my heart did quail
When I faced as a knight my foeman, and ne'er did my courage fail,

In the days when such things became me, in the days when I too
might fight,
I was armèd as thou art armèd, like thee did I ride, a knight!
And I strove for high love's rewarding, and many an evil thought 435
With the pure mind within me battled, and ever my way I wrought
To win from a woman favour! All that was in time of yore,
And my body, by fasting wasted, remembereth those days no more.'

'Now give to mine hand the bridle, for there 'neath the rocky wall
Thy steed shall abide in safety, and we, ere the night shall fall, 440
Will gather of bough and herbage, since no better food may be,
Yet I trust that both thou and thy charger fare not all too ill with me!
But Parzival deemed that surely 'twas unfitting a hermit old
Should thus lead his steed, and the bridle he would fain from his
hand withhold,

'Now courtesy sure forbids thee to strive 'gainst thine host's good-
will, 445

Let not haste from the right path lead thee, but follow my counsel
still.'

In this wise spake the old man kindly, as he bade him, so did the
knight,

And the charger he led 'neath the hillside where but seldom did sun-
rays light.

In sooth 'twas a wondrous stable where the hermit the steed would
stall,

And thro' it, from heights o'erhanging, foamed ever a water-fall. 450

The snow lay beneath our hero, no weakling was he, I ween,
Else the frost and the cold of his harness o'er-much for his strength
had been.

To a cavern the hermit led him where no breath of wind might blow,
And a fire of coals had warmed it, and burned with a ruddy glow.
And here might the guest refresh him by the fire and a taper's
light, 455

(Well strewn was the ground with fuel,) then swiftly the gallant
knight

Laid from off him his heavy armour, and warmed his limbs so cold,
And his skin in the light glowed ruddy, and his face might the host
behold.

He might well be of wandering weary, for never a trodden way
Nor a roof save the stars of heaven had he known for many a day.

In the daylight the wood had he ridden, and his couch, it had been
the ground:

'Twas well that he here a shelter, and a kindly host had found!

Then his host cast a robe around him, and he took him by his right
hand,

And he led him into a cavern where his Missal did open stand.

And as fitted the Holy Season the Altar was stripped and bare; 465

And the shrine—Parzival must know it, 'twas the spot where he once
did swear

With true hand, true oath and faithful, that ended Jeschuté's woe,

And turned her tears to laughter, and taught her fresh joy to know!

Quoth Parzival, 'Well I know it this chapel and shrine! Of yore,

As hither my wanderings led me, an oath on that shrine I swore; 470

And a spear, with fair colours blazoned, that did here by the altar
stand

I bare hence, and in sooth, I think me, right well did it serve my
hand!

Men say it much honour brought me, yet I wot not if it be so,

For in thoughts of my wife had I lost me, and naught of the thing I
know.

Yet, unwitting, two jousts had I ridden, and two foemen I
overthrew, 475

In those days all men gave me honour, nor sorrow nor shame I knew.

Now, alas! is my sorrow greater than ever to man befell!

Say, when did I bear the spear hence? The days of my wanderings
tell!

'It was Taurian,' quoth the hermit, 'who his spear in my care did
leave,

And much did he mourn its losing, and I with the knight must
grieve. 480

And four years and a half and three days shall have passed since we
lost the spear,

Sir Knight, an my word thou doubttest, behold! it is written here!'

Then he showed unto him in the Psalter how the time it had come
and gone,

And the weeks and the years he read him that silent and swift had
flown.

And he spake, 'Now first do I learn them, the days that I aimless
stray, 485

And the weeks and the years that have vanished, since my joy hath
been reft away.'

And he spake, 'Now indeed me-seemeth that my bliss it was but a
dream,

For heavy the load of sorrow that so long hath my portion been!'

'And, Sir Host, I yet more would tell thee, where cloister or church
shall be

And men unto God give honour, there no eye hath looked on me,
490

And naught but strife have I sought me, tho' the time as thou sayst be
long,

For I against God bear hatred, and my wrath ever waxeth strong.

For my sorrow and shame hath He cherished, and He watched them
greater grow

Till too high they waxed, and my gladness, yet living, He buried
low!

And I think were God fain to help me other anchor my joy had found
495

Than this, which so deep hath sunk it, and with sorrow hath closed it
round.

A man's heart is mine, and sore wounded, it acheth, and acheth still,
Yet once was it glad and joyous, and free from all thought of ill!

Ere sorrow her crown of sorrow, thorn-woven, with stern hand
pressed

On the honour my hand had won me o'er many a foeman's crest! 500

And I do well to lay it on Him, the burden of this my shame,

Who can help if He will, nor withholdeth the aid that men fain would
claim,

But me alone, hath He helped not, whate'er men of Him may speak,

But ever He turneth from me, and His wrath on my head doth
wreak!'

Then the hermit beheld him sighing, 'Sir Knight, thou shalt put
away505

Such madness, and trust God better, for His help will He never stay.

And His aid to us here be given, yea, alike unto me and thee.

But' twere best thou shouldst sit beside me, and tell here thy tale to
me,

And make to me free confession—How first did this woe begin?

What foe shall have worked such folly that God should thine hatred
win?510

Yet first would I pray thee, courteous, to hearken the word I say,
For fain would I speak Him guiltless, ere yet thou thy plaint shall lay
'Gainst Him, Who denieth never unto sinful man His aid,
But ever hath answered truly, who truly to Him hath prayed.'

'Tho' a layman I was yet ever in books might I read and learn 515
How men, for His help so faithful, should ne'er from His service
turn.

Since aid He begrudged us never, lest our soul unto Hell should fall,
And as God Himself shall be faithful, be *thou* faithful whate'er
befall;

For false ways He ever hateth—and thankful we aye should be
When we think of the deed, so gracious, once wrought of His love so
free!520

For *our* sake the Lord of Heaven in the likeness of man was made,
And Truth is His name, and His nature, nor from Truth shall He e'er
have strayed.

And this shalt thou know most surely, God breaketh His faith with
none.

Teach thy thoughts ne'er from Him to waver, since Himself and His
ways are One!'

'Wouldst thou force thy God with thine anger? He who heareth that
thou hast sworn525

Hatred against thy Maker, he shall hold thee of wit forlorn!
Of Lucifer now bethink thee, and of those who must share his fall,
Bethink thee, the angel nature was free from all taint of gall,
Say, whence sprang that root of evil which spurred them to endless
strife,

And won its reward in Hell's torments, and the death of an outcast
life?530

Ashtaroth, Belcimon, and Belat, Rhadamant, yea, and many more!
Pride and anger the host of Heaven with Hell's colours have painted
o'er!'

'When Lucifer and his angels thus sped on their downward way,
To fill their place, a wonder God wrought from the earth and clay:
The son of His hands was Adam, and from flesh of Adam, Eve 535
He brought, and for Eve's transgression, I ween, all the world doth
grieve.

For she hearkened not her Creator, and she robbed us of our bliss.

And two sons sprang forth from her body, and the elder he wrought
amiss,

Since envy so worked upon him that from wrath there sprang
disgrace,

And of maidenhood did he rob her who was mother of all his race!

540

Here many a one doth question, an the tale be to him unknown,
How might such a thing have chanced? It came but by sin alone!

Quoth Parzival, 'Now, I think me that never such thing might be,
And 'twere better thou shouldst keep silence, than tell such a tale to
me!

For who should have borne the father, whose son, as thou sayest,
reft545

Maidenhood from his father's mother? Such riddle were better left!'
But the hermit again made answer, 'Now thy doubt will I put away,
O'er my falsehood thou canst bemoan thee if the thing be not truth I
say,

For the *Earth* was Adam's mother, of the *Earth* was Adam fed,
And I ween, tho' a man she bare here, yet still was the Earth a
maid.550

And here will I read the riddle, he who robbed her of maidenhood
Was Cain the son of Adam, who in wrath shed his brother's blood:
For as on the Earth, so stainless, the blood of the guiltless fell,
Her maidenhood fled for ever! And true is the tale I tell.

For wrath of man and envy, thro' Cain did they wake to life, 555
And ever from that day forward thro' his sin there ariseth strife.'

'Nor on earth shall aught be purer than a maiden undefiled,
Think how pure must be a maiden, since God was a Maiden's Child!
Two men have been born of maidens, and God hath the likeness ta'en
Of the son of the first Earth-Maiden, since to help us He aye was
fain.560

Thus grief alike and gladness from the seed of Adam spring,
Since He willed to be Son of Adam, Whose praises the angels sing.
And yet have we sin as our birthright, and sin's pain must we ever
bear,

Nor its power may we flee! Yet pity He feeleth for our despair,
Whose Strength is aye linked with Mercy, and with Mercy goes hand
in hand,565

And for man, as a Man, He suffered, and did falsehood by truth
withstand.'

'No longer be wroth with thy Maker! If thou wouldst not thy soul
were lost—

And here for thy sin do penance, nor longer thus rashly boast,
For he who, with words untamed, is fain to avenge his wrong,
His own mouth shall, I ween, speak his judgment ere ever the time
be long.570

Learn faith from the men of old-time, whose rede ever waxeth new,
For Plato alike and the Sibyls in their day spake words so true,
And long years ere the time had ripened His coming they did foretell
Who made for our sin's Atonement, and drew us from depths of Hell.
God's Hand from those torments took us, and God's Love lifted us on
high,575

But they who His love disdained, they yet in Hell's clutches lie!

'From the lips of the whole world's Lover came a message of love
and peace,
(For He is a Light all-lightening, and never His faith doth cease,)
And he to whom love He showeth, findeth aye in that Love his bliss,
Yet twofold I ween is the message, and His token some read amiss;
580

For the world may buy, as it pleaseth, God's Wrath or His Love so
great.

Say, which of the twain wilt thou choose here, shall thy guerdon be
Love or Hate?

For the sinner without repentance, he flieth God's faith and Face,
But he who his sin confesseth, doth find in His presence grace!

'From the shrine of his heart, who shall keep Him? Tho' hidden the
thought within,585

And secret, and thro' its darkness no sunbeam its way may win,
(For thought is a secret chamber, fast locked, tho' no lock it bear,)
Yet, tho' against man it be closed, God's light ever shineth there.
He pierceth the wall of darkness, and silent and swift His spring,
As no sound betrayed His coming, as no footstep was heard to ring,
590

So silent His way He goeth—And swift as our thoughts have flown,
Ere God passed of our heart the threshold, our thoughts unto Him
were known!

And the pure in heart He chooseth; he who doth an ill deed begin,
Since God knoweth the thoughts of all men, full sorely shall rue his
sin.

And the man who by deeds God's favour doth forfeit, what shall he
gain?595

Tho' the world count him honour-worthy, his soul seeketh rest in
vain.

And where wilt thou seek for shelter if *God* as thy foeman stand,
Who of wrath or of love giveth payment, as men serve Him, with
equal hand?

Thou art lost if thy God be against thee—If thou wouldst His favour
earn,

Then away from thy wrath and thy folly thy thoughts to His
goodness turn!'600

Quoth Parzival, 'Here I thank thee, from my heart, that such faithful
rede

Thou hast given of him who withholdeth from no man his rightful
meed,

But evil, as good, requiteth—Yet my youth hath been full of care,
And my faith hath but brought me sorrow, and ill to this day I fare!'

Then the hermit he looked on the Waleis, 'If a secret be not thy
grief,605

Right willing thy woe I'll hearken, I may bring thee perchance relief;
Of some counsel may I bethink me such as yet to thyself dost fail!'

Quoth Parzival, 'Of my sorrows the chiefest is for the Grail,
And then for my wife—none fairer e'er hung on a mother's breast,
For the twain is my heart yet yearning, with desire that ne'er findeth
rest.'610

Quoth his host, 'Well, Sir Knight, thou speakest, such sorrow is good
to bear;

If thus for the wife of thy bosom thy heart knoweth grief and care,
And Death find thee a faithful husband, tho' Hell vex thee with
torments dire

Yet thy pains shall be swiftly ended, God will draw thee from out
Hell-fire.

But if for the *Grail* thou grieveest, then much must I mourn thy
woe,615

O! foolish man, since fruitless thy labours, for thou shalt know
That none win the Grail save those only whose names are in Heaven
known,

They who to the Grail do service, they are chosen of God alone;
And mine eyes have surely seen this, and sooth is the word I say!'

Quoth Parzival, 'Thou hast been there?' 'Sir Knight,' quoth the
hermit, 'Yea!' 620
But never a word spake our hero of the marvels himself had seen,
But he asked of his host the story, and what men by 'The Grail'
should mean?
Spake the hermit, 'Full well do I know this, that many a knightly
hand
Serveth the Grail at Monsalväsche, and from thence, throughout all
the land,
On many a distant journey these gallant Templars fare, 625
Whether sorrow or joy befall them, for their sins they this penance
bear!'

'And this brotherhood so gallant, dost thou know what to them shall
give
Their life, and their strength and their valour—then know, by a *stone*
they live,
And that stone is both pure and precious—Its name hast thou never
heard?
Men call it *Lapis Exilis*—by its magic the wondrous bird, 630
The Phœnix, becometh ashes, and yet doth such virtue flow
From the stone, that afresh it riseth renewed from the ashes glow,
And the plumes that erewhile it moulted spring forth yet more fair
and bright—
And tho' faint be the man and feeble, yet the day that his failing sight
Beholdeth the stone, he dies not, nor can, till eight days be gone, 635
Nor his countenance wax less youthful—If one daily behold that
stone,
(If a man it shall be, or a maiden 'tis the same,) for a hundred years,
If they look on its power, their hair groweth not grey, and their face
appears
The same as when first they saw it, nor their flesh nor their bone
shall fail
But young they abide for ever—And this stone all men call the
Grail.' 640
'And Its holiest power, and the highest shall I ween be renewed to-
day,
For ever upon Good Friday a messenger takes her way.
From the height of the highest Heaven a Dove on her flight doth
wing,
And a Host, so white and holy, she unto the stone doth bring.
And she layeth It down upon It; and white as the Host the Dove 645

That, her errand done, swift wingeth her way to the Heaven above.
Thus ever upon Good Friday doth it chance as I tell to thee:
And the stone from the Host receiveth all good that on earth may be
Of food or of drink, the earth beareth as the fulness of Paradise.
All wild things in wood or in water, and all that 'neath Heaven
flies,650
To that brotherhood are they given, a pledge of God's favour fair,
For His servants He ever feedeth and the Grail for their needs doth
care!'

'Now hearken, the Grail's elect ones, say who doth their service
claim?
On the Grail, in a mystic writing, appeareth each chosen name,
If a man it shall be, or a maiden, whom God calls to this journey
blest.655
And the message no man effaceth, till all know the high behest,
But when all shall the name have read there, as it came, doth the
writing go:
As children the Grail doth call them, 'neath its shadow they wax and
grow.
And blessed shall be the mother whose child doth the summons hear,
Rich and poor alike rejoiceth when the messenger draweth near, 660
And the Grail son or daughter claimeth! They are gathered from
every land,
And ever from shame and sorrow are they sheltered, that holy band.
In Heaven is their rewarding, if so be that they needs must die,
Then bliss and desire's fulfilment are waiting them all on high!'

'They who took no part in the conflict, when Lucifer would fight 665
With the Three-in-One, those angels were cast forth from Heaven's
height.
To the earth they came at God's bidding, and that wondrous stone did
tend,
Nor was It less pure for their service, yet their task found at last an
end.
I know not if God forgave them, or if they yet deeper fell,
This one thing I know of a surety, what God doeth, He doeth well!
670
But ever since then to this service nor maiden nor knight shall fail,
For God calleth them all as shall please Him!—and so standeth it
with the Grail!'

Quoth Parzival, 'So, since knighthood may conquer, with spear and
shield,

Both the fame of *this* life, and the blessing which Paradise shall
yield,

Since my soul ever longed for knighthood, and I fought where'er
strife might be,675

And my right hand hath neared full often the guerdon of victory,
If God be the God of battles, if He know how a man should fight,
Let Him name me as one of His servants, of the Grail let Him make
me knight!

They shall own that I fear no danger, nor from strife would I turn
aside!

But the hermit made answer gently, 'First must thou beware of
pride,680

For lightly may youth mislead thee; and the grace of humility
Mayst thou lose, and the proud God doth punish, as full surely is
known to me!

And tears filled his eyes to o'erflowing, and his sad thoughts awhile
did turn

To a story of old, and our hero he bade from its lesson learn.

And he quoth, 'Sir Knight, at Monsalväsche a king reigned in days of
yore,685

His name all men know as Anfortas, and I weep for him evermore.
Yea, and thou too shalt mourn his sorrow, for bitter the woe, I ween,
And the torment of heart and body that his guerdon from pride hath
been.

For his youth and his worldly riches they led him an evil road,
And he sought for Frau Minne's favour in paths where no peace
abode.'690

'But the Grail all such ways forbiddeth, and both knight alike and
squire

Who serve the Grail must guard them from the lust of untamed
desire.

By meekness their pride must be conquered, if they look for a
heavenly prize,

And the brotherhood holdeth hidden the Grail from all stranger eyes:
By their warlike skill and prowess the folk from the lands around,
695

They keep afar, and none knoweth where the Grail and Its Burg are
found

Save those whom the Grail shall summon within Monsalväsch' wall

—

Yet *one*, uncalled, rode thither and evil did then befall,
For foolish he was, and witless, and sin-laden from thence did fare,
Since he asked not his host of his sorrow and the woe that he saw
him bear.700

No man would I blame, yet *this* man, I ween, for his sins must pay,
Since he asked not the longed-for question which all sorrow had put
away.

(Sore laden his host with suffering, earth knoweth no greater pain.)
And before him King Lähelein came there, and rode to the Lake
Brimbane.

Libbèals, the gallant hero, a joust there was fain to ride, 705
And Lähelein lifeless left him, on the grass by the water-side,
(Prienlaskors, methinks, was his birthplace) and his slayer then led
away

His charger, so men knew the evil thus wrought by his hand that day.'

'And I think me, Sir Knight, *thou* art Lähelein? For thou gavest unto
my care

A steed that such token showeth as the steeds of the Grail Knights
bear!710

For the white dove I see on its housing, from Monsalväsch it surely
came?

Such arms did Anfortas give them while joy yet was his and fame.
Their shields bare of old the token, Titurel gave it to his son
Frimutel, and such shield bare that hero when his death in a joust he
won.

For his wife did he love so dearly no woman was loved so well 715
By man, yet in truth and honour,—and the same men of thee shall
tell

If thou wakenest anew old customs, and thy wife from thine heart
dost love—

Hold thou fast to such fair example lest thy steps from the right path
rove!

And in sooth thou art wondrous like him who once o'er the Grail did
reign,

Say, what is thy race? whence art thou? and tell me I pray thy
name!'720

Each gazed for a space on the other, and thus quoth Parzival,
'Son am I to a king and hero who through knightly courage fell,

In a joust was he slain—Now I pray thee, Sir Hermit, of this thy
 grace,
That thou, in thy prayers henceforward, wilt give to his name a
 place.
Know, Gamuret, did they call him, and he came from fair Anjou—
 725

Sir Host I am not Lähelein; if ever such sin I knew
'Twas in my days of folly, yet in truth have I done the same,
Here I make of my guilt confession, and my sin unto thee I name,
For the prince who once fell a victim unto my sinful hand
Was he whom men called 'the Red Knight,' Prince Ither of
 Cumberland.730

On the greensward I lifeless stretched him, and as at my feet he lay,
Harness, and horse, and weapons, as my booty I bare away!

Spake the host as his words were ended, (the tale he ill pleased must
 hear,)

'Ah! world, wherefore deal thus with us? since sorrow and grief and
 fear

Far more than delight dost thou give us! Say, is this thy reward
 alone?735

For ever the song that thou singest doth end in a mournful tone!
And he spake, 'O thou son of my sister, what rede may I give to
 thee?

Since the knight thou hast slain in thy folly, thy flesh and thy blood
 was he!

If thou, blood-guiltiness bearing, shalt dare before God to stand,
For one blood were ye twain, to God's justice thy life shall repay
 thine hand.740

Say, for Ither of Gaheviess fallen, what payment dost think to give?
The crown he of knightly honour! God gave him, while he might
 live.

All that decketh man's life; for all evil his true heart did truly mourn,
True balsam was he of the faithful, to honour and glory born.
And shame fled before his coming, and truth in his heart did
 dwell,745

And for love of his lovely body many women shall hate thee well!
For well did they love his coming, and to serve them he aye was
 fain,

But their eyes that shone fair for his fairness he ne'er shall rejoice
 again!

Now, may God show His mercy to thee whose hand hath such evil
wrought,
Herzeleide the queen, thy mother, thou too to her death hast brought
—'750

'Nay! Nay! not so, holy father! What sayest thou?' quoth Parzival,
'Of what dost thou here accuse me? Were I king o'er the wondrous
Grail

Not all Its countless riches would repay me if this be sooth,
These words that thy lips have spoken! And yet if I, in very truth,
Be son unto thy sister, then show that thou mean'st me well, 755
And say, without fear or falsehood, are these things true that thou
dost tell?

Then the hermit he spake in answer, 'Ne'er learnt I to deceive,
Thy mother she died of sorrow in the day thou her side didst leave,
Such rewarding her love won for her! *Thou* wast the beast that hung
On her breast, the wingèd dragon that forth from her body sprung,
760

That spread its wings and left her: in a dream was it all foretold
Ere yet the sorrowing mother the babe to her breast did hold!

'And two other sisters had I, Schoisianè she was one;
She bare a child—Woe is me, her death thro' this birth she won!
Duke Kiot of Katelangen was her husband, and since that day 765
All wordly joy and honour he putteth from him away.
Siguné, their little daughter, was left to thy mother's care:
And sorrow for Schoisianè in my heart do I ever bear!
So true was her heart and faithful, an ark 'gainst the flood of sin.
A maiden, my other sister, her pure life doth honour win, 770
For the Grail she ever tendeth—Repanse de Schoie, her name,
Tho' none from Its place may move It whose heart showeth taint of
shame,

In *her* hands is It light as a feather—And brother unto us twain
Is Anfortas, by right of heirship he king o'er the Grail doth reign;
And he knoweth not joy, but sorrow, yet one hope I ween is his, 775
That his pain shall at last be turnèd to delight and to endless bliss.
And wondrous the tale of his sorrow, as, nephew, I'll tell to thee,
And if true be thine heart and faithful his grief shall thy sorrow be!

'When he died, Frimutel, our father, they chose them his eldest son
As Lord of the Grail and Its knighthood, thus Anfortas his kingdom
won, 780

And of riches and crown was he worthy, and we were but children
still—

When he came to the years of manhood, when love joyeth to work
her will

On the heart, and his lips were fringed with the down of early youth,
Frau Minne laid stress upon him who for torment hath little ruth.

But if love the Grail King seeketh other than he find writ, 785
'Tis a sin, and in sorrow and sighing full sore shall he pay for it!

'And my lord and brother chose him a lady for service fair,
Noble and true he deemed her, I say not what name she bare;
Well he fought in that lady's honour, and cowardice from him fled,
And his hand many a shield-rim shattered, by love's fire was he
venture led.790

So high stood his fame that no hero in knightly lands afar
Could he brook to be thought his equal, so mighty his deeds of war,
And his battle-cry was "Amor," yet it seemeth unto me
Not all too well such cry suiteth with a life of humility.'

'One day as the king rode lonely, in search of some venture high 795
(Sore trouble it brought upon us,) with love's payment for victory,
For love's burden lay heavy on him, in a joust was he wounded sore
With a poisoned spear, so that healing may be wrought on him
nevermore.

For thine uncle, the King Anfortas, he was smitten thro' the thigh
By a heathen who with him battled, for he jousted right skilfully. 800
He came from the land of Ethnisé, where forth from fair Paradise
Flow the streams of the River Tigris, and he thought him, that
heathen wise,

He should win the Grail, and should hold It—On his spear had he
graven his name,
From afar sought he deeds of knighthood, over sea and land he
came.

The fame of the Grail drew him thither, and evil for us his strife,805
His hand joy hath driven from us and clouded with grief our life!'

'But thine uncle had battled bravely and men praised his name that
day—

With the spear-shaft yet fast in his body he wended his homeward
way.

And weeping arose and wailing as he came once again to his own,

And dead on the field lay his foeman, nor did we for his death make
moan!'810

'When the king came, all pale and bloodless, and feeble of strength
and limb,

Then a leech stretched his hand to the spear-wound, and the iron he
found fast within,

With the hilt, wrought of reed, and hollow, and the twain from the
wound he drew.

Then I fell on my knees, and I vowed me to God, with a heart so
true,

That henceforward the pride of knighthood, and its fame, would I
know no more,815

If but God would behold my brother and would succour his need so
sore.

Then flesh, wine, and bread I forswore there, and all food that by
blood might live,

That lust might no longer move me my life I to God would give,

And I tell thee, O son of my sister, that the wailing arose anew

When my weapons I put from off me and ungirded my sword so
true, 820

And they spake, 'Who shall guard our mysteries? who shall watch
o'er the wondrous Grail?'

And tears fell from the eyes of the maidens, but their weeping might
naught avail!

'To the Grail, then, they bare Anfortas, if Its virtue might bring relief;

But, alas! when his eyes beheld It yet heavier waxed his grief

As the life sprang afresh within him, and he knew that he might not
die;825

And he liveth, while here I hide me in this life of humility,

And the power of the Grail, and Its glory, with their monarch have
waxen weak.

For the venom, his wound that poisoned, tho' the leeches their books
did seek

Yet found they nor help nor healing—Yea, all that their skill might
learn

'Gainst the poison of Aspis, Elkontius, of Liseis, and Ecidemon, 830

All spells 'gainst the worm empoisoned, 'gainst Jecis or Meàtris;

Or all that a wise man knoweth of roots or of herbs; I wis

Naught was there in all might help him; nor rede I a longer tale

Since *God* willeth not his healing what man's skill may aught avail?'

'Then we sent to the mystic waters, in a far-off land they rise, 835
Pison, Gihon, Tigris, Euphrates, the rivers of Paradise,
And so near they flow that the perfumes which breathe from its
scented air
Shall yet to their streams be wafted—If their waters perchance might
bear
Some plant from the wondrous garden that might succour us in our
woe,
But vain thought, and fruitless labour, fresh sorrow our heart did
know!'840

'Nor here did we end our labour, for again for the bough we sought
Which the Sibyl unto Æneas as a shield 'gainst Hell's dangers
brought.
'Gainst the smoke and the fire of Phlegethon, and the rivers that flow
in Hell
Would it guard, and for long we sought it, for we thought, if such
chance befell
That the spear in Hell-fire was welded, and the poison from Hell did
spring845
That thus of our joy had robbed us, then this bough might salvation
bring!'

'But Hell, it knew naught of the poison! There liveth a wondrous bird
Who loveth too well her fledglings—Of the Pelican's love we heard,
How she teareth her breast and feedeth her young with the
quickenings food
Of her own life-blood, and then dieth—So we took of that bird the
blood,850
Since we thought that her love might help us, and we laid it upon the
sore
As best we could—Yet, I wot well, no virtue for us it bore!'

'A strange beast, the Unicorn, liveth, and it doth in such honour keep
The heart of a spotless maiden that it oft at her knee will sleep.
And the heart of that beast we took us, and we took us the red-fire
stone855
That lies 'neath its horn, if the king's wound might its healing virtue
own.
And we laid on the wound the carbuncle, and we put it the wound
within,
Yet still was the sore empoisoned nor aid from the stone might win!'

'And sore with the king we sorrowed—Then a magic herb we found,
(Men say, from the blood of a dragon it springeth from out the
ground,)860

With the stars, and the wind, and the heaven, close-bound, doth it
win its power,
Lest perchance, by the flight of the dragon, when the stars bring the
circling hour,
And the moon draweth near to her changing, (for sorer then grows
the pain,)
The herb might our grief have aided—Yet its magic we sought in
vain!'

'Then the knights of the Grail knelt lowly, and for help to the Grail
they prayed,865

And, behold! the mystic writing, and a promise it brought of aid,
For a knight should come to the castle, and so soon as he asked the
king

Of the woe that so sorely pained him his question should healing
bring.

But let them beware, man or maiden, or child, should they warn the
knight

Of his task, he no healing bringeth, greater waxeth the sorrow's
might.870

And the writing it ran, 'Ye shall mark this, forewarning shall bring
but ill,

And in the first night of his coming must the healer his task fulfil,
Or the question shall lose its virtue; but if at the chosen hour
He shall speak, *his* shall be the kingdom, and the evil hath lost its
power.

So the hand of the Highest sendeth to Anfortas the end of woe, 875
Yet *King* shall he be no longer tho' healing and bliss he know.'

'Thus we read in the Grail that our sorrow should come to an end that
day

That the knight should come who the meaning of the grief that he
saw should pray—

Then salve of Nard we took us, and Teriak, and the wound we
dressed,

And we burnt wood of Lignum Aloe for so might the king find rest.
880

Yet ever he suffereth sorely—Then fled I unto this place,
And my life little gladness knoweth till my brother hath gotten grace.

And the knight, he hath come, and hath left us, and ill for us all that
day,
(But now did I speak of his coming,) sorrow-laden he rode away,
For he saw his host's woe and asked not, 'What aileth thee here, mine
host?'885
Since his folly such words forbade him great bliss shall he there have
lost!

Then awhile did they mourn together till the mid-day hour drew
near,
And the host spake, 'We must be seeking for food, and thine horse, I
fear,
As yet shall be lacking fodder; nor know I how we shall feed
If not God in His goodness show us the herbs that shall serve our
need,890
My kitchen but seldom smoketh! Forgive thou the lack to-day,
And abide here, so long as shall please thee, if thy journey shall
brook delay.
Of plants and of herbs would I teach thee much lore, if so be the
grass
Were not hidden by snow—God grant us that this cold may be soon
o'erpast—
Now break we yew-boughs for thy charger, far better its fare hath
been895
Erewhile 'neath the roof of Monsalväschan shall here be its lot I
ween!
Yet never a host shall ye meet with who rider alike and steed
Would as gladly bid share of his substance as I, had I all ye need!
Then the twain they went forth on their errand—Parzival for his
steed had care,
While the hermit for roots was seeking since no better might be their
fare;900
And the host his rule forgot not, he ate naught, whate'er he found,
Till the ninth hour, but ever hung them, as he drew them from out the
ground,
On the nearest shrub, and there left them; many days he but ill might
fare
For God's honour, since oft he lost them, the shrubs which his roots
did bear.

Nor grudged they aught of their labour: then they knelt by the
streamlet's flow,905

And the roots and the herbs they washed there, and no laughter their
lips might know.

Then their hands they washed, and the yew-boughs Parzival together
bound

And bare them unto his charger ere the cavern again he found;

Then the twain by the fireside sat them, nor further might food be
brought,

Nor on roast nor on boiled they fed them, nor found in their kitchen
aught.⁹¹⁰

Yet so true was the love and the honour Parzival to the hermit bare
That he deemed he enough had eaten, and no better had been his fare
With Gurnemanz of Graharz, or e'en in Monsalväscher hall,
When the maidens passed fair before him and the Grail fed them
each and all.

Then his kindly host quoth, 'Nephew, despise not this food, for
know⁹¹⁵

Lightly thou shalt not find one who shall favour and kindness show,
Of true heart, without fear of evil, as fain would I show to thee.'

And Parzival quoth, 'May God's favour henceforward ne'er light on
me

If food ever better pleased me, or I ate with a better will

What a host ever set before me, such fare doth content me still.' ⁹²⁰

Their hands they need not wash them for such food as before them
lay,

'Twas no fish, that their eyes had harmed as men oft are wont to say.

And were I or hawk or falcon I had lent me to the chase,

Nor stooped to the lure unwilling, nor fled from my master's face,

But an they no better fed me than at noontide they fed, these
twain,⁹²⁵

I had spread my wings right swiftly, nor come to their call again!

Why mock at this folk so faithful? 'Twas ever my way of old—

Yet ye know why, forsaking riches, they chose to them want and
cold,

And the lack of all things joyful, such sorrow and grief of heart

They bare of true heart, God-fearing, nor had they in falsehood part;

And thus from the hand of the Highest they won payment for grief
and woe,⁹³⁰

And alike should the twain God's favour, as of old, so hereafter
know.

Then up stood they again, and they gat them, Parzival and the holy
man,
To the steed in its rocky stable, and full sadly the host began
As he spake to the noble charger, 'Woe is me for thy scanty fare, 935
For the sake of the saddle upon thee and the token I see thee bear!'

When their care for the horse was ended, then sorrow sprang forth
anew,
Quoth Parzival, 'Host and uncle, my folly I needs must rue,
And fain would I tell the story if for shame I the word may speak;
Forgive me, I pray, of thy kindness, since in thee do I comfort
seek, 940
For sorely, I ween, have I sinnèd; if thou canst no comfort find
No peace may be mine, but for ever the chains of remorse shall bind.
Of true heart shalt thou mourn my folly—He who to Monsalväschr
rode,
He who saw Anfortas' sorrow, he who spake not the healing word,
'Twas I, child and heir of misfortune, 'twas I, Parzival, alone, 945
Ill have I wrought, and I know not how I may for such ill atone!'

Spake the hermit, 'Alas! my nephew, thou speakest the words of
woe,
Vanished our joy, and sorrow henceforth must we grasp and know,
Since folly of bliss betrayed thee: senses five did God give to thee,
And methinks, in the hour of thy testing, their counsel should better
be. 950
Why guarded they not thine honour, and thy love as a man to men,
In the hour that thou satst by Anfortas? Of a truth hadst thou spoken
then!'

'Nor would I deny thee counsel; mourn not for thy fault too sore,
Thou shalt, in a fitting measure, bewail thee, and grief give o'er.
For strange are the ways, and fitful, of mankind, oft is youth too
wise 955
And old age turneth back to folly, and darkened are wisdom's eyes,
And the fruit of a life lieth forfeit, while green youth doth wax old
and fade—
Not in this wise true worth shall be rooted, and payment in praise be
paid.
Thine youth would I see fresh blooming, and thine heart waxing
strong and bold,

While thou winnest anew thine honour, nor dost homage from God
withhold.960

For thus might it chance unto thee to win for thyself such fame
As shall make amends for thy sorrow, and God thee, as His knight,
shall claim!'

'Thro' my mouth would God teach thee wisdom; now say, didst thou
see the spear,

In that wondrous Burg of Monsalväsch? As ever the time draws near
When Saturn his journey endeth—(that time by the wound we know,
965

And yet by another token, by the fall of the summer snow)
Then sorely the frost doth pain him, thy king and uncle dear,
And deep in the wound empoisoned once more do they plunge the
spear,

One woe shall help the other, the spear cure the frost's sharp pain,
And crimson it grows with his life-blood ere men draw it forth
again!'970

'When the stars return in their orbit, then the wailing it waxeth sore,
When they stand in opposition, or each to the other draw.
And the moon, in its waxing and waning, it causeth him bitter pain—
In the time that I erst have told thee then the king little rest may gain;
His flesh thro' the frost it groweth colder than e'en the snow, 975
But men know that the spear sharp-pointed doth with fiery venom
glow,

And upon the wound they lay it, and the frost from his flesh so cold
It draweth, and lo! as crystals of glass to the spear doth hold,
And as ice to the iron it clingeth, and none looseth it from the blade.
Then Trebuchet the smith bethought him, in his wisdom two knives
he made,980

Of silver fair he wrought them, and sharp was the edge and keen—
(A spell on the king's sword written had taught him such skill I
ween,)

Tho' no flame on earth can kindle Asbestos, as men do tell,
And never a fire may harm it, if these crystals upon it fell
Then the flame would leap and kindle and burn with a fiery glow
985

Till th' Asbestos lay in ashes, such power doth this poison know!'

'The king, he rideth never, nor yet may he walk, or lie,
And he sitteth not, but, reclining, in tears his sad days pass by.

And the moon's changes work him evil—To a lake they call
Brimbane
They bear him full oft for fishing that the breezes may soothe his
pain.990
This he calleth his day for hunting, tho' what booty shall be his
share,
And he vex himself to gain it, for his host 'twould be meagre fare!
And from this there sprang the story that he should but a Fisher be,
Tho little he recked the fable, no merchant I ween was he
Of salmon or aye of lamprey, he had chosen far other game 995
Were he freed from the load of sorrow and the burden of bitter pain.'

Quoth Parzival, 'So I found him; the king's skiff at anchor lay,
And for pastime, e'en as a fisher, the even he wore away;
And many a mile had I ridden that day, since from Pelrapär
When the sun stood high in the heaven, at noontide I forth must
fare;1000
And at even I much bethought me where my shelter that night might
be,
Then my uncle did fair entreat me, and my host for a space was he.'

'A perilous way didst thou ride there,' spake the host, 'one that well
they guard
Those Templars, nor strength nor cunning brings a traveller thro'
their ward,
For danger full oft besets him, and oft he his life shall lose, 1005
Life against life is their penance, all quarter these knights refuse.'

'Yet scatheless I passed that woodland in the day that I found the
king
By the lake,' quoth the knight, 'and at even his palace with grief did
ring,
And sure, as they mourned, I think me, no folk ever mourned before!
In the hall rose the voice of wailing as a squire sprang within the
door,1010
And a spear in his hand he carried, and to each of the walls he stept,
Red with blood was the spear, as they saw it, the people they
mourned and wept.'

Then answered the host, 'Far sorer than before was the monarch's
pain,
In this wise did he learn the tidings that Saturn drew near again,

And the star with a sharp frost cometh, and it helpeth no whit to
lay1015
The spear on the sore as aforetime, in the wound must it plunge
always!
When that star standeth high in heaven the wound shall its coming
know
Afore, tho' the earth shall heed not, nor token of frost shall show.
But the cold it came, and the snow-flakes fell thick in the following
night
Tho' the season was spring, and the winter was vanquished by
summer's might.1020
As the frost to the king brought sorrow and pain, so his people true
Were of joy bereft, as the moment of his anguish thus nearer drew.'

And Trevezent quoth, 'In sorrow that folk hath both lot and part,
When the spear thro' the king's wound pierceth, it pierceth each
faithful heart.
And their love to their lord, and their sorrow, such tears from their
eyelids drew1025
That, methinks, in those bitter waters had they been baptized anew.'

Spake Parzival unto the hermit, 'Five-and-twenty they were, the
maids
I saw stand before the monarch, and courteous their part they
played.'
And the host spake, 'By God's high counsel such maidens alone avail
For the care of this wondrous mystery, and do service before the
Grail.1030
And the Grail, It chooseth strictly, and Its knights must be chaste and
pure,—
When the star standeth high in the heaven then grief must that folk
endure,
And the young they mourn as the aged, and God's wrath it lasts for
aye,
And ne'er to their supplication doth He hearken and answer "Yea."'

'And, nephew, this thing would I tell thee, and my word shalt thou
well believe,1035
They who to the Grail do service, they take, and again they give.
For they take to them tittle children, noble of birth and race—
If a land be without a ruler, and its people shall seek God's Face

And crave of His Hand a monarch, then He hearkeneth to their
prayer,
And a knight, from the Grail host chosen, as king to that land doth
fare.1040
And well shall he rule that people, and happy shall be that land,
For the blessing of God goeth with him and God's wisdom doth
guide his hand.'

'God sendeth the *men* in secret, but the *maidens* in light of day
Are given unto their husbands; thus none spake to his wooing, Nay,
When King Kastis wooed Herzeleide, but joyful our sister gave,
1045

Yet ne'er might her love rejoice him for Death dug at his feet a grave.
But in life had he given thy mother both Norgals and fair Waleis,
Those kingdoms twain and their cities, Kingrivals and Kanvoleis.
'Twas a fair gift, and known of all men—Then they rode on their
homeward way,
But Death met them upon their journey, and he made of the king his
prey,1050
And over both Waleis and Norgals Herzeleide, as queen, did reign,
Till Gamuret's right hand valiant won the maid, and her kingdoms
twain.'

'Thus the Grail Its maidens giveth, in the day, and the sight of men,
But It sendeth Its knights in the silence and their children It claims
again,—
To the host of the Grail are they counted, Grail servants they all shall
be,1055
So the will of God standeth written on the Grail for all men to see.'

'He who would to the Grail do service, he shall women's love
forswear:
A wife shall none have save the Grail king, and his wife a pure heart
must bear,
And those others whom God's Hand sendeth, as king, to a kingless
land—
But little I recked such counsel, to love's service I vowed my
hand,1060
As the pride of my youth constrained me, and the beauty of woman's
eyes,
And I rode full oft in her service, and I battled for knighthood's
prize.

Fain was I for wild adventure, on jousting no more I thought,
So fair shone the love-light on me ever fiercer the strife I sought.
And thro' far-off lands and distant, in the service of love I fared, 1065
And to win sweet love's rewarding right valiant the deeds I dared.
If heathen my foe or Christian, what mattered it unto me?
The fiercer the strife that beset me, the fairer my prize should be!'

'And thus, for the love of woman, in three parts of the earth I fought,
In Europe, and far-off Asia, and in Afric' I honour sought. 1070
If for gallant jousting I lusted I fought before Gaurivon;
By the mystic Mount of Fay-Morgan I many a joust have run.
And I fought by the Mount Agremontin, where are fiery men and
fierce,
Yet the other side they burn not tho' their spears thro' the shield can
pierce.
In Rohas I sought for ventures, and Slavs were my foemen then,
1075
With lances they came against me and I trow they were gallant men!'

'From Seville I took my journey, and I sailed o'er the tideless sea
Unto Sicily, since thro' Friant and Aquilea should my journey be.
Alas! alas! woe is me, for I met with thy father there,
I found him, and looked upon him, ere I from Seville must fare. 1080
For e'en as I came to the city he there for a space abode,
And my heart shall be sore for his journey, since thence to Bagdad
he rode,
And there, as thyself hast spoken, in a knightly joust he fell,
And for ever my heart must mourn him, and my tongue of his praises
tell!'

'A rich man shall be my brother, nor silver nor gold would spare
1085

When in secret I forth from Monsalväscht at his will and his word did
fare;

For I took me his royal signet, and to Karkobra I came,
Where Plimizöl to the wide sea floweth, and the land, Barbigöl, they
name.

And the Burg-grave he knew the token, ere I rode from the town
again

Of horses and squires, as failed me, he raised me a gallant train, 1090
And we rode thence to wild adventures, and to many a knightly
deed,

For nothing had he begrudged me of aught that might serve my need.

Alone came I unto the city, and there at my journey's end
Did I leave those who had fared thence with me, and alone to
Monsalväschen wend.'

'Now hearken to me, my nephew, when thy father first saw my face
1095

Of old in Seville's fair city, there did he such likeness trace
To his wife, fair Herzeleide, that he would me as brother claim,
Tho' never before had he seen me, and secret I held my name.
And in sooth was I fair to look on, as ever a man might be,
And my face by no beard was hidden; and sweetly he spake to me,
1100

When he sought me within my dwelling—Yet many an oath I swore
And many a word of denial, yet ever he pressed me more
Till in secret at last I told him, his kinsman was I in truth,
And greatly did he rejoice him when he knew that his words were
sooth!'

'A jewel he gave unto me, and I gave to him at his will; 1105
Thou sawest my shrine, green shall grass be, yet that shineth greener
still,

'Twas wrought from the stone he gave me—and a better gift he gave,
For his nephew as squire he left me, Prince Ither, the true and brave.
His heart such lore had taught him that falsehood his face did flee,
The King of Cumberland was he, who, thou sayest, was slain by
thee. 1110

Then no longer might we delay us, but we parted, alas! for aye.
He rode to the land of Baruch, unto Rohas I took my way.

'In Celli three weeks I battled, and I deemed 'twas enough for fame,
From Rohas I took my journey and unto Gandein I came,
(Twas that town from which first thy grandsire, his name of Gandein
did take,) 1115

And many a deed did Ither, and men of his prowess spake.
And the town lieth near the river, where Graien and Drave they meet,
And the waters I ween are golden,—there Ither found guerdon sweet,
For thine aunt, Lamire, she loved him, she was queen of that fair
land,

Gandein of Anjou, her father, he gave it unto her hand. 1120
And Lamire was her name, but her country shall be Styria to this day
—

And many a land must he traverse who seeketh for knightly fray.'

'It grieveth me sore for my red squire, men honoured me for his sake,
And Ither was thy near kinsman tho' of *that* thou small heed didst
take!

Yet God *He* hath not forgotten, and thy deed shall He count for
sin,1125

And I wot thou shalt first do penance ere thou to His peace shalt win.
And, weeping, this truth I tell thee, two mortal sins shall lie
On thine heart, thou hast slain thy kinsman, and thy mother, thro'
thee, must die.

And in sooth shalt thou sore bewail her; in the day thou didst leave
her side,

So great was her love, and faithful, that for grief at thy loss she
died.1130

Now do thou as here I rede thee, repent thee and pay sin's cost,
That thy conflict on earth well ended thy soul be not ever lost.'

Then the host he quoth full kindly, 'Nephew, now say the word,
Whence hast thou yon gallant charger? Not yet I the tale have heard!'
'In a joust, Sir Host, did I win it, when I rode from Siguné's cell1135
In a gallop I smote the rider and he from the saddle fell,
And the steed was mine, I rode hence,—from Monsalväsche he came,
the knight.'

Quoth the host, 'Is the man yet living who thus with thee did fight?'
'Yea, I saw him fly before me, and beside me stood his steed.'
'Nay, if thou in such wise dost bear thee thou art scant of wit
indeed!1140

The Grail-knights dost thou rob, and thinkest their friendship thereby
to win?'

'Nay, my uncle, in strife I won it, and he who shall count it sin
Let him ask how the thing hath chanced thus, 'twas a fair fight we
fought, we twain,
Nor was it for naught that I took it, for first had my steed been slain!'

Quoth Parzival, 'Who was the maiden who the Grail in her hands did
bear,1145

Her mantle, that eve, she lent me?'—Quoth the hermit, 'That lady fair
Is thine aunt, if her robe she lent thee of the loan shalt thou not be
vain,

For surely she deemed that hereafter thou shouldst there as monarch
reign.

And the Grail, and herself, yea and I too, should honour thee as our
lord:

And a gift didst thou take from thine uncle, for he gave thee, I ween,
a sword,1150
And sin hast thou won in the wearing, since thy lips, which to speak
are fain,
There spake not the mystic question which had loosened his sorrow's
chain,
And that sin shalt thou count to the other, for 'tis time that we lay us
down.
Nor couches nor cushions had they, but they laid them upon the
ground,
And for bedding the rushes served them—too humble, I ween, such
bed1155
For men of a race so noble, yet they deemed they were not ill-spiced.

Then twice seven days he abode there, with the hermit his lot did
share,
And the herb of the ground was his portion—yet he sought not for
better fare,
Right gladly he bare such hardness that should bring to him food so
sweet,
For as priest did his host absolve him, and as knight gave him
counsel meet!1160

Quoth Parzival to the hermit, 'Say who shall he be, who lay
Before the Grail? grey was he, yet his face it was as the day!'
Spake the host, 'Titurel thou sawest, and he shall grandsire be
To thy mother, first king and ruler of the Grail and Its knights was
he.
But a sickness hath fallen on him, and he lieth, nor findeth cure,1165
Yet his face on the Grail yet looketh, by Its power shall his life
endure!
Nor his countenance changeth colour, and his counsel shall aye be
wise—
In his youth he rode far and jousted, and won to him valour's prize.'

'An thou wouldst that thy life be adorned with true worth as thy
crown of fame,
Then ne'er mayst thou hate a woman, but shall honour, as knight, her
name,1170
For women and priests, thou knowest, unarmèd shall be their hand,
Yet the blessing of God watcheth o'er them, and as shield round the
priest doth stand;

For the priest, he careth for thee, that thine end may be free from ill,
So treat thou no priest as a foeman, but serve him with right good
will.

For naught on the earth thou seest that is like to his office high,1175
For he speaketh that word unto us which our peace and our life did
buy;

And his hand hath been blest for the holding of the pledge on the
altar laid,

To assure us of sin's forgiveness, and the price for our pardon paid.
And a priest who from sin doth guard him, and who to his Lord shall
give

Pure heart and pure hand for His service, say, what man shall holier
live?'1180

Now this day was their day of parting—Trevrezent to our hero
spake,

'Leave thou here thy sins behind thee, God shall me for thy surety
take,

And do thou as I have shown thee, be steadfast and true of heart!
Think ye with what grief and sorrow the twain did asunder part.

APPENDICES

APPENDIX A THE ANGEVIN ALLUSIONS OF THE 'PARZIVAL'

One of the most striking peculiarities of this version of the Perceval legend consists in the fact that the writer closely connects his hero with a contemporary princely house, and exercises considerable ingenuity in constructing a genealogy which shall establish a relationship alike with the legendary British race of Pendragon, and with the hereditary House of Anjou. Now, that Parzival should be represented as connected with Arthur is not surprising, taking into consideration the great popularity of the Arthurian legends; the English 'Sir Percyvelle' makes the relationship even closer; there, Percyvelle is Arthur's nephew, his sister's son; but it is far more difficult to account for the Angevin connection. It has been suggested that the writer of Wolfram's French source was Walter Mapes, to whom another of the Grail romances the *Queste* is generally ascribed; and who, as is well known, was closely attached to the Court of Henry Fitz-Empress, Count of Anjou, and King of England. Setting on one side the great difference, in style and treatment, between the *Parzival* and the *Queste*, which render it impossible to believe that the same man could have treated the same legend from two such practically opposite points of view, a close examination of the Angevin allusions found in the *Parzival* reveals a correspondence between the characters and incidents of the poem, and the facts, real and traditional, of Angevin history, which seems to point to a familiarity with the subject scarcely likely to be possessed by a foreigner.

The following parallels will show that this Angevin element, though strongest in the first two books (those peculiar to Wolfram's version), is to be clearly traced even in the presentment of what we know to be traditional features of the story.

THE ORIGIN OF THE HOUSE OF ANJOU

WOLFRAM

In Book I. the origin of the Angevin family Ascribes their origin to the marriage of one is traced to the marriage of Mazadan with of the early Counts with a lady of surpassing the fairy Terre-de-la-schoie. The fairy origin beauty, whose *demon* origin was discovered of the race is referred to again in Books II. by her inability to remain in church during and VIII., the later allusion being in Mass. It was to the influence of this connection with Vergulacht, son of ancestress that the uncontrollable temper of the Angevin princes was ascribed. Richard

ANGEVIN TRADITION

Cur-de-lion is reported to have frequently said, 'We came from the Devil, and we go

back to the Devil.' (In each instance it will be noted that the supernatural element is introduced by the wife.)

GAMURET

Younger son of the King of Anjou; brought up at the court of French queen; goes to the East where he marries a Moorish queen, and becomes king of an Eastern kingdom.

Gamuret's first recorded deed of valour is the conquest, in single combat, of Heuteger, the Scotchman, who appears every morning before the gates of Patelamunt, to challenge the besieged knights.

FULK V. OF ANJOU

Son of Fulk IV. (*Rechin*), and Bertalda de Montfort. His mother eloped with, and married, Philip, king of France. She remained on good terms with her former husband, and, Fulk, having already an heir by a previous wife, was allowed to bring up her son at her own court. The elder brother dying, Fulk became his father's heir, and finally succeeded him. In 1129, after the marriage of his son, Geoffrey, with the Empress Maud, Fulk was invited by Baldwin, king of Jerusalem, to become his son-in-law and successor. Accordingly he resigned Anjou to Geoffrey, went to Jerusalem, where he married Melesinda, daughter and heiress to Baldwin, and, after the death of the latter, succeeded him as king, and reigned till his death in 1142. (Here again we note that, in each instance, the Eastern kingdom is won through the wife.)

A similar incident is recorded of Geoffrey I. (*Grisegonelle*) who, during the siege of Paris by the Danes in 978, overthrew a gigantic Northman named Ethelwulf, who daily challenged the besieged in the manner recounted in the poem. Later historians cast doubts on the truth of this story, but it appears in all the old chronicles, and was undoubtedly firmly believed in by the writers of the twelfth century.

HERZELEIDE

Widow, queen of two kingdoms, and marries Prince of Anjou.

Her son is subsequently deprived of these kingdoms by the action of *one knight*, Book III. p. 73, two *brothers*, *Ibid.* p. 80. This loss of two kingdoms by the action of Lâhelein is insisted on throughout the poem, and the reader should note the manner in which the Lâhelein, though only appearing in the Second Book, is constantly referred to; which seems to indicate that the writer attached a special importance to this character, cf. Book III. pp. 86 and 87; V. pp. 150, 154; VI. pp. 171, 188; VII. p. 196; IX. p. 272. (It may be noted that in no other

THE EMPRESS MAUDE

Widow, Empress, Lady of two Lands, England and Normandy, marries Count of Anjou.

Her son is deprived of these two kingdoms by the action of two brothers Theobald and Stephen of Blois. Though Stephen was the principal aggressor, it must not be forgotten that Theobald, the elder brother, was invited by the Normans to become their Duke on the death of Henry I.; but on arriving in Normandy, and finding that Stephen had already seized the crown of England, Theobald resigned his claim to the Duchy and threw in his lot with that of Stephen. An *English* writer (such as Mapes) would probably have overlooked the part played by Theobald. An *Angevin*, knowing the Counts

version of the legend is a previous marriage of Blois to be the hereditary foes of the House of Anjou, would hardly fail to record the fact that both brothers were concerned in the usurpation of the rights of Henry Fitz-Empress.)

THE RED KNIGHT

The Red Knight as represented in the poem, mounted before the gates of Nantes, in red armour, with red hair.

NANTES

Nantes, throughout the poem, is always treated as Arthur's chief city. Karidöl is scarcely referred to, the Round Table is kept at Nantes, and in Book X. we are told that Arthur's palace was there. This is not the case in other versions of the story.

Book IX. relates that Kiot sought for records into close connection under Henry Fitz- of the Grail race in the chronicles of Britain, Empress, Count of Anjou, Duke of France, and Ireland, and found the history at Normandy, and King of England, the last in the chronicle of Anjou.

THE RED KNIGHT

This character is of course traditional, but the special presentment of it in the *Parzival* seems to be owing to Angevin influence. In 1048 William of Normandy, being at war with, Geoffrey II. of Anjou and besieging Domfront, sent him the following curious challenge: 'If the Count of Anjou attempts to bring victuals into Domfront he will find me awaiting him without the gates armed and mounted, bearing a red shield, and having a pennon on my spear wherewith to wipe his face.'

Red hair was a distinguishing characteristic of the Angevin Counts. Fulk I. derived his name of Rufus from this peculiarity, which was inherited by many of his descendants, among them Fulk V., his son Geoffrey Plantagenet, and his grandson Henry Fitz-Empress. The writer of the *Parzival* strongly insists on Ither's red hair.

NANTES

The possession of the city of Nantes was a constant source of quarrel between the Counts of Anjou and their neighbours of Brittany. Time after time the former claimed the over-lordship of Nantes, which stood just beyond their frontier, and more than once they succeeded in making themselves masters of the coveted territory. To represent Nantes as Arthur's chief city, and Ither as claiming it, would be an alteration of the legend most natural in an Angevin writer.

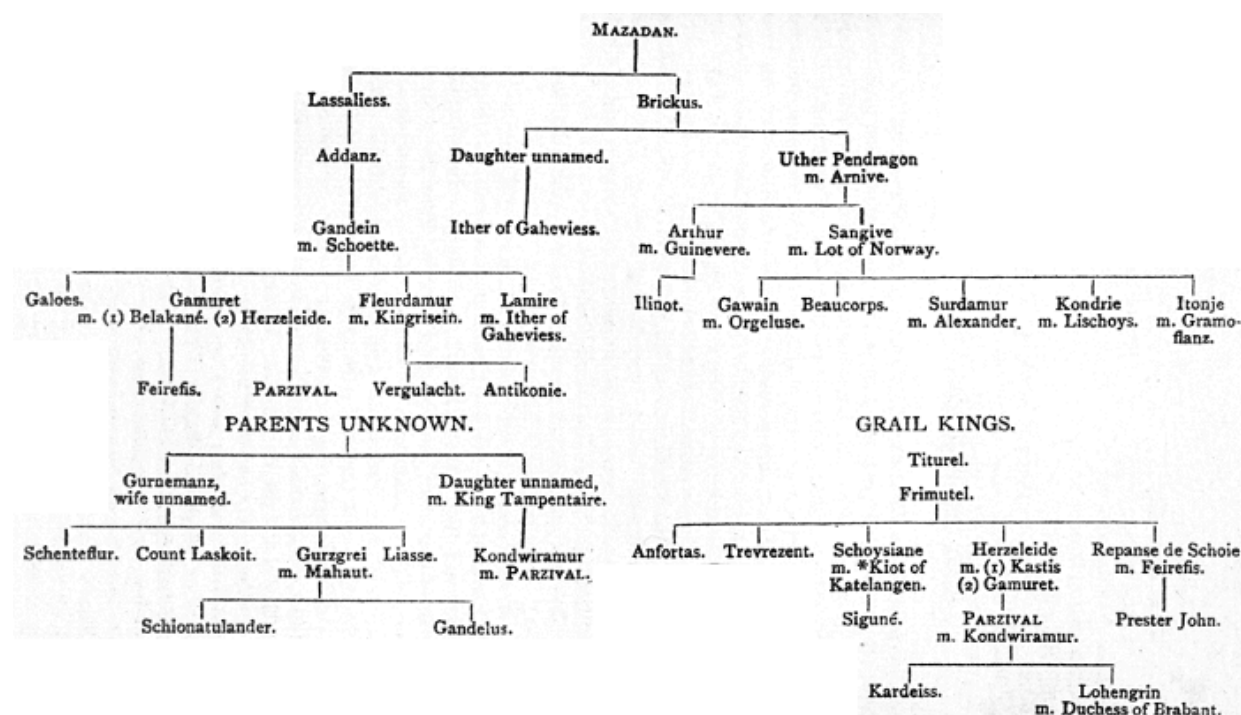
Britain, France, and Ireland were all brought into close connection under Henry Fitz- Empress, Count of Anjou, Duke of France, and Ireland, and found the history at Normandy, and King of England, the husband of Eleanor of Provence and Aquitaine, who conquered Ireland in 1172.

The peculiar presentment of the Knights of the Grail as Templars (Templeisen), having their residence in a castle surrounded by a forest, recalls the fact that a close connection between the Order of Templars and the House of Anjou had existed for some time previous to the date of this poem, a tax for the benefit of the Order having been imposed on all his dominions by Fulk V. on his return from his first pilgrimage to Jerusalem in 1120. A community of Knights Templars was founded by Henry Fitz-

Empress fifty years later at Vaubourg, in the forest of Roumare which became very famous. (The location of Monsalväs in the Pyrenees hardly seems to accord with the indications of the poem, which make it only thirty-six hours' ride from Nantes.)

Finally, the name of the poet claimed by Wolfram as his authority, Kiot=Guiot=Guy, is distinctly Angevin, the hereditary Angevin princely names being Fulk, Geoffrey, and Guy.

GENEALOGICAL TABLE.



MAZADAN.

Lassalies.

Addanz.

Gandein m. Schoettè.

Galoes.

Gamuret m. (1) Belakané.

Feirefis.

Gamuret m. (2) Herzeleide.

PARZIVAL.

Fleurdamur m. Kingrisein.

Vergulacht.

Antikonie.

Lamire m. Ither of Gaheviess.

Brickus.

Daughter unnamed.

Ither of Gaheviess.

Uther Pendragon m. Arnivè.

Arthur m. Guinevere.
Ilinot.
Sangivè m. Lot of Norway.
Gawain m. Orgeluse.
Beaucorps.
Surdamour m. Alexander.
Kondrie m. Lischois.
Itonjè m. Gramoflanz.

PARENTS UNKNOWN.

Gurnemanz, wife unnamed.
Schenteflur.
Count Laskoit.
Gurzgrei m. Mahaut.
Schionatulander.
Gandelus.
Liassé.
Daughter unnamed, m. King Tampentaire.
Kondwiramur m. PARZIVAL.

GRAIL KINGS.

Titurel.
Frimutel.
Anfortas.
Trevrezent.
Schoysiane m. [A] Kiot of Katelangen.
Siguné.
Herzeleide m. (1) Kastis.
Herzeleide m. (2) Gamuret.
PARZIVAL m. Kondwiramur.
Kardeiss.
Lohengrin m. Duchess of Brabant.
Repanse de Schoie m. Feirefis.
Prester John.

[A] Kiot is brother to King Tampentaire, cf. Book IV. p. 107, therefore Siguné is cousin to Kondwiramur as well as to Parzival.

APPENDIX B THE PROPER NAMES IN 'PARZIVAL'

One of the marked peculiarities of Wolfram's poem is the number of proper names with which it abounds, there being scarcely a character, however insignificant the rôle assigned, that is left unnamed. In the other versions of the Perceval legend this is not the case, consequently there are a vast number of names occurring in the *Parzival* to which no parallel can be found elsewhere, and which are no unimportant factor in determining the problem of the source from which Wolfram drew his poem. It would be impossible in a short Appendix to discuss the question in all its bearings, but the

following classification, based on Herr Bartsch's article on *Die Eigen-namen in Wolfram's Parzival*, will give some idea of the wide ground they cover:—

I. Names belonging to the original legend, and met with, with but little variation, in all versions. To this class belong the names of Pendragon, Arthur, Guinivere, Perceval, Gawain, Kay, Segramor; and the names of such places as Karidöl=Carduel=Carlisle, Cumberland, Waleis, Norgals, Dianasdron.

II. Names derived from a French version of the story, which may be divided into two classes:

(a) Names of which we find an equivalent in existing French sources, notably Chrétien, whose poem offers so close a parallel to the *Parzival*; examples of this class are Gurnemanz=French, *Gornemant*; Peirapär=*Beau-repaire*; Klamidé=*Clamadex*; Kingron=*Aguigrenon*; Trebuchet; Meljanz de Lys; Lippaut=*Tiebaut*; Gramoflanz=*Guiromelans* or *Guiremelanz*.

(b) Names formed by a misunderstanding of a French original: such are Soltane, from forest *soutaine*=solitary; Orilus de Lalande, from *Li orgueilleux de la lande*; and similarly, Orgeluse of Logrois, from *La orgueilleuse de Logres*; Gringuljet, the name of Gawain's horse, from *Li gringalet*, which is explained as meaning *cheval maigre et alerte*. Ligweiz-prelljus, is *Li guez perellous*, the Ford Perilous; and a notable instance of this class is the curious name Schionatulander, which is either '*Li joenet de la lande*,' 'The youth of the meadow,' or '*Li joenet à l'alant*,' 'The youth with the dog,' in allusion to the cause of the knight's death. Whence Wolfram took this name is unknown.

III. Names borrowed or quoted from other romances of the time, of those to which Wolfram alludes most frequently we know the *Erec* and *Iwein* of Hartmann von Aue; Eilhart's *Tristan*; Heinrich von Veldeck's *Æneid*, Chrétien de Troye's *Cligès*, and *Le Chevalier de la Charrette*; and the *Nibelungenlied* and *Dietrich Sage*. He also refers to other romances which have not come down to us, such are the allusions to adventures connected with Gawain in Book VI.; and to the death of Ilinot, son of King Arthur, of whom we know nothing. (The names derived from these romances are all noted, and their source given as they occur in the text.) Book I. contains some distinctly German names, such as Eisenhart, Hernant, and Herlindè, Friedebrand of Scotland and Heuteger, the source of these is doubtful, some occur in the Gudrun cycle, but it seems probable that in both instances they were derived from a common source, and, belonging as they do to a North Sea cycle, they may have reached the poem either through a French or a German medium.

IV. Names of places and people connected with Wolfram himself, such as Abenberg, Wildberg, Erfurt, the Count of Wertheim, Herman of Thuringia, etc. These were, of

course, introduced by Wolfram, and could not have existed in his French source.

V. Classical and mythological names such as Antikonie=Antigone, Ekuba, Secundilla, Plato and the Sibyls, Pythagoras, etc., Jupiter, Juno, Venus, Amor, Cupid, Lucifer, Ashtaroth, and other of the fallen angels.

VI. Oriental names. In Book IV. we have the Arabic names of the seven planets, a curious coincidence, in view of the alleged Arabic source of the Grail-myth as given in Books VIII. and IX. Names of cities such as Alexandria, Bagdad, Askalon. This latter is of course equivalent to *Escavalon* in the French versions, and the real name is doubtless Avalon, but it is by no means improbable that the change was made not by a misunderstanding, but by one who knew the Eastern city, and it falls in with the various other indications of crusading influence to be traced throughout the poem. We may add to these the names of Oriental materials such as Pfellel and Sendal. But when all these have been classified, there still remains a vast number of names undoubtedly French in origin, yet which cannot be referred to any known source, and many of which bear distinct traces of Romance or Provençal influence. Such names are Anfortas, French, *enfertez*=the sick man, with Prov. ending *as*; Trevrezent, Prov. *Treu*=peace, *rezems*=redeemed. Schoysiane, Prov. *Jauziana*, her husband is Kiot of Katelangen, *Guiot*=*Guy* of *Catalonia*. The son of Gurnemanz, Schenteflur, is Prov. *gente-flors*, fair flower. The name of Parzival's wife, Kondwiramur, Bartsch derives from *Coin de voire amour*, Ideal of true love; an interpretation which admirably expresses the union between the two. Itonjè, Gawain's sister, is the French *Idonie*, in Chrétien she is Clarissant. The knight slain by Lähelein at Brimbane is Libbèals of Prienlaskors, Libbèals being simply the old French *Li-beals*—*le bel*, and probably no more a proper name than Orilus, whilst his country seems derived from Prov. *priendre las cortz*, to seek the court. The long lists of conquered kings given in Book XV. contain many names of Greek or Latin origin, which have passed through a French source, and many others of distinctly Romance form. It is impossible to suppose that a German poet *invented* these names, and the only reasonable explanation seems to be that Wolfram drew largely, if not exclusively, from a French poem now lost, and that the language in which that poem was written partook strongly of a Provençal character, the term Provençal being applied, as Bartsch points out, not only to Provençal proper, but to the varying forms of the *Langue-d'oc*.

NOTES

NOTES

(A few Notes signed A. N. are due to Mr. Alfred Nutt.)

BOOK I

Introduction, lines 1-66. This introduction, which is confessedly obscure, both in style and thought, appears to have been written *after* the completion of the poem, and to have been intended by the writer to serve both as a key to the meaning of the poem, and as a defence of his method of treatment. That Wolfram was blamed by his contemporaries, notably by Gottfried von Strassbourg, for his lack of a polished style, and obscurity of thought, we know; and in *Willehalm* he speaks, in the following words, of the varying judgment passed upon his *Parzival*:—

'Swaz ich von Parzivâl gesprach,
des sîn aventiur mich wîste,
etzlich man daz prîste:
ir was ouch vil, diez smœthen
Und baz ir rede wæhten.

and it is evidently to these critics that the first part of the Introduction is addressed.

Lines 1-8 give the key to the whole poem: the contrast between doubt or unsteadfastness, and steadfast faith and truth, as imaged in the contrast between darkness and light, black and white. This idea runs throughout the poem, is worked out symbolically in the character and experiences of the hero, and is shown in a concrete form in the person of his brother Feirefis. The poet notes that many readers have failed, through lack of intelligence, to grasp the meaning of this parable, which is too swift and subtle for their comprehension. A parallel passage will be found in Book V. pp. 137, 138, where the figure employed is different.

The curious lines 15, 16 are explained by Bötticher as allusions to *personal* assaults made on the poet, which, by reason of the folly of the assailants, missed their mark, and are therefore to be treated with contempt.

Lines 29, 30 contain one of the quaint and homely similes which abound throughout the poem, and refer to the faithless man, *valsch geselleclîcher muot*, whose honour and steadfastness are not sufficiently strong to meet the demands made upon them.

There are three distinct divisions of the Introduction: the first, lines 1-30, is addressed to *men* only, and draws the contrast between the false and true knight; 31-49 does the same for *women*; while from 49 onwards the poet shows how the tale he is about to tell affects both sexes alike, and gives a slight sketch of the character of the hero. For the rightful understanding of this the lines 61, 62 are of great importance: 'a brave man, yet slowly wise Is he whom I hail my hero' (*er küene, trâctîche wîs, den helt ich alsus grüene*), and should be borne in mind by the student of the poem.

A full and minute discussion of this discussion of this Introduction will be found in Dr. Bötticher's *Das Hohelied von Rittersum*.

Page [5](#), line 67—'*Now they do to-day as of old-time.*' The word employed here *wälsch* simply means 'foreign,' but it is evident from the context that France is the country referred to. The *fact* was probably in the French source, the remarks upon it due to the German poet.

Page [5](#), line 80—'*Gamuret.*' The origin of this name is doubtful; in Chrétien we find a King Ban de Gomeret mentioned, and Wolfram may have derived the name from a French source, Heinmel suggests that it comes from Gamor, the son of Anguis, a Saracen prince ruling in Denmark, according to 'Arthur and Merlin;' and that the fact of his being of the race of Anguis suggested to Kiot the possibility of making him an Angevin. In the absence of any definite knowledge as to Wolfram's source it is not possible to do more than *suggest* possible derivations.

Page [7](#), lines 136, 137—'*Gylstram and Rankulat.*' With regard to the first-named place, Simrock says it has been identified with 'Gustrate' in the *Gudrun*, and, according to Grimm, this latter is to be coupled with Gailate, 'where the sun hath its setting.' *i.e.* the West. In Book XI. the patriarch of Rankulat is referred to, in company with the Baruch of Bagdad and the Emperor of Constantinople, and in all probability Armenia is meant. The king's speech therefore implies, 'Didst thou come from the furthest bounds of the earth, East or West.'

Page [8](#), line 154—'*King Gandein's son.*' Cf. Book IX. p. 285, where the origin of the name Gandein is given.

Page [8](#), lines 159, 160.—'*Then the tale it hath told a lie.*' Cf. Book IX. p. 259.

Page [8](#), lines 169, 170—'*Rich silk of Orient*' Eastern materials are referred to frequently throughout the poem; the principal seem to have been, Samite, Sendal, Achmardi, Pfellel, Plialt, and Saranthasme. Of these, some were of silk only, others, notably Saranthasme of silk inwoven with gold, Achmardi, in this poem, is always *green*. Samite and Sendal are the two generally named in our English romances.

Page [9](#), line 209—'*Two brothers of Babylon.*' This is Babylon in Egypt, now Cairo, as is evident from its close connection with Alexandria, cf. p. 12, line 277, and Book II. p. 57, line 684, and p. 59, line 754. Though, from the passage on p. [57](#), it seems as if the poet confused it with Babylon in

Assyria; it is possible that he was unaware of the fact that there were two cities of the name.

Page [15](#), line 384—'*Friedebrand*.' The introduction of names of distinctly northern origin such as Friedebrand, Hernant, and Herlindè, Heuteger, and Eisenhart, has been already noted in Appendix B as one of the problems of the *Parzival*. Two solutions have been suggested, either that they were introduced by Wolfram, or that they reached the *French* source through the medium of Normandy. The form in which the names occur in the *Gudrun* cycle seems to indicate quotation from a source known also to the writer of the *Parzival*, but they are not derived directly from the North Sea saga in its present form.

Page [16](#), line 403—'*Wouldst thou know?*' etc. It may be interesting to note here that beyond the *colour*, which the poet insists on, he apparently recognises no difference between the heathen and Christian knights and ladies. Both acknowledge the same chivalrous ideals; both are equally familiar with the eccentricities of 'Minne-dienst' (cf. line 423); and the speeches put into the mouth of Belakané, or of Rassalig, would be quite as suitable if spoken by Orgeluse, or by one of King Arthur's knights. This incident of a Christian knight marrying a Moorish princess is of frequent occurrence in Mediaeval romance.

Page [16](#), lines 423, 424—'*That which like to a hall doth stand*.' The tents of the Mediaeval period were constructed of far more costly fabrics than is usual now, cf. Book III. p. 74. and Book XI., and their size was very great, this special tent we find, from Book II. p. 36, was 'thirty pack-steeds' burden.' San Marte quotes the description of a tent captured by the Crusaders at Antioch which was adorned with walls, towers, and ramparts, contained halls and galleries, and could lodge as many as 2000 men.

Page [22](#), line 620—'*The chiming of sweet bells*.' Bells were at one time freely used not only as ornaments to the trappings of the horses but also on the armour of the knights, cf. Book III. p. 70, and Book VI. p. 163. Gradually they disappeared from use, and the bells on the Fool's dress are the last trace left of the practice, which from this poem was evidently very general at the beginning of the thirteenth century.

Page [23](#), line 623—'*Brave Beaucorps*.' This brother of Gawain appears in Book VI. p. 183, he is the only one of Gawain's brothers mentioned in this

poem. In Malory, we find *Gareth* called 'Beau-mains,' and it is possible that the two are identical. Beaucorps is evidently much younger than Gawain, and Gareth was the youngest of King Lot's sons.

Page [24](#), line 679—'*Lahfilirost*.' This seems to be a misunderstanding for '*Le fils du Rost*,' and may be classed with the misinterpretations of a French source.

Page [25](#), line 700—'*Frau Minne*.' The word *Minne* is etymologically derivable from a root 'man,' and is connected with the Latin *mens*, English 'mind' (cf. 'to have a mind to.') The original signification was that of tender care, or thought for; in Old High German it has already taken the meaning of love in its passionate aspects; finally, in Middle High German (the original language of the *Parzival*), it has become the standing expression for love betwixt man and woman. We have it in various forms as a verb, *Minnen*; as an adjective, *Minniglich*. The personification of the passion of Love as 'Frau Minne' is the work of the courtly poets of the twelfth century, and seems rather to have been derived from classical analogy than to be due to a reminiscence of an early German goddess of Love. Also, with Wolfram and his contemporaries, 'Frau Minne' must be regarded less as the personification of Love in the abstract than as the embodiment of the special love-ideal of the day. This new ideal had its rise, and assumed definite shape in twelfth century France, from whence it spread throughout the knightly society of Christendom, finding its fullest literary expression in the Arthurian romances. The historic causes which led to what was at the time an entirely novel mode of considering the relations between the sexes, and the true nature and ethical import of the chivalric conception of that relation will be briefly discussed in an Appendix to vol. II. The significance of the term is fully apparent from such passages as the present, also cf. Book VI. pp. 161, 163, 165, 171; VII. 208, 224; XII. etc.—[A. N.]

Page [27](#), line 768.—'*Morhold*,' also in Book II. p. 39. This is, of course, the well-known hero in *Tristan*. The allusion may have been in the original French source, or introduced by Wolfram, who would know Morhold from the *Tristan* of Eilhart von Oberge, composed before 1180. The most famous German poem on the subject, the *Tristan* of Gottfried von Strassbourg, was somewhat later in date.

Page [31](#), lines 886, 887—Cf. Book VIII. p. 230 and note.

Page [31](#), line 904—'*Feirefis*.' Bartsch interprets the name as *vair fils*, 'parti-coloured son.' Other critics have suggested 'Fairy's son.' The name distinctly indicates a French origin.

Page [31](#), line 905—'A *woodland-waster*,' 'wald-verschwender,' a hyperbolical term constantly employed throughout this poem to denote one who shatters many spears in fight.

BOOK II

Page [35](#), line 16, and page [57](#), line 705—'*Waleis and Norgals*.' These, the two kingdoms of Queen Herzeleide, are located by Wolfram in Spain, but they are undoubtedly Wales and North Wales (the North galis of Malory), the Northern border-land. Parzival's title throughout the poem is *der Waleis*, in French versions *le Gallois*, an evident indication of the Celtic origin of the story.

Page [39](#), lines 117-160. Of the heroes taking part in the Tourney, Uther Pendragon has been mentioned, in Book I. p. 31, in the genealogy of Gamuret. The poet carefully connects his hero with the traditional royal race of Briton as well as with the princely House of Anjou. Arthur's mother, Arnivè (not Igraine as in most versions), plays a somewhat important rôle in the later part of the poem, her imprisonment in the castle of the Magician Klingsor is fully treated of, cf. from Book XI. onwards. King Lot of Norway (not of Orkney as in the English legend) is frequently alluded to as Gawain's father, but both he and Uther Pendragon are dead before the real action of the poem commences. This is the first appearance of Gawain, who, from Book VI. onward, plays a part in the poem scarcely inferior to that of the hero, Parzival. The Kings of Arragon and Gascony do not appear again, nor are they alluded to, but Brandelidelein of Punturtois we meet with in Book XV. as the uncle of King Gramoflanz. The King of Askalon must not be confused with Vergulacht, in Book VIII., this is evidently one of his predecessors. Eidegast of Logrois is frequently alluded to later on, his murder by Gramoflanz and the desire of his lady-love, Orgeluse, to avenge him, form the *motif* of the later Gawain episodes. This is the only occasion on which Lähelein appears personally in the poem, but he is constantly alluded to throughout the course of the story (some remarks on the manner in which he is introduced will be found in Appendix A, p. [293](#)). Morhold,

cf. note to Book I. Lambekein, cf. Book V. p. 152. Gurnemanz of Graharz plays an important rôle in the Parzival legend, he is here introduced for the first time, cf. Book III.

The Tourney. In this poem we find knightly skill in horsemanship and the use of arms displayed under three distinct forms: the Buhurd, Books XII. and XV., The Tourney, Book II., and serious Warfare as in the siege of Pelrapär, Book IV., and of Beausosch, Book VII. The two first were simply intended as displays of knightly skill, and took their rise in the knightly sports of the ninth century. The Buhurd seems to have been the original German form, and at first was of a somewhat rough and uncivilised character, the knights riding in bodies at full gallop against each other, and the whole being a display of force rather than of skill.

The Tourney, or Tournament, took its rise in France, and here we find the knights, in full armour, singly displaying their prowess. Gradually the Buhurd changed its character, and throughout this poem we find Wolfram treating it as a formal display of skill in horsemanship, generally to do honour to some favoured guest, as in the reception of Gawain and Orgeluse by the knights of the Château Merveil, Book XII.; in honour of Feirefis, Book XV. Still the idea of force was not entirely eliminated, and we find Gawain, in Book VII. when he promises the child Obilot that he will fight for her father, telling her that *she* must ride the Buhurd for him, and, as noted above, the fighting here is in earnest. In the later form of Buhurd the knights wear no armour, and it is thus distinguished from the Tourney, where they were always fully armed.

The Tourney was much more complicated in its rules, and is not always easy to distinguish from the real warfare into which it not unfrequently passed. Feirefis, in Book XV., mentions *five* modes of attack which seem to have answered to the regular stages of a Tourney. Niedner explains them as follows: (1) An attack by one troop on another, with lance in rest; (2) An attack from the side, also with lance; (3) The onslaught of *one* rider on a troop of horsemen, in which the aim was to strike the one selected opponent while avoiding the blows of the others; (4) The joust proper, or single combat; (5) The *Damenstick*, a stroke for the honour of the knight's chosen lady, which followed on the joust, and was specially challenged by knights of exceptional valour. In the Tourney at Kanvoleis (the only Tourney proper in the poem), it is the two first stages in which Gamuret takes no part, he

only mingles in the fray when the time arrives to display the valour of the single champions. The joust, or single combat, was a feature of earnest, as of mimic, warfare, and it is not always easy to distinguish between the two.

In each case the great point was the display of skill in horsemanship, and the use of the lance or spear. The knights rode at full speed towards each other, and the aim of each was to strike his opponent in the centre of the shield, 'The four nails,' Book III. p. 98, or at the fastening of the helmet, Book IX. p. 257, and Book XII. In either event if the blow was well aimed, and delivered with sufficient force, the knight was thrown backward off his steed. It might happen that both knights were struck, and succeeded in keeping their seat, while their spears were shivered, then a second joust must be ridden. If either knight were thrown from his saddle, or his steed fell with him, then he was held to be vanquished, but if, as not unfrequently happened, the girth of the saddle broke, and the rider were thrown, *then* the joust was held to be undecided, and, in the case of real warfare, the issue was fought out with swords on foot. Cf. the combat between Parzival and Klamidé, Book IV. pp. 119, 120. In Book V. we find Parzival and Orilus fighting with swords on horseback: this is unusual. In real warfare the knights would fight till one was slain, or till the issue was indisputably decided by one being felled to the ground. We occasionally find the combat decided by sheer strength of arm, one knight clasping the other and throwing him to the ground; so Parzival conquers Orilus, Book V. p. 149, and Gawain, Lischois, Book X. Both in Tourney and real warfare the fight was generally closed by the vanquished giving his pledge or surety to the victor, who not unfrequently sent him to yield himself prisoner to some favoured lady, so Parzival sends Kingron, Klamidé, and Orilus to Kunnewaaré. If the vanquished knight refused to yield he would be slain, but this did not often happen. The death of Ither of Gaheviess is due to a mischance. Armour and horse were the prize of the victor, though in the case of the foe being slain it seems to have been thought an unknighly deed to take them, such 'robbery of the dead' was termed *rêroup*, and Trevrezent, Book IX. p. 273, strongly blames both Lähelein and Parzival for such action.

The Tourney would often be held simply for honour, the prize being something comparatively trifling, such as a hawk, cf. Tourney at Kanedig, alluded to in Book III. p. 77, and again in Book V. p. 155, but occasionally

the guerdon was far higher, as at Kanvoleis where the band and kingdoms of Queen Herzeleide were the prize of the victor. Any disputes would be referred to a court of judges from whose verdict there was no appeal. In such Tournaments it was customary not to retain the horse and armour, but to accept a ransom fixed by the *owner*. This is evidently alluded to in Book II. 45, where we find these rules disregarded in the heat of conflict.

Opposed to this Tourney 'for honour' was the Tourney 'for booty,' when the aim of the knights was to capture as many steeds and make as many prisoners as possible, the ransom being fixed by the *captor*. Wolfram does not mention such a Tourney, but with the decay of knighthood such conflicts appear to have almost entirely displaced the nobler strife. It will be understood, of course, that though a joust or single combat might either be settled beforehand, as in the case of Kingrimursel's and Gramoflanz' challenge to Gawain, or be brought about by a chance meeting, as when Vergulacht and the knight of Monsalväscht fight with Parzival, a Tourney was carefully arranged beforehand, and the knights summoned by invitation. The knights generally assembled on the Saturday, and the Tourney would be held on the Monday, the interval being employed in careful inquiry as to the claim of those present to take a part in such knightly sport. The knights were divided into two bodies of equal strength, headed by the most experienced warriors present, and single champions would not unfrequently try their skill against each other on the eve of the Tourney proper. Not unfrequently the passions of the knights were roused to such a pitch that this *Vesper-spiel* became a serious encounter, and the combatants were so exhausted that the Tourney could not be held, as was the case at Kanvoleis. From the abuses connected with these meetings, which not unfrequently lapsed into serious warfare, and caused wanton loss of life, they were looked upon with disfavour by the Church, and in some cases were positively forbidden.

Page [42](#), line 236—'*Rivalein*,' according to Eilhart, the father of Tristan.

Page [44](#), line 279—'*I have named unto ye a lady*.' This is the queen of France, Anflisé, whose connection with Gamuret is alluded to in Book I. p. 9. This episode was probably suggested by facts in Angevin history, cf. Appendix. A reference to their connection will be found in Book VIII. p. 233.

Page [46](#), lines 351-60. Galoes the king of Anjou has not been named before. The name occurs in Hartmann's *Erec*, and may have been borrowed from there. The name of his lady-love is given in Book VII. p. 199. The slayer of Galoes was Orilus, Book III. p. 77.

Page [48](#), line 406—'*No wife was she but a maiden.*' Book IX. p. 283, where a full account of Herzeleide's marriage will be found, '*Herzeleide.*' The modern German rendering of this name carries with it its own interpretation in the play of words familiar through Wagner's *Parsifal*, '*Ihr brach das Leid das Herz und Herzeleide starb.*' But the original form, Herzeloyde, indicates, in Bartsch's opinion, a Southern French modification, *loyde* being a variant of *hildis*, *oildis*. The name Rischoydè, we know in its form of Richilda, and Herzeloyde seems to come from the same root. Professor Rhys (*Arthurian Romance*, p. 180) has suggested derivation from the Welsh *argelwythes* = 'the lady,' but the suggestion has not won general acceptance.

Page [54](#), line 614—'*The maid and her lands he won.*' Readers will doubtless remark the fact that though we meet with numerous allusions to marriages and marriage festivities throughout the poem, yet in no single instance is the marriage attended by a religious ceremony. This is an indication of the original date of the story, which testifies to a very early stage of social development. The original idea of marriage was that of a contract made by mutual consent publicly before witnesses, as we find here in the marriages of Gamuret with Belakané and Herzeleide, or later on in Book IV., the marriage of Parzival and Kondwiramur. The mutual promise being given and witnessed, the contract was complete, and the marriage might be consummated at once. The office of the Church seems at first to have been confined to conferring a benediction on a union already completed, and therefore we find that, even so late as the thirteenth century, the religious ceremony followed, and did not precede, the marriage night. San Marte, in his note on the subject, quotes more than one romance of this date where this is the case, and it was not till the idea of marriage as a sacrament had displaced that of marriage as a civil contract that the religious ceremony became essential to a valid union. The fact that Wolfram, with his high ideas of the binding nature of the marriage-vow, never once mentions the religious ceremony is a strong argument in favour of the presumption that the subject-matter of the *Parzival* is considerably older than his treatment of it. Marriage between a Christian and a heathen was held to be null and void,

and, according to the ideas of the age, Herzeleide was fully within her rights in claiming Gamuret as her husband and in regarding his previous marriage as non-existent. The costly presents made by the bridegroom, as for instance the gift of Waleis and Norgals to Herzeleide by her first husband, seem to have been a survival of the idea that the woman was property, to be bought by the intending husband. The bride, on her part, gave equally rich gifts, so we find Kondwiramur bestowing castles and lands on Parzival, and the mutual interchange of these gifts was an essential part of the marriage contract.

Page [56](#), line 674—'*The panther*.' The badge of the House of Anjou was a leopard.

Page [59](#), lines 744, 745. The idea that a diamond might be softened by the application of a he-goat's blood is very old. San Marte says it is mentioned by Pliny. Hartmann refers to it in his *Erec*, and it seems to have been a general belief in the Middle Ages.

BOOK III

The first two books of this poem are peculiar to Wolfram. Among the different versions of the Perceval legend which we possess there is a curious diversity of statement as to the parentage of the hero; though, as a rule, they agree in the main facts of the death of his father, either before, or shortly after, Perceval's birth, and his being brought up in the desert by his widowed mother.

With the Third Book we find ourselves on ground common to most transcribers of the legend; and in this and the following books a table of the traditional events contained in the book, with the other versions of the story in which they occur, will be given. The following are the Romances of the Grail-cycle which deal more particularly with the Perceval legend.—

Li Conte del Graal, poem by Chrétien de Troyes; left unfinished at Chrétien's death; it was continued by three other writers; the poem as we have it, is the work of at least four different hands.

Peredur: Welsh tale found in the Red Book of Hergest.

Perceval: A French prose romance, ascribed by many critics to Robert de Borron.

Sir Percyvelle of Galles: English metrical romance—author unknown.

Perceval li Gallois: French prose romance, also by an unknown writer.

TRADITIONAL EVENTS

The son of a widowed mother; Brought up in the desert; Meeting with knights and departure for Arthur's court.	Chrétien: Peredur; Sir Percyvelle.
Meeting with Jeschuté. 'The Lady of the Tent.'	<i>Ibid.</i>
Meeting with Siguné.	In this place only in <i>Perceval</i> , later meeting in the other versions.
Arrives at Arthur's court and demands knighthood.	All the versions.
Meeting with the Red Knight; slays him; and takes his armour.	Chrétien: Peredur, and Sir Percyvelle closely agree as to the meeting. All agree as to the wearing of the red armour. In <i>Perceval</i> , alone, hero does not kill the knight who originally owns it.
Laughter of Kunnewaaré; speech of Antanor and their smiting by Kay.	Chrétien: maiden and fool; Peredur; dwarf and companion.
Arrival at castle of old knight, who counsels hero.	Chrétien: Sir Percyvelle.

(It will be found that, from Books III. to XIII. inclusive, there is a very close parallelism between Wolfram's poem and Chrétien's share of *Li Conte del Graal*.)

Introduction, lines 1-45. This introduction, like that to Book I., appears to have been written *after* the completion of the poem, and to have been intended by the poet as a defence of his attitude towards women; certainly the lines 12-15 presuppose certain statements which had aroused the wrath of the lady hearers of the poet. The whole passage is interesting on account of its strongly personal character. In Book VI. Wolfram refers more than once to the lady who has wronged him (pp. 163, 166, 191), and in terms that show, as here, that he bitterly resented her treatment. The line 'Born was I unto the bearing of knightly shield and spear,' is the only definite

statement as to the poet's rank in life which we possess, and in the light of his lasting fame as a poet it is curious to find him holding his gift of song as of less account than his knightly deeds, which do not seem to have been more remarkable than those of his fellows.

From Book IV. p. 122, we learn that Wolfram was married, and, from the concluding lines of Books VI. and XVI., it is clear that the *Parzival* was composed with a view to winning, or retaining, the favour of a lady, but the only direct personal allusion throughout the entire poem is that to the Margravine of Heitstein in Book VIII. p. 232, and the passage is too vague to allow of our identifying the lady named either with Wolfram's faithless love, or with her for whose sake he composed his poem; certainly the Margravine was not his wife.

Page [67](#), line 61—'*Soltanè's strand*.' This is one of the many instances in the poem in which an adjective has been taken as a proper name. In the French source it was undoubtedly an adjective meaning 'solitary,' 'waste.' In Chrétien we find *la gaste forest soltaine*; other versions speak of the woods, or the desert, none but this gives a proper name.

Page [69](#), line 158—'*Ulterleg's Count*.' *Oultre-lac*, 'beyond the lake,' cf. Louis D'outremer. This is again an instance of a qualifying term used as a proper name.

Page [72](#), line 220—'*Meljakanz*.' This exploit is quite in keeping with the character of the knight, cf. Book VII. p. 198. In Malory we meet with the same character, as Sir Meliagraunce; and the story of his abduction of Guinevere, and her rescue by Launcelot is there given in full.

Page [72](#), line 240—'*For some cunning wile of woman*.' It is curious to note that nothing comes of these elaborate precautions on the part of Herzeleide. Parzival's fool's dress seems to excite very little attention, nothing is said of it on his appearance at Arthur's court, nor do we hear of any one mocking him for it. The effect produced by his personal beauty is much more strongly insisted upon. There is also a decided discrepancy between the mother's anxiety to keep her son from danger and her suggestions to him to avenge the wrong Lâhelein has done him.

Page [73](#), line 267—'*Lâhelein*,' Cf. Appendix A, and remarks on this character. Heinzel suggests that Lâhelein=Llewellwyn, a prince of South

Wales who conquered North Wales in 1015. But if a parallel between the boyhood of Parzival and that of Henry Fitz-Empress be intended, as seems probable, the Welsh connection is of too early a date. The remarks in Heinzel's pamphlet, 'Ueber Wolfram von Eschenbach's *Parzival*,' as to Lâhelein being undoubtedly an historical personage, are worthy of note. It is remarkable that we find no equivalent to this character in other versions of the story.

Page [74](#), line 287—'*Briziljan's wood*.' Most probably Broceliande, where so many of the adventures of King Arthur and his knights take place. Undoubtedly this wood was in Brittany, but the localities in the poem are much confused.

Page [74](#), line 297—'*Duke Orilus of Lalande*.' This name is again a misconception of a French original, '*Li Orgueilleux de-la-lande*,' which Wolfram has taken as a proper name. In other versions the lady is unnamed. (It may be noted that Wolfram almost invariably names his characters; and often goes to some trouble to connect them with each other, and the main thread of his story. This tendency to account for everything, *sum motiviren*, is a marked feature in Wolfram's writings.)

Page [76](#), line 365—'*Thy brother, King Lac's son Erec*.' An allusion to the Erec of Hartmann von Aue (founded upon Chrétien's Erec and dealing with the same subject as found in the Welsh tale of *Geraint* and the late Laureate's Enid) where the tournament at Prurein is described.

Page [77](#), line 374—'*Proud Galoes*.' The slaying alike of Parzival's uncle Galoes, and of his kinsman Schionatulander (p. [80](#)) by Orilus, Lâhelein's brother, is also peculiar to Wolfram, but it is curious that the *Rache-motif* thus introduced is not followed up, and when Parzival overthrows Orilus it is to avenge the shaming of Jeschuté, nor, though Orilus mentions his brother as having won *two* kingdoms, Book V. p. 150, does Parzival connect the mention with the loss of his own heritage. This seems to indicate that the special rôle assigned in this poem to the two brothers was not a part of the original story, and has not been perfectly fitted into the framework.

The name of Orilus' wife, Jeschuté, is supposed to be derived from a misunderstanding, Wolfram having interpreted the verb *gisoit*, lay, as a proper name.

Page [77](#), line 375—'*The knight Plihopleheri.*' A knight of the Round Table mentioned in Hartmann's *Iwein* (founded on Chrétien's *Chevalier au Lyon*, the subject-matter of which is the same as that of the Welsh *Lady of the Fountain*).

Page [78](#), line 409—This shaming of Jeschuté will strongly recall to English readers the story of *Enid and Geraint*.

Page [79](#), line 437—'*Siguné and Schionatulander.*' The loves of these two are related in Wolfram's unfinished poem of *Titurel*, where the full account of Schionatulander's fatal chase of the hound, or brachet, is given. The adventure with the weeping damsel occurs in other versions of the Perceval legend, but in none does she play so important a part as in the *Parzival*, *vide* Book V. p. 141; Book IX. p. 252; and Book XVI. Her parentage is given in Book IX. p. 274.

Page [79](#), line 466—'*Thou art Parzival.*' The interpretation here given of the hero's name betrays clearly its French origin, *Perce-val*. In the *Krône* of Heinrich von Türlin the writer explains *Val* as *Thal*=valley, or *Furch*=furrow. Wolfram seems to have understood it in this second sense, and has given the name a symbolic meaning peculiar to himself. In Chrétien's poem no derivation or interpretation of the name is given, and the hero himself guesses his name; nor do the special terms of endearment, evidently quoted by Wolfram from a French source, occur in Chrétien's version of the story.

Page [80](#), line 497—'*'Twas a churl.*' Wolfram's aristocratic contempt for peasants may be noted in other passages, cf. Book II. p. 43, and VII. p. 219.

Page [81](#), line 517—'*Herr Hartmann von Aue.*' Hartmann von Aue was a famous German poet of the twelfth century. If not absolutely the first to introduce the Arthurian legends into Germany (Eilhart's *Tristan* is earlier than Hartmann's works), he was the writer who first rendered them popular in that country. His principal poems are *Erec*, written about 1191; and *Iwein* 1202, both of which are frequently referred to by Wolfram. They were founded on two poems by Chrétien de Troyes, *Erec* and *Le Chevalier au Lyon*, but Hartmann was not a mere translator; he handled his materials with considerable skill, and with an insight into the characters and motives of his *dramatis personæ* which is distinctly a feature of the German presentment of these legends. Enid and her mother Karnafite are characters

in the *Erec*. The story of another of Hartmann's poems, *Der arme Heinrich*, is well known to English readers through Longfellow's version of it in *The Golden Legend*.

Page [82](#), line 534—'*No Kurwenal was his teacher.*' Kurwenal is the friend and tutor of Tristan. In Malory we find the name 'Gouvernail,' and it seems probable that here again we have a term denoting an office converted into a proper name.

Page [82](#), line 549—'*Ither of Gaheviess.*' Ither = Welsh *Idêr*; Gaheviess = *gas-vies*, old wood. Chrétien calls him '*de la forêt de Kinkerloi.*'

Page [82](#), line 544—'*The Red Knight.*' This character is evidently one of the traditional features of the story; though the circumstances of the meeting differ, there is no version without its 'Red Knight.' In those romances of the Grail-cycle in which Perceval has been deposed from his original position as hero in favour of Galahad, we find the latter wearing the armour, and bearing the title, of the Red Knight. Here again Wolfram is the only writer who names him, but it is somewhat startling to find the king of *Cumberland* claiming *Brittany*. From Book IX. pp. 273 and 285, we learn that he was Parzival's kinsman. It may be interesting here, and may help to the better understanding of the poem, if we describe the armour of a knight at the end of the twelfth century. The principal piece of defensive armour was the Hauberk (Halsberg), a coat formed of rings of steel which reached to the knee, and had sleeves ending in iron gauntlets. Attached to this, and forming one piece with the Halsberg, was the Härsenier, a cap of chain mail which was drawn over the head below the helmet. The upper part of the face was protected by the 'Nasen-band,' a band of iron provided with eye-holes; and the lower part by the 'Fintäle,' a part of the 'Härsenier' which passed round and over the chin; above this the helmet was fastened. (The use of the word 'visor' in the translation is an anachronism, as the visor proper was not introduced till later, but there was no other word which would express what was meant with equal brevity and clearness.) Foot and leg were clad in hose of iron, and the knee and elbow were specially protected by plates of iron or *schinnelier*. Over this harness many knights wore the *Waffen-rock*, a long sleeveless garment of silk on which the badge of the knight was embroidered in gold and jewels. The sword was girt above this garment. The knight would also bear his distinguishing badge on helmet, shield, and the truncheon of his spear. The shield was of wood,

strengthened with bands of metal, and often decorated with precious stones, cf. the description of Feirefis' shield in Book XV. The shield was long-shaped, three-cornered, and was held in the left hand close to the body, the spear was carried in the right, so that the horse was guided by the *knee*, not by the *hand*, of the rider. The spear was a blade of steel, set into a long heft of wood, or reed, *Röhr*, probably Bamboo, sometimes even the rough trunk of a young tree, as in Book IV. p. 519. Shield and spear were alike painted in the same colours as the robe of the knight, and the horse had a like covering of silk beneath the saddle and over the coat of mail with which it was protected. The description given by Wolfram of the arms and accoutrement of the Red Knight of Parzival, Book IV. p. 19, and Orilus, Book V. pp. 147-148, *seq.*, will give a very clear idea of the appearance of a knight in full battle-array.

Page [83](#), line 570—'*To the Table Round I came.*' Here we find an allusion to two methods of laying claim to a property. There seems a difference of opinion as to the first; Simrock holds that the pouring out of the wine constituted the claim; Bartsch, that the point of the action lay in carrying off some part of the property claimed. This seems the more probable interpretation, the pouring out of the wine then, as well as the sprinkling the queen, would be accidental. In Chrétien the indignation of king and queen at the insult is far more strongly emphasised. The burning of a wisp of straw, as a declaration of rights claimed, is mentioned by Grimm in his *Deutsche Rechtsalterthümer*.

Page [83](#), line 586—'*Iwanet.*' The diminutive of Iwein, the well-known hero of Hartmann's poem (the Owain, son of Urien of Rheged, of Welsh tradition).

Page [83](#)—'*Parzival at the court of King Arthur.*' There are some distinctive features in Wolfram's version of this incident. Parzival's behaviour towards the King, though unconventional, is far less discourteous than that ascribed to him either by Chrétien or by the English 'Sir Percyvelle.' In Chrétien's poem, Perceval rides into the hall, where he finds the king and courtiers plunged in grief at the insult offered to them by the Red Knight. The king does not reply to Perceval's greeting, and the lad rides so close to him that his horse's head knocks off the king's cap. A reason for the failure of the Knights of the Round Table to avenge the insult offered by the Red Knight is suggested in the fact that they are already wounded in battle. [The student

of Irish heroic saga cannot fail to recall the strange disability under which the knights of Conchobor's court suffered at times and which completely prostrated them. The province of Ulster would have lain defenceless were it not that the Cuchulainn alone was free from the disability, and single-handed defied the men of the rest of Ireland. There are many points of contrast between the *enfances* of Cuchulainn and those of Perceval—A.N.] The kindly feeling shown both by Arthur and Guinevere towards Ither is not paralleled in Chrétien, where the Red Knight is represented as Arthur's deadliest foe, and Guinevere is like to die of shame and wrath at the insult offered to her. Chrétien also places Perceval's refusal to dismount here, whereas Wolfram places it on his arrival at Gurnemanz' castle. In Chrétien the hero tells the Red Knight of his intention to demand his armour from Arthur, and there is no trace of the courteous and poetical greeting which Ither here addresses to Parzival. The confusion of the Red Knight with the hero's own personal foe is of course due to the introduction of the Lähelein episode which is peculiar to Wolfram; but Chrétien has a most curious passage connected with Perceval's inability to disarm his dead antagonist:

'Ains auroie par carbonées
Trestout escarbelliè le mort,
Que nule des armes enport;'

which as it stands is decidedly difficult of interpretation; while in the English Sir Percyvelle we find the hero saying:

'My moder bad me,
Whenne my dart solde brokene be
Owte of the irene brenne the tree,'

which evidently indicates the source of Chrétien's curious remark. An examination of the different versions seems to show that, while the German is the fuller and more poetical, the French is here closer to the original form of the story.

Pages [85](#) and [86](#), lines 635, 658—'*Kay the Seneschal*.' The character of Kay is one of the problems of the Arthurian legends. In all the tales he is represented as filling the office of Seneschal, and in all he is represented as a man of rough manners, violent temper, and bitter tongue. The Seneschal

(*Senes-schalh*), the oldest servant, was master of the ceremonies, one of the chief personages of a royal household, and not unfrequently the trusted confidant of the king; but such a chastisement as Kay here, and in other versions, inflicts upon Kunnewaaré, was distinctly *outside* his office, and, taking into consideration the standing of Kunnewaaré and Antanor, quite inconceivable. Here, as in other instances, we have traces of an original tradition dating from a time when a far rougher code of manners and customs obtained. Wolfram, while adhering closely to his source, and to the traditional representation of Kay's character, was evidently extremely puzzled by the undignified and discourteous part allotted to him, and in Book VI. (p. 169) he diverges from the story in order to explain what he feels to be a difficulty, and to defend Kay at some length. The Northern French poets apparently felt the same, and as Kay is generally represented as Arthur's foster-brother they invented the fable that the unknightly traits in his character were due to his having been committed to the care of a peasant nurse when his mother took charge of the infant Arthur.

Page [85](#), line 652—'*The maiden Kunnewaaré*.' The 'laughing damsel' seems to be an archaic and misunderstood element in the Grail romances. A common incident of folk-tales is for the hero, fool, lout, or tatterdemalion, to win to wife a princess who has not laughed or spoken for years by inducing her to do either of these things. Some such incident has apparently been woven into an heroic romance, the main outlines of which were already fixed, so that the actual conclusion, marriage of the hero with the laughing damsel, has been disturbed. Note, however, the homage paid by Parzival to Kunnewaaré, and her evident affection for him (Book VI. pp. 181-185). Her name too is suggestive, it has been derived from *la pucele a la gonne vaire* (the maiden with the coloured robe), but in its present form it is suspiciously like Kondwiramur, and it should be noted that it is the rejected lover of this queen whom Kunnewaaré eventually marries. Is it possible that the Perceval romance from which both Chrétien and 'Kiot' drew contained doublets of this personage? In the one case in her original, in the other in a modified form. An instructive parallel may be adduced from the saga of Cuchulainn. He is the hero of an Andromeda episode and should by rights wed the delivered heroine, but the story being already fixed before the episode was assimilated, the heroine is passed on to a companion of the hero.—[A. N.]

Page [89](#), line 766—'*Maestricht, or e'en Cologne.*' German art, in the early Middle Ages, reached its highest level in the Rhenish provinces, especially at Cologne.

Page [91](#), line 828—'*Gurnemanz of Graharz.*' The old knight who instructs the hero in knightly duties is a traditional part of the story, and belongs to most of the versions. In Peredur, he is identified with the Fisher King, Perceval's uncle. In Chrétien his name is given as Gonemans of Gelbort; in Gerbert, Chrétien's continuator, he is, *Gornemant* (one of several points of contact between Gerbert and Wolfram's source).

Page [91](#), line 847—'*He bade them lead the guest in.*' This is one of the many passages which afford an interesting glimpse of the manners and customs of a bygone age. It may be well to summarise here what we know of the reception and treatment of a guest in the Middle Ages. If a strange knight rode into the courtyard of a castle he was received by squires and pages, who held his bridle and assisted him to dismount. The guest was then conducted to a chamber where he was disarmed and provided with suitable robes. In every important household there was a *Kleider-kammer*, or wardrobe, presided over by a chamberlain, whose office it was to see that all guests were provided with garments fitted to their station. The preparation of these dresses was the work of the women of the household, and it can have been no light task, as even if a whole company arrived they would all expect to be provided with the requisite dress. The guest, being robed, was then conducted to the great Hall, which was in the upper story of the castle. Half-way on the staircase leading to it, he would be met, and welcomed with the kiss of greeting, by both host and hostess (cf. Book IV. p. 107), and led by them into the Hall where he would receive the greeting of the assembled company. When all were seated the guest would say who he was, and whence he came, but, if he kept silence on this point, it was not etiquette to ask him till the next morning (cf. Book III. p. 95). The evening meal then followed, after which, on occasions of great festivity, such as that recounted in Book XIII. (marriage feast of Gawain and Orgeluse) there would be dancing, otherwise the time seems to have been spent in conversation till the appearance of the wine-cup, *Nacht Trunk*, gave the signal for separation. Then knights conducted the guest to his chamber, where pages disrobed him, and apparently waited with lighted tapers till he fell asleep. The account given here of Parzival's visit to Gurnemanz gives a

very good idea of how the following day would be spent, indeed Wolfram's love for detailed description, and accuracy of statement render this poem peculiarly valuable to a student of the manners and customs of the Middle Ages.

From various hints in the Gawain episodes, notably Books X. and XI., it seems as if the privilege extended to a guest might on occasion be construed with a freedom decidedly repellent to modern ideas.

Page [96](#), lines 984, 985—'*Full five shall thy senses be.*' Cf. Book IX. p. 200.

Page [98](#), line 1055—'*The prince bade his daughter hither.*' The introduction of Gurnemanz' daughter, and her incipient love affair with Parzival is peculiar to this version. There is a curious discrepancy to be noted between the apparent susceptibility of the hero here and in Book IX. pp. 260, 261, and his indifference to feminine charms displayed elsewhere, notably in his rejection of Orgeluse's advances and neglect of the Château Merveil adventure. The latter presentment seems most in accordance with Parzival's character; is the susceptibility to be ascribed to the *poet*?

Page [99](#), line 1080—'*I lose once more a son.*' The sons of the old knight are mentioned in other versions, but Wolfram alone names them. The circumstances of Schenteflur's death are recounted in Book IV. p. 121; the account given of the other two sons is largely borrowed from Hartmann's *Erec*, where the strife for the hawk at Kanedig, and the venture, Schoie-de-la-kurt (which is not a person, but an expedition), is fully recounted. Brandigan is Klamidé's kingdom, cf. Book IV.; Mabonagrein, his cousin, Book IV. p. 123. Mahaut is another form of the name Matilda. From *Titirel* we learn that Gurzgrei and Mahaut were the parents of Schionatulander, Siguné's lover, cf. also Book VIII. p. 245 and note.

BOOK IV TRADITIONAL EVENTS

Arrival at besieged city; maiden of the castle beseeches the hero's aid; overthrow of her enemies and final marriage with maiden.	Chrétien and his continuator Gerbert; Peredur; Sir Percyvelle.
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Name of the maiden; Chrétien, Blanche-fleur; Sir Percyvelle Lufamour; Peredur unnamed.

Page [103](#), line 17—'*Who rideth astray, etc.*' According to Simrock this passage in the original contains a play upon words which cannot be reproduced in translation: Slegel—schlegel, the word employed for *axe* here, signifying, in some parts of Germany, 'a fallen tree.'

Page [104](#), line 26—'*The city of Pelrapär.*' In Chrétien the name of the city is 'Beau-repaire,' of which this is evidently the German rendering. The substitution of *p* for *b* is still a distinguishing mark of German pronunciation of French. In *Sir Percyvelle* it is 'the maiden land.'

Page [104](#), line 38—'*The King Klamidé.*' This character is named by Wolfram and Chrétien only; in *Peredur* he is the Earl; in *Sir Percyvelle*, 'Sowdane.' Chrétien calls him 'Clamadex,' and it is worthy of note that in *Perceval li Gallois* the son of the Red Knight slain by Perceval is called 'Clamadas,' evidently a variant of the same name.

Page [105](#), line 78—'*My lord the Count of Wertheim.*' Wertheim is in Lower Franconia. Bartsch thinks either Poppo I. or his son Poppo II. is referred to here. From the expression used, 'my lord,' it seems as if Wolfram had at one time been in his service.

Page [106](#), line 89—'*Trühending.*' There are three places of this name in the neighbourhood of Eschenbach: Hohen, Alten, and Wasser-Trühending. The latter is still famous for its *krapfen*, a kind of pancake.

Page [107](#), line 119—'*Kiot of Katelangen (i.e. Catalonia) and Manfilot.*' Kiot is the father of Siguné, and appears again in Book XVI. The account of his marriage with Schoisianè, her death, and his subsequent adoption of the life of a hermit will be found in Book IX. p. 274. From Wolfram's unfinished poem of *Titirel* we learn that Manfilot was his companion.

Page [107](#), line 133—'*The twain Isoldé.*' An allusion to Isoldé la Belle, the wife of King Mark of Cornwall, and mistress of Sir Tristan; and Isoldé of the white hand, Tristan's wife.

Page [109](#), line 208, *seq.*—'*Till the cry of heart-sorrow woke him.*' This nocturnal visit of the Lady of the castle to the hero's chamber seems to be part of the original tradition, and it is evident by the apologetic manner in which Wolfram tells the story that he is somewhat puzzled by

Kondwiramur's conduct. From the Introduction to Book VII., and also from the blame he bestows on Chrétien for having done a wrong to the story, *Diese Märe unrecht gethan*, we gather that Wolfram set a high value on fidelity to his source, and these and similar apologetic passages must be explained by the unwillingness of the poet to depart from the traditional form of the legend, while, at the same time, the story, representing as it did the manners and customs of an earlier and ruder period, was somewhat distasteful to him.

Page [110](#), line 243—'*Kingron the Seneschal*.' This character is Aguigrenons in Chrétien, elsewhere he is unnamed. Mr. York Powell points out that Wolfram's form presupposes an Aguigrenons, which would either indicate that the existing MSS. of Chrétien, or Chrétien himself, misread *u* for *n*, or that Wolfram did *not* get his version by ear as he maintains (or that Wolfram was following a source other than Chrétien).

Page [114](#), line 365, seq.—'*The marriage night*.' A similar account is given by Gerbert, one of the continuators of Chrétien. (Chrétien himself does not record the marriage, which takes place on a later visit of the hero to Beau-repaire.) In Gerbert's version we have an indication of later influence, as the motive-power is the recognition by both Perceval and his bride of the superiority of virginity to the married state. Wolfram's version seems far more in accordance with the character of the hero, and is probably closer to the original form of the story.

Page [116](#), line 420—'*Galogandres, Duke of Gippones*.' This character and Count Narant only appear here. Uckerland is probably a corruption of Oultreland, as noted in Book III.

Page [118](#), line 505—'*Gringorz*.' The French *Gringoire*—Gregory. All this account of Klamidé's arms, charger, etc., is peculiar to Wolfram; whose fondness for minute and descriptive detail is a noticeable characteristic.

Page [121](#), line 598—'*Dianasdron*.' Dinaderon en Gales in Chrétien, who does not mention Karminöl. In the roll of King Arthur's knights we find such names as Sir Dinas, Sir Dinant, Sir Dinadan; all of which seem to come from the same root. The name is probably Keltic, and belongs to the original version of the story.

Page [123](#), line 660—'*Mabonagrein*.' Cf. Book III. p. 108 and note.

BOOK V

TRADITIONAL EVENTS

Hero meets with the Fisher King; visits the Grail Castle, sees the Grail, lance, etc., but asks no question, and is therefore reproached by maiden with dead knight.	Chrétien and continuators: Peredur; Perceval; Perceval li Gallois. (Sir Percyvelle omits everything connected with the Grail.)
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(The reader will find all this part of the legend, the varying forms of the visit to the Grail Castle, the Fisher King, the Grail, etc., fully discussed in Mr. Alfred Nutt's *Studies on the Legend of the Holy Grail*.)

Page [131](#), line 58—'*Abenberg's field*.' Castle and town of Abenberg, in the neighbourhood of Eschenbach.

Page [131](#), line 75—'*Repanse de Schoie*.' This name appears to signify 'Thought of joy.' The Grail maidens are not named in other versions.

Page [132](#), line 87—'*Then one to the host would call him*.' This was evidently the Court Jester, always a privileged person.

Page [132](#), lines 109, 110—'*Lignum Aloe*.' Bartsch holds this to be a mistake of the poet, who has misunderstood the old French word *Aloer*. Chrétien has simply *seces boises*. 'Wildberg' was the home of the poet, who is here making allusion to his poverty, as in Book IV. p. 106.

Page [132](#), line 111—'*And the host had bid them lay him*.' 'The Maimed King' invariably figures in the Grail Romances, whether they deal only with the Quest, as here, or with the early history of the Grail. He is generally wounded through the thighs, either with a lance, or with a sword, but the circumstances under which he receives the wound vary greatly. In most of the versions he is met with while engaged in fishing, and is known as the Fisher King, or the 'Rich Fisher.'

Page [132](#), line 125—'*The bleeding lance*.' This is a feature in most of the Grail Romances, and seems to have been an original feature of the story, though it had not the close connection with the *Grail*, which the fully developed Christian legend has given to it. In the earlier versions of the story it is the weapon with which the Maimed King was wounded; finally, it became the spear with which our Lord's side was pierced on the cross.

Wolfram, who never appears to connect the Grail with the Passion, gives it the first meaning. The visit to the Grail Castle is told in varying forms, but the King, the Grail, Sword, and Lance almost invariably appear, and the hero is either Perceval or his companion Gawain, but Perceval is, undoubtedly, the original hero of the Quest.

Page [133](#), line 137 and *seq.*—'*The Grail Procession.*' In Chrétien this is much more simply treated. There are two squires bearing candlesticks, and two maidens, one of whom carries the Grail, the other a silver dish, *tailleur*. Wolfram has evidently seized the opportunity to give play to his love of detailed description, and his account of the Grail Feast and the Grail Maidens is far more elaborate than any given elsewhere.

Page [136](#), line 223—'*The food-supplying powers of the Grail.*' In other romances of the cycle we find similar powers attributed to the Grail. Malory, who borrowed largely from the *Queste* and *Grand S. Graal*, gives a like account. There is evidently a connection between this feature of the Grail, and the food-supplying talismans which figure largely in the legendary lore of most countries.

Page [137](#), line 247—'*A squire who a sword did bear.*' Cf. p. [144](#), lines 472 and *seq.* This incident also occurs in Chrétien, and in varying form in most of the versions. In this poem the meaning and use of the sword are somewhat inexplicable. In Chrétien that sword will break in *one* peril, known only to its maker, and then can be made whole by dipping it in a *lake*. Wolfram's account seems to be based on a misunderstanding of a French original. In some of the other versions the sword is already broken, and can only be made whole by the achiever of the Quest. In Wolfram the sword is a very puzzling feature of the story, with which indeed it seems to have little or no connection. The sword, which breaks in Parzival's deadly combat with his unknown brother, is not *this* sword, but the one taken from Ither of Gaheviess.

Page [137](#), line 267—'*The fairest of old men ancient.*' Titurel, cf. Book IX. p. 287.

Page [137](#), line 273—'*'Tis a symbol good, the bowstring.*' Introduction to Book I., line 9, and note.

Page [139](#), line 325—'*The garden of Paradise.*' This is one of the allusions which seem to connect the Grail in Wolfram's version with an Oriental source, cf. p. [135](#).

Page [141](#), line 371—'*A hidden hand drew the rope taut.*' Chrétien has the incident of the drawbridge rising, but in no other version are the reproaches addressed to the hero immediately on his leaving the castle, they are invariably put into the mouth of the maiden with the dead knight. In the *Perceval* the maiden's words, 'The Lord hates thee,' recall Wolfram's *Ihr sult varen der sunnen has*, which Bartsch says is an ancient formula of declaring a person accurst, and unworthy of the light of day.

Page [141](#), line 381—'*Doubled the throw of sorrow.*' Cf. Book III. p. 100; Book II. p. 47. Similes borrowed from games of chance are not unusual in this poem.

Page [141](#), line 397—'*A woman's voice make moan.*' This meeting with the maiden *after* the visit to the Grail Castle is in most versions the only one. In Chrétien she now tells the hero his name which he learns or guesses for the first time. It was not improbably this incident which led either Wolfram, or his source, to place a first meeting earlier in the story while still retaining one in the original position. Wolfram, with characteristic love for detail, follows up the history of Siguné far more fully than other writers of the cycle.

Page [142](#), line 427—'*Monsalväsche.*' Probably 'Mont Sauvage,' in allusion to its wild and lonely position. A full account of the Grail and its keepers is given in Book IX. pp. 270, 271.

Page [143](#), line 463—'*Lunete.*' A character in Hartmann's *Iwein*, from which the episode is quoted. Cf. Book IX. p. 252, and opening of Book XII.

Page [144](#), line 475—'*Trebuchet.*' This name is also given in Chrétien; he is alluded to again p. [147](#), and in Book IX. p. 281, in connection with the knives of silver mentioned in line 498 of this book.

Page [147](#), line 595—'*Tenabroc.*' Also p. [133](#), line 146. This name is borrowed from Hartmann's *Erec*. Chrétien has 'Danebroc.'

Page [147](#), line 601—'*Beälzenan.*' According to Bartsch this name is combined from Provençal, *beal*, fair; *enan*, height='the fair height,' which would suit very well with the position of Angers, the capital of Anjou.

Page [152](#), line 760—'*Wild Taurian, Dodine's brother.*' Cf. Book IX. p. 265. Taurian does not seem to have been identified, but *Dodine* appears, in many of the Arthurian romances, always with the title of 'Le Sauvage.' So we find him named in Malory. Wolfram seemed to have transferred the characteristic from one brother to the other.

Page [155](#), line 849—'*Iofreit the son of Idöl.*' This is the French name Geoffrey. Mentioned again in Book VI. line 168. Most critics identify this character with Chrétien's *Giflès li feus Do*.

BOOK VI TRADITIONAL EVENTS

Blood drops on the snow and love-trance of hero.	Chrétien: Peredur.
Overthrows Kay and Segramor.	(Perceval Li Gallois relates a similar incident of Gawain.)
Hero is cursed by Grail messenger for his failure to ask the question.	Chrétien: Peredur. (In Perceval there is a cursing by Merlin.)

Page [159](#), line 2—'*From Karidöl and his kingdom.*' Karidöl=Carduel or Cardoile, the Anglo-Norman form of Carlisle. This is undoubtedly Arthur's original capital, but throughout this poem Nantes seems to be regarded as the royal city. Curiously enough we find the two names combined in Gautier de Douzens, one of the continuators of *Li Conte del Graal*, who introduces, as one of his *dramatis personæ*, Carduel of Nantes.

Page [160](#), line 29—'*Whitsuntide.*' An examination of the Romances will show this statement to be correct; Pentecost and Christmas seem to have been the two feasts held in especial honour at King Arthur's court.

Page [160](#), line 49—'*Blood-drops on the snow.*' Both Wolfram and Chrétien insist only on the *two* colours, red and white, and the fact that they are puzzled by, and think it necessary to explain, the presence of snow at Whitsuntide shows that they are taking over the incident from an older source. As a matter of fact it is to be found in tales unconnected with the Arthurian cycle, and of varying nationality. In Peredur (Welsh) a raven has settled upon the body of a wild goose killed by a falcon, and the hero thinks of *three* colours (black, for hair; white, for skin; red, for cheeks); in the *Fate*

of the *Sons of Usnech*, an Irish tale written down before the middle of the twelfth century, and probably centuries older, these three colours are likewise present, but it is a calf instead of a wild goose that is slain, and it is the heroine, not the hero, who is fascinated by the colours. The incident has always been a favourite one with Celtic story-tellers (cf. *Argyll Tales*, M'Innes and Nutt, pp. 431-34), and curiously it is the slain-bird, instead of the slain-calf version which predominates, although the *Fate of the Sons of Usnech* is probably the most famous of all Irish stories, and no traceable literary influence of the Welsh tale upon Irish romance is known. Those familiar with Grimm's fairy tales will remember a similar incident in the story of *Snowdrop*, where the queen pricks her finger, and wishes for a daughter with hair as black as the ebony window-frame, skin as white as the snow, and cheeks as red as the blood; but here, of course, the 'fascination' element is absent. I have attempted to show ('the *lai* of Eliduc and the *mürchen* of Schneewittchen,' *Folk Lore*. iii. I), that the Gaelic version of the Schneewittchen type of story represents the earliest attainable form of the story.—[A. N.]

Page [162](#), line 87—'*Segramor*,' or Saigremors. This knight is a familiar figure in the Arthurian Romances, and the episode is quite in accordance with his general character. Chrétien calls him 'Le Desreè' (uncurbed, impetuous). In Malory he is 'Le Desirous.' Cf. also Book VIII. p. 241.

Page [163](#), line 121—'*To seek for the magic pheasant*.' Simrock thinks this an allusion to a popular folk-tale, in which a magician, condemned to death, contrives to escape by setting his judges and executioner to seek for the fallen bird, by the irresistible strains of his magic pipe.

Page [166](#), line 235—'*Heinrich of Veldeck*.' A German poet who lived towards the end of the twelfth century. His translation of the *Æneid*, founded on a French version of the poem, was extremely popular, and Wolfram frequently refers to it in his *Parzival*.

Page [169](#), line 321—'*Herman of Thuringia*.' This Landgrave of Thuringia is well known to history as a generous patron of the literature of his day. His court at the Wartburg was the resort of all the leading poets, and it filled a place in the literary life of the twelfth century only comparable to that taken by the neighbouring court of Weimar six hundred years later. The terms in

which Wolfram speaks of the guests at the Wartburg is quite in keeping with what is known of the Landgrave's lavish hospitality.

Simrock renders a passage from Walther von der Vogelweide which describes the tumultuous life of the court as follows:

'Wer in den Ohren siech ist oder krank im Haupt,
Der meide ja Thuringen's Hof, wenn er mir glaubt.
Käm er dahin, er würde ganz bethöret;
Ich drang so lange zu, dass ich nicht mehr vermag,
Ein Zug fährt ein, ein anderer aus, so Nacht als Tag,
Ein wunder ists, dass da noch Jemand höret.'

The *Wartburg-krieg*, a poem of the end of the thirteenth century, in which the principal poets of the age are represented as competing in song before the Landgrave, supposes this contest to take place in 1207, and is doubtless an echo of what was no unusual incident at that date. Wolfram's poem of *Willehalm* was composed at the wish of the Landgrave, and in it he speaks of the death of his patron. Herman died in 1216, and the brilliant life at the Wartburg came to an end; his successor Ludwig, the husband of S. Elizabeth, having little taste for literature.

Page [169](#), line 325—'*And so Knight Walter singeth.*' Walther von der Vogelweide, one of the most famous of German lyric poets, was of knightly birth but small means; he seems to have supported himself by his art, leading a wandering life at the principal courts of his day. Of his connection with Wolfram nothing is known, save the fact of their being together at the court of the Landgrave Herman in the early years of the thirteenth century. The line here quoted does not occur in any of Walther's extant poems.

Page [169](#), line 328—'*Heinrich of Rispach.*' Nothing seems to be known of the character here referred to. From the fact that there is a Rispach in the neighbourhood of Eschenbach, Bartsch conjectures that it was some one personally known to Wolfram.

Page [171](#), line 385—'*The time when the knife's sharp blade.*' Wolfram is here quoting from an unknown source. No such adventures are recorded in any Romance that has come down to us; but they are quite in keeping with Gawain's character.

Page [176](#), line 529—'*The right of the Round Table*.' This custom is alluded to in other Arthurian Romances, and we meet with it again in Book XIII. Here Wolfram seems to imply merely that the king did not eat in public with his knights, *i.e.* at the Round Table, before they had heard of some knightly venture; in Book XIII. he speaks as if no meal might be partaken of by any of the courtiers till this came to pass. The first rendering seems to be the correct one. [The whole incident is thoroughly in keeping with the conventions of early Irish romance, in which the personages are invariably subject to strict rules and obligations, *geasa*, to use the Irish word.—A.N.]

Page [177](#), line 585—'*The Grail Messenger*.' This incident occurs in both Chrétien and Peredur, but the messenger is unnamed, or simply termed 'The Loathly Damsel.' Such a damsel is met with in the *Perceval*, but when she reaches King Arthur's Court she is transformed into a maiden of surpassing beauty. It will be noted that one of the queens imprisoned in Château Merveil also bears the name of Kondrie (p. [189](#)). Mr. Nutt, in his *Studies on the Legend of the Holy Grail*, suggests this was originally the Loathly Damsel released from the transforming spell. (It may be noted that Wagner has kept this idea, and in the first act his Kundrie is the Loathly Messenger; in the second, 'Kondrie la Belle.') Chrétien's description of Kondrie's appearance is even more repulsive than Wolfram's. In Book X. we have a curious account of the origin of these strange people.

[The 'Loathly Damsel' is one of those personages that most clearly testify to the reliance of the romance-writers upon a traditional popular basis, and also in this instance to the specific Celtic origin of that popular basis. A commonplace of folk-tales of the 'task' class is that the hero is helped by a personage having private ends of his or her own to serve, as, until the hero achieves the Quest (which he never does unaided), the helper cannot be released from a spell, generally of transformation into an animal, but sometimes into a shape of surpassingly hideous ugliness. The oldest European variant of this latter type with which I am acquainted is to be found in an Irish folk-tale imbedded in the so-called Cormac's Glossary, a compilation of the tenth century. I have given this in full (*Argyllshire Tales*, M'Innes and Nutt, pp. 467, 468). In its *outré* horror the description of the bespelled king's son strikingly recalls that of Kundrie. Such a task story, in which the hero is helped by a transformed personage, who cannot be delivered until the Quest is achieved, is one of the main staples of the

Perceval cycle, but it is only in the Welsh tale of *Peredur* that the incident appears in a straightforward and intelligible form. The sudden transformation from foulness to radiant beauty is met with in another connection earlier in Ireland than elsewhere in Europe: the incident of the Perilous Kiss, in which the embrace of a courteous knight frees a bespelled damsel from loathly disguise, an incident frequently associated with Gawain, is, as I have shown (*Academy*, April 30, 1892), of early occurrence in Ireland. Another element which goes to the complex individuality of Kundrie can be paralleled from early Irish romance. As the female messenger of the fairy dynasty of Mazadan, she corresponds to Leborcham, the female messenger of the semi-mythic King Conchobor, the head and centre of the oldest Irish cycle of heroic romance. Like Kundrie, Leborcham was of startling and unnatural hideousness, and she is brought into special connection with Cuchulainn the chief hero of the Ulster cycle, as Kundrie is with Perceval the chief hero of one group of the Arthur romances.—A.N.]

Page [181](#), line 697—'*Château Merveil*.' The adventure of this magic castle, achieved by Gawain, is related at length in Book XI.

Page [184](#), line 806—'*Kingrimursel*.' The name of this character in Chrétien is Guigambresil, of which this is evidently the German rendering. Here, again, Wolfram either heard or read Gingambresil.

Page [185](#), line 839—'*Tribalibot*.' This is India.

Page [186](#), line 859—'*The heathen queen of Ianfus*.' The name of this queen, we find from line 1009, was Ekuba; one of the few classical names we find in this poem.

Page [189](#), line 977—'*The Greek, Sir Klias*.' This is Cligès, the hero of Chrétien's poem of that name, son of the Greek Emperor Alexander and Surdamour, sister to Gawain, cf. Book XII. Malory has Sir Clegis, probably the same name.

Page [190](#), line 1002—'*Twelve spears of Angram*.' Angram was probably in India, and noted for its steel. Oraste-Gentesein seems to be the name of the country from which the reed, or bamboo, was brought. Cf. Book VII. pp. 218, 219.

BOOK VII

TRADITIONAL EVENTS

Meeting with army of Meljanz of Lys; Gawain takes part in the tournament, and overthrows Meljanz.	Chrétien: Perceval relates the same incident, with the difference that Perceval overcomes both Gawain and Melians.
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Introduction, line 1-16—This passage is somewhat obscure, but the meaning appears to be that the poet thinks he may possibly be blamed for leaving the history of Parzival, his chief hero, to follow the fortunes of Gawain; and would excuse himself for so doing by the plea of fidelity to his source. Very few of the romances of this date can be considered *original* works in the sense in which we would now employ that term; they were mostly a re-statement, or re-combining of traditional material, and it was a point of honour to adhere closely, in the march of incident, to the original form, though the poet was free to do as Wolfram has done, and introduce personal and contemporary allusions, or give his own interpretation of the meaning of the tale. The fact that Wolfram here so strongly blames those who depart from the traditional form of the story, and at the end of his poem specially accuses Chrétien of having sinned in this way, seems a strong argument against the theory that Chrétien, and Chrétien alone, was Wolfram's source of information.

Page [195](#), line 2—'*Gawain.*' *Gauvain* (French), *Gwchmai* (Welsh). In all the earlier versions of the Grail story this knight plays a part only secondary to that of the chief hero Perceval. Certain episodes of which he is sole hero, in Chrétien as in Wolfram, break the course of the Perceval story, though Wolfram, with considerable skill, has brought them into close connection with the main thread of the legend. With Chrétien's continuators, too, Gawain is an important character, he also visits the Grail Castle and fails to ask the question; and a German version of the Grail legend, *Diu Krône*, by Heinrich von Türlin, makes him the chief hero, it is he who achieves the Quest and heals Anfortas. It is noticeable that none of the earlier versions know anything of either Lancelot or Galahad as Grail-seekers; Wolfram does mention the former, but only incidentally, and throughout his poem he evidently looks upon Gawain as the typical Arthurian knight, the pride and glory of the Round Table. It is curious that, though he feels himself

compelled to apologise for some of the characters, to make an elaborate defence for Kay, and find excuses for Kondwiramur, Wolfram never has a word of blame for Gawain, and strong as the contrast is between his morality and that of Parzival, he certainly never draws a comparison to the disadvantage of the former; as husband of Orgeluse and lord of the Château Merveil, Gawain's lot in life is brilliant enough to awaken the envy of Kay who is jealous for King Arthur's honour. The whole presentment of Gawain in the poem is an eloquent commentary on the moral teaching of the original Arthurian legend, of which he is the oldest representative. Later compilers seem to have felt this, and as the legend gradually became ecclesiasticised, and assumed the form of a religious romance, so the original heroes of the story were gradually supplanted by others, whose characters, in the opinion of monkish compilers lent themselves more to purposes of moral edification. Thus Perceval the married man was forced to yield to Galahad the celibate, and, though he was never driven out of the story, was relegated to a secondary position; and Gawain, whose character in the early romances defied any attempt at converting him into a moral example, became merely a foil to the superior virtue of his companions, while the adventures originally ascribed to him were passed over to the repentant sinner Lancelot. The order of Grail heroes seems to have been as follows: Perceval, Gawain; Perceval, Gawain, Lancelot; Galahad, Perceval, and Lancelot. It is in this last order that they have come down to us through Malory's redaction of the legends.

Page [196](#), line 34—'*The steed from Monsalväsch came.*' Cf. Book IX. p. 273, where Parzival's possession of a Grail-steed leads to his being mistaken for Lâhelein.

Page [198](#), line 96—'*Meljakanz.*' Cf. Book III. p. 72 and note.

Page [198](#), line 105—'*Meljanz of Lys.*' It will be seen, from the list of traditional events given above, that this character appears in other versions of the Perceval legends. Though the context is different, the name with but little variation appears in other of the Grail romances, Malory has Melias de Lile, in every instance the name indicates a French origin.

Page [198](#), line 119—'*Lippaut.*' The name of this character in Chrétien is Tiebaut of Tintaguel, the German is evidently a rendering of this French name. Tintaguel seems to point to a Keltic original.

Page [199](#), line 124—'*Obie and Obilot.*' Bartsch considers that both these names are derived from a French source, Obie, from the verb *obier*, signifying excitable, passionate; Obilot, from the French *belot*, a fair child. In Chrétien the sisters are unnamed, but the younger is called *La pucière as mances petites*.

Page [199](#), line 136—'*Galoës and Annora.*' Here we learn, for the first time, the name of Galoës' love, cf. Book II. p. 46 and note. Annora is the same name as Eleanor.

Page [200](#), line 168—'*Lisavander.*' The French has several variations of this name, Teudaves, Travezdates, Trahedavet.

Page [205](#), line 318, and p. [219](#), line 781—'*A charger the king bestrode.*' This is an allusion to the captivity of Queen Guinevere and her rescue by Lancelot. Kay was among her would-be liberators, and was smitten by Meljakanz: 'enbor ûs dem satele hin, daz in ein ast der helm gevienc, und bi der gurgelen hienc.' This incident is related in Hartmann's *Iwein*; but the subsequent freeing of the queen by Lancelot, referred to on p. 219, is taken from Chrétien's *Chevalier de la Charrette*. The adventure is again alluded to in Book XII.

Page [210](#), line 493—'*Gawain and Obilot.*' Though Chrétien and Wolfram agree here in the main outline of the story, yet the details differ completely, and the episode as related by the German poet is far more graceful and poetical in treatment. In Chrétien the elder sister strikes the younger in the face, and it is in order to avenge this insult that the child begs Gawain to fight for her. It is the father, and not the child herself, who suggests presenting the knight with a token; he bids Gawain at first pay no attention to her request, and there is no trace of the pride and affection with which Lippaut evidently regards both his daughters, or of the confidence between father and child which is so charming a feature in Wolfram's poem. Gawain, according to Chrétien, does not present his little lady with the captured monarch, but only with his steed, a compliment she shares too with his hostess and her daughters. In the French poet we have nothing of the amusing assumption of maiden dignity by the child Obilot, or of the graceful courtesy, half serious, half laughing, with which Gawain falls in with her whim, and sustains his part in the pretty play. Critics have bestowed much praise on this book, and on the character of the child Obilot,

and some have thought that, in the picture of father and child, and in the words put into Lippaut's mouth, we have a glimpse of the home life of the poet, and an expression of personal feeling. In *Willehalm*, Wolfram refers to his daughter's dolls, and throughout his poems he frequently alludes to children, their ways, and their amusements. However that may be, nowhere else in the poem does *Gawain* appear to so much advantage as in this episode.

Page [211](#), line 522—'*Parzival*.' Cf. Book VI. p. 188, line 941.

Page [216](#), line 668—'*Even now shall the Erfurt vineyards*.' etc. An allusion to the siege of Erfurt by the Landgrave Herman in 1203. As the poet speaks of the traces of strife as being yet visible, this book of the *Parzival* must have been written not long after that date.

Page [217](#), line 715, and *seq.*—'*The captive Breton knights*.' It is doubtful to what romance Wolfram here makes allusion. Chrétien, in his *Chevalier la Charrette*, relates the capture of some of Arthur's knights by King Bagdemagus-Poidikonjonz, when Meljakanz carried off Guinevere, but they were released by Lancelot. Wolfram seems to have known another version of the story, as he evidently did know a romance dealing with the fate of Arthur's son, Ilinot, of whom we know nothing. He refers to this at length in Book XII. Cluse seems to betoken an enclosed space, a ravine, Chrétien calls it *Le passage des pierres*—The Gampilon was a fabulous beast of the dragon type, also mentioned in the *Gudrun*.

Page [218](#), line 733—'*The Red Knight*.' It is worth noticing that, throughout the *Gawain* episodes, Wolfram never loses sight of his principal hero; if *Parzival* does not appear personally, as he does in this book, he is always alluded to in direct connection with the development of the story, *e.g.*, Book VIII. pp. 242, 243. This is not the case in Chrétien, where the *Gawain* episodes are entirely independent. Some critics have evolved an elaborate theory to account for the importance assigned to *Gawain* in this and following books, and maintain that Wolfram felt that while *Parzival* was a prey to spiritual doubt and despair, it was more artistic to keep him in the background than to make him the hero of a series of chivalrous adventures. The more probable solution seems to be exactly the opposite, viz., that the *Gawain* episodes were already introduced into the legend, that Wolfram, or his source, felt it a flaw that they should have so little connection with the

main thread of the story, and therefore conceived the idea of introducing the principal hero, and, by keeping him always more or less *en évidence*, making it possible to weave the Gawain adventures into the fabric of the legend, instead of leaving them an excrescence on its surface—a conception which was finally perfected by the connection of Orgeluse, Gawain's lady-love, with both Parzival and Anfortas, thereby bringing all the different elements of the tale into touch each with the other.

BOOK VIII TRADITIONAL EVENTS

Arrival of Gawain at castle; committed to care of lady to whom he makes love; is attacked by her people and defends himself with a chess-board.	Chrétien: Peredur.
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The *Perceval* gives an account of an adventure with a lady and a chess-board of which Perceval is the hero, but the circumstances differ entirely, being similar to those of an episode found in *Gautier de Douzens* and also in *Peredur*.

Page [229](#), line 14—'*Askalon*.' The name of this city in Chrétien is Escavalon, apparently a variant of Avalon. The name in Wolfram may be either a misunderstanding of the French original, or it is not impossible that Askalon, being well known to the Crusaders of that time, was purposely substituted for a similar sounding-title.

Page [230](#), line 26—'*Æneas and Dido*.' An allusion to the *Æneid* of Heinrich von Veldeke, to which Wolfram often refers. We learn from line 121 that the writer was already dead. Cf. note, Book VI.

Page [230](#), line 41—'*Where Mazadan reigned as Monarch*.' Cf. Book I. p. 31, and Book IX. p. 263. There is evidently a confusion here between the fairy and her kingdom. Fay-Morgan is, of course, the fairy-queen, and the name seems later to have been transferred to Arthur's sister, who is called Morgan le Fay in Malory. Terre-de-la-schoie, given in Book I. as the name of the lady, is her kingdom; the confusion probably arises from a misunderstanding of the French source. We find, on p. [240](#), that the mother of King Vergulacht, Fleurdamur, was sister to Gamuret, consequently

Parzival and Vergulacht are first cousins, and we are meant to understand that Gawain, who, as a lad, had seen Gamuret at Kanvoleis (Book II. p. 39), was struck by the king's likeness to his uncle and cousin, though he evidently knows nothing of the relationship; cf. Appendix A for notes on the supposed origin of the Angevin race.

Page [231](#), line 58—'*Not such as in Karidöl.*' This is the longest of the many allusions to the *Erec* of Hartmann von Aue, and refers to the same incident as Book III. p. 81, cf. note on passage.

Page [232](#), line 106—'*The Margravine of Heitstein.*' This name varies greatly in the MSS., but both Lachmann and Bartsch give the reading in the text. The Margravine mentioned is identified with the wife of Berchtold von Chamm and Vohburg, who died in 1204.

Page [233](#), line 146—'*Of my father's sister,*' etc. This line is curious as giving a very early instance of a play upon words familiar to us in modern puzzles. Gawain, of course, simply states that he is 'his father's son,' and gives the queen no information whatever as to his birth.

Page [234](#), line 181, and seq.—'*At length did she chance on some chess-men,*' etc. It should be noted that chess-men, in the Middle Ages, were often of a very large size, and would form no despicable weapons. In Chrétien's version of the incident he specially speaks of these as ten times larger than other chess-men, and of very hard ivory. Adventures in which a chess-board plays a part are of not infrequent occurrence in the Grail romances.

Page [234](#), line 190—'*The Burger maids of Tollenstein.*' Tollenstein is a town in the neighbourhood of Eschenbach; the allusion is evidently to some kind of Carnival sports held there. Mock Tournaments, in which women took part, are often alluded to in old French and German poems. The point of the allusion evidently is that they fought for mere sport, while Antikonie fought in defence of her guest, and her action is therefore held the more praiseworthy.

Page [235](#), line 221—'*The knight who to battle bade him.*' Cf. Book VI. p. 184 and note.

Page [236](#), line 257—'*With a lance-thrust by Ekunât.*' Ekunât has been already named in Book III. p. 99. It seems doubtful whence Wolfram derived this incident.

Page [238](#), line 316—'*As Kiot himself hath told us.*' This is the first time Wolfram names the source whence he drew his poem. It has already been noted in the Introduction that the existence of this Kiot is a matter of debate, as no poem of his has come down to us, and apparently no other writer mentions his name. This passage should be compared with Book IX. p. 262, where the nature of the MS. in which Kiot found the story of Parzival and the Grail is stated. It certainly seems clear that Wolfram *had* a source of information other than the poem of Chrétien de Troyes; his other statements as to contemporary events and contemporary literature are perfectly accurate, and we do not find him inventing feigned names for other writers of the day; it therefore seems somewhat unreasonable to conclude, simply because we know nothing of Kiot's work, that Wolfram here, and in other passages, is, to put it mildly, inventing an elaborate fiction. The fact of the great popularity obtained by Chrétien's version of the Grail legend is quite enough to account for the disappearance of a version which, for some reason or other (very probably its curious account of the Grail), had failed to attract the popular fancy.

Page [240](#), line 363—'*If Turnus thou fain wouldst be.*' An allusion to the *Æneid* of Heinrich von Veldeck, where Turnus reproaches Tranzes for cowardice, and is answered in much the same strain as Liddamus answers Kingrimursel.

Page [240](#), line 387—'*Nay, why should I be a Wolfhart?*' This passage to line 398 is an allusion to the great German epic, the *Nibelungenlied*, the various lays composing which seem to have been brought into order and welded into a literary whole about this time. Wolfram's version of the cook's appeal to Gunther varies slightly from the received text and probably represents an older form.

Page [241](#), line 407—'*Sibech ne'er drew a sword.*' This is an allusion to the story of Dietrich von Berne, parts of which were incorporated in the *Nibelungenlied*, where, however, this special incident is not to be found. Ermenrich was uncle to Dietrich and Emperor of Rome; Sibech, who seems to have been as faithless as he was cowardly, to avenge a personal injury, counselled the Emperor to a course which brought about the ruin of himself and his people.

Page [242](#), line 452—'*The wood Læhtamreis.*' Tamreis, as we find from Book XII., is the name of a tree, this proper name seems to be combined from *Læh*, old French *les* = near, and *tamreis* (tamarisk?). The knight is, of course, Parzival. Chrétien has not this incident; which is a proof of Wolfram's superior skill in controlling the thread of his story.

Page [245](#), line 541—'*At Schoie-de-la-Kurt.*' Cf. note to Book III., where we find the account of this venture, and of the death of Gurzgrei, son of Gurnemanz. Gandelus is the brother of Schionatulander, Siguné's love.

Page [247](#), line 597—'*To the Grail must his pathway wend.*' It is a very curious feature, both in this poem and in that of Chrétien, that the Grail Quest, undertaken by Gawain, is allowed to drop into oblivion. Wolfram only makes one more allusion to it, Book XI., and Chrétien apparently ignores it altogether. In other versions of the story, and notably in Chrétien's continuators, the achievement of the Grail Quest by Gawain is an important feature. It is true that Chrétien's portion of the *Conte* breaks off short before the end of the Gawain episode, and that those who maintain that Wolfram had no other source than Chrétien point to this as a proof of their theory, urging that had Chrétien finished the poem he would undoubtedly have brought Gawain to Monsalväsche, and that Wolfram, deserted by his source at this point, carried the Gawain Quest no further. But it must be noted that Wolfram, who, according to this theory, has hitherto followed Chrétien with remarkable fidelity, shows no embarrassment at the loss of his guide, but, by bringing Gawain promptly into touch with Parzival, finishes his poem in a thoroughly coherent and harmonious manner, his conclusion agreeing, in certain peculiar features, with his Introduction, which, also, is unknown to Chrétien. The simplest solution appears to be that *both* Chrétien and Wolfram were in possession of a common source, wherein the Gawain episodes were presented in an incomplete and abbreviated form. Mr. Nutt points out that the Gawain Quest, as related by Chrétien's continuators, not only fails to agree with Chrétien's commencement, but also presents features more archaic than those of the Perceval Quest.

BOOK IX TRADITIONAL EVENTS

Hero meets with pilgrims who reproach him for bearing arms on Good Friday, and direct him to a hermit, who points out his sins and gives him absolution.	Chrétien: Peredur: Perceval
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Introduction to line 25. This spirited opening, with its invocation of the embodied 'Frau Aventiure,' is peculiar to Wolfram. The entire episode is much more briefly treated by Chrétien, who brings his hero at once in contact with the pilgrims, and has neither the meeting with Siguné nor the combat with the Grail knight.

Page [251](#), line 5—'*Frau Aventiure*.' This is a personification of the 'story' and of the spirit of romantic story-telling. Grimm (*Kl. Sr.* i. 83-112) claims that we have here a survival of the personifying instinct which led the northern poets to make 'Saga' a daughter of Odin. The word itself is simply taken over from French romance where *or dist l'Aventure* is a standing initial formula, in which *Aventure* exactly renders the *maere* of the opening quatrain of the *Nibelungenlied*.—[A. N.]

Page [251](#), line 6—'*Whom Kondrie, to find the Grail*.' Cf. Book VI. p. 187.

Page [252](#), line 34—'*The sword that Anfortas gave him*.' Cf. Book V. pp. 137 and 144, and note.

Page [252](#), line 47—'*Schionatulander and Siguné*.' This is Parzival's third interview with his cousin, who has a much more important rôle assigned to her in this poem than in the other romances. The hero meets her at every important crisis in his life; on his first entrance into the world, Book III. p. 79; after his visit to the Grail Castle, Book V. p. 141; now, previous to his interview with the hermit; and finally, in Book XVI. after he has won the Grail kingdom and been reunited to his wife, he finds her dead, and buries her with her lover. Siguné's parentage is fully given on p. [274](#) of this book.

Page [257](#), line 204—'*The Templar bold*.' This identification of the knights of the Grail with the Templars (Templeisen) is a marked peculiarity of Wolfram's poem. Nothing at all answering to the Grail kingdom and its organisation, as described in the Parzival, is to be found elsewhere. The introduction of this spiritual knighthood, chosen by Heaven, and, with special exceptions, vowed to celibacy, seems intended as a contrast with, and protest against, the ideal of worldly chivalry and lax morality portrayed

in Arthur's court. Are we to attribute this feature of the poem to Wolfram himself or to his source? Judging from the value Wolfram placed upon fidelity to tradition it seems scarcely probable that he would have departed so far from his model as to introduce such an entirely new and striking element into the story; nor have we any trace of the poet-knight's connection with the order of Templars; but if the writer of the admitted French source was an Angevin, who had been in the East during the Angevin rule in Jerusalem, the connection is easily explained. Certainly, to judge from the freedom with which the introduction to the story has been handled, 'Kiot' does not seem to have been hampered with an undue respect for the traditional form of the legend.

Page [258](#), line 223—'*Nor Lähelein, nor Kingrisein, etc.*' Kingrisein is the father of Vergulacht, supposed to have been slain by Gawain, cf. Book VIII. p. 240. King Gramoflanz plays an important part in the poem from Book XII. onward. Count Laskoit, cf. Book III. p. 99.

Page [258](#), line 230, and *seq.*—'*One turning the ground was snow-clad.*' Cf. reference to spring snow in Book VI. p. 160. The pilgrim train met by Parzival differs in the versions. The Montpellier MS. of Chrétien has three knights and ten ladies; other MSS. one knight and twenty ladies. Wolfram's account is more natural and more poetical.

Page [259](#), line 263—'*Dost thou mean Him, etc.*' The address of the knight in Chrétien is longer and conceived in quite a different spirit. It contains one remarkable passage; speaking of the Crucifixion the knight says: '*Li fol Juis—c'on devroit tuer comme ciens,*' a speech entirely out of keeping with the spirit of love and charity characterising Wolfram's Old Knight, and Hermit. The German poem is, throughout, remarkable for the wide spirit of tolerance displayed towards those outside the Christian pale; note, *e.g.*, Book I. and especially the character of Feirefis as depicted in the two closing books of the work. The religious teaching in this ninth book is not only fuller than in Chrétien, but seems based on a much clearer realisation of the position of the *individual* soul towards its Creator. The elementary truths of Christianity are much more fully stated, and display a familiarity with the theological speculations of the day which renders them peculiarly interesting. There is no parallel, either, in Chrétien to the fine speeches which Wolfram puts into the mouth of his hero. The whole episode in the French poem lacks the dignity and impressiveness which stamp it in the

German version; it is in this book, and in the account of Parzival's boyhood, that Wolfram's poetical genius touches its highest point, and his superiority to Chrétien is most clearly seen.

Page [261](#), line 337—'*Towards Fontaine Sauvage*,' etc. Cf. Book V. p. 151.

Page [261](#), line 348—'*Kiot*.' Cf. note to Book VIII. It is noticeable that there is no corresponding passage to this in Chrétien; the explanation of the Grail mystery given in the *Conte du Graal* is due to Chrétien's continuators, and occurs in the later part of the poem.

Page [262](#), line 359—'*Flegetanis*.' A curious contradiction will be noted here. A few lines above we read that no heathen skill could have revealed the mysteries of the Grail, and yet apparently it was a heathen who first wrote of them. The whole account of the Grail reads like a not-too-successful attempt to Christianise a purely pagan legend.

Page [263](#), line 383—'*And in Britain, France, and Ireland, etc.*' Cf. Appendix A and note on Mazadan, Book VIII. Nevertheless, the connection of the Grail race with the House of Anjou, save through Herzeleide's marriage with Gamuret, is nowhere stated, nor how Titurel was descended from Mazadan, the ancestor alike of Arthur and of Gamuret.

Page [265](#), line 465—'*The altar and shrine*.' Wolfram appears to be absolutely correct here; during the Middle Ages, a shrine, or reliquary, was generally placed on the altar, the use of a cross was of comparatively late date. It is curious that Chrétien, otherwise more ecclesiastical in his details than Wolfram, has missed the characteristic feature of the stripped altar; on the other hand, he notes that Perceval spends *Easter* with the Hermit, and receives the Sacrament, while Wolfram passes Easter over without mention. (It is rather odd to find Chrétien's Hermit saying *Mass* on Good Friday!)

Page [267](#), line 531—'*Ashtaroth*.' Bartsch says that these names are derived from Talmudic tradition; Belcimon being Baal-Schemen, a god of the Syrians; Belat, the Baal of the Chaldeans. Rhadamant is, of course, the Greek ruler of the under-world.

Page [267](#), line 533, and seq.—'*When Lucifer and his angels*.' The belief that the creation of man was directly connected with the fall of the rebel angels was very widespread, though the relation of the two as cause and effect was sometimes the reverse of that stated here. None of the editions of the

Parzival give a direct reference to the source of the curious 'riddling' passage which follows, but the theory of the maidenhood of the earth was a favourite one with Mediæval writers.

Page [268](#), line 572—'*Plato and the Sibyls*.' A curious proof of the belief of the Mediæval Church in the Christian nature of the Sibylline prophecies is found in the first line of the *Dies Iræ*:

'Dies Iræ, Dies Illa,
Solvat sæclum in favilla
Teste David cum Sibylla.'

Page [270](#), line 615, and *seq.*—'*The Grail*.' The account of the Grail given by Wolfram is most startling, differing as it does from every other account which has come down to us. Wolfram evidently knows nothing whatever of the traditional 'vessel of the Last Supper,' though the fact that the virtue of the stone is renewed every *Good Friday* by a *Host* brought from Heaven seems to indicate that he had some idea of a connection between the Grail and the Passion of our Lord. Various theories have been suggested to account for the choice of a precious stone as the sacred talisman; Birch Hirschfeld maintains that it arose entirely from a misunderstanding of Chrétien's text, the French poet describing the Grail as follows:

'De fin or esmeree estoit;
Pieres pressieuses avoit
El graal, de maintes manieres,
Des plus rices et des plus cieres
Qui el mont u en tiere soient.'

But how Wolfram, who, in other instances appears to have understood his French source correctly, here came to represent an object of gold, adorned with *many* precious stones, as *a* precious stone, does not appear. And it must be noted that this importance assigned to a jewel is not out of keeping with the rest of the poem. From the jewel of Anflisé, the ruby crown of Belakané, and the diamond helmet of Eisenhart in the first book, to the long list of precious stones adorning the couch of Anfortas in the last, the constant mention of jewels is a distinct feature of Wolfram's version, and cannot be paralleled by anything in Chrétien. Moreover, in two other

instances, viz. the armour of Feirefis in Book XV., and the couch of Anfortas already mentioned, mystical and strengthening powers are attributed to them. The MSS. vary in their spelling of the stone, giving *Lapis, Lapsit, Jaspis, exillis, exilix* or *erillis*; and it is impossible to identify the stone of the Grail with any known jewel. The fact that Wolfram alone of all the writers of this cycle gives this version of the legend, seems to point rather to a peculiarity in his source than to a genuine tradition of the origin of the Grail-myth. In any case it is most probable that the responsibility for the statement rests with the author of Wolfram's French source rather than with Wolfram himself.

Page [271](#), line 665—'*They who took no part in the conflict.*' This account of the neutral angels is partially contradicted by Trevrezent in Book XVI. during his last interview with Parzival, when he openly admits that he had spoken untruly in order to induce Parzival to give up his Quest for the Grail. This contradiction introduces a good deal of uncertainty as to what really is the moral aim of the poem.

Page [273](#), line 711—'*The white dove I see on its housing.*' This, the badge of the Grail knights, is peculiar to the German poem. Those familiar with Wagner's *Parsifal* will not need to be reminded that the dove and the swan are represented by him as the sacred birds of the Grail. The connection with the swan will be found in Book XVI.

Page [273](#), line 737—'*O thou son of my sister.*' The relationship of uncle and nephew between the hermit and the hero of the Quest obtains in most of the versions. The relationship with the wounded king varies, sometimes he is the hero's grandfather.

Page [274](#), line 759—'*Thou wast the beast that hung,*' etc. Cf. Book II. p. 58. This incident of the mother's dream is peculiar to Wolfram.

Page [274](#), line 771—'*Repanse de Schoie.*' Cf. Book V. p. 135 and Book XVI. She finally marries Feirefis, Parzival's half-brother.

Page 375, line 785—'*But if love the Grail King seeketh.*' This explanation of the wound of Anfortas as the punishment of unlawful love is peculiar to Wolfram, and is in accordance with the superior depth and spirituality of his treatment of the legend. In the other versions the king is wounded in battle or accidentally. The various remedies tried for the wound, related on pp.

[276](#), [277](#), give a curious idea of the surgical skill of the Middle Ages, and seem drawn from a mixture of Oriental and classical sources. The names in line 830 are derived from the Greek, and signify various serpents, with the exception of Ecidemon, which we learn in Book XV. was an animal greatly feared by snakes, perhaps the Ichneumon. The reference to Æneas and the Sibyl is from the *Æneid* of Heinrich von Veldeke.

The legend of the pelican is well known, and the first part of the passage referring to the unicorn, its love for a spotless maiden, was a widespread fiction of the Mediæval times, but the assertion that the carbuncle is found under the unicorn's horn seems peculiar to Wolfram, and illustrates what has been said above as to his employment of precious stones.

On p. [281](#) we find a full account of the influence of the planets upon the wound.

Page [278](#), line 867—'A knight should come to the castle.' This promised healing of the king by means of a question put by the hero is a marked 'folklore' feature of the tale. Mr. Nutt points out in his *Studies* that in the Grail legend we have a version of the well-known visit to a magic castle influenced by two distinct formulas familiar to folklore students, (a) where the object of the hero is to avenge the death, or wounding, of a relative—the Feud-quest; (b) to release the inhabitants of the castle from an enchantment—the un-spelling quest. The bleeding lance seems to be connected with the first (perhaps also the sword, but its employment both in Wolfram and Chrétien is so enigmatic that it is difficult to know what import to attach to it), the question with the second. The form of the question differs here; in all the other versions it is connected with the Grail: 'Whom serve they with the Grail?' Here, directly with the wounded king, 'What aileth thee, mine uncle?' Birch Hirschfeld maintains, first, that the question was a 'harmless invention' of a predecessor of Chrétien's (thus ignoring the archaic character of the incident); secondly, that Wolfram, having misunderstood Chrétien's account of the Grail, was naturally compelled to invent a fresh question. Of the two, Wolfram's question seems distinctly the more natural, and the more likely to occur to the mind of a simple youth like Parzival; and he has also made much better use of the incident. It is Parzival's failure in the spirit of charity, in the love due 'as a man to men,' that constitutes the sin of the omitted question. Mr. Nutt well remarks that 'It is the insistence upon

charity as the herald and token of spiritual perfection that makes the grandeur of Wolfram's poem.'

Page [283](#), line 1038—'*If a land be without a ruler.*' Here we have the germ of the well-known story of Lohengrin, related in Book XVI. We learn from this passage that Lohengrin's mission was no isolated instance, but a part of the office of the Grail knights. Wolfram's whole presentment of the Grail kingdom, as won by an act of love to a fellow-man, and used for the benefit of others, offers an ideal, not only curiously modern in tone, but in striking contrast to the glorification of spiritual selfishness which we find in other Grail romances. Elsewhere, the aim of the achiever of the Quest is purely to save his *own* soul, and, the task accomplished, he passes away leaving the world none the better for his work. If we look at the concluding lines of the poem, Book XVI., we shall find that Wolfram had quite a different idea of a man's duty to the world of his day.

Page [283](#), line 1045—'*King Kastis wooed Herzeleide.*' Cf. Book II. p. 48.

Page [284](#), line 1070—The account of Trevrezent's wanderings is curious, as it mixes up fabulous places such as Agremontin, the home of the Salamanders, and Fay-Morgan, with such well-known names as Seville, Sicily, and Aquilea. Rohas has been identified with a range of mountains in Styria; Celli is also in Styria. The derivation of 'Gandain' from a Styrian town is very curious. Whether the name was in Wolfram's source or not, we cannot decide, but the connection can only have been introduced by the German poet.

Page [286](#), line 1127—'*Two mortal sins.*' It is curious that in no other version of the story is the slaying of the Red Knight regarded as a sin. Here, however, it is quite in keeping with the pronounced knightly character of the poem. Ither is Parzival's near kinsman, apparently both cousin, and uncle by marriage (lines 1108 and 1119), and to fight with one connected either by the tie of blood or of friendship is regarded throughout as a breach of knightly faith, cf Books XIV. and XV. where Parzival fights, unwittingly, with Gawain and Feirefis. In Chrétien the hermit tells Perceval that it is his sin in causing the death of his mother which has sealed his lips before the Grail; Wolfram seems to regard his silence independently, and, as noted above, the sin, there, seems to be failure in charity and in recognising the

bond of universal brotherhood; which failure, indeed, is at the root of the 'two mortal sins.'

Page [287](#), line 1159—'*Titurel*.' The father of the Fisher King is not named in Chrétien, and indeed is only alluded to in an obscure and enigmatical passage as being nourished by the Grail. This statement is peculiar to these two writers, and seems to indicate that they were in possession of a common source.

Page [287](#), line 1169—'*An thou wouldst that thy life be adorned*.' The passage which follows here to line 1180 should be noted, as it seems to be an interpolation; it has no connection whatever with the context, and is in quite a different tone from the knightly and unecclesiastical character of the rest of Trevrezent's teaching.

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